- Jesus Christ is our suffering Prophet, our High Priest, our righteous King and the Judge for all Creation
  - Sinful mankind requires someone assume these roles so we can know, serve and enjoy God the Father
    - We need a Prophet to explain the Father to us
    - We need a Judge to convict unrighteousness
    - We need a High Priest to intercede for our sins with the Father
    - And we need a King to lead us into righteousness
  - In the Old Testament, the Lord gave Israel each of these roles
    - Prophets were sent to the people
    - Priests were appointed to serve in the tabernacle
    - Judges ruled the people
    - And ultimately kings ruled the nation
  - Yet in each case, scripture demonstrates that human actors were not sufficient to the needs of the people
    - Judges failed to stem the tide of sin among the people
    - Prophets were ignored and usually murdered
    - Priests became corrupt and self-serving
    - Kings turned tyrannical and despotic
    - And so Jewish society remained far from the God Who called them into covenant
    - Like all men, Israel needed a Savior Who could serve and save mankind in these roles
- The books of Samuel tells of the rise of Israel's kings in this OT story
  - Our study of 1 Samuel is actually the study of the first half of a single work called Samuel
    - Prior to the Septuagint, 1 Samuel and 2 Samuel were one work in the Jewish Bible
    - They were later divided for convenience in the same way as Chronicles and Kings
    - The earlier parts of the book were probably written by Samuel
    - But the rest were later finished by other prophets like Gad or Nathan
  - The first seven chapters of 1 Samuel overlap with the final period of Judges
    - During these chapters, Samson is the judge of Israel when Samuel is born and becomes his contemporary
    - At Samson's death, Samuel begins to judge Israel
  - Eventually, Israel demands a king in Chapter 8

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        - Then from Chapter 8 until 31, we trace the reign of Israel's first king, Saul: a man after the people's heart
        - Midway through the book, we're introduced to Saul's eventual successor, David: a man after God's heart
        - Both Saul and David reigned for 40 years
        - Leading to a rivalry during the final half of the book
- There are several notable themes in this historical work, which we will highlight as we move through the book
    - Key among them is the sovereignty of God in ruling His people
        - Even as the people of Israel reject judges and demand a king, the Lord is still very much ruling over His people
        - He brings a king to satisfy the people's fleshly desires for status, ego and image
        - And quickly the people see the folly of Saul
    - Having made His point, then the Lord elevates a successor the people overlooked, David
        - This new man will one day become king
        - But not before the Lord allows Saul's life to play out even as he tries to destroy the man the Lord anointed
        - The delay gives opportunity for David to write most of the Psalms
        - And it forms a picture of the suffering Messiah awaiting to enter into His kingdom
    - Finally, the books of Samuel also reinforce the superiority of God's word as spoken through the prophets
        - During the time of patriarchs and judges, the Lord spoke to the people through their leaders
        - Once kings arrived, God only revealed Himself through prophets, beginning with Samuel
        - Kings would lead, but even the kings had to turn to prophets to know the Lord's word
        - Thereby demonstrating that God's word is the highest authority in God's creation
    - But before we get to all that, we dive into Chapter 1 and Samuel's background story

1Sam. 1:1 Now there was a certain man from Ramathaim-zophim from the hill country of Ephraim, and his name was Elkanah the son of Jeroham, the son of Elihu, the son of Tohu, the son of Zuph, an Ephraimite.
1Sam. 1:2 He had two wives: the name of one was Hannah and the name of the other Peninnah; and Peninnah had children, but Hannah had no children.
1Sam. 1:3 Now this man would go up from his city yearly to worship and to

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sacrifice to the LORD of hosts in Shiloh. And the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were priests to the LORD there.
1Sam. 1:4 **When the day came that Elkanah sacrificed, he would give portions to Peninnah his wife and to all her sons and her daughters;**
1Sam. 1:5 **but to Hannah he would give a double portion, for he loved Hannah, but the LORD had closed her womb.**
1Sam. 1:6 **Her rival, however, would provoke her bitterly to irritate her, because the LORD had closed her womb.**
1Sam. 1:7 **It happened year after year, as often as she went up to the house of the LORD, she would provoke her; so she wept and would not eat.**
1Sam. 1:8 **Then Elkanah her husband said to her, "Hannah, why do you weep and why do you not eat and why is your heart sad? Am I not better to you than ten sons?"**
1Sam. 1:9 **Then Hannah rose after eating and drinking in Shiloh. Now Eli the priest was sitting on the seat by the doorpost of the temple of the LORD.**
1Sam. 1:10 **She, greatly distressed, prayed to the LORD and wept bitterly.**
1Sam. 1:11 **She made a vow and said, "O LORD of hosts, if You will indeed look on the affliction of Your maidservant and remember me, and not forget Your maidservant, but will give Your maidservant a son, then I will give him to the LORD all the days of his life, and a razor shall never come on his head."**

- Our story opens with Samuel's parents
  - Samuel was born to a man named Elkanah
    - He is described as a "certain man" in the opening verse
    - In other words, his identity doesn't matter except for his relationship to the story's main character
  - Elkanah lived about 5 miles north of Jerusalem in Ramah
    - He was a Levite by birth, according to 1 Chr. 6, so he was a priest
    - But Eli's living in a small town in central Ephraim
    - He's not living in a Levite town as he should
    - This is our first clue that this man isn't focused on obeying the Law
  - Nevertheless, in v.3 we also hear he travels annually to worship in Shiloh
    - Shiloh was the location of the tabernacle during the years from Joshua until David, when it was moved to Jerusalem
    - Jerusalem was an unconquered Jebusite city in these days
- Elkanah also practices bigamy, which has always been contrary to God's design of marriage
  - This is the second clue that Elkanah was not a particularly godly man
    - His two wives are Hannah and Peninnah

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        - From Peninnah he received many sons and daughters, but Hannah was barren
        - The prospect of Hannah ever having children seems remote at this point
    - The Lord withholds the giving of children to a woman in scripture from time to time
        - Hannah reminds us of Sarah and Rebecca, two women who would only have a child if the Lord performed a miracle
        - In reality, we should understand these circumstances in the opposite way
        - These women couldn't have children in the first place so that when a child finally came, the arrival would be "pregnant" with meaning
        - So the arrival of Hannah's first child would mark a special moment in God's plan
    - In v.4 we learn Elkanah was a decent provider to this family, including always giving his wives and children their allotted portions
        - But in sympathy and love to Hannah, he gave her a double portion
        - Much like with Hager and Sarah, Peninnah resented her husband's favoritism directed toward Hannah
        - Which led Peninnah to mock and torment Hannah over her lack of children
        - To be childless in this time in history was the height of dishonor for any woman, and Peninnah turned the knife
    - Here's another example to remind us that the Bible always looks negatively upon a man taking multiple wives
        - Whenever we see a man taking multiple wives, the circumstances of his life always reflect the mistake of that choice
        - Usually, we see the consequences of this sin play out as jealousy and bitterness among the wives
        - Which is completely logical, considering a man's affections were always intended to be directed toward one woman alone
        - And there are other negative consequences tooHannah was a devout and godly woman, and we're told she traveled regularly to the tabernacle in Shiloh to seek the Lord's mercy for her barrenness
    - And each time as she prayed at the tabernacle, Hannah would weep and fast hoping to receive a positive response from the Lord
        - Meanwhile, Peninnah, who was there with the rest of the family, would provoke Hannah again
        - Mocking Hannah's hope in the Lord
        - Hannah's persistent hope in the possibility that the Lord might grant her a child was evidence of her faith in God's promises
        - Even as Peninnah's mocking would suggest she was not a God fearing woman
    - Meanwhile, her husband wasn't the most sensitive sort either
        - He dismisses Hannah's misery in a cold and uncaring way
        - First, he asks why she was so upset while worshipping at the tabernacle?

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        - Why bother praying and fasting and weeping over the lack of a child?
    - He flippantly asks, isn't having him as a husband better than ten sons?
        - Why would a wife need anything beyond a husband??
        - So not only has Peninnah mocked Hannah but so has her husband
        - All Hannah had was her faith in the Lord and His mercy
    - You can see just how godly this woman was when you read the first part of v.9
        - When her husband tells her to rise up from her weeping and fasting to eat, Hannah does what he instructs
        - I doubt she felt like doing so, but she obeyed her husband's request nonetheless
        - Everything about this woman's life testifies to her godliness
        - Even her name, which means "grace"
- Meanwhile, in v.9 we learn that the priest at the tabernacle was a man called Eli
    - Though he's not mentioned in the Book of Judges, Eli also judged Israel for 40 years before Samson became a judge
        - When Hannah returned on another day to the temple to pray and weep again, Eli was there to observe her
        - This time as she prayed to the Lord, Hannah was moved to make a vow to the Lord in the hope she would finally receive the child she desperately wanted
    - She declared that if the Lord should give her a son, this son would be dedicated to serving God from birth
        - Moreover, he would be raised as a Nazarite
        - Nazarites were men who took a vow to be dedicated to serving the Lord
        - And as evidence of that vow, they neither cut their hair nor drank alcohol
    - Hannah was essentially bargaining away the companionship of her son
        - From an early age, her son would be in the company of the priests learning the Law and serving in the tabernacle
        - This is a serious sacrifice on her part
        - She is trading away the very thing she seems to want most
- In reality, what she wants is something even more important than the companionship of a son
    - She wants the honor of the Lord's favor
        - It was understood in that day that a barren woman had been made barren by the will of God
            - It wasn't bad luck or chance
            - It was the purposeful act of a sovereign God
        - And therefore, a barren woman viewed her circumstances as the Lord

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withholding His favor from her
        - Which is why Hannah's prayer was to receive the favor of the Lord
        - And it explains her willingness to bargain away the very thing she requested
    - This too is evidence of her faith
        - For since she believed that her barrenness was of the Lord's doing
        - Then she also understood that if the Lord were to grant her a child, it could only mean He had some specific purpose in mind for reversing her situation
        - Therefore, she concludes that any such a child must have a special future in God's plan
        - So she loses nothing in acknowledging the obvious: the child would belong to God
    - But if Hannah received a son, she would gain greatly because she would be vindicated before her enemies
        - So she makes her request as Eli watches

1Sam. 1:12 Now it came about, as she continued praying before the LORD, that Eli was watching her mouth.
1Sam. 1:13 As for Hannah, she was speaking in her heart, only her lips were moving, but her voice was not heard. So Eli thought she was drunk.
1Sam. 1:14 Then Eli said to her, "How long will you make yourself drunk? Put away your wine from you."
1Sam. 1:15 But Hannah replied, "No, my lord, I am a woman oppressed in spirit; I have drunk neither wine nor strong drink, but I have poured out my soul before the LORD.
1Sam. 1:16 "Do not consider your maidservant as a worthless woman, for I have spoken until now out of my great concern and provocation."
1Sam. 1:17 Then Eli answered and said, "Go in peace; and may the God of Israel grant your petition that you have asked of Him."
1Sam. 1:18 She said, "Let your maidservant find favor in your sight." So the woman went her way and ate, and her face was no longer sad.

- As all this is taking place, the priest is observing Hannah praying
    - In this time of history, most public prayer was out loud not silent
        - People prayed out loud to relieve a burden before the Lord
        - In the same way that we might "vent" to a person in charge
    - But Hannah is praying without making a sound which was unusual
        - Eli notices her lips are moving but no sound is coming out of her mouth
        - So Eli makes an assumption that Hannah is drunk

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        - And he chastises her for it
    - Naturally, Hannah defends herself
        - In v.15 she says she is suffering in her spirit
        - She uses a beautiful turn of phrase when she says she hasn't taken in strong drink but has poured out her spirit before the Lord
        - And in v.16 she explains she has been praying like this for some time
        - But she never mentions her vow to Eli
    - Eli must have realized he had come to a wrong conclusion from the moment she began to speak
        - Clearly, she's fully in control of her senses
        - So he quickly backs down and tells her to go in peace
        - And then he adds, may the Lord grant her petition
- This encounter seems innocent to us, but it meant much more to Hannah
    - The high priest and judge of Israel took notice of Hannah during prayer
        - It was highly improbable that a man of such power and importance in Israel would take note of anyone in particular
        - Much less to notice a woman
        - For him to pronounce a blessing upon her prayer request was like hitting the lottery for Hannah
    - Remember in this day Eli was priest, judge and prophet of Israel
        - He was the man though whom the Lord spoke to Israel
        - And the prophet of Israel just said, may the Lord grant Hannah her request
    - I'm sure Hannah heard his blessing as a confirmation that the Lord was already at work in answering her request
        - Notice in v.18 she breaks her fast
        - And she is no longer sad
        - This is a woman operating in faith from beginning to end
        - In faith she put her request before the Lord
        - And now in faith, when she receives a word from the Lord, she rests in that word
- But will she keep her vow concerning her son when the time comes?

1Sam. 1:19 Then they arose early in the morning and worshiped before the LORD, and returned again to their house in Ramah. And Elkanah had relations with Hannah his wife, and the LORD remembered her.
1Sam. 1:20 It came about in due time, after Hannah had conceived, that she gave birth to a son; and she named him Samuel, saying, "Because I have asked him of the LORD."

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1Sam. 1:21 Then the man Elkanah went up with all his household to offer to the LORD the yearly sacrifice and pay his vow.
1Sam. 1:22 But Hannah did not go up, for she said to her husband, "I will not go up until the child is weaned; then I will bring him, that he may appear before the LORD and stay there forever."
1Sam. 1:23 Elkanah her husband said to her, "Do what seems best to you. Remain until you have weaned him; only may the LORD confirm His word." So the woman remained and nursed her son until she weaned him.

- After they travel back to Ramah, they return to regular life
  - And in the course of events, Hannah becomes pregnant
    - At this point, the miracle of her conception would have only served to strengthen her confidence and faith
    - At the first indication that she was with child, Hannah must have felt such joy at the confirmation that the Lord answered her
  - Whatever doubts she might have had were wiped away at that point
    - Such is the Lord's work in our lives as well
    - Even when we believe and hope for the Lord to answer affirmatively, there is always room for doubt even in the life of a believer
    - That's why the Lord commonly gives us encouragement along the way
  - Usually, the Lord moves in our lives by means of a series of smaller steps
    - With each step, the Lord will ask us to persist in our belief and trust Him for the rest of the plan
    - And as the Lord comes through with each step along the path, His faithfulness is a sign to encourage us forward
  - Like with Hannah, each step we take along that path will require faith and trust
    - Even after her husband and his wife mocked her, she maintained her determination
    - Though he ordered her to leave the temple, nevertheless she returned on another day
    - But the Lord never asks more of us than we are capable of giving
    - And as we take the next step in faith, the Lord will show up to encourage us onward
      - Just as He did when Eli encouraged Hannah's faith
    - And so the next step comes easier
  - But here's the catch…we'll never reach the end of the path the Lord has prepared for us if we give up at a point along the way
    - We often think of a walk of faith as an "all or nothing" proposition

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        - We are either walking with the Lord or we aren't
      - And if we are speaking of saving faith, then it is an "either/or" proposition
      - But for the one who is a believer, then a walk of faith is truly a matter of degrees
      - We experience more and more of what it means to walk with the Lord as we follow Him in the small steps He asks of us
- Then in v.20 Samuel is born to Hannah
  - The name Samuel probably means something like "heard of God" or "God hears"
    - He is Hannah's only son
    - And yet she will give him up as she promised
  - When Samuel was born, his father prepared to travel to the tabernacle in Shiloh to pay his vow
    - In Lev 27 the Law required that when a person made a vow to the Lord, that vow must be accompanied by an offering
    - This rule has a parallel in modern contract law, where no contract is considered valid without a payment of consideration
    - Here it's called Elkanah's vow, because Hannah's vow became his vow once he heard of his wife's decision yet didn't challenge it
    - So Elkanah is obligated to pay the offering associated with her vow
  - But Hannah declines to accompany her husband at the tabernacle
    - First, Hannah wasn't required to make the trip
    - But she won't go now because she would have had to take her infant son with her
    - And she is so committed to her vow, that she won't bring him near the tabernacle until she is ready to leave him there
    - Clearly, she's not going back on her vow to the Lord
  - She says she will keep the boy only long enough to wean him
    - But this length of time was considerably more heartbreaking for Hannah than it may appear to us
    - In the ancient times, weaning traditionally took place at the age of five years
    - While it would be difficult for any mother to give up a child, this woman is giving up her five-year old son
    - This is no small sacrifice for this mother

1Sam. 1:24 Now when she had weaned him, she took him up with her, with a three-year-old bull and one ephah of flour and a jug of wine, and brought him to the house of the LORD in Shiloh, although the child was young.
1Sam. 1:25 Then they slaughtered the bull, and brought the boy to Eli.
1Sam. 1:26 She said, "Oh, my lord! As your soul lives, my lord, I am the woman

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who stood here beside you, praying to the LORD.
1Sam. 1:27 **"For this boy I prayed, and the LORD has given me my petition which I asked of Him.**
1Sam. 1:28 **"So I have also dedicated him to the LORD; as long as he lives he is dedicated to the LORD." And he worshiped the LORD there.**

- Hannah knew this day would come, and as promised she brought Samuel to the Lord
  - She brought a significant thanks offering with the boy
    - A bull, which was very expensive
    - Plus a large quantity of flour and wine
    - The value of the items she brought were evidence of her great thankfulness to the Lord
  - After she performed the sacrifice, she presented her son to Eli
    - He may have recognized the mother yet still been surprised to see her place a boy into his hands
    - And after reminding Eli of who she was, Hannah declares her young son is now a ward of the tabernacle
    - The Lord gave Hannah the answer to her prayer
    - So the time has come to make good on her vow
- Notice in v.28, she declares that Samuel will be dedicated to the Lord
  - The word for dedicated in Hebrew conveys the idea of giving something completely to the Lord
    - She was holding nothing back
    - And because she was willing to give up her only son, Israel gained a prophet and kingmaker
    - There is an obvious picture of Christ in her actions
  - Samuel is the first, and one of the most important, prophets of the Old Testament
    - Not only did he write major parts of the books that go by his name, but he also likely wrote Ruth and Judges
    - This man had been a gift to Hannah
    - And she made him a gift back to the Jewish people
  - Hannah's choice to give up Samuel is a beautiful example of how all God's children should respond to His gifts
    - Whatever the Lord has given us should be made available to the Lord for His use
    - Paul tells us to make our lives a living sacrifice, and this is what that looks like
    - Holding nothing back, giving Him our all
    - And when we do that, He can take our sacrifices and make them into so much more than we can imagine

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- Notice at the end of v.28 we're told that "he" worshipped the Lord there
  - The "he" is a reference to Samuel
    - Samuel begins to worship the Lord from the start of his time with Eli's family
    - If we wonder how Hannah could leave her young son in the hands of a man like Eli, consider she wasn't entrusting Samuel to Eli
    - She placed Samuel in the care of the Lord
    - The Lord raised this boy
  - Her logic must have been something like this:
    - If the Lord opened Hannah's womb to give her Samuel, then the Lord must have a specific plan for Samuel's life
    - Therefore, Hannah can trust the Lord to care for Samuel…even through the hands of a man like Eli
    - Hannah shows the full impact of living with trust in God's sovereignty in our daily lives
    - We have to learn to act with the trust we claim to have
    - Do we trust the Lord to take care of our kids when they answer His call?
  - In fact, the story of Eli and his sons makes clear that God's will is responsible for the outcome of each person's life
    - And the Lord's will brings blessing for obedience and consequences for disobedience
    - But regardless of whether we obey or not, the Lord's will will be done
- After this dedication Hannah praises the Lord in song, recorded in the first part of Chapter 2

1Sam. 2:1 **Then Hannah prayed and said,**
"My heart exults in the LORD;
My horn is exalted in the LORD,
My mouth speaks boldly against my enemies,
Because I rejoice in Your salvation.
1Sam. 2:2 **"There is no one holy like the LORD,**
Indeed, there is no one besides You,
Nor is there any rock like our God.
1Sam. 2:3 **"Boast no more so very proudly,**
Do not let arrogance come out of your mouth;
For the LORD is a God of knowledge,
And with Him actions are weighed.
1Sam. 2:4 **"The bows of the mighty are shattered,**
But the feeble gird on strength.
1Sam. 2:5 **"Those who were full hire themselves out for bread,**

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But those who were hungry cease to hunger.
Even the barren gives birth to seven,
But she who has many children languishes.
1Sam. 2:6 **"The LORD kills and makes alive;**
He brings down to Sheol and raises up.
1Sam. 2:7 **"The LORD makes poor and rich;**
He brings low, He also exalts.
1Sam. 2:8 **"He raises the poor from the dust,**
He lifts the needy from the ash heap
To make them sit with nobles,
And inherit a seat of honor;
For the pillars of the earth are the LORD'S,
And He set the world on them.
1Sam. 2:9 **"He keeps the feet of His godly ones,**
But the wicked ones are silenced in darkness;
For not by might shall a man prevail.
1Sam. 2:10 **"Those who contend with the LORD will be shattered;**
Against them He will thunder in the heavens,
The LORD will judge the ends of the earth;
And He will give strength to His king,
And will exalt the horn of His anointed."
1Sam. 2:11 **Then Elkanah went to his home at Ramah. But the boy ministered to the LORD before Eli the priest.**

- Hannah's song sounds like it was sung right in Penninah's face
  - This song is a close match to the one David sings at the end of 2 Samuel
    - Both begin with a reference to the strength of the Lord as a horn and a rock
    - Both speak of a deliverer and salvation
    - Both end with a mention of His anointed
  - These two songs serve as bookends for the entire book of Samuel
    - And they both teach a similar lesson about the Lord and His ruling over His people
    - In fact, Hannah's song serves as a roadmap for understanding the rest of this book and 2 Samuel
- Hannah starts by declaring she can speak boldly and find strength in the face of her enemies because she finds her joy in the salvation God brings
  - In v.2 she echoes that there is no other rock, no other god besides the Lord
    - When you remember the Lord is seated on His throne, we cease our boasting and we take comfort in our afflictions
    - The Lord is never not reigning over His Creation

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        - So that when things seem to be going against us and the world is falling apart, the Lord is orchestrating all these events
        - An understanding of God's sovereignty in everyday events is the single most powerful spiritual insight any Christian can obtain
        - It will set everything else in your life in its proper perspective
    - Next, Hannah declares that the Lord is a God of knowledge in v.3
        - That He weighs every action He takes
        - In other words, everything God does has purpose and meaning
        - And the consequences of His every action are well-considered taken into account in His planning
        - Simply put, there is never a "Plan B" with God
    - Therefore, Hannah's many years of waiting factored into God's plan
        - Samuel was to be born, but not a day too soon
        - Therefore, Hannah's years of mocking and waiting were not wasted
        - Nor did they suggest God was slow or uncaring
- Furthermore, the Lord places His strength on the side of the weak, not the mighty
    - There is a familiar phrase people throw around, sometimes even claiming that it's a statement found in the Bible
        - They say "the Lord helps those who help themselves"
        - But of course this statement does not appear in the Bible
        - More importantly, this *concept* isn't biblical
    - The Lord is not inclined to help those who help themselves
        - Instead, He's inclined to help those who confess they can't help themselves and therefore appeal to Him for the help they need
        - And the Lord delights to assist these people, who gird themselves with His strength Hannah says
    - In v. 5 Hannah points out the foolishness of those who already have plenty yet still hire themselves out for work to gain even more
        - It's foolish because it represented a waste of time and energy and a lost cause in the end
            - Meanwhile, those who are hungry are fed by the Lord
        - And those who have many children still languish because their children aren't a comfort to them
            - While the barren woman is blessed with seven children she never expected
    - In other words, the world is busy working to obtain the very things that the Lord is prepared to grant to those who seek for Him
        - As Jesus said

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Matt. 6:31 "Do not worry then, saying, 'What will we eat?' or 'What will we drink?' or 'What will we wear for clothing?'
Matt. 6:32 "For the Gentiles eagerly seek all these things; for your heavenly Father knows that you need all these things.
Matt. 6:33 "But seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.

- The Lord helps those who can't help themselves
- And none of us can truly help ourselves, though sometimes we make the mistake of thinking we can
- And we run the risk of spending our time on the wrong things while missing the chance to see God bless us in our dependence
- From here, Hannah's song moves to existential issues
  - She declares God brings both life and death as He sees fit
    - He determines the destination of all men's souls, whether Hell or Heaven
    - He also sets the station of our lives
    - Some people will be poor
    - Some people will be rich – all according to God's will
  - But the Lord creates the poor and needy, Hannah says, so that He can show Himself strong and compassion as He raises them up
    - And the Lord has the power to raise up the poorest and place them at the table of kings
    - Prophetically, she alludes to shepherd boys becoming king
    - For the Lord is in control of all men's lives and delights to show His power as He moves men like pieces on a chess board
- In v.9, Hannah moves finally into questions of God's grace in the lives of men
  - The Lord is working to keep the feet of His godly ones
    - Godly refers to those who by faith have been saved and made children of God
    - And these the Lord "keeps" so that they remain His forever
  - But those who are wicked, which is all who do not know the Messiah sent to die in our place, will be silenced in darkness of Hell
    - The plan God has authored for our salvation works this way to preclude anyone from pointing to their own strength as a means of salvation
    - No man will prevail by strength
    - Not even kings who attempt to rule by their own power
    - Instead, those who prevail will do so by the strength of the Lord
  - And that strength is found in the Anointed One sent on our behalf

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        - In v.10 Hannah ends by declaring the coming Messiah as King for God's people
        - The Lord will judge the earth and give strength to His King
        - The anointed who will be exalted
        - This song forms a loose outline of the books of Samuel, and we'll refer back to it from time to time as we study the rest of the book
- To end tonight, in v.11 we're told that the family returns home but Samuel stays with Eli
    - The story follows Samuel to tell the story of his new home
        - He has brothers who serve as a contrast to his godliness
        - And his new father, Eli, is a man with many problems of his own
    - Remember, this is the time of Judges when men did what was right in their own eyes
        - Furthermore, the men are weak leaders in their homes
        - Eli will represent that clearly
        - Nevertheless, the Lord is raising Samuel
        - So despite the poor family dynamic, Samuel turns out OK

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- Samuel opened his first book with a brief look at his family origins
  - He was born to a woman who promised to give him away in service to the Lord
    - And since the Lord was the One Who made it possible for Samuel to be born, we know this was the Lord's intention
    - Samuel is going to be a servant of the Lord
    - He is the son of a priest, so he's qualified to serve according to the Law
  - But his family is not the family we would expect to produce a child to lead Israel's priesthood
    - Nor is he likely to receive the favor of the existing priesthood
    - Since Eli already has sons to serve in the temple
    - So how will the Lord bring Samuel into a position of service given he lacks the proper pedigree?
- This question hints at important themes developing in this chapter
  - First, God will remove those who fail to seek Him in faith and obedience
    - Those who serve Him in selfish desire and pursuit will be thrown down
    - We remember the early chapters of this book are set in the times of the Judges
    - A time when men did what was right in their own eyes
  - Secondly, the Lord will raise up unlikely men to fill the void left by the departure of the expected leaders
    - Corrupt men will not stand no matter their pedigree
    - And the one upon whom God places His seal will rise
  - The content of Chapter 2 is arranged in a very structured manner to reinforce these points
    - We've already seen the opening of the chapter begin with a song that spoke of God defending the weak and frustrating the strength of men
    - And our next section is framed by bookends that repeat this theme in a new way

1Sam. 2:11 Then Elkanah went to his home at Ramah. But the boy ministered to the LORD before Eli the priest.
1Sam. 2:12 Now the sons of Eli were worthless men; they did not know the LORD
1Sam. 2:13 and the custom of the priests with the people. When any man was offering a sacrifice, the priest's servant would come while the meat was boiling, with a three-pronged fork in his hand.
1Sam. 2:14 Then he would thrust it into the pan, or kettle, or caldron, or pot; all that the fork brought up the priest would take for himself. Thus they did in Shiloh to all the Israelites who came there.
1Sam. 2:15 Also, before they burned the fat, the priest's servant would come and

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say to the man who was sacrificing, "Give the priest meat for roasting, as he will not take boiled meat from you, only raw."
1Sam. 2:16 **If the man said to him, "They must surely burn the fat first, and then take as much as you desire," then he would say, "No, but you shall give it to me now; and if not, I will take it by force."**
1Sam. 2:17 **Thus the sin of the young men was very great before the LORD, for the men despised the offering of the LORD.**
1Sam. 2:18 **Now Samuel was ministering before the LORD, as a boy wearing a linen ephod.**

- Notice how this section opens in v.11
  - The boy, Samuel, is ministering to the Lord before Eli the priest
    - To minister simply means to serve
    - So Samuel is serving the Lord even as Eli is priest
    - The statement is eye opening, since we would expect the appointed high priest to do the serving
    - But there's a young boy doing the work of service
  - And then we're introduced to Eli's sons
    - In v.12 we're told they are "worthless" men
    - Worthless means ungodly, wicked
    - Two reasons are given for why they were worthless
  - First, they do not know the Lord
    - Simply put, they are not saints
    - They are unbelieving Israel
    - They serve as examples of men, like the Pharisees of Jesus' day, who claim to be near God and yet are far from Him
  - Secondly, they abuse their service as priests by despising the offering to the Lord
    - In v.13 they do not know the customs of the priests with the people
    - These customs refer to the Levitical rules God gave Israel
    - Imagine two men serving as priests who are not familiar with the customs of priests
    - And this isn't merely a matter of ignorance
    - They despise these customs, preferring to do things their own way for selfish reasons
- So the contrast that begins this section has on the one hand a young Samuel serving God while the established priests are abusing their positions
  - If you glance down to vs.17-18, notice you find the same pattern

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        - In v.17 you see the same conclusion regarding the priests
        - They despised the offering and their sin was great
        - But in v.18 we find Samuel ministering before the Lord
        - And this time we see him wearing a miniature priest outfit, which only serves to reinforce the image of an unlikely hero
    - So what comes between these bookends is documented evidence of the brothers' guilt
        - They would steal the offering from the Lord
        - Part of the offering was to be boiled and a certain portion was to remain with the priests as their allotted portion
        - But these boys would choose whatever portion they desired from the pot
        - The brothers insisted the meat to be consumed by fire on the altar be given to them raw so they could roast it and eat it later
        - If someone objected, they would take it by force
    - These men were offensive to the Lord and the people
        - They are examples of the way people in positions of great power may become self-seeking and arrogant
        - That's why it's healthy to maintain a degree of cynicism when observing the piety of men and women in positions of religious authority
        - Many are every bit as pious as they appear
        - But others are merely working the crowd
        - Don't be sucked in by the persona or position…worship the Lord and give little regard to His servants
- The contrasts continue in the next section

1Sam. 2:19 **And his mother would make him a little robe and bring it to him from year to year when she would come up with her husband to offer the yearly sacrifice.**
1Sam. 2:20 **Then Eli would bless Elkanah and his wife and say, "May the LORD give you children from this woman in place of the one she dedicated to the LORD." And they went to their own home.**
1Sam. 2:21 **The LORD visited Hannah; and she conceived and gave birth to three sons and two daughters. And the boy Samuel grew before the LORD.**

- This passage begins with a little encouragement to all mothers
    - If you were troubled at the thought of Hannah dumping her little boy off at the tabernacle and turning her back, it turns out it's not that way
        - Hannah gets to see her son at least annually

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        - And because of her sacrifice, Eli the priest makes a point of blessing her when she visits with a promise of children
        - And in time, Hannah has more children to take the place of Samuel
            - Five children: the number of grace, the meaning of her name
        - The Lord blesses Hannah for her obedience
    - But she hasn't forgotten Samuel, and so when she visits, she brings a little priestly robe for him
        - Since clothes wear out and Samuel was growing, Hannah brought a new robe each year
        - We can't help but to smile as we think of her bringing a child-sized robe to the tabernacle
        - Clearly, she's encouraging her son into a specific walk of life
    - Although Samuel was qualified to be a priest (being a descendant of Kohath) and he has been dedicated to the tabernacle service, he's not the son of Eli
        - And therefore, there is no reason to expect Samuel will become Eli's successor
        - And yet Samuel is wearing a miniature ephod
        - And only the High Priest wore an ephod
        - Hannah was saying something about where she believed God was taking Samuel
- So we see Samuel looking like the future High Priest, but he's not going to be the High Priest of Israel
    - The Lord has a different plan for Samuel
        - Samuel will serve as a priest, but he will never become the High Priest
        - Instead, he will be the final judge of Israel
        - And he will be the first prophet of Israel
    - Remember, this is the moment in Israel's history when the Lord is ready to disassociate the roles of leader, priest and prophet
        - In Moses' day, the roles were united as God brought the Law
        - Moses was the people's intercessor for the covenant with the Lord
        - He was the leader of the people
        - And he was a prophet who brought the word
    - With Joshua's entry into the land and the establishment of the tabernacle, the Lord separated the role of leader and intercessor
        - Joshua led the people while priests interceded before the altar
        - The leader was also the prophet for the people, bringing the word of the Lord
        - This has been the pattern through the period of Judges up to Samuel's day
    - But the Lord is now going to separate the role of prophet

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- So that there will be leaders, priests and prophets
- Though Samuel is qualified to be a priest, he must be a prophet
- And in this role of prophet, his first task will be to depose the current family of priests

1Sam. 2:22 Now Eli was very old; and he heard all that his sons were doing to all Israel, and how they lay with the women who served at the doorway of the tent of meeting.
1Sam. 2:23 He said to them, "Why do you do such things, the evil things that I hear from all these people?
1Sam. 2:24 "No, my sons; for the report is not good which I hear the LORD'S people circulating.
1Sam. 2:25 "If one man sins against another, God will mediate for him; but if a man sins against the LORD, who can intercede for him?" But they would not listen to the voice of their father, for the LORD desired to put them to death.
1Sam. 2:26 Now the boy Samuel was growing in stature and in favor both with the LORD and with men.

- The story of Eli's sons is really the story of Eli and his sons
  - First, his sons were the worst sort
    - We've already heard they are godless and worthless
    - And beside robbing people and despising the Lord's offering, they are committing the worst sexual immorality
    - They are having sexual relations with prostitutes at the doorway of the tabernacle
    - Sex with prostitutes was a common practice among Canaanite pagans
    - So in effect these priests were engaging in pagan worship practices
  - Then we have Eli
    - First, we're told Eli was very old
    - At first, you might think this detail is intended to paint Eli as a sympathetic figure in the story
    - But the opposite was true
    - Eli's sons are full grown men and have been under Eli's authority for many years
    - And as an elder, Eli's word and authority should have been treated with unquestioned respect
- Instead these men are clearly completely out of control, and we're told in v.24 that Eli chastises his sons for the evil that Eli hears is "circulating" or passing around
  - Notice that Eli isn't disturbed by their behavior so much as by the fact that it's become a point of public complaint or gossip

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        - Eli is concerned about his reputation and the reputation of his family name
        - He's like a monarch that knows his sons are reckless playboys, but doesn't pay attention unless they embarrass the family
        - And if this is truly the first time Eli has heard of his sons' exploits, then it would mean Eli is guilty of gross negligence as High Priest
        - Either way, his sons' behavior reflects negatively on the father
    - Eli is a popular preaching example of the sin of bad parenting
        - Biblically, parents aren't responsible for the behavior of their children
        - But they are held to account for poor parenting choices that allowed bad behavior to develop
        - Every child is born in sin, and therefore every child is prone to misbehavior
        - Knowing that, every parent is expected to take the necessary steps to discipline to child to address that sin
        - Some kids are easier than others, but all need discipline
- Eli was old, which means he had years to mold the character of these sons – but he failed to do so
    - And even now we can see how he failed
        - When Eli hears of his sons' behavior, his response is a mild talking-to
        - He counsels them as if he were speaking about running in the halls of the tabernacle or showing up for work late
        - Eli's heard that his sons are stealing from the Lord, despising the offering, threatening violence against worshippers, fornicating with prostitutes and defiling the tabernacle
        - Any one of those offenses is punishable by death, and yet this man does nothing except shake a finger and say "tsk, tsk"
    - If Eli were the kind of father the Lord requires, he would have removed his sons from service and likely put them to death
        - But honestly if Eli were that kind of father to begin with, the situation would never have come to this point
        - And that's the lesson of scripture to all parents

Prov. 22:6 **Train up a child in the way he should go,**
Even when he is old he will not depart from it.

Eph. 6:4 **Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.**

- Notice the promise of scripture is that lessons taught to our children early will produce life long dividends, according to Proverbs

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- And Paul says that bringing up a child starts with discipline and progresses to instruction
- Because if a child is not accustomed to correction, they will give little attention or respect to the instruction of elders – whether parents or teachers
- That's what we see here…Eli's sons neither listen to him nor respect him because he will not hold them accountable for their sin

- But though a human parent will not hold children accountable, the Father in Heaven does
  - And as weak as Eli may be, he is endowed to speak the word of the Lord
    - And so he speaks perhaps more truth than he realized when he tells his sons that they are sinning against the Lord
    - He says if a man sins against another man, then he can expect the Lord will mediate
  - Eli's advice to his sons is specious at best
    - He says that if a man sins against another man, then the Lord will mediate
    - But sinning against the Lord leaves no hope
    - This is not sound theological advice
    - Sinning against another man (i.e., murder) is just as punishable as sinning against the Lord directly, as his sons are doing
    - In fact, his sons are doing both
  - If this kind of twisted logic is representative of the training Eli gave his sons growing up then it's no wonder they have little regard for right vs. wrong
    - This is like telling your children that it's ok to cheat on your taxes because you're not hurting anyone
    - Or a mafia boss who orders murders of rival bosses but apologizes for cussing in front of the priest
- Notice at the end of v.25 that the Lord had already determined how to handle these boys
  - He has determined to put them to death as would be expected for these offenses
    - In a very real sense, Eli's failures as a father have led to the death of his sons
    - And the same can still happen among today's parents, including in believing families
  - When parents shrink back from their responsibilities, the Lord may step into that gap
    - Sometimes the Lord will show mercy by raising up a godly child despite the mistakes of the parents
    - Sometimes the Lord will bring discipline upon the ungodly child by allowing the consequences of their sin to come back upon them
    - And sometimes the Lord may even take the step like the one He took in this case

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        - We take these chances when we abdicate our responsibility to discipline and instruct our kids in the way of the Lord
- Finally, look at the contrast with Samuel once more
    - In v.26 he is growing in stature and favor with the Lord and men
        - This is a statement remarkably similar to what is said about Christ in Luke
        - Samuel is headed in one direction while Eli's family is headed in another
    - Now we're beginning to see how Samuel will emerge from this family on top
        - He is obeying while they are not obeying
        - Just as Hannah was obeying while her sister wife was not
        - Obedience results in blessing, while disobedience results in defeat and judgment
        - Perhaps above all others, this is the lesson of the books of Samuel
- And now the time has come for the Lord to do as He declared
    - Only He will do much more than take the sons' lives

1Sam. 2:27 Then a man of God came to Eli and said to him, "Thus says the LORD, 'Did I not indeed reveal Myself to the house of your father when they were in Egypt in bondage to Pharaoh's house?
1Sam. 2:28 'Did I not choose them from all the tribes of Israel to be My priests, to go up to My altar, to burn incense, to carry an ephod before Me; and did I not give to the house of your father all the fire offerings of the sons of Israel?
1Sam. 2:29 'Why do you kick at My sacrifice and at My offering which I have commanded in My dwelling, and honor your sons above Me, by making yourselves fat with the choicest of every offering of My people Israel?'
1Sam. 2:30 "Therefore the LORD God of Israel declares, 'I did indeed say that your house and the house of your father should walk before Me forever'; but now the LORD declares, 'Far be it from Me — for those who honor Me I will honor, and those who despise Me will be lightly esteemed.
1Sam. 2:31 'Behold, the days are coming when I will break your strength and the strength of your father's house so that there will not be an old man in your house.
1Sam. 2:32 'You will see the distress of My dwelling, in spite of all the good that I do for Israel; and an old man will not be in your house forever.
1Sam. 2:33 'Yet I will not cut off every man of yours from My altar so that your eyes will fail from weeping and your soul grieve, and all the increase of your house will die in the prime of life.
1Sam. 2:34 'This will be the sign to you which will come concerning your two sons, Hophni and Phinehas: on the same day both of them will die.
1Sam. 2:35 'But I will raise up for Myself a faithful priest who will do according to what is in My heart and in My soul; and I will build him an enduring house, and

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he will walk before My anointed always.
1Sam. 2:36 **'Everyone who is left in your house will come and bow down to him for a piece of silver or a loaf of bread and say, "Please assign me to one of the priest's offices so that I may eat a piece of bread."'"**

- A man is sent to Eli
  - We don't know who this man is, but in the days before prophets, he would have been called a "seer"
    - If there was a difference between the two it was in the magnitude of their ministry and their message
    - In this case, a man is sent to Eli for a moment with a single message pertaining to him
    - This seems to be the extent of the Lord's use of this man
  - What he came to say to Eli was intended to rock his world
    - The Lord begins by reminding Eli of Whose house the tabernacle is and for Whom the sacrifices are offered
    - The house and its functioning were established by and for the Lord's purposes
    - And those who serve in the tabernacle were assigned their place by God as well
    - So of course the Lord takes a personal interest in how men serve Him there
  - The point is that a failure to serve Him properly should be cause for great concern for Eli
    - And yet Eli is guilty of kicking at the Lord's sacrifice and offering
    - He honors his sons above the Lord
    - And now we learn, Eli has been enjoying the meat that his sons steal just as they did
    - Now we see additional reasons for why Eli offers just a half-hearted rebuke of his sons
    - He isn't entirely unhappy that they do what they do, since he profits from it too
- It's important to note that the Lord decided to send this word to Eli, not to the sons directly
  - It shows us who the Lord holds accountable for the situation
    - The Lord sees Eli was the guilty one when he allows his sons to act as they do
      - Just as we said earlier that a parent shares a degree of culpability when they contribute to the delinquency of a child
    - And the Lord declared that Eli is honoring his sons above the Lord when he fails to correct and restrain them
      - I used to tell my kids after they had made a mistake and they were objecting to a punishment that:

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        - "The Lord tells parents to discipline children. When you do the wrong thing, you can't expect me to do the wrong thing by not punishing you."
      - To not discipline your children is to sin against the Lord
    - And Eli is equally guilty of their offenses when he enjoys the fruit of their sin
      - The saddest sight is a parent who celebrates the sin of their kids, whether laughing off their rude behavior or congratulating them for finding a way to cheat on a test
  - In v.30 we find essentially the theme of the books of Samuel, expressing the thought I gave a moment ago
    - Those who honor the Lord will be honored
    - While those who despise the Lord will be forgotten
    - This is true for Samuel vs. Eli and his sons
    - And it will be true for David vs. Saul
- Then the Lord reveals his plan for Eli's sons and his entire family line
  - In a nutshell, the Lord declares that He will cut off Eli's family line from serving as priests in the tabernacle
    - All the sons of Levi were called to serve in the priesthood perpetually
    - But this particular family line would cease to serve due to the sin of Eli and his sons
  - But in v.33 the Lord goes a step further declaring that the fulfillment of this curse will not happen quickly
    - It will take years to play out so that the Lord can make sure His point is well understood in Israel
    - Later generations in Eli's family will enter into the priesthood only so long as to die in the prime of life
    - One after another will die, leaving the people to recognize that the family of Eli has been cursed by God
  - In v.35 the Lord promises to raise up a faithful priest to replace Eli's family line
    - The final fulfillment of this curse happened in Solomon's day
    - Solomon removed Eli's great-great grandson, Abiathar, from office
    - And no member of Eli's family line ever serves as priest again
  - In his place, Solomon installs the priest Zadok
    - Notice that this priest is said to walk before God's anointed always
    - This is a reference to the Messianic Kingdom
    - Because in Ezekiel 44 and 48 we're told that the descendants of Zadok serve in the Millennial Temple as priests
  - That's how thoroughly the Lord moves to remove one line and install another
    - Where before Eli's family abused their power as priest and stole food from the

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Lord and others in the tabernacle
        - In the future, they will be lowly in society and beg for charity from the priests
        - Because this one family acted in such foolish ways, they set the course of future generations on a downward path
- Notice in v.34 the Lord says that Eli will receive a sign that all this seer has declared will come to pass
    - Since Eli won't be alive to see the entire prophecy play out, the Lord is prepared to prove to him that it will happen as promised
        - And the sign will be particularly harsh, though entirely justified
        - Both of Eli's wicked sons will die on exactly the same day
        - The point of course is that two boys dying on the same day can't be a coincidence
        - Especially when it's predicted in advance
        - Never mind the pain of losing both sons at all
    - How do we suppose Eli might react to this prophecy?
        - Perhaps he would cry out in repentance and ask for the Lord's mercy?
        - Remember when David heard that he would lose his son because of his sin with Batsheba?

2Sam. 12:13 Then David said to Nathan, "I have sinned against the LORD." And Nathan said to David, "The LORD also has taken away your sin; you shall not die.
2Sam. 12:14 "However, because by this deed you have given occasion to the enemies of the LORD to blaspheme, the child also that is born to you shall surely die."
2Sam. 12:15 So Nathan went to his house. Then the LORD struck the child that Uriah's widow bore to David, so that he was very sick.
2Sam. 12:16 David therefore inquired of God for the child; and David fasted and went and lay all night on the ground.
2Sam. 12:17 The elders of his household stood beside him in order to raise him up from the ground, but he was unwilling and would not eat food with them.

- David made appeals to the Lord and fasted and prayed and kept vigil hoping the Lord might relent
- That's how a man after God's heart responds to the Lord when he learns he has sinned against the Lord
- But what does Eli do?
    - We don't hear anything at this point, which in itself is telling
        - In the next chapter, Eli will hear from the Lord again on this matter

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        - From Samuel directly next time
    - And when we see his reaction in that case, we will learn that his response is anything but David's
        - We're seeing the rationale behind the Lord raising up Samuel to lead the people
        - The leaders of Israel are corrupt (as you see in the book of Judges)
        - And now we learn the priests of Israel are corrupt
        - And we have yet to see prophets arise in the land
        - So where do men go for godly direction within Israel?
    - It's evident that men cannot rule even under God's authority because sin is a barrier to obedience
        - Instead, God must bless those who will serve and raise them up to replace those who won't
        - And in Chapter 2 we see a chiastic structure that points out this truth
    - Chiasms are hard to explain, because they are by their very nature visual representations
        - Dr. Thomas Constable suggests the following chiasm

A. The song of Hannah, concluding with reference to the Lord's anointed (2:1-10)
B. Samuel ministers before the Lord (2:11)
C. The sins of Eli's sons (2:12-17)
D. Samuel ministers before the Lord (2:18-19)
E. Eli blesses Samuel's parents (2:20- 21a)
D.' Samuel grows in the Lord's presence (2:21b)
C.' The sins of Eli's sons (2:22-25)
B.' Samuel grows in the Lords' presence (2:26)
A.' The oracles of the man of God, concluding with reference to the Lord's anointed (2:27-36)

- **The "point" of the chiasm is the point of the message**
    - Eli blesses his successor without knowing it
    - Samuel is being prepared to step into his place
    - Just as Samuel's parents raised a godly child to replace the ungodly children Eli was raising
    - The Lord removes the disobedient to install the obedient

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- We've covered Samuel's birth and his arrival in Eli's family
  - And now the story turns to Samuel's call to serve the Lord
    - Of course, we already know that Hannah has dedicated Samuel to the Lord
    - And we know why she made her vow
  - But what of Samuel's own perspective?
    - We might wonder how he felt about being "dumped" at the tabernacle by his parents?
    - He saw them periodically, so we know he knows them
    - Therefore, he knows he's been dedicated to the temple service
    - But what does this mean to a young boy?
  - At some point, the true purpose in his dedication must become real for him
    - And the day has come for a revelation from the Lord
    - Chapter 3 is Samuel's call, and his first prophecy, from God
    - And once again, that prophecy centers on Eli's family

1Sam. 3:1 Now the boy Samuel was ministering to the LORD before Eli. And word from the LORD was rare in those days, visions were infrequent.
1Sam. 3:2 It happened at that time as Eli was lying down in his place (now his eyesight had begun to grow dim and he could not see well),
1Sam. 3:3 and the lamp of God had not yet gone out, and Samuel was lying down in the temple of the LORD where the ark of God was,
1Sam. 3:4 that the LORD called Samuel; and he said, "Here I am."
1Sam. 3:5 Then he ran to Eli and said, "Here I am, for you called me." But he said, "I did not call, lie down again." So he went and lay down.
1Sam. 3:6 The LORD called yet again, "Samuel!" So Samuel arose and went to Eli and said, "Here I am, for you called me." But he answered, "I did not call, my son, lie down again."
1Sam. 3:7 Now Samuel did not yet know the LORD, nor had the word of the LORD yet been revealed to him.

- The start of Samuel's ministry is both humorous and profound
  - First, we're told again that Samuel is ministering to the Lord before Eli
    - The Hebrew word for boy in v.1 is a word that generally refers to a young man, not a young child
    - Josephus said that Samuel was 12 years old in this moment
    - Young, but at the same time he's been working in this role for sometime now
  - Yet until this point, Samuel hadn't heard from the Lord personally
    - We're told he was ministering to the Lord though, so clearly the young man was

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intent on being a servant of God
        - But until the Lord revealed Himself to Samuel, his service was merely an aspiration
        - And his purpose in service was to fulfill a calling assigned to him by his parents
    - But if Samuel's service was to become genuine, it required a call from the Lord
        - Unless and until the Lord called Samuel and anointed him, his service couldn't fulfill God's purpose
        - His situation is something like that of a child that has been baptized as an infant and is told to go to church
        - And he says his prayers at night and knows the Bible stories by heart
        - But until the Lord places a call on that boy's heart, his acts of piety are works of ritual and obedience to his parents
        - But in time, the Lord will reveal Himself to such a one, and in that moment the heart quickens to serve the Living God
- The Lord is ready to give Samuel a call as a prophet, a man who will hear the voice of the Lord and relate what he learns to men
    - Notice at the end of v.1 we're told this is a time in which men didn't routinely hear from the Lord
        - Visions from the Lord were not absent
        - But they were rare, which means men were living with only the Law and the book of Joshua to guide them
        - And it has been 300 years since Joshua was written
        - Beyond that, the Lord has only revealed His word in moments through judges
    - Now the Lord is going to call Samuel as a prophet, and being a prophet is a thankless, difficult job
        - You have to respond to the word of the Lord no matter when He calls
        - You can't take a day off or tell the Lord you're busy
        - And you have to be willing to tell people things they won't want to hear
        - And you have to place your allegiance to the Lord above human relationships, being willing to leave behind family and friends
        - Remember that few prophets lived out their lives, since most were martyred
- So given Samuel's young age, it makes sense that the Lord's first call upon Samuel would give him an opportunity to see what the prophet's job entails
    - Eli is lying down in his bed located in the tabernacle courtyard
        - As High Priest he essentially lived in the tabernacle compound, which was his home
        - This is long before the high priest became a position of riches and wealth, though we can see the seeds of such thinking in his sons

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        - But in this day the job was more like a fireman, living in the firehouse
    - Meanwhile, Samuel is also sleeping in the tabernacle, probably in the courtyard
        - In v.3 we're told Samuel is in the temple
        - But the Hebrew word for temple is *hekal*, which is better translated "court"
        - So Samuel isn't sleeping inside the Holy Place, since priests were required to remain standing inside the tabernacle
        - Instead, he's sleeping somewhere in the courtyard of the tabernacle, where the ark of the Lord was kept
    - While he sleeps, the Lord calls to Samuel
        - We don't know what that call was like, of course, but it appears to be an audible voice
        - Because Samuel responds as if he's heard Eli calling him
        - Samuel's first response is to say "Here I am"
        - When he gets no further response, he gets up to find Eli, assuming Eli called him
        - At this point, he finds Eli sleeping, and when he wakes Eli, the old man says I didn't call you…go back to sleep
- So far this scene has a comical quality to it, as we see the Lord calling Samuel and Samuel mistaking the voice of the Lord for Eli's voice
    - In fact, the entire exchange happens a second time
        - A second call from the Lord and a second trip to Eli
        - And again, Eli says go back to sleep, it wasn't me
    - As we laugh at the situation, stop and ask yourself why the Lord let this moment develop
        - Notice in the first encounter Samuel immediately responded "Here I am"
        - If the Lord wanted to have a conversation with Samuel, He has His moment
        - The Lord could have avoided any possibility of mistaken identity right then
        - But instead, the Lord says nothing, leading Samuel to get up and investigate
    - Only once Samuel has encountered Eli and returned to his place does the Lord call again
        - And once again the Lord allows the scene to play out without interrupting it
        - Clearly, the Lord is orchestrating this moment for some purpose
        - Can we make some conclusion for what the Lord wants to teach Samuel and us?
- Remember, Samuel is about to receive his call to serve the Lord
    - And this call will lead to Samuel representing the Lord to the people of God
        - He will bring the word of the Lord
        - He will no longer answer to the authority of an earthly priest like Eli

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- The Lord wants Samuel to understand that his instructions will come from a God Who has elected to reveal Himself to one man only
  - Not all men will hear what Samuel hears
  - Not even the High Priest of Israel will hear what the Lord will reveal to Samuel
- What better way to make this clear than to demonstrate to Samuel that no one else is hearing what Samuel is hearing
  - And in a perfect pattern of three, the Lord calls Samuel
  - By the time Samuel realizes this call is from the Lord, he's also been made aware that his call is unique

- Notice in v.7 we're told that Samuel did not yet know the Lord and had not had the word of the Lord revealed to him
  - This phrase raises some interesting questions:
    - Does the comment simply mean Samuel had not yet had a personal encounter with the Lord of the type he's having now?
    - That's a common interpretation, but that interpretation makes the entire statement unnecessary
    - Obviously, Samuel had never heard from the Lord as yet
    - That's the whole point of Chapter 3, and so this statement seems entirely unnecessary if that is its only point
  - Another possibility is that this is the moment that the Lord revealed Himself to Samuel's heart, bringing Samuel saving faith
    - In this interpretation, we view Samuel's earlier dedication in the tabernacle as simply service rendered as a dutiful son
    - He's serving the ritual of the Law without actually knowing the reality of the Living God
    - Under these circumstances, Samuel would be very much like the millions and millions of men and women who have attended churches of one kind or another
    - And have genuflected, prayed, kneeled, and chanted on cue
    - But have no personal relationship with the Lord
  - Perhaps this is the moment of Samuel's calling into faith, a moment like the one Paul had on the road to Damascus
    - Remember, Paul was a Pharisee of Pharisees, as he put it
    - He was the pre-eminent student in Judaism
    - Paul would have put even Samuel to shame
  - And yet Paul didn't know the Lord in his heart
    - It required that Paul encounter the Word on the road, to truly answer His call
    - And remember, when Paul received his call he responded to the voice yet wasn't even sure Who he was answering

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        - But it was the moment the Lord revealed Himself to a man who had been supposedly serving God all his life
- And what did it take to bring both Paul and Samuel into the Light? As v.7 says, it required that the word of the Lord be revealed to both
    - In Paul's day, the Word had already become flesh, and so Paul's exposure to the word came in the Person of the Risen Lord Himself
        - But in Samuel's day, the Lord was still called the Angel of the Lord
        - And so Samuel is going to have an encounter with the Lord in this form

1Sam. 3:8 So the LORD called Samuel again for the third time. And he arose and went to Eli and said, "Here I am, for you called me." Then Eli discerned that the LORD was calling the boy.
1Sam. 3:9 And Eli said to Samuel, "Go lie down, and it shall be if He calls you, that you shall say, 'Speak, LORD, for Your servant is listening.'" So Samuel went and lay down in his place.
1Sam. 3:10 Then the LORD came and stood and called as at other times, "Samuel! Samuel!" And Samuel said, "Speak, for Your servant is listening."
1Sam. 3:11 The LORD said to Samuel, "Behold, I am about to do a thing in Israel at which both ears of everyone who hears it will tingle.
1Sam. 3:12 "In that day I will carry out against Eli all that I have spoken concerning his house, from beginning to end.
1Sam. 3:13 "For I have told him that I am about to judge his house forever for the iniquity which he knew, because his sons brought a curse on themselves and he did not rebuke them.
1Sam. 3:14 "Therefore I have sworn to the house of Eli that the iniquity of Eli's house shall not be atoned for by sacrifice or offering forever."

- On the third occasion, the Lord calls Samuel and once more Samuel goes to Eli
    - Samuel must have thought that Eli was playing a trick on him
        - We should note that Samuel's patient heart of service is evident in this moment
        - Who among us would show this much patience under the same circumstances?
        - Wouldn't we start to show frustration at this point?
        - Or perhaps we would just stay in bed assuming it's a prank?
    - But young Samuel is so dedicated to service that he gets up each and every time he's heard a voice and returns to Eli without complaint
        - And Eli must have known Samuel's heart for service
        - So when Samuel returns a third time, Eli suspects something else is going on, since he knows the boy wouldn't be playing
        - And he comes to realize the Lord is speaking to Samuel

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    - Given how rare it was to hear the Lord's voice, you have to wonder if Eli was surprised by this encounter
        - Or perhaps the earlier visit from the oracle was intended to get Eli's attention
        - And because he had recently heard from the Lord, perhaps he was more sensitive to that possibility
- In any case, Eli tells Samuel to go back and lay down and when the voice returns, say "Here I am Lord" and then listen
    - Eli gives instructions like he's been there before himself
        - When Samuel returns, sure enough the Lord responds
        - And Samuel has his encounter with the Word of the Lord
    - Once again, why didn't the Lord just begin with His message in the first encounter?
        - We already said the Lord wanted Samuel to appreciate that he was receiving something uniquely appointed
        - But this call and response pattern is also an important detail to the story
        - Samuel needed to learn to hear the Lord's call and recognize it
        - Not because the Lord is incapable of making Himself heard
        - But because He is intent on training His servant to know Him intimately
    - Samuel didn't know the Lord, but it was time he came to know Him
        - And that process of coming to know the Lord begins with a call from the Lord to those the Lord selects to hear
        - And then once the time arrives to hear, the word of God opens the ears and the called will hear and respond
        - And so Samuel awaits the call, and then only when he hears the call and responds does the Lord reveal Himself
        - As Paul says

Rom. 10:17 **So faith comes from hearing, and hearing by the word of Christ.**

- At this point the Lord gives Samuel his first "word from the Lord"
- The Lord's first words to Samuel aren't an explanation for Who He is or what's happening
    - There's no "Hello Samuel, I'm the Lord"
    - If you remember in Acts when Saul meets the Lord on the road, Jesus doesn't make introductions either
    - When the Lord steps into our lives and calls us into a relationship with Him, He needs not introduce Himself
    - His revelation of Himself is sufficient to bring us into the family of God
    - As Paul said elsewhere:

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2Cor. 4:6 **For God, who said, "Light shall shine out of darkness," is the One who has shone in our hearts to give the Light of the knowledge of the glory of God in the face of Christ.**

- Samuel has had the Light of Christ shined into his heart, and now he's in a relationship with the Living God
  - Since the relationship is established, it's time to get down to business
  - Once we enter into that relationship, the expectation is that we immediately begin to serve the Lord
  - As Jesus said to Peter and Andrew

Matt. 4:18 **Now as Jesus was walking by the Sea of Galilee, He saw two brothers, Simon who was called Peter, and Andrew his brother, casting a net into the sea; for they were fishermen.**
Matt. 4:19 **And He said to them, "Follow Me, and I will make you fishers of men."**
Matt. 4:20 **Immediately they left their nets and followed Him.**

- For Samuel, the first assignment is not a pleasant one
  - The Lord tells Samuel He is prepared to do something so remarkable in Israel that people who hear about it will be amazed
    - This phrase is more than just hyperbole
    - It's a marker to indicate what news the Lord is preparing to bring
    - We know it includes the revelation about Eli's family
    - But it goes beyond that detail
  - The Lord is looking beyond this single moment of revelation
    - He's referring to the revelation that a monarchy is going to be established in Israel
    - How do we know that?
    - Because this comment about ears tingling only occurs one other place in the Bible, in Jeremiah 19 (quoted again in 2 Kings 21)

Jer. 19:1 **Thus says the LORD, "Go and buy a potter's earthenware jar, and take some of the elders of the people and some of the senior priests.**
Jer. 19:2 **"Then go out to the valley of Ben-hinnom, which is by the entrance of the potsherd gate, and proclaim there the words that I tell you,**
Jer. 19:3 **and say, 'Hear the word of the LORD, O kings of Judah and inhabitants of Jerusalem: thus says the LORD of hosts, the God of Israel, "Behold I am about to bring a calamity upon this place, at which the ears of everyone that hears of it will tingle.**

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Jer. 19:4 "Because they have forsaken Me and have made this an alien place and have burned sacrifices in it to other gods, that neither they nor their forefathers nor the kings of Judah had ever known, and because they have filled this place with the blood of the innocent
Jer. 19:5 and have built the high places of Baal to burn their sons in the fire as burnt offerings to Baal, a thing which I never commanded or spoke of, nor did it ever enter My mind;
Jer. 19:6 therefore, behold, days are coming," declares the LORD, "when this place will no longer be called Topheth or the valley of Ben-hinnom, but rather the valley of Slaughter.

- In this passage the Lord declares the end of the Jewish monarchy
  - Just as it began with Samuel with ears excited at the news
  - So it will end with ears shocked by the revelation that Israel will cease having a king
  - Until the Messiah comes, that is
  - No man apart from Christ will ever rule as king over Israel
  - Some like Antiochus and Herod have tried, but they were not legitimate nor did their reign last
- So the Lord's announcement is an allusion to greater things to come beyond this single revelation concerning Eli
  - The Lord tells Samuel that there is big news coming and he's the man who will deliver it to Israel
    - But before we get to all that, the Lord needs Samuel to deliver Eli a personal message
    - Eli gets confirmation that he and his sons are going to be cut off
    - Notice in v.12 the Lord says that everything He's already spoken concerning Eli is going to happen
    - So this is not new information for Eli…it's a confirmation
    - He repeats that Eli's house will have no opportunity for atonement for these sins but they will have a curse placed on them
  - Once again, we wonder why the Lord needed Samuel to deliver this confirmation to Eli?
    - First, Eli is the high priest, so the Lord could have spoken to Eli directly
    - Secondly, the Lord has already revealed this truth to Eli through an earlier prophet so why bother repeating Himself through Samuel?
  - The answer has little to do with Eli and everything to do with Samuel
    - This is Samuel's opportunity to practice delivering bad news to people who won't like to hear it
    - This will take courage and it will teach him a lesson about serving God rather

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than pleasing men
        - When the Lord says speak, we speak
        - And whatever response the word of the Lord generates is the intended reaction the Lord wanted
        - We can't control it nor should we attempt to soften it
- Today, believers aren't arrested at night with a "word from the Lord", since Hebrews tells us that the counsel of God is complete in Christ through His word
    - But we have a similar challenge when we're tasked to share what we know from the word
        - There are many places in scripture that won't please those we might share it with
        - People won't like to hear what the Bible says about sin, especially sin that society has embraced and determined is acceptable
        - People don't like to learn that Hell is a real place that real people go when they die in their sins
        - And people don't like to know that they aren't OK the way they are and that they must repent
    - But these messages, and many more truths, are the word we've been told to share with the world
        - The same word that condemns sin also proclaims the good news of salvation
        - The same word that speaks of Hell offers the promise of Heaven
        - The same word that convicts us saves us
    - We need to learn the lesson that the Lord is working to teach Samuel
        - We take what the Lord gives us and we share it without editing and without fear
        - The Lord in His wisdom has determined this is the one right message
        - We do not have liberty to change it or hide it
- This was the situation Samuel faced at this moment…does he dare share this news with his surrogate father and the high priest of Israel?
    - What will be the repercussions? What might the High Priest do to Samuel when he hears this statement?
        - As we watch what Samuel does, remember he's likely about 12 years old
        - And Eli's sons are fully grown and ruthless
    - This is a test of Samuel's heart to speak the word of the Lord without concern for the personal consequences
        - This is a test for every prophet
        - But we're getting a chance to see how the Lord trains His prophets for this difficult assignment

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1Sam. 3:15 So Samuel lay down until morning. Then he opened the doors of the house of the LORD. But Samuel was afraid to tell the vision to Eli.
1Sam. 3:16 Then Eli called Samuel and said, "Samuel, my son." And he said, "Here I am."
1Sam. 3:17 He said, "What is the word that He spoke to you? Please do not hide it from me. May God do so to you, and more also, if you hide anything from me of all the words that He spoke to you."
1Sam. 3:18 So Samuel told him everything and hid nothing from him. And he said, "It is the LORD; let Him do what seems good to Him."

- Smartly, Samuel decides he's probably woken Eli one too many times already tonight
  - Probably better to save this news until morning, so Samuel goes back to sleep
    - But when morning comes, Samuel isn't feeling much more like sharing what he's learned
    - Nevertheless, he got up and begun the duty of the day
    - And naturally Eli eventually encounters Samuel
  - Eli asks Samuel to share the news, which we can see as a measure of God's grace to prompt Samuel to do the right thing
    - Confronted with the question, Samuel has little choice but to answer Eli
    - In fact, Eli pronounces his own prophecy on Samuel
    - That if Samuel isn't willing to share the word the Lord gave him, then the things God proclaimed would come upon Samuel
    - Clearly Eli could tell Samuel had bad news he was reluctant to share, which made Eli all the more curious to hear it
  - So Samuel shares the news the Lord commanded him to share, and Eli's reaction is nothing like Samuel expects
    - As we said last week, when a man hears the Lord is prepared to take the lives of his sons, we might expect him to react with more concern or passion
    - But Eli seems either indifferent or simply resigned to what's coming
    - But at the very least, we see no indication of repentance in Eli
- Eli is a man who is old, tired and weary under the burden of serving
  - He has raised two sons who have no regard for the Lord and who despise the priesthood
    - His sons will die
    - His family will be cut off from the priesthood
    - And he will live out his remaining days with the burden of knowing what the Lord has planned
  - The only blessing in his life was a young man that the Lord entrusted into his care for a few years, and now even that man is a source of pain

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        - Not for who is or what he does but for what the Lord says through him
        - Such is the life of a prophet
        - They bring the word of the Lord, good news to those who love the Lord and serve Him obediently
        - But sorrow to those who are far from the Lord
    - And as is usually the case, those who are in power are those who know the sorrow of the Lord's word
        - And as a result, they are prone to bringing persecution against the Lord's prophet
        - Samuel will be spared much of that persecution
        - But later prophets will not be so fortunate
        - And in fact, from Samuel to Christ, the Lord's prophets are increasingly persecuted for they minister to an increasingly apostate people
- Meanwhile, the young Samuel has just begun his work for the Lord

1Sam. 3:19 **Thus Samuel grew and the LORD was with him and let none of his words fail.**
1Sam. 3:20 **All Israel from Dan even to Beersheba knew that Samuel was confirmed as a prophet of the LORD.**
1Sam. 3:21 **And the LORD appeared again at Shiloh, because the LORD revealed Himself to Samuel at Shiloh by the word of the LORD.**

- Samuel grew to adulthood, and the Lord was with him and let none of Samuel's words fail
    - This means that every time the Lord gave Samuel a word to share, the word Samuel spoke came to pass as the Lord promised
        - And Samuel says specifically that the Lord let none of his words fail (literally: fall to the ground, as in an arrow that misses)
        - So Samuel was always 100% accurate in his prophecy
        - This is important, because this is the biblical test for anyone who calls themselves a prophet
    - In Deuteronomy 18, Israel was told that the only legitimate prophet is one that is never wrong

Deut. 18:17 **"The LORD said to me, 'They have spoken well.**
Deut. 18:18 **'I will raise up a prophet from among their countrymen like you, and I will put My words in his mouth, and he shall speak to them all that I command him.**
Deut. 18:19 **'It shall come about that whoever will not listen to My words which he**

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shall speak in My name, I Myself will require it of him.
Deut. 18:20 **'But the prophet who speaks a word presumptuously in My name which I have not commanded him to speak, or which he speaks in the name of other gods, that prophet shall die.'**
Deut. 18:21 **"You may say in your heart, 'How will we know the word which the LORD has not spoken?'**
Deut. 18:22 **"When a prophet speaks in the name of the LORD, if the thing does not come about or come true, that is the thing which the LORD has not spoken. The prophet has spoken it presumptuously; you shall not be afraid of him.**

- The Lord promised Israel would receive a Prophet, Who was to be Christ
- But of course other prophets would also arise before the Messiah appeared, and the test is the same for all of them
- When they speak from the Lord, everyone must listen to the prophet
- If they reject the word of the Lord, the Lord will reject them
- But then the Lord anticipates the people's question of how do we tell the difference between a true prophet and a false prophet?
    - The answer the Lord gives is: perfection
    - If something the prophet says does not come to pass, they are showing themselves to be a false prophet
    - You shall not fear such a person, meaning you can safely ignore what he says, since he isn't speaking with the authority of God
- Elsewhere, the Lord says such a person must be put to death because they were not a prophet at all
    - Essentially, the rule is someone is either 100% perfect in his pronouncements or else he was always 100% fraud
    - No true prophet is ever wrong
- So Samuel's own testimony to the legitimacy of his office is his perfect record of prediction
    - And that perfect record spreads as news throughout Israel
        - From Dan, which was the northern most tribe
        - To Beersheba, the Southern most city in the land
        - Everyone knew and accepted Samuel's authority as a prophet
    - Given how long it had been since the people had been given a prophet (over 300 years), this must have been a dramatic development for the people
        - When the Lord steps out of 300 years of virtual silence and provide a prophet, you have to wonder what's coming
        - And there were big changes coming for the people
        - But those changes are foreshadowed by events with the Ark

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- Which Samuel introduces in v.21 – which takes us to Chapter 4 next week

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- Our introduction to Samuel is complete and we're ready to follow the man into his career as judge and prophet of Israel
  - The young man is now grown
    - He is a prophet and he is judging Israel alongside Samson at this time
    - But Israel's age of judges is drawing to a close
    - And the dawn of a new period is here
  - The seeds of that change will be sown in the events of Chapters 4-6, which cover the wanderings of the Ark
    - The Ark features prominently throughout the books of Samuel
    - The Ark's circumstances serve to illustrate a key deficit in Jewish society
    - Over the past 300 years, the people of Israel have forgotten the power and authority of the Lord Who rules and guides His people
    - The days of Moses and Joshua are a distant memory
    - And in their place, the people now think only of themselves and their place in the world in terms no different than the surrounding cultures
  - As we've seen with Eli and his sons, the tabernacle in Shiloh and the sacrificial system centered on that modest building are merely ritual for many
    - The judges are viewed principally as military captains
    - And Jewish society has lost virtually any concept of God present among them, much less ruling over them
- But the Lord is still faithful despite the unfaithfulness of the people
  - So He's about to reassert Himself among the people by means of the most visible evidence of His presence and power within Israel
    - The Ark is the visible evidence of God dwelling with His people
    - When it sits in the Holy of Holies, it supports the glory of God
    - And wherever it goes, it displays God's power among the nations
  - But Israel has long ago departed from an understanding of the Ark's true purpose and meaning
    - So in these days, the Ark is little more than a religious relic
    - It has become mystical rather than meaningful
    - As happens any time men move from relationship to religion
    - From worshipping God to worshipping images
- So the next three chapters show the people of God acting as pagans, while the neighboring pagans recognize the work of the living God

1Sam. 3:21 **And the LORD appeared again at Shiloh, because the LORD revealed Himself to Samuel at Shiloh by the word of the LORD.**
1Sam. 4:1 **Thus the word of Samuel came to all Israel. Now Israel went out to**

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meet the Philistines in battle and camped beside Ebenezer while the Philistines camped in Aphek.
1Sam. 4:2 **The Philistines drew up in battle array to meet Israel. When the battle spread, Israel was defeated before the Philistines who killed about four thousand men on the battlefield.**
1Sam. 4:3 **When the people came into the camp, the elders of Israel said, "Why has the LORD defeated us today before the Philistines? Let us take to ourselves from Shiloh the ark of the covenant of the LORD, that it may come among us and deliver us from the power of our enemies."**
1Sam. 4:4 **So the people sent to Shiloh, and from there they carried the ark of the covenant of the LORD of hosts who sits above the cherubim; and the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, were there with the ark of the covenant of God.**

- The transition into our story happens at the end of Chapter 3, when we're told the Lord appears to Samuel at Shiloh again
  - The Lord appeared to Samuel as a boy earlier in Chapter 3
    - And thereafter, the Lord continued to make Himself known to Samuel as he ministered in the tabernacle
    - During this time the Lord is revealing His word to Samuel such that what Samuel would speak became equivalent to the Lord's word
  - Notice in v.1 that the word of the Lord has now just become the word of Samuel
    - The Lord's will and purposes are now being made known among His people through His word given to a prophet in Shiloh
    - This is the first time the Lord has spoken in this way for over 300 years
    - Remember, Samson is still ruling Israel as a judge
    - But it's Samuel that is speaking for the Lord in this time
- Meanwhile, the people of Israel are thinking and acting as if the Lord's will is a mystery no one can solve
  - At the end of v.1 Israel is in conflict with the Philistines, who control the western plains of Canaan
    - The Philistines were fierce enemies of Israel in the land
    - They were a people group that originated from Crete in present-day Greece
    - They sailed their way to Canaan as early as Abraham's time
    - But the Philistines didn't take over large portions of western Canaan until about 1200 BC, 100 years before this time
  - They lived principally in five city-states along the sea plain
    - Ashdod, Ashkelon, Gaza, Gath, Ekron
    - You may remember that the Lord directed Israel away from the Philistines when He directed them into the land after the Exodus

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        - They were a strong warring people
        - Samson spent much of his time as judge in war with the Philistines
        - They were eventually defeated by Hezekiah
- But at this point, they are a very strong people, and the Lord is giving them a measure of success against the people of Israel
    - Their success is in keeping with the recurring pattern throughout the period of the judges
        - Israel sins against the Lord in practicing idolatry
        - The Lord responds by punishing Israel at the hands of their enemies
        - Then when the people have come to repent and call upon the name of the Lord, He relents by raising up a judge to free the people
        - Ultimately, that judge restores peace for a time
    - But from judge to judge, the cycle deteriorates
        - The people become increasingly pagan
        - The judges become increasingly ungodly even as they serve the Lord's purposes
        - And after each reinstatement, Israel's ungodliness is more ungodly than the last
        - It's a downward spiral
- Now during Samson, the Lord is chastising the people under the Philistines
    - At the end of v.1, the Israelite army meets the Philistines in battle near Aphek
        - This town is located in the eastern edge of the Jezreel valley just north of Carmel
        - It defined the northern border between the two nations
        - And this battle was a disaster for Israel
    - In v.2 we're told that the Philistines defeated Israel killing 4,000 men
        - The people of Israel limp back to Shiloh with their tails between their legs
        - And then begins the review process
    - Notice Israel asks the right question
        - Why did the Lord let Israel lose?
        - They recognize that their fortunes turn on the Lord's providence
        - If they lose, it means the Lord has withheld His blessing from the battle
    - This was the right question for them to ask and it's the right question we need to ask in our lives
        - There is no moment of our life that isn't under the Lord's providence
        - When trials and disappointments come our way, we need to conduct a similar kind of soul searching
        - Why is the Lord allowing this to happen?

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        - And more specifically, what are we to gain or learn from this trial?
        - Since we know the Lord is about accomplishing good in our lives
- Israel asks the right question, but they don't arrive at the right answer
    - They assume that they haven't been harnessing the power of God properly
        - They propose taking the Ark of the Covenant out of the Holy of Holies and carrying it with them into the battle
        - They use the Ark like a pagan idol
        - This is a perfect picture of how unbelieving people relate to the power of God
        - It's mystical, magical, and something we can manipulate
    - The correct answer to the question was, God is disciplining us for our sin and we must repent to restore fellowship with Him
        - And when we repent, the Lord will restore us in fellowship according to His mercy and His faithfulness to His covenant
        - In other words, the correct answer recognized they needed a God-centered solution for a man-centered problem
        - Instead, they assumed they had a God-centered problem they could solve with a man-centered response
        - God was too far away from the battle
        - In reality, it was Israel that was far from God
- The real irony of their situation is that they came to Shiloh to get God, but they completely missed Him
    - Samuel tells us that God was speaking to Israel from Shiloh through the prophet
        - If the people wanted to know why the Lord let them lose the battle, they only needed to hear the word of the Lord
        - They travel back to Shiloh, they ask the right question, but they don't seek the answer in the right place
        - They chose the symbols of God over the word of God
    - And of course, we need not look very hard in our own culture to see this same mistake repeated countless times, both inside the church and out
        - Certainly, many false religions, including those claiming to be Christian, have set the word of God aside
        - And in its place these groups have substituted their own views of God
        - In particular, they approach God like a genie, living in a lamp
        - If only they come close to the objects of their faith, saying the right words, making the right gestures, then they will appease God
        - They repeat the mistake of these Israelites
    - Even Christians can fall into this wrong thinking, becoming victims of thinking that moves to a man-centered view of our relationship with God

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        - Our walk with Christ becomes more superstition than Spirit-led
        - We carry crosses, we pause for a moment before a painting of "Jesus" on the church wall
        - We display ornate, unread Bibles on cloth-covered tables
        - We recite obscure prayers hidden deep in the Old Testament assuming they contain special power
        - We bake "Ezekiel bread" or keep certain Jewish feasts
        - We speak in certain ways, sing certain hymns, and only the King James Version, please…
    - In every case, we're reducing God to something we can control and manipulate to our own desires
        - Icons replace insight and relics replace relationship
        - So we can bend God's will to our needs, or so we think
        - When instead we should be bending our will to meet God's standards for holiness and obedience
        - And those standards are made clear to us in His word
- That's the contrast Samuel is emphasizing here…the Lord is ready to speak and lead His people through His anointed prophet, but they aren't listening
    - And who is leading the people into the tabernacle to claim the Ark?
        - None other than Eli's corrupt sons
        - They move the Ark from its place and the people are thrilled to have it working for them, or so they think

1Sam. 4:5 As the ark of the covenant of the LORD came into the camp, all Israel shouted with a great shout, so that the earth resounded.
1Sam. 4:6 When the Philistines heard the noise of the shout, they said, "What does the noise of this great shout in the camp of the Hebrews mean?" Then they understood that the ark of the LORD had come into the camp.
1Sam. 4:7 The Philistines were afraid, for they said, "God has come into the camp." And they said, "Woe to us! For nothing like this has happened before.
1Sam. 4:8 "Woe to us! Who shall deliver us from the hand of these mighty gods? These are the gods who smote the Egyptians with all kinds of plagues in the wilderness.
1Sam. 4:9 "Take courage and be men, O Philistines, or you will become slaves to the Hebrews, as they have been slaves to you; therefore, be men and fight."

- Notice how the Philistines responded?
    - They hear the shouting of the people and make inquiries to know what the yelling was about

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        - Somehow, probably by spies, they learn that the people had retrieved the very same Ark that Israel had carried from Egypt
        - It's been nearly 400 years since the people entered the land, but still the Philistines remember what the Lord did in freeing Israel
        - They declare woe to us because they have never experienced dread like this before
        - If the Lord of Israel could wipe out powerful Egypt then certainly the Philistine army stood no hope of winning, right?
    - Isn't it interesting that the Philistines react with reverence and awe in remembering the great things God has done for Israel in the past
        - They are the pagans in this story
        - They are the ones who should be overlooking the power of God in His true form and relying on idols
        - And yet it's the pagans who respect the power of the Living God
        - While the people of God have casually invaded the Holy of Holies and violated God's law by removing the Ark against God's instructions
        - It's God's people that are treating Yahweh as a relic, while the pagans display fear of the Lord
    - Samuel's narration is intended by the author to draw our attention back to the Jews' victory at Jericho
        - In that battle, Israel followed the Lord's orders to carry the Ark around the city seven times
        - And the people were to shout to raze the walls of the city
        - So here again the people carry the Ark and the people shout
        - They are repeating the instructions of the Lord, except these instructions weren't given to them
- This is a classic mistake of God's people, and it's repeated down to this very day
    - We take words the Lord gave to another people in another time and we appropriate them for ourselves
        - We like what God said in the past
        - We view it as a recipe, something we can reuse like watching a rerun on TV
        - And we assume if we do what God told someone else to do, we will get the same results that someone else got
        - In this case, the people assume that if carrying the Ark and shouting defeated Jericho, then it will work against the Philistines
    - Once again, this thinking requires taking the living word of the Living God and turning it into ritual and superstition
        - God speaks to people with specific intent for specific reasons
        - And unless He states that His words are true for all men and all time, then we

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are not free to assume as much

- For example, I've been asked if God is obligated to save an entire household after one member of the family comes to Christ
- When I've asked why someone thinks this will happen, they point to the story of Cornelius in Acts 10-11
- In that story we're told how Peter heard that the Lord intended to save Cornelius and all his household

- Obviously, this is an example of the same kind of misuse of scripture
  - The fact that the Lord intended to save all Cornelius' family doesn't become a prescription for how the Lord will move in every family
  - Similarly the fact that the Lord chose to defeat Jericho with His Ark and the people shouting, doesn't make that method a prescription for defeating armies
  - To see the Israelites misusing the Lord's instructions in this way proves they are far from Him and are not accustomed to His word

- In v.9 the Philistines try to shore up the courage of the troops saying they must be tough or else become slaves of Israel
  - Here we see the limits of their faith in Yahweh
    - They acknowledge His power but they still assume that a courageous and determined army can beat Israel and their God
    - So clearly the Philistines are not bowing their knees to the Living God
    - And in that regard, they are no different from Israel itself
- Of course God wasn't about to reward the Israelites' sin in removing the Ark with a victory in the battle

1Sam. 4:10 So the Philistines fought and Israel was defeated, and every man fled to his tent; and the slaughter was very great, for there fell of Israel thirty thousand foot soldiers.
1Sam. 4:11 And the ark of God was taken; and the two sons of Eli, Hophni and Phinehas, died.

- Once again, the Philistines defeat the Israelite army
  - We don't know where this battle took place exactly, but it appears to have taken place within a short walk from Shiloh (see v.12)
    - Not a man in Israel could stand in the battle that day
    - Everyone ran and when you're running, you can't defend yourself
    - Exactly 30,000 Jewish men died in battle that day
  - The number 3 stands out to reminds us Who permitted this slaughter
    - In fact, the magnitude of this loss was far greater than the previous loss

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        - Which in itself proved that the Lord was not with the people
    - Also dying in this battle were both sons of Eli
        - They must have accompanied the Ark into the battle and then been caught up in the resulting melee
        - In fact, we can assume they were the priests who entered the Holy of Holies to retrieve the Ark in the first place
        - Their death is fulfillment of the Lord's promise to Eli that both his sons would die on the same day
    - And God even orchestrated the circumstances of their death so that no one would have reason to debate the justification for God's actions
        - Not that He needed any additional justification for taking their lives
        - I'm sure few tears were shed in Israel for their passing
- More importantly, the Lord allowed the Philistines to capture the Ark
    - Clearly, the Lord is permitting the Ark to leave Israel for a good reason
        - The Philistines couldn't have captured the Ark unless the Lord permitted
        - And it soon becomes apparent what the Lord is at work to accomplish
    - Beginning with some unfinished business with Eli

1Sam. 4:12 Now a man of Benjamin ran from the battle line and came to Shiloh the same day with his clothes torn and dust on his head.
1Sam. 4:13 When he came, behold, Eli was sitting on his seat by the road eagerly watching, because his heart was trembling for the ark of God. So the man came to tell it in the city, and all the city cried out.
1Sam. 4:14 When Eli heard the noise of the outcry, he said, "What does the noise of this commotion mean?" Then the man came hurriedly and told Eli.
1Sam. 4:15 Now Eli was ninety-eight years old, and his eyes were set so that he could not see.
1Sam. 4:16 The man said to Eli, "I am the one who came from the battle line. Indeed, I escaped from the battle line today." And he said, "How did things go, my son?"
1Sam. 4:17 Then the one who brought the news replied, "Israel has fled before the Philistines and there has also been a great slaughter among the people, and your two sons also, Hophni and Phinehas, are dead, and the ark of God has been taken."
1Sam. 4:18 When he mentioned the ark of God, Eli fell off the seat backward beside the gate, and his neck was broken and he died, for he was old and heavy. Thus he judged Israel forty years.
1Sam. 4:19 Now his daughter-in-law, Phinehas's wife, was pregnant and about to give birth; and when she heard the news that the ark of God was taken and that her father-in-law and her husband had died, she kneeled down and gave birth,

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for her pains came upon her.
1Sam. 4:20 **And about the time of her death the women who stood by her said to her, "Do not be afraid, for you have given birth to a son." But she did not answer or pay attention.**
1Sam. 4:21 **And she called the boy Ichabod, saying, "The glory has departed from Israel," because the ark of God was taken and because of her father-in-law and her husband.**
1Sam. 4:22 **She said, "The glory has departed from Israel, for the ark of God was taken."**

- A Benjamite survives the battle to return and report the result to High Priest, Eli
  - He is clearly disheveled and looks like a defeated soldier
    - He finds Eli on the road waiting to hear the news
    - Eli has heard the battle commotion and is wondering how Israel fared
    - Notice he's particularly worried about the Ark
    - Like a father who lends his prized sports car to his newly licensed teenage son
    - He's more worried about the car than he is about his son
  - When the soldier comes, he explains what's happened
    - He explains he came from the battle lines
    - And in short, Israel has lost a great battle
    - In fact Eli's two sons are both dead
  - Finally, the soldier says the Philistines have captured the Ark of the Lord
    - At the news of the Ark, Eli falls backward beside the gate
    - The gate refers to the multi-chambered entrance to a walled city
    - To sit by the gate probably meant Eli was seated on the top of the wall of the city at the gate, where people could get a good look at the battle in the distance
- When Eli hears the news of the Ark's capture, he appears to pass out in shock
  - And as he falls backward, he lands on the ground and breaks his neck and dies
    - Interestingly, Samuel says Eli was old and "heavy"
    - Heavy would mean the man was overweight, which seems to be a commentary by Samuel on Eli's self-indulgence
    - Which is something we've seen in his raising of his sons
  - But there is an interesting word play in Hebrew at work here too
    - The Hebrew word for heavy is *kaved*
    - Later in v.21 we're told that the glory of the Lord has departed from the tabernacle, as indeed it has with the departing of the Ark
    - The Hebrew word for glory is *kavod*

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- So the juxtapositioning of these two very similar words in the narrative make a commentary on Eli's reign as High Priest
  - Eli made himself *kaved* rather than giving the Lord *kavod*
  - In a sense Eli took the glory for himself rather than using his position to give the Lord glory
  - And so on the same day Eli lost everything, Israel lost the glory of the Lord

- Here's one more time for us to remember that the priority in any ministry is to glorify the Lord, not to enrich ourselves or impress others
  - And these goals are mutually exclusive
    - When we seek to serve ourselves, we necessarily stop serving God
    - He stops benefitting from our service and we stop receiving His pleasure
  - We need to apply this standard to those who serve us as well
    - If a man or woman is intent on serving themselves instead of serving God, it will be apparent
    - And when we detect this turn, we need to use discernment and look elsewhere for spiritual counsel
  - Notice that Eli reacted to the news of the Ark, not to the news of his sons
    - It would seem to confirm for us that Eli was not particularly attached to his sons
    - Perhaps later in life he had come to realize the kind of sons he had raised
    - Perhaps he had regrets that they were a source of dishonor to the Lord
    - Nevertheless, it was too late for Eli and his family
- The final episode in the family story is Eli's daughter-in-law, Phinehas' wife
  - Notice she is never named in this short account
    - That in itself tells us that she is not important to the story except in her words
    - She was pregnant during this time
    - And as she hears the disturbing news of her husband and father-in-law's death, she gives birth prematurely
    - Josephus reported that she gave birth at seven months
    - And in giving birth, we're told in v.20 that the mother dies
  - Before she dies she names her son Ichabod, which means literally "no glory" in Hebrew, reflecting the departure of the glory from the tabernacle
    - The glory of the Lord has indeed departed
    - And it will not return until Solomon builds the temple and returns the Ark to the Holy of Holies
- Though this girl speaks correctly, in a sense she is also repeating the error of all Israel
  - She has associated the presence of the Lord in Israel with a physical object
    - She is saying that the Lord is absent Israel because an artifact has been

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removed
        - Like those who believe the Lord only lives inside Church buildings
    - So this girl is lamenting the departure of God and feeling far from God
        - But it's been said that if you feel far from God, it's not the Lord Who has moved
        - The Lord is still with Israel
        - But Israel has departed from the Lord
        - And they are suffering the trials of a people who have become so distant from the Lord that they treat Him as a relic
- In stark contrast with the pagan approach of the apostate Israelites, the Philistines are about to have a very personal encounter with the living God

1Sam. 5:1 Now the Philistines took the ark of God and brought it from Ebenezer to Ashdod.
1Sam. 5:2 Then the Philistines took the ark of God and brought it to the house of Dagon and set it by Dagon.
1Sam. 5:3 When the Ashdodites arose early the next morning, behold, Dagon had fallen on his face to the ground before the ark of the LORD. So they took Dagon and set him in his place again.
1Sam. 5:4 But when they arose early the next morning, behold, Dagon had fallen on his face to the ground before the ark of the LORD. And the head of Dagon and both the palms of his hands were cut off on the threshold; only the trunk of Dagon was left to him.
1Sam. 5:5 Therefore neither the priests of Dagon nor all who enter Dagon's house tread on the threshold of Dagon in Ashdod to this day.
1Sam. 5:6 Now the hand of the LORD was heavy on the Ashdodites, and He ravaged them and smote them with tumors, both Ashdod and its territories.
1Sam. 5:7 When the men of Ashdod saw that it was so, they said, "The ark of the God of Israel must not remain with us, for His hand is severe on us and on Dagon our god."
1Sam. 5:8 So they sent and gathered all the lords of the Philistines to them and said, "What shall we do with the ark of the God of Israel?" And they said, "Let the ark of the God of Israel be brought around to Gath." And they brought the ark of the God of Israel around.
1Sam. 5:9 After they had brought it around, the hand of the LORD was against the city with very great confusion; and He smote the men of the city, both young and old, so that tumors broke out on them.
1Sam. 5:10 So they sent the ark of God to Ekron. And as the ark of God came to Ekron the Ekronites cried out, saying, "They have brought the ark of the God of Israel around to us, to kill us and our people."
1Sam. 5:11 They sent therefore and gathered all the lords of the Philistines and said, "Send away the ark of the God of Israel, and let it return to its own place,

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so that it will not kill us and our people." For there was a deadly confusion throughout the city; the hand of God was very heavy there.
1Sam. 5:12 **And the men who did not die were smitten with tumors and the cry of the city went up to heaven.**

- This chapter doesn't require much explanation, though there is probably a lot we could say about it
  - In summary, the Ark goes on a tour of the Philistine cities
    - It moves from near Shiloh directly west past Aphek to the sea
    - Then it moves down the Via Mars to Ashdod
  - The Ashdodites decided this war booty should be placed in the temple dedicated to their god Dagon
    - Dagon was the fertility god of the Philistines
    - He is pictured as part man, part fish
    - In fact, the word *dag* in Hebrew means fishy part
    - He was the god of grain and was responsible for giving bountiful harvest
    - Like most false gods, he originated among people in Mesopotamia – the home ground of Satan
  - When the Ark is placed in Dagon's temple, the Lord knocks the Dagon idol over during the night
    - The idol is placed on its face, which is a position of worship
    - These idols were typically quite large, standing tens of feet hight
    - So it was no small matter to find this idol on the ground
  - The Philistines are shocked to find their so-called god worshipping the God of Israel, so they place it back in position
    - The next night the Lord repeats the process
    - Only the second time, the Lord removes the head and hands of the statue
    - This symbolizes the removal of the authority and power of this idol
    - From this point forward the priest of this false god wouldn't dare enter into the temple of this idol, leaving it empty
- At this point, we begin to see the Lord acting again in the narrative
  - Up to this point, the Lord has been understood to be working behind the scenes
    - He's withholding His blessing in Israel
    - And He removed His glory from the tabernacle
    - But He's not seen as actively working until now
  - At this point, He begins to take His anger out on the Philistines
    - In Ashdod the Lord brings a plague of tumors against the people in the city

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        - The Hebrew word for tumors comes from a root word that means “to swell”
    - This could be almost any kind of swelling
        - But the in v.9 the Hebrew word for “broke out” refers to the groin area specifically
        - So it’s likely the Lord is sending a plague of hemorrhoids upon the people
        - This is a serious problem
- Somehow the leaders of the city determine that this curse is the result of the Hebrew God
    - So they quickly determine the Ark needs to go
        - Rather than send it back to Israel, the caring Philistines decide to send it on to their fellow Philistines
        - They determine to send it to Gath, the southernmost Philistine city
    - Very quickly, the citizens of Gath likewise find it difficult to sit down
        - So then the Ark is off again to Ekron
        - And the news of the Ark precedes it, so that even as the Ark is being delivered to Ekron, the people are lamenting
        - They declare that it has come to kill them
        - These must be some case of hemorrhoids if they fear death!
    - In fact, we’re told there was a “deadly confusion” throughout Ekron
        - The suggestion is a great panic that led to people dying at each other’s hand
        - The city is dissolving into chaos and anarchy as a result of the Ark’s arrival
        - Those in the city who weren’t killed receive the tumors and all suffer
- Once again, Samuel is a master of contrast in his narrative
    - In Chapter 4, the nation of Israel tried to use the Ark to access the power of God for their own purposes
        - And God didn’t play along
        - Israel couldn’t repackage God to fit their desires
        - So the Lord hides Himself from His own people leaving them to stumble
        - They are a culture of evil and sinful desires living like pagans
    - In Chapter 5, the Philistines, a pagan people, treat the Ark with reverence and awe
        - They try to incorporate it into their pantheon of gods
        - But the Lord of Israel will not be controlled by pagans either
    - Now He shows Himself by bringing judgment to the pagans in a particularly degrading way
        - His will is controlling the circumstances
        - If the people want to access the power of God through a relic, the Lord is

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content to demonstrate His power through that instrument
- But He won't perform as they expect
- The Jews expected victory and received defeat
- The Philistines expected to be blessed by possession of the Ark
- And instead they were cursed

- No man can own or manipulate God
  - His will be done
  - Not ours

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- Last week's study ended in the somewhat humorous plight of the Philistines, who had unknowingly acquired a deadly artifact
  - After defeating the Israelites in battle, they captured the Ark of God
    - Once they brought it into their cities, one after another, the Lord visited the people with great tumors and death
    - The Ark made its way from city to city as residents tried to escape its destruction
  - As we observed last week, the Lord permitted this entire sequence of events to make a point both to Israel's enemies and to Israel itself
    - The nation of Israel was largely apostate
    - During the time of Judges, men did what was right in their own eyes
    - Which is a concise way of saying that Israel didn't consult the Lord or His word for counsel and direction
    - They didn't make the Lord's desires their priority
  - Instead, the people let their own personal agendas and fleshly desires dictate their paths
    - And nothing exemplified this truth better than the Israelites' decision to send the Ark into battle
    - After having been utterly crushed by the Philistines in battle, the people assemble at the house of the Lord in Shiloh questioning their fate
    - Why did the Lord lead them into battle only to bring them defeat?
    - What should they do to curry the Lord's favor for the next battle?
- They asked the right questions, but instead of seeking the Lord in His word for the answers, they do what seemed right in their own eyes
  - We learned last week that Samuel was ministering to Israel from Shiloh speaking the word of the Lord consistently
    - And yet the people make no effort to seek Samuel's counsel
    - Much less to ask what the Lord desired from the people
  - Instead, they propose the Ark solution with the help of the two corrupt sons of the High Priest
    - The effect of their folly was an even more devastating defeat
    - The death of the High Priest and his sons
    - And the loss of the Ark
  - So the Lord permits these outcomes to teach Israel a lesson about how one approaches and serves the Living God
    - And yet the faithfulness of God was also evident in the way He allowed the Philistines to capture the Ark
    - Their holding of the Ark gave opportunity for the Lord to defend Israel Himself

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        - After the Lord granted these enemies of Israel such a great military victory, they could have conquered all the land
        - But the Lord saddled them with a great pestilence so that they were weakened and distracted, unable to re-engage in battle
        - More importantly, the Lord is displaying His power against the nations on behalf of His chosen people
- But the lessons for both Israel and the Philistines are not over yet
    - The Ark still needs to make its way back into Jewish hands
        - Ironically, God will use the Philistines to demonstrate to Israel the appropriate way to approach the Lord
        - But then the Israelites must relearn where they go to find the Lord's counsel and blessing
        - Not in superstition and ritual but according to His word
    - So we start in Chapter 6 tonight, in the story of the Ark's return from the Philistines to Israel

1Sam. 6:1 Now the ark of the LORD had been in the country of the Philistines seven months.
1Sam. 6:2 And the Philistines called for the priests and the diviners, saying, "What shall we do with the ark of the LORD? Tell us how we shall send it to its place."
1Sam. 6:3 They said, "If you send away the ark of the God of Israel, do not send it empty; but you shall surely return to Him a guilt offering. Then you will be healed and it will be known to you why His hand is not removed from you."
1Sam. 6:4 Then they said, "What shall be the guilt offering which we shall return to Him?" And they said, "Five golden tumors and five golden mice according to the number of the lords of the Philistines, for one plague was on all of you and on your lords.
1Sam. 6:5 "So you shall make likenesses of your tumors and likenesses of your mice that ravage the land, and you shall give glory to the God of Israel; perhaps He will ease His hand from you, your gods, and your land.
1Sam. 6:6 "Why then do you harden your hearts as the Egyptians and Pharaoh hardened their hearts? When He had severely dealt with them, did they not allow the people to go, and they departed?
1Sam. 6:7 "Now therefore, take and prepare a new cart and two milch cows on which there has never been a yoke; and hitch the cows to the cart and take their calves home, away from them.
1Sam. 6:8 "Take the ark of the LORD and place it on the cart; and put the articles of gold which you return to Him as a guilt offering in a box by its side. Then send it away that it may go.
1Sam. 6:9 "Watch, if it goes up by the way of its own territory to Beth-shemesh, then He has done us this great evil. But if not, then we will know that it was not

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His hand that struck us; it happened to us by chance."

- It's been seven months of torment for the people of the five Philistine cities
  - The number seven in scripture is God's way of communicating completeness
    - As we use the expression "100%" to mean the whole or completeness of something, so God uses "7"
    - So when we see seven months go by before the Ark is able to return to Israel, we are seeing the hand of God at work
    - Clearly, these people wanted the Ark gone on Day 1, given the calamity it produced
    - But it couldn't leave until God's purpose had been done, and the number seven reminds us that the purpose was now complete
  - After seven months, the priests of Dagon and the diviners (or cultic prophets) were asked what will solve this problem?
    - How can they get rid of the Ark of the Lord?
    - How do we send it away?
  - If we stop to think about that question for a moment, we realize it says something about the attitude of these pagans
    - Why can't they simply destroy the thing or sink it at sea?
    - Why don't a bunch of men just carry the thing back to Israel's land and dump it on the side of the road?
    - Why is it so hard to get rid of it?
- The answer is that these pagans had an instinctive understanding that gods don't work that way
  - The power of God extends well beyond the physical realm
    - So it's not merely an issue of where the Ark resides physically
    - The problem the Philistines are facing is that the Lord of that Ark is not pleased with them
  - And one way or another, the Philistines must find a way to appease the Lord's wrath for their sin against Him
    - They realize that simply returning a wooden box isn't going to suffice
    - Instead, they must divine what will satisfy the Lord
  - Here we see the pagans operating with a fear and understanding of God's true power and divine authority
    - They are still pagans, so they do not understand the Lord as the One true God
    - Nevertheless, they at least appreciate divine power
    - In fact, we could say that the Philistines are demonstrating more fear of the Lord than Israel is at this time

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- So how do these people appease the wrath of a God they don't know? How do they understand His desires when they do not have His word to counsel them?
  - That's why they are seeking to discern it in other ways, through the advice of their own priests
    - Notice the solution the priests offer begins with an admission of guilt
    - The Ark can't just be sent away on its own
    - The people of the cities must include a guilt offering
    - Something of value must accompany the Ark as display of an admission of sin and a display of contrition
  - Even pagans understand that you can't come before an angry God empty handed
    - In other words, there must be a payment for sin in some form
    - In this case, the Philistines are working without benefit of God's word and His Law, which was given to Israel alone
    - So they have to improvise a solution
  - The priests propose that the Ark must be sent away with ten objects made of solid gold
    - They arrive at the number ten by taking the five Philistine cities and creating two objects for each city
    - The objects are tumors and mice
    - Assuming these objects were substantial in size, this is a sizable amount of wealth, perhaps as much as $1M in today's money
- First, why these objects?
  - Well, the tumors are an obvious choice
    - The plague was one of deadly tumors
    - So the offering is constructed in a form that memorializes God's work
  - The mice seem to be an odd choice, though some have suggested a logical connection
    - Mice are often associated with the spread of bubonic plague, which causes large tumors on the body
    - Therefore, perhaps the tumors was actually the Black Death
  - Taken together, the ten golden objects are a testimony to the Lord's wrath brought against the people for their sin in taking the Ark
    - In fact, the number 10 in scripture stands for "testimony"
    - So this becomes a clear sign testifying to the Lord's judgment against the Philistines' sin
- Finally, it's interesting that these pagans do not propose to make idols of God Himself
  - This would have been the more likely choice for a pagan people
    - When they wanted to honor a god, they set up physical representations of that

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god
    - Like we saw earlier with Dagon in his temple
    - But now they choose other objects to honor the God of Israel, which was in keeping with God's Law forbidding graven images
  - How ironic that the people of God, who had the word of the Lord, treated the Ark as a graven image as they dragged it into battle
    - While the pagans of the land have conspicuously avoided creating an image to God
    - Though they do not have the Law
    - As Paul wrote:

Rom. 2:14 For when Gentiles who do not have the Law do instinctively the things of the Law, these, not having the Law, are a law to themselves,
Rom. 2:15 in that they show the work of the Law written in their hearts, their conscience bearing witness and their thoughts alternately accusing or else defending them,

- Then in v.6 the priests declare that this testimony would be to the glory of the Lord of Israel
  - That's exactly the purpose in this entire episode
    - The people of Israel had the Ark by God's grace
    - And the Ark and the tabernacle and the entire nation of Israel were created to be a light testifying to the nations
    - Together, they were to testify to the truth of God to His glory
    - But Israel neglected that calling and became a people serving only themselves
  - So, the Lord allowed the pagans of the land to take possession of His Ark
    - And by their possession of it, they became a testimony to God's glory
    - Obviously, their testimony came in the form of judgment, but it came nonetheless
  - We can chose to be a testimony of God in our obedience
    - Or we can be a testimony to God's judgment for our disobedience
    - But one way or the other, the Lord will be glorified
    - In fact, the priests remind the people that the Lord has made them an example like He did Egypt
  - This is ironic, because earlier the Philistines expressed fear when they heard the Israelites had brought the Ark into the camp
    - They said at that time, this is the Ark of the Lord who destroyed Egypt
    - It turns out they were prophetic, because now they are comparing themselves

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to Egypt again

- So now they have their plan to appease the Lord's wrath, but how will they know if God is appeased by their offering?
  - This leads to the second part of the priests' plan
    - They construct an improbable set of circumstances that will reveal the will of a sovereign and all-powerful God
    - They take two nursing cows and yoke them to a cart
    - They will place the Ark and guilt offering on the cart and send it in the direction of Israel
    - If the cows continue on their own to Israel, then the Lord has accepted their offering
    - If they return, then the people know the Lord has not answered them affirmatively
  - The people can be sure this represents God's will because the deck is stacked against success
    - Nursing cows will not voluntarily leave their young
    - So if these cows are yoked and allowed to walk where they prefer, they will not head to Israel
    - They would return to their young
    - So if they go to Israel, it can only mean they were led there by the invisible sovereign hand of a God pleased with the offering
  - So the Philistines have demonstrated the need to display repentance and propitiation before God, and now they testify that God is sovereign
    - That He controls all things and speaks to those who seek His counsel
    - Granted, they are only seeing God in a limited way
    - And they do not possess the saving faith to acknowledge Him as Lord of Lords and King of Kings
    - Nevertheless, they are teaching Israel a thing or two about how one approaches the Living God
- So then they executed the plan as instructed…

1Sam. 6:10 Then the men did so, and took two milch cows and hitched them to the cart, and shut up their calves at home.
1Sam. 6:11 They put the ark of the LORD on the cart, and the box with the golden mice and the likenesses of their tumors.
1Sam. 6:12 And the cows took the straight way in the direction of Beth-shemesh; they went along the highway, lowing as they went, and did not turn aside to the right or to the left. And the lords of the Philistines followed them to the border of Beth-shemesh.

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1Sam. 6:13 **Now the people of Beth-shemesh were reaping their wheat harvest in the valley, and they raised their eyes and saw the ark and were glad to see it.**
1Sam. 6:14 **The cart came into the field of Joshua the Beth-shemite and stood there where there was a large stone; and they split the wood of the cart and offered the cows as a burnt offering to the LORD.**
1Sam. 6:15 **The Levites took down the ark of the LORD and the box that was with it, in which were the articles of gold, and put them on the large stone; and the men of Beth-shemesh offered burnt offerings and sacrificed sacrifices that day to the LORD.**
1Sam. 6:16 **When the five lords of the Philistines saw it, they returned to Ekron that day.**
1Sam. 6:17 **These are the golden tumors which the Philistines returned for a guilt offering to the LORD: one for Ashdod, one for Gaza, one for Ashkelon, one for Gath, one for Ekron;**
1Sam. 6:18 **and the golden mice, according to the number of all the cities of the Philistines belonging to the five lords, both of fortified cities and of country villages. The large stone on which they set the ark of the LORD is a witness to this day in the field of Joshua the Beth-shemite.**

- Once they were hitched up and sent on their way, the cows head directly east
  - In a true miracle, the cows go out of Ekron and toward Israel though they had never been harnessed to a yoke before
    - They should have resisted pulling
    - And they had calves waiting for them, so they should never have left town
    - But they go straight without meandering
  - And just to emphasize how the cows are operating according to the Lord's will, we're told they're lowing the whole way
    - This is a protest
    - The cows are very unhappy about leaving their calves
    - It's not in their nature to do what they're doing, but they are going because they are obeying their Creator and have no choice otherwise
  - These cows can serve as a beautiful picture of every child of God
    - By our fallen nature, we are not prone to follow and obey
    - Scripture says we are naturally inclined to serve our flesh rather than to follow the Spirit
    - But when we hear the word of God and do it, we demonstrate our love for Him
  - But like those cows, we will feel like lowing as we go
    - We may feel scared or uncomfortable
    - God's word never says that serving the Living God will be painless or trouble

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free
        - Nevertheless we go forward, for that's what a heart of service does
- The cows head straight for Beth-shemesh, a small village about 15 miles west of Jerusalem
    - Beth-shemesh was the closest Jewish town to the Ark's last stop on the Philistine tour in Ekron
        - The name Beth-shemesh means house of the sun
        - Under the Canaanites, it probably held a temple to the Canaanite sun god
    - As the Ark made its way along the seven mile journey up from the plains to the hill country, it passed through the Sorek Valley
        - This was the home of Samson, who was ruling at this time as well
        - Likely the Ark passed by many Jewish villagers working in their fields or walking on the same road
    - We might wonder why no one stopped the cart or tried to claim the Ark
        - The entire nation knew it had been lost seven months earlier
        - And the people were happy to see it, as we read
        - So how did it make it all the way to Beth-shemesh untouched?
- Because under the Mosaic Law, only the priests were permitted to handle the Ark of the Covenant
    - And even then, the priests were required to carry it using poles that slipped through golden rings on the side
        - If anyone else touched it, it meant death
        - So the Ark is moving in a solitary parade
        - Everyone who sees it is too afraid to interrupt its journey
    - But in these days, Beth-shemesh was a Levitical city
        - This means the town is full of Levites who were qualified to handle the Ark and bring it back to the tabernacle
        - And the first Levite to see the Ark in the town was a man named Joshua
        - His name is also the name of the Messiah, Jesus (Yeshuah)
        - So we could say the Ark is claimed by the priest named Yeshuah
    - So Joshua's first thought is to give thanks for the Lord returning the Ark
        - And in God's providence, He provided all that was required for the sacrifice
        - With the Ark came the cows that would be sacrificed
        - And with the Ark came the cart that would become the wood for the sacrificial fire
        - And the Ark stopped immediately before a large stone uncut by human hands
- In other words, God gave His people the Ark, the sacrifice, the wood and the altar

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- And He provided a priest named Yeshuah
- Can you see the message the Lord has embedded in these details?
- A message of grace and rescue?

- What has Israel done to warrant the return of their precious Ark?
  - Did Israel repent first? Sacrifice first?
  - There is no evidence they have become the godly people the Lord desired
- But after seven months, the Lord returns His Ark to His people
  - He returns it as a matter of His grace, since He made those cows walk where they did
  - And God gave everything required for the restoration of fellowship
  - And He provided a man qualified to officiate at the altar
  - It was grace and grace alone that made this restoration possible
  - And God did all the work on behalf of His people
  - Obviously, we have a beautiful picture of the Gospel in Christ
- With the Ark and the guilt offering on the altar (rock), the Levites sacrificed and thanked the Lord
  - But that's not all that was going on during this day

1Sam. 6:19 **He struck down some of the men of Beth-shemesh because they had looked into the ark of the LORD. He struck down of all the people, 50,070 men, and the people mourned because the LORD had struck the people with a great slaughter.**
1Sam. 6:20 **The men of Beth-shemesh said, "Who is able to stand before the LORD, this holy God? And to whom shall He go up from us?"**
1Sam. 6:21 **So they sent messengers to the inhabitants of Kiriath-jearim, saying, "The Philistines have brought back the ark of the LORD; come down and take it up to you."**
1Sam. 7:1 **And the men of Kiriath-jearim came and took the ark of the LORD and brought it into the house of Abinadab on the hill, and consecrated Eleazar his son to keep the ark of the LORD.**
1Sam. 7:2 **From the day that the ark remained at Kiriath-jearim, the time was long, for it was twenty years; and all the house of Israel lamented after the LORD.**

- Apparently, during this day some of the priests decide to check out what's inside the Ark
  - Now the priests were permitted to carry the Ark
  - But no one was permitted to look inside the Ark, according to Number 4:5
  - So these priests, those who were given custody of the Ark, are quickest to violate the

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Law

- Here's further evidence that the hearts of the people, including the priests, remain far from God's word
  - Once again, their irreverent behavior stands in contrast to the way the pagans feared and respected the Ark, at least at a point
  - So if the Lord judged the pagans for their disobedience, how do you think the Lord should respond to a people who know better?
  - And not just the Jewish people, but the priests in particular
- The Lord responds by keeping His word according to the Law, putting to death 50,070 men
  - The number is remarkable for its magnitude and its symbology
  - This must have represented a sizable number of the male Levites living in Beth-shemesh
  - And the extra seventy men tacked on at the end makes clear that this was the work of the Lord in response to their sin
  - (Some translations report a much smaller number, but the textual support favors the larger number as does the peoples' response.)
- In response to the death of so many, the remaining Levites lament and ask rhetorically who is able to stand before the Lord?
  - This is an interesting response
    - They don't say, we have sinned and the Lord punished us according to His word – which would have been the truth
    - Instead, they suggest the Lord is unreasonable
    - Implying that no one could remain alive in the face of such a fierce and unreasonable God
    - Clearly we don't yet see repentant hearts at work
  - So in an ironic twist, they do very much as the pagans
    - They call for a small neighboring town to accept the Ark
    - The town is called Kiriath-jearim, which is another 10 miles east
    - This is not a Levite town, so there was no one in this town capable of handling or moving the Ark
  - So they find a man named Abinadab to house the Ark and they consecrated his son, Eleazar, to attend to the Ark
    - Basically, a corrupt and dysfunctional priesthood dumps the most precious object from the house of God in a random Jewish home
    - And they deputize a young man to attend to the Ark, which basically meant to guard it
    - And then they run away
    - If you remember the scene at the end of the movie Raiders of the Lost Ark, when

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it's rolled into a giant warehouse, that's what's happening here

- And here it remained for 20 years while Shiloh lamented its absence
  - The people of Israel were determined to use the Ark like a cultic object
    - They assumed they could receive God's blessings by putting the Ark to work
    - To which God replied, no you can't
    - And instead of blessing, they received His judgment
  - Now that the Ark has returned, the people still have an unhealthy fascination with the Ark as a relic
    - So the Lord hides it for twenty years
    - And he virtually wipes out one city of the corrupt priesthood
  - His point to the people is that He cares about His covenant and the peoples' obedience to the Law of that covenant
    - If they want to receive His blessing, obey the covenant they entered into
    - If they want to see the Ark, then treat it as the Law requires
    - Everything comes back to the word of God
- So with that recognition, we reach a turning point of sorts in the period of judges, when the people begin to listen to the word of the Lord

1Sam. 7:3 **Then Samuel spoke to all the house of Israel, saying, "If you return to the LORD with all your heart, remove the foreign gods and the Ashtaroth from among you and direct your hearts to the LORD and serve Him alone; and He will deliver you from the hand of the Philistines."**
1Sam. 7:4 **So the sons of Israel removed the Baals and the Ashtaroth and served the LORD alone.**
1Sam. 7:5 **Then Samuel said, "Gather all Israel to Mizpah and I will pray to the LORD for you."**
1Sam. 7:6 **They gathered to Mizpah, and drew water and poured it out before the LORD, and fasted on that day and said there, "We have sinned against the LORD." And Samuel judged the sons of Israel at Mizpah.**

- Now Samuel returns to the foreground of the story
  - The last time we saw him, he was giving the word of the Lord in Shiloh
    - But no one was listening
    - Now that the people have endured a slaughter at the hands of their enemies
    - And another at the hand of the Lord, they are ready to listen it would seem
  - So Samuel says, here's the answer you've been missing
    - If you return to the Lord with all your heart, removing the idols and serving God alone, you will see the delivery you want

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        - The Lord will put an end to the torment of the Philistines
        - But the people must seek Him on God's terms
        - Not in superstition or ritual
        - But according to the covenant
    - So the people do as Samuel suggests
        - There is clear evidence of repentance
        - The people head down to a town near the Jordan and begin a fast to the Lord
        - Samuel prays to the Lord for deliverance from the Philistines
        - And the people poured out water to the Lord, a washing ceremony indicating repentance
    - What a contrast with the previous episode
        - Before they went out in prideful confidence wielding the Ark
        - Attempting to control the Lord like any other idol
        - Now they set aside idols and submit to the Lord in humble hearts
        - This is how God's people approach
- Now we see the result:

1Sam. 7:7 Now when the Philistines heard that the sons of Israel had gathered to Mizpah, the lords of the Philistines went up against Israel. And when the sons of Israel heard it, they were afraid of the Philistines.
1Sam. 7:8 Then the sons of Israel said to Samuel, "Do not cease to cry to the LORD our God for us, that He may save us from the hand of the Philistines."
1Sam. 7:9 Samuel took a suckling lamb and offered it for a whole burnt offering to the LORD; and Samuel cried to the LORD for Israel and the LORD answered him.
1Sam. 7:10 Now Samuel was offering up the burnt offering, and the Philistines drew near to battle against Israel. But the LORD thundered with a great thunder on that day against the Philistines and confused them, so that they were routed before Israel.
1Sam. 7:11 The men of Israel went out of Mizpah and pursued the Philistines, and struck them down as far as below Beth-car.
1Sam. 7:12 Then Samuel took a stone and set it between Mizpah and Shen, and named it Ebenezer, saying, "Thus far the LORD has helped us."
1Sam. 7:13 So the Philistines were subdued and they did not come anymore within the border of Israel. And the hand of the LORD was against the Philistines all the days of Samuel.
1Sam. 7:14 The cities which the Philistines had taken from Israel were restored to Israel, from Ekron even to Gath; and Israel delivered their territory from the hand of the Philistines. So there was peace between Israel and the Amorites.

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- With the people of Israel massed on their eastern border in the valley, the Philistines think this is their opportunity
  - The people of Israel will be sitting ducks
    - And when Israel learns that an army is approaching, they are naturally afraid
    - But notice the change in response from times prior
    - This time they turn to Samuel and ask him to appeal on their behalf
  - Last time they could have done this very same thing, but they elected to follow Eli's sons into the tabernacle and claim the Ark
    - Now they make the right choice and ask the Lord's anointed to intercede
    - And Samuel burns an offering and cries to the Lord, and the Lord hears and answers
    - This is the first time we've been told the Lord heard and answered the people of Israel
  - Finally, when it comes time for battle, the Lord fights the fight entirely
    - The people don't even have to raise a finger
    - The Lord confuses the army of the Philistines so that the people of Israel can defeat them easily
    - And later they run the Philistines out of their cities
    - And all during Samuel's life the people are free from the tyranny of the Philistines
    - All this made possible by trusting in the Lord by His word
  - As Hannah sang at Samuel's conception and as Zechariah says as well

Zech. 4:6 **Then he said to me, "This is the word of the LORD to Zerubbabel saying, 'Not by might nor by power, but by My Spirit,' says the LORD of hosts.**

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- As we move into 1 Samuel 8, we begin the next major section of this book
  - We're at the end of the historical period in Israel called the period of the Judges
    - It's the time when men were doing what was right in their own eyes
    - Which is to say they were not doing right in God's sight
    - The entire Jewish society has gone from bad to worse since Joshua
    - And even when a judge was raised up to direct the people, it was temporary at best
    - And in the end the people rebelled again, even worse than before
  - The best proof of how far the people have fallen is found in the children of those called to lead the people
    - Earlier in the book we met the High Priest, Eli, and his sons
    - These men were charged with leading Israel from the tabernacle in Shiloh
    - And yet it would be hard to find men more corrupt
    - These men eventually met their fate, and the people likewise
  - Then we see the rise of Samuel as the man of God, a prophet seeking to serve God, and directing the people back to following God
    - Last week Samuel convinced the people to put aside their idols and follow God with their whole heart
    - This time when they faced their enemy, they took the path of faith and found the victory
    - And then Samuel began to judge Israel for 40 years
    - So we naturally assume that Samuel's rise to judge was the happy ending to our story of judges
- Not so fast…Chapter 8 opens with a shocking result to remind us of how evil the time of judges truly was

1Sam. 8:1 And it came about when Samuel was old that he appointed his sons judges over Israel.
1Sam. 8:2 Now the name of his firstborn was Joel, and the name of his second, Abijah; they were judging in Beersheba.
1Sam. 8:3 His sons, however, did not walk in his ways, but turned aside after dishonest gain and took bribes and perverted justice.

- Near the end of Samuel's life, his grown sons are ready to assume responsibility, and Samuel appoints them as judges
  - His sons were Joel and Abijah, and these men judged in Beersheba in southern Judah
    - Now if anyone should be able to raise godly sons, we would expect it would be Samuel

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        - But in v.2 we learn that these sons were no better than Eli's own corrupt sons
        - Presumably, they started out right, otherwise we wouldn't expect Samuel to entrust a judgeship to them
    - But in v.2 we're told they turned aside
        - They came into power and saw an opportunity to benefit themselves
        - They pursued dishonest gain like bribes, extortion and the like
        - They perverted justice, giving favorable judgement to those who made a payment over those who deserved justice
    - How did Samuel's sons come to such a surprising end? Do we blame Samuel as we did Eli?
        - In this case, the scriptures offer no critique of Samuel
        - There is no indication that Samuel deserves blame
        - Instead, the text is clear that they were already grown and working in their positions before they elected to turn aside
        - They were grown men making their own choices
        - So if Eli's sons can be an example of bad parenting, then Samuel's sons are a reminder that good parents don't guarantee perfect children
- So where do we go to explain such a dramatic turn? The answer is central to these Chapters in 1 Samuel
    - This period of Jewish history is so double-minded and without godly direction that not even a judge's own sons will persist in doing God's will
        - When Samuel was writing the book of Judges and penned that book's well-known phrase, was he thinking of his sons?
        - His sons did what was right in their own eyes, not according to his father's eyes
    - That's the situation that brings us to the this point in 1 Samuel
        - The people are beyond reach by a judge
        - And now that even their judges are without integrity, the people themselves recognize there is no hope for men to follow God
        - So they demand a king

1Sam. 8:4 Then all the elders of Israel gathered together and came to Samuel at Ramah;
1Sam. 8:5 and they said to him, "Behold, you have grown old, and your sons do not walk in your ways. Now appoint a king for us to judge us like all the nations."
1Sam. 8:6 But the thing was displeasing in the sight of Samuel when they said, "Give us a king to judge us." And Samuel prayed to the LORD.
1Sam. 8:7 The LORD said to Samuel, "Listen to the voice of the people in regard to all that they say to you, for they have not rejected you, but they have rejected

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Me from being king over them.
1Sam. 8:8 **"Like all the deeds which they have done since the day that I brought them up from Egypt even to this day — in that they have forsaken Me and served other gods — so they are doing to you also.**
1Sam. 8:9 **"Now then, listen to their voice; however, you shall solemnly warn them and tell them of the procedure of the king who will reign over them."**

- The elders of the people see the evil in Samuel's sons and realize that this corruption can't continue
  - Their concern over these sons is not unreasonable and their protests are not the problem
    - They say, you have grown old Samuel
    - They mean, you won't rule us forever, and God-forbid your sons are left in authority over us
    - Therefore, we need a solution
  - Everything up to this point is fine, but it's the solution they propose that's the problem
    - The elders ask Samuel to appoint a king over Israel to rule the people
    - Here they begin to go wrong
    - They ask for a change of authority from God ruling the people to a human king ruling
  - Moreover, they offer the wrong reason for their recommended solution
    - They want a king so they can be like every other nation
    - Forgetting that God intended Israel to be a nation distinct and separate from other nations
    - So they point to Samuel's sons as the problem, but they use it as an excuse to ask for what they have long wanted
    - The people tried to install a king twice before, once under Gideon
    - And again under Abimelech, the corrupt judge who followed Gideon
- Samuel knew the people were making a rash choice, and he worries for what the Lord will say in response
  - In v.6 it says the thing was displeasing to Samuel
    - The word in Hebrew for displeasing is *raa*, which is the Hebrew word for wicked and evil
    - The request is evil, for it amounts to a rejection of the Lord's ruling over the people through judges
  - The people could have solved this problem without rejecting the Lord
    - Rather than ask for a king, the people could have simply asked that the Lord send them a new judge who wasn't corrupt

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        - Instead, they reject the Lord's way of ruling over His people
- But if truth be told, the people have been rejecting the Lord's authority for some time
    - They have rebelled against every judge who has ruled over them
        - They do what is right in their eyes, not God's sight
        - So this is just the final straw of rebellion that has marked the entire time in the land since Joshua
        - Such is the wickedness of man's heart
        - Nothing can tame the sin of men, not the Law, not judges, and not even kings as the people will soon discover
    - Meanwhile, the Lord answers Samuel's concerns with mercy and pity for the people
        - Samuel's worry at this point is that he might be assigned some blame for this predicament, much the way Eli bore the blame for Israel
        - He wondered if the people's rebellion would be traced to him since his sons, like Eli's, were the cause for the trouble
    - But the Lord reassures Samuel that he's not in trouble with the Lord
        - He says, go ahead and do as the people demand
        - Because they are rejecting me, not you
        - In other words, Samuel couldn't have stopped this rebellion no matter what he did as judge
        - The people's hearts strayed from God continually
- In v.8, the Lord gives a brief synopsis of the history of Israel since they entered under Joshua
    - They have never been a people to obey and respect the word of God, at least not for long
        - They forsake the Lord continually and chase after other gods
        - And so Samuel is experiencing this same rejection as well
    - Notice the Lord doesn't say that Samuel's sons are the problem or that Samuel shares some blame
        - At this point the sons are just a distraction from the real problem, which is the peoples' hearts
        - They aren't interested in obedience
        - So that even if Samuel's sons had been perfect judges, the people would have still wanted a king eventually
        - And we know that because their real motivation was to be like other nations
    - When God's people make our goal aligning with the world over following the Lord, we forsake Him and reject His authority
        - We may not realize that's what we're doing
        - But these two pursuits are literally opposites

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        - Which is why the Lord equates seeking a king like the other nations, with rejecting Him
- But the people don't realize how their sinful hearts will always lead them wrong
    - When sin is conceived it seems like the perfect plan, because our flesh responds in eager anticipation
        - But our flesh lies, and it's only after sin gives birth to action that we come to understand the consequences
        - And so in mercy, the Lord offers the people a chance to understand the consequences in advance
        - So the Lord tells Samuel to explain to the people all the things that will happen when one man has enough authority to do whatever he pleases
    - For such is monarchy
        - A king has no equal in the land
        - And if the Lord anoints a king, then the Lord will ensure that his power is unchallenged until such time the Lord decides
        - And while power corrupts, absolute power corrupts absolutely
        - And a king is absolute power personified
- So Samuel explains the consequences of what's coming with a monarchy

1Sam. 8:10 So Samuel spoke all the words of the LORD to the people who had asked of him a king.
1Sam. 8:11 He said, "This will be the procedure of the king who will reign over you: he will take your sons and place them for himself in his chariots and among his horsemen and they will run before his chariots.
1Sam. 8:12 "He will appoint for himself commanders of thousands and of fifties, and some to do his plowing and to reap his harvest and to make his weapons of war and equipment for his chariots.
1Sam. 8:13 "He will also take your daughters for perfumers and cooks and bakers.
1Sam. 8:14 "He will take the best of your fields and your vineyards and your olive groves and give them to his servants.
1Sam. 8:15 "He will take a tenth of your seed and of your vineyards and give to his officers and to his servants.
1Sam. 8:16 "He will also take your male servants and your female servants and your best young men and your donkeys and use them for his work.
1Sam. 8:17 "He will take a tenth of your flocks, and you yourselves will become his servants.
1Sam. 8:18 "Then you will cry out in that day because of your king whom you have chosen for yourselves, but the LORD will not answer you in that day."

- The Lord speaks through Samuel with a stern warning

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    - First, a king will need an army to protect his reign
        - And the warriors will come from among the people he rules over
        - Mothers and fathers will give up sons in great number to the army
        - And there will be placed in harm's way on the whim of the king
    - Secondly, the king will need servants and workers to sustain the lifestyle of an all-powerful monarch
        - Teams of men will be ordered to plow and harvest fields for the king
        - And others will be workers to make equipment for the sovereign
        - And daughters will go to work in the kitchens and palaces
    - And where will these fields come from for all this material and farming?
        - From the people of course
        - The king must tax the people and appropriate their land
        - And take servants and animals
        - And when you can't pay the taxes, you yourselves will becomes indentured servants
    - In summary, sinful, human royalty acts like a parasite
        - They take the best from the people
        - Because kings are never satisfied with less than the best
        - And the people live to serve the king, not the other way around
- The Lord warned them in advance of this burden, but the people won't listen
    - They assume that a king will be good news for them
        - And because they rejected the Lord, they will know all these things
        - When the weight of this expense and depravation becomes a reality, the people will cry out to God for relief but find none
    - How predictable…they ask for the wrong thing for the wrong reasons, and the Lord tells them in advance what to expect
        - Still they persist and eventually will know all the Lord promises
        - But then they will cry out to Him as if they are the victims
        - If they are the victims, they are victims of their own disobedience

1Sam. 8:19 Nevertheless, the people refused to listen to the voice of Samuel, and they said, "No, but there shall be a king over us,
1Sam. 8:20 that we also may be like all the nations, that our king may judge us and go out before us and fight our battles."
1Sam. 8:21 Now after Samuel had heard all the words of the people, he repeated them in the LORD'S hearing.
1Sam. 8:22 The LORD said to Samuel, "Listen to their voice and appoint them a

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king." So Samuel said to the men of Israel, "Go every man to his city."

- If it wasn't clear enough already, the people repeat their explanation that they want to be like other nations
  - They want a king to judge them and go out before them, that is to lead them and to fight their battles
    - Each of these roles was to be fulfilled by the Lord Himself
    - As He's demonstrated, He is more than capable of doing so
    - The Lord has judged Israel through the Law and gone out before Israel in their wanderings and fought Israel's enemies under Joshua
- Ultimately, the Lord will fulfill these roles in the Person of Christ in the Kingdom

Mic. 4:1 And it will come about in the last days
That the mountain of the house of the LORD
Will be established as the chief of the mountains.
It will be raised above the hills,
And the peoples will stream to it.
Mic. 4:2 Many nations will come and say,
"Come and let us go up to the mountain of the LORD
And to the house of the God of Jacob,
That He may teach us about His ways
And that we may walk in His paths."
For from Zion will go forth the law,
Even the word of the LORD from Jerusalem.
Mic. 4:3 And He will judge between many peoples
And render decisions for mighty, distant nations.
Then they will hammer their swords into plowshares
And their spears into pruning hooks;
Nation will not lift up sword against nation,
And never again will they train for war.
Mic. 4:4 Each of them will sit under his vine
And under his fig tree,
With no one to make them afraid,
For the mouth of the LORD of hosts has spoken.
Mic. 4:5 Though all the peoples walk
Each in the name of his god,
As for us, we will walk
In the name of the LORD our God forever and ever.

- Until then, kings are incapable of administering righteousness or bringing peace
- So Samuel passes word to the Lord, Who says then go appoint a king for the people

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- Specifically, the Lord tells Samuel to “listen to their voice”
- In other words, not only is Samuel going to follow their request in granting them a king
- But he is also to follow their desires in who he appoints

- The Lord is going to bring Samuel a man who fits the people’s expectations to a “t”
  - The Lord knows the hearts of the people
  - So the candidate will be a perfect match
  - But of course this will be to the people’s own undoing
  - And so that in the result, the Lord can teach a lesson
- So Samuel tells them to go back to their cities to await his decision

1Sam. 9:1 Now there was a man of Benjamin whose name was Kish the son of Abiel, the son of Zeror, the son of Becorath, the son of Aphiah, the son of a Benjamite, a mighty man of valor.
1Sam. 9:2 He had a son whose name was Saul, a choice and handsome man, and there was not a more handsome person than he among the sons of Israel; from his shoulders and up he was taller than any of the people.

- Chapter 9 is the selection of that king, a Benjamite named Saul
  - And right from the start, we learn that Saul comes straight from central casting
    - He is exactly the guy you want to play the part of king, at least as far as external appearances
    - He comes from excellent Benjamite stock, the descendent of a might man of valor
  - Saul’s name means “asked for of God” and he is a hunk
    - He is literally, according to scripture, the most handsome man in Israel
    - I find it interesting that the word of God can make such a judgment
    - We tend to think that attractiveness is largely subjective
    - But the word of God says that Saul was #1 among all Israel in this category
    - And he stood a full head taller than anyone else in Israel
    - Later, we learn he’s in his late 20s, which is perfectly suited to the people’s desires
- Saul is literally a perfect example of what men expect when they imagine a king
  - They want someone who looks the part
    - Because men judge with the flesh according to our own desires
    - But God’s ways are not man’s ways
  - That’s why the Lord chose to bring Christ into the world in such a humble and lowly

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way

- Nothing about Jesus' earthly appearance would attract the flesh

Is. 53:1 **Who has believed our message?**
And to whom has the arm of the LORD been revealed?
Is. 53:2 **For He grew up before Him like a tender shoot,**
And like a root out of parched ground;
He has no stately form or majesty
That we should look upon Him,
Nor appearance that we should be attracted to Him.
Is. 53:3 **He was despised and forsaken of men,**
A man of sorrows and acquainted with grief;
And like one from whom men hide their face
He was despised, and we did not esteem Him.

- God's choice to endow Christ with a humble appearance was intended to mock man's foolishness to judge by looks
- And the story of Saul is a classic account of just such a folly
- So now we watch as the Lord directs Saul to Samuel's attention so that the people will receive just what they wanted

1Sam. 9:3 **Now the donkeys of Kish, Saul's father, were lost. So Kish said to his son Saul, "Take now with you one of the servants, and arise, go search for the donkeys."**
1Sam. 9:4 **He passed through the hill country of Ephraim and passed through the land of Shalishah, but they did not find them. Then they passed through the land of Shaalim, but they were not there. Then he passed through the land of the Benjamites, but they did not find them.**
1Sam. 9:5 **When they came to the land of Zuph, Saul said to his servant who was with him, "Come, and let us return, or else my father will cease to be concerned about the donkeys and will become anxious for us."**
1Sam. 9:6 **He said to him, "Behold now, there is a man of God in this city, and the man is held in honor; all that he says surely comes true. Now let us go there, perhaps he can tell us about our journey on which we have set out."**
1Sam. 9:7 **Then Saul said to his servant, "But behold, if we go, what shall we bring the man? For the bread is gone from our sack and there is no present to bring to the man of God. What do we have?"**
1Sam. 9:8 **The servant answered Saul again and said, "Behold, I have in my hand a fourth of a shekel of silver; I will give it to the man of God and he will tell us our way."**
1Sam. 9:9 **(Formerly in Israel, when a man went to inquire of God, he used to say,**

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"Come, and let us go to the seer"; for he who is called a prophet now was formerly called a seer.)
1Sam. 9:10 **Then Saul said to his servant, "Well said; come, let us go." So they went to the city where the man of God was.**
1Sam. 9:11 **As they went up the slope to the city, they found young women going out to draw water and said to them, "Is the seer here?"**
1Sam. 9:12 **They answered them and said, "He is; see, he is ahead of you. Hurry now, for he has come into the city today, for the people have a sacrifice on the high place today.**
1Sam. 9:13 **"As soon as you enter the city you will find him before he goes up to the high place to eat, for the people will not eat until he comes, because he must bless the sacrifice; afterward those who are invited will eat. Now therefore, go up for you will find him at once."**
1Sam. 9:14 **So they went up to the city. As they came into the city, behold, Samuel was coming out toward them to go up to the high place.**

- In a twist of irony, the Lord directs Saul to Samuel through a search of his own…for a donkey
  - Saul's search reveals a number of things about his character at this early point in his life
    - First, he's willing to serve his father in a devoted and sacrificial way
    - Searching for lost donkeys is one thing, but the distance Saul travels is remarkable
    - It's about 35 miles total
  - Secondly, he's aware of the societal customs of not coming to a man of God empty-handed
    - Notice Samuel makes clear that Saul and the servant perceive Samuel to be merely a seer
    - A seer was a diviner, and not necessary a godly one
    - And to receive the help of a seer required a payment, because they earned their living this way, like a fortune teller
  - Of course, Samuel isn't a seer, as he clarifies, since he's a true prophet of God
    - Nonetheless, the point is that Saul shows some courtesy and respect for custom and respect to the position
    - That's another plus for Saul
  - Thirdly, Saul has the humility to stop and ask a woman for directions
    - This is hard enough for any man
    - But in this culture, it was particularly difficult for a man to seek assistance from a strange woman
- Overall, we are introduced to Saul as a man with great potential and seemingly a good

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heart as well

- Here's the danger of judging with our eyes rather than on relying on the Lord's counsel
  - Even when we are seeing the best in a person, we can't know the inner workings of their heart
  - More importantly, we can't know the future
  - We don't know how they will respond to stress, temptation, success, failure
- But God knows these things, so if we trust in His counsel we will never be wrong
  - As we said, the people aren't interested in God's counsel
  - So they will naturally love this guy
  - And he has potential, at least in the sense that he starts well
- Finally, it's interesting that this man has never heard of Samuel and knows nothing of his role as prophet of Israel
  - Either Saul has been so isolated and kept so busy with his father's affairs that he hasn't kept up with current affairs
  - Or he is remarkably naïve
  - Either way, it would seem to disqualify this man from public service
  - One commentator observed that Saul went hunting for donkeys and found a kingdom
  - While a prophet went hunting for a king and found a young man ignorant of political affairs

- On this day, the Lord ensured that Saul and Samuel would find one another, as Samuel was preparing to officiate at a high place altar

1Sam. 9:15 Now a day before Saul's coming, the LORD had revealed this to Samuel saying,
1Sam. 9:16 "About this time tomorrow I will send you a man from the land of Benjamin, and you shall anoint him to be prince over My people Israel; and he will deliver My people from the hand of the Philistines. For I have regarded My people,
because their cry has come to Me."
1Sam. 9:17 When Samuel saw Saul, the LORD said to him, "Behold, the man of whom I spoke to you! This one shall rule over My people."
1Sam. 9:18 Then Saul approached Samuel in the gate and said, "Please tell me where the seer's house is."
1Sam. 9:19 Samuel answered Saul and said, "I am the seer. Go up before me to the high place, for you shall eat with me today; and in the morning I will let you go, and will tell you all that is on your mind.
1Sam. 9:20 "As for your donkeys which were lost three days ago, do not set your

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mind on them, for they have been found. And for whom is all that is desirable in Israel? Is it not for you and for all your father's household?"
1Sam. 9:21 **Saul replied, "Am I not a Benjamite, of the smallest of the tribes of Israel, and my family the least of all the families of the tribe of Benjamin? Why then do you speak to me in this way?"**

- Scenes like this are so interesting to me because they just scream to us about the Lord's sovereignty
- Every step Saul and Samuel took they took of their own accord, or so they supposed
  - Saul walked 35 miles looking for wayward donkeys
  - Samuel was on his regular circuit performing sacrificial services for the people
  - Yet the Lord was carefully moving them so that on this day they would meet
  - As Proverbs says

Prov. 16:9 **The mind of man plans his way,**
But the LORD directs his steps.

- The day before Saul even arrived, the Lord tells Samuel what's coming
  - He will encounter a man that he will anoint as king
  - Samuel knows this is about to happen
  - He doesn't know who or how but he's ready
- And Saul knows even less
  - In fact, the Lord's telling Samuel to expect the visit even before Saul has determined to enter the city
  - And yet he does enter
  - Which means every detail of Saul's day was under God's control
  - This is not unique to Saul and Samuel…this is how God is operating every day in every life
  - There is no such thing as coincidence in God's Creation
- God's instructions to Samuel carry an interesting element of mercy
  - The Lord says that this king he anoints will be used by God to free Israel from the Philistines who have returned to molesting the people
    - Even though they reject the Lord, He remains faithful
    - And though they will regret having a king, the Lord will continue to lead Israel through this man
    - This pattern of hearing the people cry and freeing them from their enemies is the pattern of Judges
    - So in this sense, we see the final cycle of judges playing out in Samuel's day with

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the rise of the monarchy

- Then Samuel sees Saul and the Lord says, this is the guy
  - Saul asks Samuel if he knows where the seer is, reminding us that Saul doesn't know Samuel
  - Samuel tells Saul he will spend some time with him
  - And to convince Saul that Samuel can help him, Samuel tells Saul exactly what he was seeking – which is a sure proof of Samuel's prophetic ability

- But then Samuel drops a bombshell on Saul
  - He says, isn't everything desirable in Israel appointed for you and your household?
    - This language doesn't specifically say, you will be the greatest in the land – but it implies as much
    - We can see that Samuel's words aren't lost on Saul, since he responds incredulously
  - He says, I'm in the least tribe of Israel – which was true
    - So in terms of human standards and priorities, how can he expect to ever be in a position to receive such honor in Israel?
    - And by human standards, he was correct
    - But of course, he didn't know what God was prepared to do

1Sam. 9:22 Then Samuel took Saul and his servant and brought them into the hall and gave them a place at the head of those who were invited, who were about thirty men.
1Sam. 9:23 Samuel said to the cook, "Bring the portion that I gave you, concerning which I said to you, 'Set it aside.'"
1Sam. 9:24 Then the cook took up the leg with what was on it and set it before Saul. And Samuel said, "Here is what has been reserved! Set it before you and eat, because it has been kept for you until the appointed time, since I said I have invited the people." So Saul ate with Samuel that day.
1Sam. 9:25 When they came down from the high place into the city, Samuel spoke with Saul on the roof.
1Sam. 9:26 And they arose early; and at daybreak Samuel called to Saul on the roof, saying, "Get up, that I may send you away." So Saul arose, and both he and Samuel went out into the street.
1Sam. 9:27 As they were going down to the edge of the city, Samuel said to Saul, "Say to the servant that he might go ahead of us and pass on, but you remain standing now, that I may proclaim the word of God to you."

- Apparently, Samuel had planned ahead after hearing the Lord pronounce that today would be the day he found the king
  - Samuel told the leaders of the city to assemble in a hall near the high place

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        - In this hall, he had a lavish feast planned with a cook assigned to prepare the lamb to Samuel's instructions
        - No one knew why they were assembled or who the guest of honor would be
        - Samuel was so confident in the Lord's word, he could make such an effort without fear of being disappointed
    - So as Saul greets Samuel, he is immediately invited to eat with everyone
        - And more than that, Samuel puts Saul at the head of the table where a king would be seated
        - And then Samuel calls for the cook to bring out the best portion of the animal for Saul to eat
        - Saul must have been thinking he was dreaming the whole time, or else he was suspicious this was a grand practical joke
- Then they return to the city and have a private evening discussion on the roof, which was a common meeting place in the cool night air
    - The setting was both more comfortable and private
        - Wouldn't you love to have heard that conversation?
        - Samuel explaining that the Lord had selected Saul to be a king, Israel's first monarch
        - And Saul asking questions trying to understand how all this is happening to him
        - Like someone winning a lottery he didn't even play
    - As the chapter ends, we see Samuel preparing to anoint Saul as the king
        - Next time we meet we'll pick up here

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- So now Israel will receive a king, a man that perfectly suits their desire to be ruled like all the other nations
    - And as we enter Chapter 10, the prophet Samuel anoints this new king

1Sam. 10:1 Then Samuel took the flask of oil, poured it on his head, kissed him and said, "Has not the LORD anointed you a ruler over His inheritance?

- Last week we learned Saul is young, strong, tall, handsome and seems to have a good heart
    - But in a sense, he's too perfect for the job
    - Historically speaking, Saul's selection runs contrary to God's usual pattern
    - God usually selects the least obvious option, the one you didn't see coming
- But Saul is the obvious candidate according to human expectations
    - He's the Ishmael in this story, not the Isaac; he's the Esau, not the Jacob
    - And it's Saul's perfect suitability to the job that becomes our first clue that the Lord is up to something unusual here
    - That the story of Saul is bigger than merely giving Israel a king
- Our second clue came also last week, when we learned that Saul is a Benjamite
    - Back in Genesis 49, at the end of Jacob's life, the Lord spoke prophetically concerning the future kings of Israel
    - Speaking of the tribe of Judah, the Lord declared:

Gen. 49:8 "Judah, your brothers shall praise you;
Your hand shall be on the neck of your enemies;
Your father's sons shall bow down to you.
Gen. 49:9 "Judah is a lion's whelp;
From the prey, my son, you have gone up.
He couches, he lies down as a lion,
And as a lion, who dares rouse him up?
Gen. 49:10 "The scepter shall not depart from Judah,
Nor the ruler's staff from between his feet,
Until Shiloh comes,
And to him shall be the obedience of the peoples.

- The prophecy for Judah was that this tribe would have dominion over the other tribes
    - Judah's reign was compared to a lion, the king of the beasts
        - And a scepter, the symbol of royal authority, would not depart from Judah's hand
        - Neither would a king's ruling staff be relinquished by Judah to another tribe

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        - In simple terms, Judah – and Judah alone – would rule over Israel
    - And that rule would continue from generation to generation within Judah until Shiloh comes, that is the Messiah comes to rule forever
        - In v.10 Jacob said once the tribe of Judah receives the right to rule, it can never be taken away
        - The Messiah Himself must come from Judah for that reason, to continue the reign as Jacob prophesied
- But when the time comes to anoint the first king of Israel, the Lord selects a Benjamite not a member of Judah
    - Does this mean that Saul is somehow an illegitimate king?
        - Or perhaps the Lord is making a mistake?
        - Or going back on His word?
    - None of those conclusions are correct, of course
        - Saul is very much a legitimate and anointed king
        - Saul will rule with the full authority of any other earthly king
        - And the Lord is certainly not making a mistake in selecting the man
    - But the Lord has selected Saul as king as an exception to prove the rule
        - One day the Lord will anoint a member of Judah as king as He promised
        - And when that day comes, only Judah may rule from that point forward
        - But that day hasn't come yet…so the Lord may appoint a Benjamite as the first king without breaking His word
- But why start outside the tribe of Judah at all?
    - Saul's reign will serve as an epilogue to the time of Judges and prologue to the kings of Judah
        - Judges was the time in Israel when men did what was right in their own eyes
        - And the final act of that period was to demand a king like all nations
        - They don't want the Lord to rule over them
        - They want to experience ruling by one like them
    - And that's who God gives them
        - A man who, like all the Israelites, was called into a special position with all the advantages God could give
        - And in the end, he will squander that opportunity in idolatry and greed – just as the Israelites did as a nation
    - We're watching the Lord conclude the time of Judges with a final example to the people
        - This is what follows from acting according to their own desires
        - Saul will be anointed and equipped to rule with the power of the Spirit

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        - But his life will serve as the example of what comes of seeking to live according to the flesh rather than Spirit
- In v.1 Samuel anoints Saul as king with a flask of oil
- This moment comes in the morning Samuel sends Saul off after their rooftop conference
    - Saul's head is still spinning with the news
    - But Samuel presses on, symbolizing the empowering of the Holy Spirit by pouring oil over Saul's head
    - Prior to this moment, only priests and the tabernacle were anointed by oil in scripture
    - Now we see a new office being anointed, that of king
- The use of oil is merely symbolic
    - The Spirit of God will empower this man to serve as king, but that moment hasn't come as yet
    - So to picture the Spirit's arrival, the prophet used oil
    - Still Saul must have been wondering if all this was to be believed
    - How could he know Samuel was telling the truth?
- Samuel says Saul will rule over God's inheritance
    - But this is probably a truncated version of Samuel's actual words
    - In the Septuagint, the full statement is:

1Sam. 10:1 **Then Samuel took a small container of olive oil and poured it on Saul's head. Samuel kissed him and said, "The LORD has chosen you to lead his people Israel! You will rule over the LORD's people and you will deliver them from the power of the enemies who surround them. This will be your sign that the LORD has chosen you as leader over his inheritance. (NET Bible)**

- As we see at the end of the LXX version, Saul is told he will receive signs that the prophet's word is trustworthy
    - Each sign Saul will receive involves a set of circumstances
        - Each circumstance is so specific that when they come to pass, they can only mean that the prophet has access to the mind of God
        - And in that way they validate the prophets' word concerning Saul's anointing as king
        - But each sign carries its own symbolic message to Saul concerning his new mission
        - So even as they provide confirmation, they also offer counsel

1Sam. 10:2 **"When you go from me today, then you will find two men close to**

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Rachel's tomb in the territory of Benjamin at Zelzah; and they will say to you, 'The donkeys which you went to look for have been found. Now behold, your father has ceased to be concerned about the donkeys and is anxious for you, saying, "What shall I do about my son?"'

- The first sign is connected to Saul's search for his lost donkeys
  - As Saul journeys home, he will encounter two men who tell him that the donkeys have been found
  - And he will find that his father's concern will have turned to Saul himself, just as Saul suggested earlier
  - Saul's father will say, "What shall I do about my son?"
  - But in Hebrew, the question is, "What of my son?" meaning what becomes of my son?
- Saul will encounter these men near the place Rachel was buried
  - Rachel was the beloved wife of Jacob
  - She bore Jacob's two favorite sons, Joseph and Benjamin
  - Rachel died in giving birth to Benjamin, who became the father of the Benjamites
- So what's the lesson here?
  - Saul's responsibility for his father's estate are no longer his concern
    - The Lord will care for Saul's father
    - This was an important relief for a son, who bore special responsibility to care for his father
  - Instead, the Lord has appointed this Benjamite to guard the Lord's inheritance
    - Remember Benjamin was the only son of Jacob to be born in the Promised Land, which is Israel's inheritance
    - The other eleven sons were born outside the land and only entered when Jacob returned
    - So the Lord has selected a Benjamite to steward the inheritance in which his tribe was born
  - In a sense, we can say that Saul was the natural heir of the land, since his forefather was born in it
    - But does the Lord's inheritance come by natural means?
    - Is it made available to those who qualify by earthly, human means?
    - Or does it require faith in the promises of God?
    - Even the number of men Saul meets reminds us that this is the dividing line among all men (2 is the number of division)
    - So Saul will be the exception to prove the rule
- Then Saul receives his second sign

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1Sam. 10:3 **"Then you will go on further from there, and you will come as far as the oak of Tabor, and there three men going up to God at Bethel will meet you, one carrying three young goats, another carrying three loaves of bread, and another carrying a jug of wine;**
1Sam. 10:4 **and they will greet you and give you two loaves of bread, which you will accept from their hand.**

- Journeying farther, Saul will come to the oak of Tabor where he will meet three men going to worship at Bethel
  - They carry items for the sacrifice including goats, bread and wine
  - When they encounter Saul, they will give him two loaves of the bread unsolicited
  - This he will accept from their hand
- These foods were reserved for the sacrifice to the Lord, but they will be given into Saul's hand
  - Obviously, this indicates a blessing for Saul in that the people will support his needs
  - But the fact that this provision was intended for the Lord before being redirected to Saul is a dark cloud over his reign
  - Saul will turn the opportunity to guard the inheritance of the people into a chance to enrich himself
  - He will abuse his power and seek to glorify himself
- Finally, Bethel is the place where Jacob saw the ladder coming down from Heaven
  - In that moment, Jacob made a "deal" with the Lord

Gen. 28:19 **He called the name of that place Bethel; however, previously the name of the city had been Luz.**
Gen. 28:20 **Then Jacob made a vow, saying, "If God will be with me and will keep me on this journey that I take, and will give me food to eat and garments to wear,**
Gen. 28:21 **and I return to my father's house in safety, then the LORD will be my God.**
Gen. 28:22 **"This stone, which I have set up as a pillar, will be God's house, and of all that You give me I will surely give a tenth to You."**

- Jacob made his willingness to obey and follow the Lord conditional on the Lord's willingness to care for him
  - But the Lord's faithfulness to Jacob had nothing to do with Jacob's faithfulness
  - It was because of a promise the Lord made to Abraham, Isaac and then Jacob
- Saul's second sign indicates that while Saul will ultimately be unfaithful, nevertheless the Lord will remain faithful

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- Saul's life is a story of shipwrecked faith
- But Saul is nevertheless a man saved by faith
- And the Lord remains faithful to him

- Finally, Saul's third sign

1Sam. 10:5 "Afterward you will come to the hill of God where the Philistine garrison is; and it shall be as soon as you have come there to the city, that you will meet a group of prophets coming down from the high place with harp, tambourine, flute, and a lyre before them, and they will be prophesying.
1Sam. 10:6 "Then the Spirit of the LORD will come upon you mightily, and you shall prophesy with them and be changed into another man.

- Saul eventually travels a little further to the southwest to Gibeon, the hill of God
  - There he is met by a group of prophets prophesying and Saul will join them
    - The Spirit of the Lord will come upon Saul and he will also prophesy
    - The simple message confirms to Saul he will receive the anointing of the Spirit, which is the ultimate confirmation of his selection as king
    - And by that Spirit he is equipped for every good work in serving the Lord
  - But as with the first two signs, the location foreshadows the sorry end to Saul's reign
    - Gibeon was originally a Hivite city
    - After the Israelites entered the land under Joshua, the people living in the city tricked Israel into forming a covenant with them
    - The covenant prevented Joshua and subsequent generations from conquering the city
    - And it required that Joshua defend the city
    - Joshua still enslaved the people to serve Israel
    - Later Joshua designated Gibeon a Levite city
  - At some point in Saul's reign he decided to break the covenant and conquer the city, attempting to put all in the city to death
    - We hear about this in 2 Samuel

2Sam. 21:1 Now there was a famine in the days of David for three years, year after year; and David sought the presence of the LORD. And the LORD said, "It is for Saul and his bloody house, because he put the Gibeonites to death."

- So this town becomes a legacy to Saul's greedy ambitions
  - Ultimately, the Gibeonites get to name their retribution for Saul's violation of the covenant

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    - They call for seven of Saul's descendants to be executed as retribution
    - David agrees, and then later buries the bodies of the seven plus the bones of Saul in Benjamin
- So Saul receives the Spirit of the Lord in the beginning, but in the end he dies without the Spirit
    - And he's back in the place he started
    - The tribe of Benjamin has its time as king
    - And then it's buried
    - Once again, Saul is the exception that proves the rule that 'not by might nor by power, but by My Spirit,' says the LORD
- And so it comes to pass as Samuel said

1Sam. 10:7 **"It shall be when these signs come to you, do for yourself what the occasion requires, for God is with you.**
1Sam. 10:8 **"And you shall go down before me to Gilgal; and behold, I will come down to you to offer burnt offerings and sacrifice peace offerings. You shall wait seven days until I come to you and show you what you should do."**
1Sam. 10:9 **Then it happened when he turned his back to leave Samuel, God changed his heart; and all those signs came about on that day.**
1Sam. 10:10 **When they came to the hill there, behold, a group of prophets met him; and the Spirit of God came upon him mightily, so that he prophesied among them.**
1Sam. 10:11 **It came about, when all who knew him previously saw that he prophesied now with the prophets, that the people said to one another, "What has happened to the son of Kish? Is Saul also among the prophets?"**
1Sam. 10:12 **A man there said, "Now, who is their father?" Therefore it became a proverb: "Is Saul also among the prophets?"**
1Sam. 10:13 **When he had finished prophesying, he came to the high place.**

- Samuel tells Saul that as he encounters these moments, particularly the final sign, do what the occasion requires
    - After these experiences, Samuel tells Saul he will meet him in Gilgal and they will offer sacrifices
        - With that Samuel dismisses Saul
        - And all that Samuel prophesied took place
    - But as Saul sets out on this journey, an important moment takes place near the beginning
        - We're told that the Lord "changed" Saul's heart
        - The wording here leaves little doubt concerning what happened

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        - To “change” a heart means the Lord takes a person’s spiritual natural and brings it to life
    - Why did Samuel include this statement in the narrative at this point?
        - First, it explains what’s coming next
        - Saul is about to prophesy showing the presence of the Lord’s Spirit
        - The man is being prepared for that intimate experience with the Lord
    - More importantly, this detail prepares us to interpret an event that comes later in Saul’s story in Chapter 16
        - The Spirit of the Lord will depart from Saul at that point
        - We’ll look at the significance of that moment when we get there
        - For now understand that the coming of the Spirit on Saul follows his heart change
        - So we know he has been made new by God’s Spirit
- When Saul reached the point of prophesying with the prophets in v.11, we’re told that the people were amazed to see the son of Kish suddenly among the prophets
    - Their shock was probably a result of Saul’s stunning appearance
        - Prophets were generally not a glamorous lot
        - Hebrews describes them as men who struck a rather pathetic pose
        - And rightly so, since they were usually mistreated by the very ones they came to inform
    - But then you have this really tall and really handsome young man working with the old, scraggly prophets
        - It must have been a striking sight
        - And the people are incredulous
        - So they ask if Saul is indeed one of the prophets now?
    - Saul prophesying is clear evidence to Saul and everyone else that the Lord’s Spirit was present and working in him
        - This was an outward display intended to demonstrate to the people that Saul was indeed selected by the Lord
        - This display is in keeping with how the Lord typically works by His Spirit
        - The Spirit of God works with the flesh of men to demonstrate the anointing and approval of God
- Notice in v.12 that someone asks “Who is their father?”
    - This question means where is this power coming from?
        - And the answer is the Lord in Heaven
        - He is prompting this display, which was the point
        - The people are supposed to see this display and make that conclusion

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- The people come to the wrong conclusion, however
  - They assume Saul has become a prophet
  - Time will soon tell that he hasn't become a prophet
  - He's become a king
  - But since this is the first time someone other than a prophet has been anointed by the Spirit, their confusion is understandable
  - Still, their mistake is memorialized in an idiom asking "Is Saul among the prophets??"
  - The question is ironic, because Saul will turn out to be the last person you might consider to be a true prophet
  - So the fact that some mistook him for a prophet later becomes ironic humor
- After this moment, Saul proceeds to the high place to await Samuel as instructed, and a conversation begins

1Sam. 10:14 Now Saul's uncle said to him and his servant, "Where did you go?" And he said, "To look for the donkeys. When we saw that they could not be found, we went to Samuel."
1Sam. 10:15 Saul's uncle said, "Please tell me what Samuel said to you."
1Sam. 10:16 So Saul said to his uncle, "He told us plainly that the donkeys had been found." But he did not tell him about the matter of the kingdom which Samuel had mentioned.

- Naturally, Saul's uncle asks what happened to him while he was away
  - Saul could have told him the whole story
  - Instead, he decides to only mention the donkeys
  - We could see this as an example of Saul's humility
  - Or we could see this as an example of his duplicity
- Now the time comes for the king to be revealed to the people

1Sam. 10:17 Thereafter Samuel called the people together to the LORD at Mizpah;
1Sam. 10:18 and he said to the sons of Israel, "Thus says the LORD, the God of Israel, 'I brought Israel up from Egypt, and I delivered you from the hand of the Egyptians and from the power of all the kingdoms that were oppressing you.'
1Sam. 10:19 "But you have today rejected your God, who delivers you from all your calamities and your distresses; yet you have said, 'No, but set a king over us!' Now therefore, present yourselves before the LORD by your tribes and by your clans."

- Samuel gives the people the reminder of why they are receiving a king

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- He reminds them that the Lord has been faithful to bring them out of Egypt and into the land by His own hand
  - Nevertheless, the people rejected the Lord's authority over them
  - And demanded a king to rule them
  - Nothing good can come from a decision forged in a desire to end the Lord's rule over His people
  - So we know that whatever comes next will necessarily be a problem
- And so Samuel says to the people, with an ominous tone, that it's time to stand before Lord and get what they asked for

1Sam. 10:20 Thus Samuel brought all the tribes of Israel near, and the tribe of Benjamin was taken by lot.
1Sam. 10:21 Then he brought the tribe of Benjamin near by its families, and the Matrite family was taken. And Saul the son of Kish was taken; but when they looked for him, he could not be found.
1Sam. 10:22 Therefore they inquired further of the LORD, "Has the man come here yet?" So the LORD said, "Behold, he is hiding himself by the baggage."
1Sam. 10:23 So they ran and took him from there, and when he stood among the people, he was taller than any of the people from his shoulders upward.
1Sam. 10:24 Samuel said to all the people, "Do you see him whom the LORD has chosen? Surely there is no one like him among all the people." So all the people shouted and said, "Long live the king!"
1Sam. 10:25 Then Samuel told the people the ordinances of the kingdom, and wrote them in the book and placed it before the LORD. And Samuel sent all the people away, each one to his house.
1Sam. 10:26 Saul also went to his house at Gibeah; and the valiant men whose hearts God had touched went with him.
1Sam. 10:27 But certain worthless men said, "How can this one deliver us?" And they despised him and did not bring him any present. But he kept silent.

- At this point, we might expect that Samuel would just point to Saul and announce he was the king
  - But that's not how the selection took place
    - Saul rises to king in three steps
    - First, he was anointed by Samuel, indicating that the Lord had determined to elevate him to that position
    - But this anointing was entirely a private affair between Samuel and Saul
  - Now that the time has come for the people to recognize their new leader, the Lord orchestrates a public moment to designate Saul
    - In v.20 a lot is taken to designate which tribe would produce the king

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        - And Benjamin is chosen by lot
        - Then the Matrite family, which was Saul's family
        - Finally, Saul is named by lot
    - Clearly, this shows that the Lord was working to ensure the process of lots arrived at the proper person
        - The process may have looked random to an outsider
        - But the people of Israel understood instinctively that the outcome was a reflection of the Lord's will
        - And it's still a truth today, that no outcome in life is outside the control of the Lord
- When it fell to Saul, they couldn't find him
    - So the people inquired of the Lord, through Samuel, has this man come yet?
        - In other words, they wonder if perhaps he has yet to be born
        - But Samuel answers that Saul is hiding among the baggage
        - The word for baggage is a general Hebrew word for armory or furniture or jars
        - So it's likely Saul was hiding behind vessels used in the sacrificial worship at this altar
    - It's comical, of course, but why is Saul hiding?
        - It seems to be a combination of fear and humility
        - Saul is not seeking to elevate himself at this point, which is admirable
        - And so the people go looking for him
        - And when they find him, they realize he is a head taller than anyone else in Israel
        - Certainly, this man must be the one God has chosen, because…well, just look at him!
- This is the first confirmation that the Lord's plan to appeal to the fleshly desires of the people has been successful
    - The people are taken by Saul's physique
        - Samuel feeds their fleshly response saying, "See, there is no one else like this guy"
        - And to that we get the predictable response, "Long live the king"
        - In other words, the people are convinced that Saul is a perfect match because of his appearance
        - To be fair, they know he was selected by lots too
    - But I wonder what their response might have been if the lots had fallen upon a weak, short and comely fellow
        - Would the people have been so quick to embrace him?

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        - Probably not
        - And in time their fleshly impulses will prove their undoing
    - Samuel tells the people the ordinances of the king, which are the rules that guide a king in Israel
        - These were probably similar to the rules Samuel gave the people in the first place
        - The king will do whatever he wishes
        - And the people will have no recourse
- Saul then retreats to his home in Gibeah, which is only about three miles north of the Old City of Jerusalem
    - You can stand on Gibeah today, a suburb of the city of Jerusalem, and see the old city clearly
        - In that sense, we could say that Saul was close
        - But he misses the mark
        - He was God's choice, yes
        - But it was a response to the people's sinful desires
        - And so he is the exception that will ultimately prove the rule
- God knew that Saul needed more than merely popular support to reign
    - He would need military might to ensure he could consolidate power as king
        - So the Lord inclines the hearts of valiant men to support and defend their new king
        - These men accompany Saul to his home
    - But all is not well in this new kingdom
        - Some worthless fellows decided that this man couldn't be the right choice
        - So immediately Saul is faced with opposition
        - As we'll see, the Lord was committed to Saul, even though He's appointed a man of the people's choosing, not a man after God's heart
        - He will defend Saul against these worthless fellows
    - Saul was not without wisdom however
        - So he was wisely overlooked their opposition for the time being
        - There would be a time to consolidate his power
        - And now was not that time

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- The reign of Saul has begun
  - He is celebrated by the people and anointed by the Spirit
    - And as he begins his reign, he will be tested early
    - But the Lord will show Himself through Saul to confirm Saul's authority as king
  - This is an important early step for Saul, since being king isn't merely about personal charisma or good looks
    - The people need to know that Saul isn't merely a poser
    - Yet we know that Saul has no formal training for this role
    - So it's entirely likely that Saul could be in way over his head
    - But the Lord's Spirit rests on Saul and that's all the preparation he needs for the job
  - The story begins in Chapter 11

1Sam. 11:1 Now Nahash the Ammonite came up and besieged Jabesh-gilead; and all the men of Jabesh said to Nahash, "Make a covenant with us and we will serve you."
1Sam. 11:2 But Nahash the Ammonite said to them, "I will make it with you on this condition, that I will gouge out the right eye of every one of you, thus I will make it a reproach on all Israel."
1Sam. 11:3 The elders of Jabesh said to him, "Let us alone for seven days, that we may send messengers throughout the territory of Israel. Then, if there is no one to deliver us, we will come out to you."
1Sam. 11:4 Then the messengers came to Gibeah of Saul and spoke these words in the hearing of the people, and all the people lifted up their voices and wept.
1Sam. 11:5 Now behold, Saul was coming from the field behind the oxen, and he said, "What is the matter with the people that they weep?" So they related to him the words of the men of Jabesh.

- The story begins with an Ammonite named Nahash
  - The Ammonites were the longtime enemies of Israel, living east of the Jordan
    - They are the descendants of Ammon, one of the sons from Lot's incestuous relationship with his daughters
    - They have long tormented the Israelites
  - Earlier in the book of Judges, the Ammonites had been defeated under the judge Japhthah
    - Now we hear of an Ammonite named Nahash who seems to be intent on exacting revenge for the earlier defeat
    - He attacks at a place in the Jordan river valley about 25 miles south of the Sea of Galilee

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        - The town is called Jabesh-gilead and it apparently had no chance to defend itself against the Ammonites
    - So the men of the town offer to surrender to the Ammonites
        - In return they ask for a covenant of peace
        - A covenant would have committed the Ammonites to preserve and defend the people of the city
        - They would have still been slaves of the Ammonites, but at least they wouldn't be killed
- In v.2 Nahash, whose name means serpent, replies that he will make a covenant if every person in the city agrees to have their right eye gouged out
    - While this may sound especially cruel – and certainly it is harsh treatment – it was not an unusual request
        - Taking the right eye of an enemy vanquished in battle was a custom of the day
        - The point of maiming someone in this way was to eliminate their effectiveness in battle
        - Without a right eye, warriors couldn't aim a bow and arrow
        - And a soldier couldn't look out behind a shield that protected the left eye
    - Furthermore as Nahash says, the effect would be to make the people a reproach in the land
        - Their lack of two eyes would forever mark them as defeated vassals of the Ammonites
        - This is certainly a stiff penalty to keep your earthly life
- In response the people tell Nahash to give them seven days to see if they can find a better offer
    - They are looking for defenders willing to lay their lives on the line to defend the city
        - Now why would Nahash agree to this condition?
        - The only explanation is that Nahash had little reason to think help would come
    - Remember, we're at the end of the time of judges when the nation did what was right in their own eyes
        - Which means they didn't operate as a single nation
        - Each tribe and city lived semi-independently and often with disregard for sister tribes
        - And Nahash assumes no one else is going to take up the invitation to enter into a battle to the death for this city
        - So he's willing to wait a week to get what he wants without a battle
- When word reaches Saul's town, the people react with weeping out of sympathy for their brothers in Jabesh-gilead
    - They weep assuming nothing could be done to stop this assault

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        - Israel doesn't have a standing army
        - And they have lost their warring strength for the most part
        - So the people naturally assume they have no way to save this town
    - Then Saul hears about the threats
        - Interestingly, we find him plowing his field
        - He is the king of the land and yet he's simply returned to the work he did before
    - Why is Saul not acting as king?
        - The likely answer is that Saul didn't know what else to do as king
        - There was no palace to move into
        - There was no calendar of kingly events to attend to
        - And he still needed to eat
    - Also, this willingness to return to everyday activities continues to suggest he is a humble man at this point
        - He has no expectations for himself
        - Perhaps Saul has begun to wonder if his new title means anything more than a ceremonial role
        - We can only speculate, but all that is about to change for Saul

1Sam. 11:6 Then the Spirit of God came upon Saul mightily when he heard these words, and he became very angry.
1Sam. 11:7 He took a yoke of oxen and cut them in pieces, and sent them throughout the territory of Israel by the hand of messengers, saying, "Whoever does not come out after Saul and after Samuel, so shall it be done to his oxen." Then the dread of the Lord fell on the people, and they came out as one man.
1Sam. 11:8 He numbered them in Bezek; and the sons of Israel were 300,000, and the men of Judah 30,000.
1Sam. 11:9 They said to the messengers who had come, "Thus you shall say to the men of Jabesh-gilead, 'Tomorrow, by the time the sun is hot, you will have deliverance.'" So the messengers went and told the men of Jabesh; and they were glad.

- Notice at the outset that the Spirit of the Lord comes upon Saul in a mighty way
    - The Spirit's power and direction is responsible for the sequence of events that follows, which tells us that the Lord is working to create the outcome
        - But take note first that the Spirit is said to come upon Saul
        - This suggests the Spirit was not already with Saul
        - Yet we saw earlier in this book when the Spirit came upon Saul and changed his heart

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- This is evidence that the work of the Spirit in this time doesn't involve a permanent indwelling
  - The Spirit comes at a time for a purpose
  - But then He may depart and that departure isn't necessarily an indication that the Spirit disapproves of or has abandoned the individual
  - It simply reflects the difference in the ministry of the Spirit in this day compared to the Church age
  - The Spirit comes as goes as needed to effect the outcome the Lord desires
- The effect of the Spirit's arrival in this moment is to fill Saul with righteous anger, bold courage and wisdom
  - Saul had a family connection to this town
  - During the civil war at the end of Judges, the tribe of Benjamin was so devastated the remaining men took wives from this town
  - So Saul is angered over the prospect of his people suffering
- So he immediately takes a yoke of oxen plowing his field and kills them on the spot in the field
  - And he took the pieces of oxen and called messengers to carry them throughout the land of Israel calling for "volunteers" for the fight
  - He says that "Saul and Samuel" call for men to join the fight, to remind the people that he was anointed by Samuel
- The point of the oxen pieces is obvious: refusing your king's request meant losing your livelihood as farmers
  - No oxen meant no animals to work the field
  - And Saul chose this sign because he anticipated that the people might refuse his request by citing the need to remain in the fields and plow
  - So Saul takes that excuse away, since without oxen they will have no need to remain in the fields
- Saul's choice to cut up the animal also harkens back to another event that took place in his home town
  - That event is recorded in Judges 19
  - We'll cover it in our Judges story

- Notice that the people felt the "dread of the Lord"
  - That's a term we don't hear often
    - The "dread of the Lord" can also be translated the "fear of the Lord"
    - And that's a phrase we know well
    - It means that men and women realize they are being called to obey the Lord
    - And they are concerned with the consequences of not doing so
  - This is a healthy state for God's people

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- In our modern, "enlightened" culture we assume that fear is never a good thing
- But that's not the Bible's perspective
- Fear of the Lord is a very good thing
- Luke tells us that fear of the Lord is external evidence that a church is healthy

Acts 9:31 **So the church throughout all Judea and Galilee and Samaria enjoyed peace, being built up; and going on in the fear of the Lord and in the comfort of the Holy Spirit, it continued to increase.**

- Fear of displeasing the Lord and fearing the consequences of sin is absolutely the best place a Christian can be in a fallen world
  - And it's the absence of this perspective that leads men and women to feel comfortable with sin
  - And comfort with sin is never preferable to fear of the Lord
- In this case, the fear of the Lord led the nation to respond in the right way by coming to fight in Saul's army
  - A total of 330,000 men assemble in response to Saul's call
    - This is by far the greatest military force assembled in Israel since the days of Joshua 300 years earlier
    - They are assembled in Bezek, which is about 16 miles from Jabesh-gilead
  - The number is notably specific
    - 300,000 and 30,000 points to the Lord's work in raising this army, the number 3 being the number of God
    - So here's the Spirit driving the people to respect the authority of God's anointed
  - Finally, Saul tells the messengers to send word to the city that they will be rescued before the end of the afternoon the following day
    - Remember Saul has only seven days to bring this fight to the city
    - This includes travel time
    - So we know these events are unfolding rapidly
    - And when the city hears the news, they are glad for obvious reasons

1Sam. 11:10 **Then the men of Jabesh said, "Tomorrow we will come out to you, and you may do to us whatever seems good to you."**
1Sam. 11:11 **The next morning Saul put the people in three companies; and they came into the midst of the camp at the morning watch and struck down the Ammonites until the heat of the day. Those who survived were scattered, so that no two of them were left together.**

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- The next day was the seventh day, and so the city owed a response to Nahash
  - To buy some time, the men of the city cleverly say to Nahash they will come out of the city tomorrow and he may do whatever seems good
    - In Hebrew, the words they spoke were a little different
    - They say, you can do what is right in your eyes
    - It's a way of suggesting they are ready to have their eyes put out
    - And yet they know they are merely drawing the army out into the open where they can be defeated by Saul
  - The next morning Saul approaches with three companies of men, probably about 100,000 in each
    - This is a huge force and probably dwarfed the Ammonites
    - Since the Israelites hadn't mustered a force of this size in three centuries, we can be sure the Ammonites were not expecting such an opponent
  - Saul routs the army of the Ammonites, scattering them so far apart that no man stood with another
    - This is a huge victory for Saul, one the people never expected
    - We know they didn't expect it because just a week earlier they were weeping at the news of the Ammonites' threats
    - No one could have anticipated that Israel could act in unison and with such power and success
  - This was something altogether new
    - The time of Judges was a time when the people did what each person thought was right and best for himself
    - It was a selfish and hedonistic culture
    - Judges only managed to hold the people to God's law for short periods of time
    - But inevitably the people turned back to their fleshly desires
  - Their individualistic sin led to ruin time and time again, so the prospect of uniting in service to God and to great effect was virtually unknown in the land
    - But now under a king the people had a taste of what was possible when led by God's anointed
    - And they are excited for what the future under a king means
    - And they are determined to put to an end any dissension against the Lord's anointed

1Sam. 11:12 Then the people said to Samuel, "Who is he that said, 'Shall Saul reign over us?' Bring the men, that we may put them to death."
1Sam. 11:13 But Saul said, "Not a man shall be put to death this day, for today the Lord has accomplished deliverance in Israel."
1Sam. 11:14 Then Samuel said to the people, "Come and let us go to Gilgal and

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renew the kingdom there."
1Sam. 11:15 **So all the people went to Gilgal, and there they made Saul king before the Lord in Gilgal. There they also offered sacrifices of peace offerings before the Lord; and there Saul and all the men of Israel rejoiced greatly.**

- We remember at the end of Chapter 10 that some men were dissenting at the coronation of Saul as king
  - At that time we're told Saul said nothing in response to their objections
    - Saul knew he was in no position to fight them anyway
    - This was a wise decision on his part
    - Engaging in a fight before you have the high ground is suicide
  - But now Saul has the high ground so to speak
    - He has won a great military victory
    - And the manner of the assembly and the outcome testify to the Lord's working in Saul
    - So the people aren't just pleased with the victory, but they realize the Lord is at work in this man
  - So this is the right moment for Saul to consolidate power knowing he has the support of all the people
    - Yet when they suggest the dissenters be put to death, Saul stops them
    - Once again, Saul's heart seems to be in the right place
    - He remarks that this is a victory won by the Lord for His people
    - And therefore this is not the right time for vengeance
    - We all celebrate this victory
  - Saul's magnanimous gesture is a face-saving way for his enemies to rethink their opposition
    - Saul isn't unwilling to challenge his opposition
    - He is simply giving them a chance to pledge their allegiance
    - This is a far more effective strategy to consolidating power
    - It's far better to consolidate without bloodshed than by bloodshed
- Therefore, Saul calls for the people to join him in a second coronation, one absent dissenting voices
  - This is the opportunity for those who previously opposed Saul to change their minds publicly
    - When the coronation happens, these men will be among those bowing to the king
    - And with that gesture, Saul puts an end to an opposition

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- This also appears to have been a moment when the nation recommitted itself to the covenant of Moses
  - They offer peace sacrifices to the Lord
  - This seems to indicate that they are reconciling with the Lord to the terms of that covenant
- All of this is an artful and wise way for Saul to shore up his position as king in the land
  - And Samuel is recording these details to reflect Saul's strong starting point in his role
  - The Lord anointed Saul and empowered him for service
  - And he's doing well, showing patience, mercy and fortitude
- But this is only a start
  - This is the first of three times that Saul and Samuel will meet at Gilgal
  - The second time will be a turning point in Saul's reign as king when he turns from good to bad
  - And the third will bring Saul's reign to an end

- For the past three chapters, we've been talking about the rise of a king in Israel
  - In Chapter 8 the people asked for a king and Samuel responded
    - Specifically, he warned the people that asking for a king would result in bad things happening
    - But then the story moves forward to the selection of Saul
    - And eventually in Chapter 11 we see his success on the battlefield
    - And all the while he seems humble and reasonable
  - What happened to the problems?
    - Well they are coming, but Samuel first wants to emphasize the good start any man can produce
    - In fact, to reinforce Saul's good start, Samuel tells the same story twice
    - In the next three chapters we again hear a warning from Samuel
    - Followed by Saul's adventures and success in battle with a humble heart
    - But then the pattern will begin to change
- Let's look at the beginning of that second pattern, starting with Samuel issuing yet another warning to the people about following a king

1Sam. 12:1 **Then Samuel said to all Israel, "Behold, I have listened to your voice in all that you said to me and I have appointed a king over you.**
1Sam. 12:2 **"Now, here is the king walking before you, but I am old and gray, and behold my sons are with you. And I have walked before you from my youth even to this day.**

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1Sam. 12:3 "Here I am; bear witness against me before the Lord and His anointed. Whose ox have I taken, or whose donkey have I taken, or whom have I defrauded? Whom have I oppressed, or from whose hand have I taken a bribe to blind my eyes with it? I will restore it to you."
1Sam. 12:4 They said, "You have not defrauded us or oppressed us or taken anything from any man's hand."
1Sam. 12:5 He said to them, "The Lord is witness against you, and His anointed is witness this day that you have found nothing in my hand." And they said, "He is witness."

- Samuel's second warning is beginning to sound a little personal, as if Samuel has been personally wounded by their rejection
  - But in reality he's simply making a point about the state of their hearts
    - He reminds them that when he was in charge as judge, he had done nothing wrong in his service to the people
    - And the people confirm his assertion in v.4
    - And Samuel goes an extra step and asks for anyone to testify to the contrary before God whether Samuel has defrauded anyone
  - Now we remember that Samuel's sons were a problem in these ways, and it was Samuel himself that recorded his son's exploits in this book
    - But Samuel also wants the record to reflect that he was not a bad judge
    - And furthermore, the call for a king was not the result of his mismanagement of the people
    - Though they pointed to his sons as a cause, in reality it was simply their own desires leading them there
  - He also says I'm old and I've served you my whole life
    - We also know this is true as earlier chapters told us
    - Samuel was working in the tabernacle from an early age
  - But nevertheless, it was the people who came to him and demanded a king
    - He didn't suggest it; rather, he listened to their voice
    - So the rise of a king in Israel could never have been said to be a result of Samuel's errors
    - He hadn't been unfaithful to his role in service to the people
    - They brought it upon themselves
- So with that out of the way, Samuel proceeds to testify that their rejection of the Lord was also wholly unjustified

1Sam. 12:6 Then Samuel said to the people, "It is the Lord who appointed Moses and Aaron and who brought your fathers up from the land of Egypt.

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1Sam. 12:7 **"So now, take your stand, that I may plead with you before the Lord concerning all the righteous acts of the Lord which He did for you and your fathers.**
1Sam. 12:8 **"When Jacob went into Egypt and your fathers cried out to the Lord, then the Lord sent Moses and Aaron who brought your fathers out of Egypt and settled them in this place.**
1Sam. 12:9 **"But they forgot the Lord their God, so He sold them into the hand of Sisera, captain of the army of Hazor, and into the hand of the Philistines and into the hand of the king of Moab, and they fought against them.**
1Sam. 12:10 **"They cried out to the Lord and said, 'We have sinned because we have forsaken the Lord and have served the Baals and the Ashtaroth; but now deliver us from the hands of our enemies, and we will serve You.'**
1Sam. 12:11 **"Then the Lord sent Jerubbaal and Bedan and Jephthah and Samuel, and delivered you from the hands of your enemies all around, so that you lived in security.**
1Sam. 12:12 **"When you saw that Nahash the king of the sons of Ammon came against you, you said to me, 'No, but a king shall reign over us,' although the Lord your God was your king.**

- Samuel's testimony before the people is of the Lord's faithfulness in the face of the people's repeated unfaithfulness
  - The Lord promised to bring Israel out of Egypt, which He did
    - The Lord sent a deliverer to the people
    - And kept His word spoken to Abraham centuries earlier
    - In v.9 Samuel says that when the people entered the land, they sinned against Him by entering into idolatry
  - He's summarizing the entire book of Judges in a few verses
    - The cycle of sin and rebellion was repeated throughout the years of the judges
    - Yet each time the people cried out for relief, the Lord responded with mercy for the people
    - Repeatedly, the Lord sent judges to rescue the people, men like Gideon, Jephthah and lastly Samuel
  - And now the people found Nahash coming against them, and though before they cried to God for deliverance this time they cried for a king to save them
    - Here is the the turning point Samuel wants to emphasize
    - The people have long been unfaithful to the Lord
    - And He has routinely responded with discipline through the oppression of Israel's enemies
    - And this pattern was exactly what the Lord promised to do when He set forth the terms of the Mosaic Covenant with the people

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        - And He has also been faithful to secure the victory when the people asked
        - But this time they didn't ask the Lord
- Now we know the Lord worked through Saul just as He had the judges
    - But Samuel's point is how the hearts of the people are changing, not how the Lord is changing
        - The Lord has and will remain faithful
        - But the people are moving steadily away from a reliance on the Lord
        - And the central problem with seeking a king is the way it puts further distance between the people and their dependence on the Lord
    - This still happens for us today
        - The more we become self-dependent or at least imagine ourselves to be self-sufficient, the more we forget how utterly dependent we truly are on the Lord
        - This is the nature of sinful flesh…we imagine ourselves to be little gods at all times, in control of everything
        - The people of Israel were willing to turn to a human king over an all-power God because our flesh is always more attracted to fleshly things
        - Spiritual solutions generally take a backseat to something of the world
        - And now that the people have a king, they will turn to him before seeking the Lord
    - Now the irony is that the Lord is still on the throne and ruling, even through a king
        - But our awareness of Him has been diminished
        - And our flesh begins to overrule our spirit
        - That's Samuel's concern and his warning for the people as he watches them seek after and celebrate Saul's victory
        - Even though in the past the Lord has been faithful to provide these victories once the people's heart has turned back to Him
- Samuel makes this very point next

1Sam. 12:13 **"Now therefore, here is the king whom you have chosen, whom you have asked for, and behold, the Lord has set a king over you.**
1Sam. 12:14 **"If you will fear the Lord and serve Him, and listen to His voice and not rebel against the command of the Lord, then both you and also the king who reigns over you will follow the Lord your God.**
1Sam. 12:15 **"If you will not listen to the voice of the Lord, but rebel against the command of the Lord, then the hand of the Lord will be against you, as it was against your fathers.**

- Samuel says this gate swings both ways

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- Even though you have selected a king over you, both you and your king must continue to seek and serve the Lord just as was expected in the time of Judges
- If you do these things, then both the people and the king will prosper according to the terms of the covenant
- If you fail to obey the Lord, then everyone will suffer
- In other words, having a king doesn't change the covenant or the people's requirement to know, follow and obey the Lord

- And then Samuel gives the people a sign from the Lord to confirm his words and the people respond

1Sam. 12:16 "Even now, take your stand and see this great thing which the Lord will do before your eyes.
1Sam. 12:17 "Is it not the wheat harvest today? I will call to the Lord, that He may send thunder and rain. Then you will know and see that your wickedness is great which you have done in the sight of the Lord by asking for yourselves a king."
1Sam. 12:18 So Samuel called to the Lord, and the Lord sent thunder and rain that day; and all the people greatly feared the Lord and Samuel.
1Sam. 12:19 Then all the people said to Samuel, "Pray for your servants to the Lord your God, so that we may not die, for we have added to all our sins this evil by asking for ourselves a king."
1Sam. 12:20 Samuel said to the people, "Do not fear. You have committed all this evil, yet do not turn aside from following the Lord, but serve the Lord with all your heart.
1Sam. 12:21 "You must not turn aside, for then you would go after futile things which can not profit or deliver, because they are futile.
1Sam. 12:22 "For the Lord will not abandon His people on account of His great name, because the Lord has been pleased to make you a people for Himself.
1Sam. 12:23 "Moreover, as for me, far be it from me that I should sin against the Lord by ceasing to pray for you; but I will instruct you in the good and right way.
1Sam. 12:24 "Only fear the Lord and serve Him in truth with all your heart; for consider what great things He has done for you.
1Sam. 12:25 "But if you still do wickedly, both you and your king will be swept away."

- Samuel proves that his words are spoken under the inspiration of the Spirit by use of a supernatural sign
  - This sign was performed in order to validate the word of the prophet before the people
    - And they certainly get the point

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        - The fear of the Lord returns for the people, leading them to confess their sin and pledge obedience
        - These are nice words, but Samuel knows they are empty unless backed by action
    - So Samuel repeats that they cannot place their trust in fruitless things
        - The Lord is here to stay and His relationship with His people will not come to an end
        - They cannot escape accountability to the covenant He established with them
        - Furthermore, Samuel will continue in his role to guide and pray for the people even as they have asked for a king
- The ultimate course for this people is to fear the Lord, serve Him in truth and consider the great things the Lord has done for His people
    - I recommend you circle v.24 in your Bible
        - Meditate on Samuel's counsel
        - If you want to remain in the pleasure of the Lord, repeat these three spiritual disciplines and watch how it impacts your obedience
    - First, Samuel says fear the Lord
        - We've already spoken on the spiritual value of maintaining a healthy fear of the Lord's judgment and the consequences of not pleasing Him
        - Never let go of that perspective and you will be in a good position to choose right over wrong
        - Your flesh will be disciplined by your fear
        - And you will see yourself becoming more Christ-like as the Spirit uses that fear to motivate your good behavior
    - Secondly, serve the Lord in truth
        - Samuel joins two principles into one
        - Serving the Lord means devoting your life's purpose to the purposes of God and His glory and His kingdom
        - Make your life about that outcome and do so informed by the truth of Scripture
        - Studying and understanding God's word is essential to uncovering God's purposes in your life and in your ministry
        - So study the word to know God's will and then seek to serve that will in your goals and priorities of life
    - Finally, Samuel says consider the great things the Lord has done for you – beginning with your salvation
        - Make regular observance of all His provision, mercy, kindness and love for you
        - Talk to your family and friends about all the Lord has done and is doing to care for you and grow you in Christ
        - Keep these things on the front of your mind, and you will be less tempted to

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stray after worldly offers for the same

- Just as Israel should have remembered the Lord's faithfulness to them, instead of thinking about what earthly kings could give them
- This is a great antidote to our flesh's desire for the next big thing instead of resting in the Lord

- With these reminders, Samuel ends with a final warning
  - If they do wicked things, expect the Lord to bring a judgment upon the people
    - And no earthly king will be able to save them or stop the judgment
    - The Lord remains on His throne

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- Last week we noticed a pattern in Samuel's narrative of Saul's early time as king
  - The pattern serves to introduce Saul while foreshadowing where the nation was headed under his leadership
    - The pattern consisted of three parts in Samuel's narrative
    - He begins with a warning to the people about seeking a king instead of the Lord
    - Secondly, Samuel explains Saul's exploits emphasizing his humble heart
    - Finally, Saul is called into a climactic battle to demonstrate the Lord was working through him to care for God's people
  - We've gone through this pattern once already in the earlier chapters
    - And we've started the second go 'round
    - In Chapter 12 last week, we finished the lesson hearing Samuel's second warning to the people
  - The second warning was more intense
    - Samuel describes Saul as the king whom you have chosen, that you asked for
    - In other words, the people have made their bed and they are about to lie in it
    - And a king won't save the people from God's judgment when they disobey the covenant
    - Both the people and the king will be swept away
- Chapter 12 formally ends the period of Judges in the history of Israel
  - Now the people are ruled by a king
    - But the prophets will still be a part of the scene
    - Kings will not have the word of God
    - And as kings go wrong, it will fall to prophets to keep them and the people honest
  - And herein lies the key problem with Israel's demand of a king
    - Kings are people too, and like all men they will sin
    - When the people sinned in the past, the Lord spoke through a prophet to judge the people
    - They could listen to the word spoken through the judge, repent and be rescued from God's judgment
    - In that way, the Lord was judging His people, and by the counsel of God's word, the people were rescued from their own sin
  - But what happens when the person speaking the word of God is no longer the most powerful person in the land?
    - What happens when a sinful king begins to lead the people away from God?
    - What will such a man say to a prophet who comes to give him counsel and correct him and the nation?

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        - Do we think a monarch will receive such critique gladly?
        - It would take a very humble, godly sort to receive the rebuke of a prophet
        - And most kings aren't that sort
- So from this point forward, Israel has made it much more difficult for the word of God to counsel them away from destruction and into obedience
    - God will remain faithful, so He will continue to send prophets to the king and to the people
        - But more often than not, the prophet will not be heard
        - Instead, the king, who doesn't like his power to be challenged or his sin to be rebuked, will lead the people in persecuting the prophets
        - Such that most prophets will be martyred as a result
        - Culminating in Christ's own death
- There's a bit of irony in all this
    - Samuel gave Saul his power
    - And as Samuel anointed the king, he declared that the people were wrong to want him
    - Suggesting to Saul that he shouldn't even have the job
    - And at first, Saul didn't want the job
    - But then he took it knowing that this was an unwise move
- So Saul should have determined to lean heavily on Samuel's counsel and rebuke
    - Had he done so, God's word spoken through the prophet would have still been front and center
    - And the people and their king might have avoided the problems Samuel warned would come
    - But of course that doesn't happen
    - Saul becomes the instrument to fulfill the prophecy spoken against him and Israel
- Speaking of Saul's downfall, let's move back to Samuel's three part pattern
    - The next part covering Saul's exploits begins in Chapter 13

1Sam. 13:1 **Saul was thirty years old when he began to reign, and he reigned forty two years over Israel.**
1Sam. 13:2 **Now Saul chose for himself 3,000 men of Israel, of which 2,000 were with Saul in Michmash and in the hill country of Bethel, while 1,000 were with Jonathan at Gibeah of Benjamin. But he sent away the rest of the people, each to his tent.**
1Sam. 13:3 **Jonathan smote the garrison of the Philistines that was in Geba, and the Philistines heard of it. Then Saul blew the trumpet throughout the land, saying, "Let the Hebrews hear."**

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1Sam. 13:4 **All Israel heard the news that Saul had smitten the garrison of the Philistines, and also that Israel had become odious to the Philistines. The people were then summoned to Saul at Gilgal.**

- For such a simple statement, there is a remarkable amount of controversy surrounding v.1 of this chapter
  - The controversy begins in the original Hebrew manuscripts
    - The original manuscripts are all missing numbers of Saul's age and all but the final number of the years he ruled
    - In fact, the Dead Sea Scrolls are missing v.1 altogether
    - In the Hebrew manuscripts that do include v.1, the words read:

Saul was . . . years old when he began to reign, and he reigned . . . two years over Israel."

- This is the only verse in scripture to address Saul's age when he began to rule
  - So without the missing number, we're left guessing about Saul's age
  - The NASB proposes 30 years old
  - Other versions propose 40 years old
  - Some versions simply show nothing in keeping with the original Hebrew
  - That leads to the first controversy
- The second controversy is how long Saul reigned
  - We know he reigned longer than 2 years but how much longer?
    - But what number do we place in front of the 2?
    - Well, in acts 13:21 we're told

Acts 13:21 **"Then they asked for a king, and God gave them Saul the son of Kish, a man of the tribe of Benjamin, for forty years.**

- So Acts says Saul reigned for 40 years
  - So where does the "2" enter in?
  - Perhaps Saul reigned 42 years and the time given in Acts 13 was merely rounded down
  - Or perhaps Saul reigned exactly 40 years as Acts says
  - In which case we conclude Samuel was recording the number of years Saul had been ruling when the events of Chapter 13 came to pass
- And if you believe Samuel was giving the total number of Saul's reign, then you

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introduce a third controversy

- When did the events of Chapter 13 take place?
- Did they happen early in the 42 years or later? It's hard to know

- There are various attempts to resolves these mysteries
  - I've looked at these various explanations, and I have my opinion
    - I believe the second part of v.1 was intended to time the events of Chapter 13
    - So it reads correctly to say 2 years
    - The events of Chapter 13 happened 2 years into Saul's reign
    - Therefore, Saul's total reign was 40 years just as Acts 13 says, not 42 years as the NASB concluded
  - That's leaves only the controversy over the age of Saul
    - Some translations conclude Saul was thirty when he began to rule
    - They take this view primarily because if Saul ruled 40 years, then he died in battle at age 70, which is fairly old
    - This camp finds it hard to imagine that anyone older than 70 could have entered into battle
    - Plus a younger age of 30 seems to fit better with the description of a young Saul in the earlier chapters of 1 Samuel
  - But other translations like the NASB favor an interpretation of 40 years old
    - They take this view because of v.3 in this chapter
    - In v.3 we're told that Jonathan leads an army into battle, which means he must have been at least 20 or older
    - If Saul began to rule at the age of 30 and this battle happened two years into Saul's reign…
      - Then Saul would have fathered Jonathan at age 12
    - So the most reasonable conclusion is that Saul began to reign at age 40
    - And he had been ruling for 2 years when the events of Chapter 13 took place
- The point in all this is that Saul hasn't been in charge for very long before the problems start to develop
  - The events of the chapter begin with Saul sending a warning shot across the bow of the Philistines
    - Two years after Saul takes rule, he decides to put the Philistines on notice that the land belonged to Israel
    - On a plain a few miles north of Jerusalem, the Philistines had stationed a garrison of troops
    - They occupied this territory to keep an eye on the Israelites and to defend the entry to the costal plains of the Philistine cities
  - Saul wanted to clear the area of Philistines, so he takes 3,000 men and splits them

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into two groups

- Saul leads one group of soldiers coming from Michmash 1.5 miles to the north
- While a second group led by Saul's son, Jonathan, approached from 3 miles away in the south from Saul's hometown of Gibeah
  - It's a classic pincer move

- Jonathan's troops finish the battle, destroying the garrison
  - The word then gets back to the Philistine cities on the coastal plain
  - Saul knows there will be a retaliation, which was his intent when he provoked them
  - So in v.3 we're told he blows a trumpet to call Israel to arms for the ensuing battle
  - And the people show up in response to the call of the king

1Sam. 13:5 Now the Philistines assembled to fight with Israel, 30,000 chariots and 6,000 horsemen, and people like the sand which is on the seashore in abundance; and they came up and camped in Michmash, east of Beth-aven.
1Sam. 13:6 When the men of Israel saw that they were in a strait (for the people were hard-pressed), then the people hid themselves in caves, in thickets, in cliffs, in cellars, and in pits.
1Sam. 13:7 Also some of the Hebrews crossed the Jordan into the land of Gad and Gilead. But as for Saul, he was still in Gilgal, and all the people followed him trembling.

- And the Philistines respond
  - They bring a force of 30,000 chariots and 6,000 horsemen while the number of the foot soldiers was innumerable
    - If Saul wanted to provoke the Philistines, he succeeded beyond all expectations
    - The Philistines have brought everything and the kitchen sink
    - They enter in Michmash and wait to engage Saul
  - On v.6 my translations says the people saw they were in a "strait" but the word in Hebrew means simply afflicted or distress
    - The Israelites gathered in Gilgal, which is next to Jericho in the Jordan river valley on the far eastern border of Israel
    - They are distressed to hear that the Philistines had gathered such a large force
    - Some responded to their fear by hiding in caves, cellars, cliffs and bushes
    - Others were running from the fight going east over the Jordan river into Gad
    - But Saul stayed with what remained of his trembling troops in Gilgal
- This is the turning point in Saul's time as king

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1Sam. 13:8 Now he waited seven days, according to the appointed time set by Samuel, but Samuel did not come to Gilgal; and the people were scattering from him.
1Sam. 13:9 So Saul said, "Bring to me the burnt offering and the peace offerings." And he offered the burnt offering.
1Sam. 13:10 As soon as he finished offering the burnt offering, behold, Samuel came; and Saul went out to meet him and to greet him.
1Sam. 13:11 But Samuel said, "What have you done?" And Saul said, "Because I saw that the people were scattering from me, and that you did not come within the appointed days, and that the Philistines were assembling at Michmash,
1Sam. 13:12 therefore I said, 'Now the Philistines will come down against me at Gilgal, and I have not asked the favor of the Lord.' So I forced myself and offered the burnt offering."

- We're told that Saul waits seven days according to a time set by Samuel
  - This reminds us of instructions Samuel gave Saul immediately after his anointing in Chapter 10

1Sam. 10:5 "Afterward you will come to the hill of God where the Philistine garrison is; and it shall be as soon as you have come there to the city, that you will meet a group of prophets coming down from the high place with harp, tambourine, flute, and a lyre before them, and they will be prophesying.
1Sam. 10:6 "Then the Spirit of the Lord will come upon you mightily, and you shall prophesy with them and be changed into another man.
1Sam. 10:7 "It shall be when these signs come to you, do for yourself what the occasion requires, for God is with you.
1Sam. 10:8 "And you shall go down before me to Gilgal; and behold, I will come down to you to offer burnt offerings and sacrifice peace offerings. You shall wait seven days until I come to you and show you what you should do."

- This first trip to Gilgal for sacrifices took place at the end of Chapter 11
  - But apparently Samuel had given Saul these instructions again in preparation for their battle against the Philistines
    - So Saul knew how this was supposed to go down
    - Saul knew Samuel would follow him to Gilgal after seven days
    - After the seventh day, Samuel arrives to lead Saul and the people in making sacrifices to the Lord
    - These sacrifices would make a way for the Lord's intercession on behalf of the people
  - But in v.8 we're told that Saul notices his troops are dwindling throughout the week

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        - And we can easily imagine the scene
        - Each morning Saul wakes up and inspects his camp only to find more men missing
        - As the week goes on, he begins to worry about how he can win this battle
        - It may remind us of a previous military leader who saw the Lord reduce the number of his army down to 300 (Gideon)
    - Toward the seventh day, the wait has become unbearable and the worry reaches a climax
        - Saul must be thinking to himself, why does the king have to wait on an old man to help win a battle?
        - It makes the king look weak and indecisive
        - After all it's just a process of cutting up animals and burning the meat on a fire
        - Hardly rocket science
- So before the end of the seventh day, Saul can't take it any longer, so he commands that the people bring him the animals for the sacrifice
    - And Saul, a Benjamite, offers the sacrifices for the people
        - In making the sacrifice himself, Saul is violating the prophet's orders
        - This isn't a matter of the Mosaic Law, because there is no tabernacle at Gilgal
        - This is simply a matter of obeying the word of the Lord
    - We can see how seriously the Lord took obedience to the word of the prophets by the example of a later king, Hezekiah
        - King Hezekiah was called to cleanse the temple
        - And he followed the instructions of the prophets to the letter

2Chr. 29:25 **He then stationed the Levites in the house of the Lord with cymbals, with harps and with lyres, according to the command of David and of Gad the king's seer, and of Nathan the prophet; for the command was from the Lord through His prophets.**

- A command from a prophet was a command from the Lord
- So to disobey the prophet meant to disobey the Lord
- More specifically, Saul was placing his authority over that of the prophet and the word
- Saul had no reason to act in this way
    - The seventh day was not yet concluded
    - The Lord and his prophet had not failed in their promise
    - It's interesting that Saul was determined to conduct the sacrifice yet not worried about doing so in accordance with the Lord's word

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- This calls into question what Saul thought about the sacrifice in the first place
- It appears to be merely ritual to him

- Sure enough, as soon as Saul had finished conducting the sacrifice, he looks up to see Samuel approaching
  - Samuel challenges Saul asking, what have you done?
    - The question alludes to much more than merely the sacrifices
    - It points to much more serious consequences for Saul
  - Saul offers an excuse to Samuel, which is that Samuel took too long
    - And then Saul says that he feared the Philistines would attack while the people were without the protection of the Lord
    - Again, it seems that Saul views the sacrificial program as winning the Lord's protection
    - Would the Lord have allowed the people to be destroyed if Saul was still waiting for Samuel when the attack began?
  - The answer you offer depends on your faith in God's word
    - Would the Lord keep His promises?
    - Does the Lord have the power to protect His people regardless of Samuel's timing?
    - If only Saul had recognized his period of waiting was a test of his heart rather than a test of his patience
- Samuel's response is immediate and unforgiving

1Sam. 13:13 Samuel said to Saul, "You have acted foolishly; you have not kept the commandment of the Lord your God, which He commanded you, for now the Lord would have established your kingdom over Israel forever.
1Sam. 13:14 "But now your kingdom shall not endure. The Lord has sought out for Himself a man after His own heart, and the Lord has appointed him as ruler over His people, because you have not kept what the Lord commanded you."
1Sam. 13:15 Then Samuel arose and went up from Gilgal to Gibeah of Benjamin. And Saul numbered the people who were present with him, about six hundred men.

- Samuel's response may seem harsh, but it's appropriate when you consider the meaning of Saul's actions
  - Samuel says Saul has not kept the commandment of the Lord
    - The commandment was the one spoken to Saul through Samuel
    - The command was to wait for the prophet because the Lord expected the prophet to do the sacrifice
    - The king didn't have the authority to sacrifice, for that is not the role of a king

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- So when Saul made this mistake, he was indicating that the word of God was not his authority
  - Instead, Saul was becoming his own authority
  - And the moment he tried to rule Israel outside God's authority, he forfeited his authority to rule
  - In fact, Samuel says that Saul could have had the kingdom over Israel forever
- That statement leaves us scratching our heads, because we know that the rule over Israel couldn't remain with a Benjamite
  - But remember, Samuel is speaking about what was humanly possible
  - From Saul's point of view, there was nothing preventing his family from having a dynasty…except his own sin
  - And therefore, the fall of Saul was inevitable
  - So we can hear Samuel's words as a theoretical possibility, not a theological possibility
  - Saul was always going to sin and forfeit the kingdom
  - And as we said in the beginning of this story, Saul becomes the exception to prove the rule

- Because of Saul's choice to dismiss the authority of the Lord's word, his kingdom will not endure
  - In fact, the Lord has already sought to identify your successor among the people
    - This successor will be a man after God's heart, which means this man will have the goal of pleasing the Lord
    - And with that goal, he will endeavor to rule the people knowing that the Lord is the true ruler working through the king and His prophets
    - Unlike Saul who, in just two short years, has come to believe he has the authority on his own to rule the nation
  - Remember, we said that the chief problem with a king ruling God's people is that human kings don't take criticism kindly
    - And Saul has just received stinging criticism
    - He's been fired, except the Lord will allow him to remain on the throne for many years
    - The decades between this moment and Saul's death offer the Lord time to prepare the next king to receive the throne
- Meanwhile, Samuel leaves Saul alone on the battlefield without the Lord's blessing for the battle with the Philistines
  - Saul counts his army and finds only 600 men
    - The number 6 in scripture is the number of fallen sinful man
    - And it couldn't be more appropriate for the fallen king's army to have only 600 men

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- Saul takes his meager army up to Geba, about 1.5 miles from the Philistine army

1Sam. 13:16 Now Saul and his son Jonathan and the people who were present with them were staying in Geba of Benjamin while the Philistines camped at Michmash.
1Sam. 13:17 And the raiders came from the camp of the Philistines in three companies: one company turned toward Ophrah, to the land of Shual,
1Sam. 13:18 and another company turned toward Beth-horon, and another company turned toward the border which overlooks the valley of Zeboim toward the wilderness.

- After Samuel leaves, Saul, Jonathan and the 600 men went back up to Geba
  - Immediately, we see Saul beginning to falter as king
    - He no longer has the midas touch
    - Because the Lord is no longer blessing Saul
    - Saul is still acting as king
    - But the Lord has no interest in propping him up before the people
  - The Philistines are still waiting for their confrontation with Saul
    - But Saul is hiding, daring not to enter into battle against such a superior foe
    - So the Philistines venture out in three directions
    - They head out north, east and west looking for Saul
    - Fortunately for Saul, he's hiding south of the Philistines so he isn't found
- As these raids continue, Samuel explains to his readers that the Philistines had a distinct advantage over the people of Israel

1Sam. 13:19 Now no blacksmith could be found in all the land of Israel, for the Philistines said, "Otherwise the Hebrews will make swords or spears."
1Sam. 13:20 So all Israel went down to the Philistines, each to sharpen his plowshare, his mattock, his axe, and his hoe.
1Sam. 13:21 The charge was two-thirds of a shekel for the plowshares, the mattocks, the forks, and the axes, and to fix the hoes.

- The Philistines knew how to smelt iron but the Israelites had not yet developed the skill to make iron tools
  - And the Philistines declined to share their blacksmith techniques with the Jews
  - Yet they would sell them some iron tools
- So when the Israelite's tools needed repair or sharpening, they were forced to return to

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the Philistines for blacksmith services

- And merely sharpening a tool was two-thirds of a shekel, which was a a inflated price
- This was a costly monopoly, as Samuel reports
- All this meant that the Philistine armies had a decisive advantage in war since they had iron swords and shields

1Sam. 13:22 **So it came about on the day of battle that neither sword nor spear was found in the hands of any of the people who were with Saul and Jonathan, but they were found with Saul and his son Jonathan.**
1Sam. 13:23 **And the garrison of the Philistines went out to the pass of Michmash.**

- Only Saul and Jonathan have swords made of iron
  - The Lord has left Saul to lie in the bed he made in disobeying the Lord
    - Saul has only 600 men
    - They have no armor or weapons
    - Only the king and his son have decent weapons
  - Remember what got Saul into trouble in the first place?
    - He was impatient and worried that his army would become insufficient to win the battle
    - Now because of his impatience, Saul has found himself in exactly the place he worried about
    - His lack of obedience to God's word brought about the very outcome he assumed he had to fix through disobedience
- And at this point, the Philistines decide to mass for battle
  - All this bad news doesn't mean the Lord will leave His people unprotected
    - This is an important detail to the story of Saul
    - Saul's unfaithfulness will not result in the Lord becoming unfaithful to His people
    - But He is making a point to Israel
  - He raised up Saul as king as an exception to prove the rule
    - The rule I'm speaking about is the prophetic promise God made to provide a king from the tribe of Judah to rule Israel
    - Ultimately, that king will be Christ
    - But before then, other men of Judah will rule
  - Saul is the exception to show what happens when God's people are not content to wait on the Lord and obey His word
    - The people ran ahead of the Lord in demanding a king before the Lord's

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anointed was ready to rule
    - Remember, David was barely born when the people demanded a king
  - So the Lord provided a temporary solution – Saul – who was an exception to the rule proving the error of seeking to act outside God's word
    - By his sin, Saul has proven true the rule that only Judah can rule Israel
    - Ironically, the Lord used Saul's example of running ahead of the Lord into disobedience to remind the people of their mistake in demanding a king early
- Yet the people still need God's leadership and mercy or else they will be destroyed by their enemies
  - And the Lord will remain faithful to His word
    - So even as Saul has erred, the Lord will work to care for His people
    - But He does so through someone other than Saul
    - Once again, David simply isn't ready to rule yet
    - So the Lord must work with someone else for a time
- And that person is Saul's son, Jonathan

1Sam. 14:1 **Now the day came that Jonathan, the son of Saul, said to the young man who was carrying his armor, "Come and let us cross over to the Philistines' garrison that is on the other side." But he did not tell his father.**
1Sam. 14:2 **Saul was staying in the outskirts of Gibeah under the pomegranate tree which is in Migron. And the people who were with him were about six hundred men,**
1Sam. 14:3 **and Ahijah, the son of Ahitub, Ichabod's brother, the son of Phinehas, the son of Eli, the priest of the Lord at Shiloh, was wearing an ephod. And the people did not know that Jonathan had gone.**
1Sam. 14:4 **Between the passes by which Jonathan sought to cross over to the Philistines' garrison, there was a sharp crag on the one side and a sharp crag on the other side, and the name of the one was Bozez, and the name of the other Seneh.**
1Sam. 14:5 **The one crag rose on the north opposite Michmash, and the other on the south opposite Geba.**

- Earlier in Chapter 9, the Lord declared to Samuel that Saul would be the one who would free Israel from the Philistines
  - And now we learn it will be a member of Saul's family to fulfill that promise
    - Saul seems to be staying in his hometown resting comfortably with no intention of engaging the enemy
    - He has his 600 bodyguards protecting him
    - And he seems content to just hide

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- Interestingly, Samuel notes that the descendants of Eli's sons were still operating the tabernacle in Shiloh
  - Why mention this detail here?
  - First, notice that Samuel mentions both sons of the disgraced priest Phinehas
  - The first son, Ahijah, inherited the position of high priest after the death of Phinehas and Eli
  - But the other son, Ichabod is mentioned too…why?
- Remember, Ichabod means the glory has departed
  - So Samuel wants to connect Saul with the discredited family of Eli
  - Just as the glory of the Lord departed the tabernacle during the time of Eli's family, so had Saul's reign lost its glory
  - These two families are the perfect bedfellows in Samuel's story

- While Saul sits in comfort in his home, his son is not content to sit still
  - Without telling dad, Jonathan decides to act to win the battle
    - He goes alone with only his armor bearer
    - An armor bearer is like a caddie to a golfer, holding his important weapons and armor
  - So forget Saul's 600, and Gideon's 300…Jonathan is about to fight the multitudes of the Philistines by himself
    - This is faith indeed
    - The Philistines are in Michmash while Jonathan is coming up from Geba
    - Separating these two sites was a steep wadi canyon running east-west
    - And this is the path Jonathan plans to take in launching a surprise attack against this incredibly powerful army
- Why would Jonathan engage in this suicide mission?

1Sam. 14:6 **Then Jonathan said to the young man who was carrying his armor, "Come and let us cross over to the garrison of these uncircumcised; perhaps the Lord will work for us, for the Lord is not restrained to save by many or by few."**

- The simple answer is faith
  - We'll study Jonathan's victory next week
  - But it's already easy to see that Saul's son will become an example of faith to contrast with his father's failure to trust in God's word

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- Saul's days as king are numbered
  - The prophet declared that Saul was no longer God's choice as king
    - Although the Lord has not yet removed Saul
    - Nor has the Lord even removed His Spirit from Saul
    - But nevertheless, Saul's reign will come to an end
  - Meanwhile, Saul remains in power for a time to serve a couple of purposes
    - First, Saul's successor isn't ready to assume the throne yet
      - David is too young and inexperienced
      - God wants to season this young man, ironically using Saul as David's antagonist
    - Finally, the Lord wants to show the people of Israel the error of selecting a man with their flesh
    - So Saul gets a few decades to rule even after the Lord declares the end is coming
- Then as we ended last week early in Chapter 14, we were introduced to Saul's son, Jonathan
  - Jonathan was leading part of Saul's small army…a very small army
    - In fact, Jonathan's army is so small it consists of only himself and his armor bearer
    - Jonathan has left Saul secretly to take the fight to the Philistines
  - We'll look tonight at how Jonathan wins this battle
    - Before that, let's remember why the Lord is elevating Saul's son to prominence
    - Normally, a king's son would be expected to follow the king into power
    - But we know that the Lord will not permit Jonathan to assume the throne
    - Yet the Lord will give him a measure of success for a time
  - Jonathan becomes an instrument the Lord uses to bless the people of Israel despite their king
    - He will also become a means to ensuring the transfer of power from Saul to David comes with a measure of peace
    - We'll look at that transition later
- For now, the Lord uses Jonathan to bring about a military victory while exposing his father's growing impatience and rash behavior
  - Jonathan's decision to enter into battle by himself was an action taken in faith
    - He believed the Lord was willing to deliver a victory
    - He figured he needed to step out in faith to see what the Lord willed

1Sam. 14:6 Then Jonathan said to the young man who was carrying his armor,

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"Come and let us cross over to the garrison of these uncircumcised; perhaps the Lord will work for us, for the Lord is not restrained to save by many or by few."
1Sam. 14:7 **His armor bearer said to him, "Do all that is in your heart; turn yourself, and here I am with you according to your desire."**
1Sam. 14:8 **Then Jonathan said, "Behold, we will cross over to the men and reveal ourselves to them.**
1Sam. 14:9 **"If they say to us, 'Wait until we come to you'; then we will stand in our place and not go up to them.**
1Sam. 14:10 **"But if they say, 'Come up to us,' then we will go up, for the Lord has given them into our hands; and this shall be the sign to us."**

- Jonathan was operating in faith, but it's not blind faith
  - It's faith based in a knowledge of the Lord and his word
  - Jonathan knew that the Lord had declared that the Philistines were under divine judgment
  - He knew that in the past the Lord had delivered great victories to Israel with small armies
  - He knew the Lord was willing to give signs to His warriors who sought His direction
  - And he knew that one must act in faith if he hoped to see the Lord's response
- So Jonathan took a calculated step of faith
  - When we talk about acting in faith, this is what we mean
  - It's not a gamble or wishful thinking
  - I can't play the lottery and expect a windfall because I played with a hopeful expectation
  - Acting in faith means working with an understanding of God's promises, an awareness of His revealed will and a confidence in His ability to direct our steps
  - Jonathan possessed all these things
- When Jonathan announces his desire to attack, the armor bearer shows equal faith in agreeing to accompany Jonathan
  - He tells Jonathan to follow his heart, turn yourself, I am with you according to your desire
    - The better translation would be do what your heart is inclined to do and I am with you, my heart is as your heart
    - The armor bearer is also operating in faith
  - Jonathan may be acting in bold faith, but he doesn't repeat his father's mistake of acting impetuously without clear direction from the Lord
    - So Jonathan devises a test to learn the Lord's will
    - He will make his way into the canyon and will walk into the open to expose themselves to the men on the top of the hill

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        - If the men at the top come down to engage with Jonathan, then he and the armor bearer will conclude the Lord is not giving them victory and will flee
        - If the enemy beckons Jonathan to come up to them, then Jonathan will conclude the Lord is granting them victory
    - This sign makes some sense militarily
        - If you have the high ground and are confident in your strength and position, you would move down to engage the weaker enemy
        - But if you are fearful, you would stay in place and wait for the enemy to come to you
        - So Jonathan's sign determines whether the enemy feels confident or weak
        - And a weak enemy was to be an indication that the Lord was preparing to defeat them

1Sam. 14:11 When both of them revealed themselves to the garrison of the Philistines, the Philistines said, "Behold, Hebrews are coming out of the holes where they have hidden themselves."
1Sam. 14:12 So the men of the garrison hailed Jonathan and his armor bearer and said, "Come up to us and we will tell you something." And Jonathan said to his armor bearer, "Come up after me, for the Lord has given them into the hands of Israel."
1Sam. 14:13 Then Jonathan climbed up on his hands and feet, with his armor bearer behind him; and they fell before Jonathan, and his armor bearer put some to death after him.
1Sam. 14:14 That first slaughter which Jonathan and his armor bearer made was about twenty men within about half a furrow in an acre of land.
1Sam. 14:15 And there was a trembling in the camp, in the field, and among all the people. Even the garrison and the raiders trembled, and the earth quaked so that it became a great trembling.

- So the Philistines see Jonathan appear from out of the canyon walls
    - They recognize the Hebrews are preparing to attack so they call Jonathan up saying they have something to tell him
        - This was merely an excuse to get Jonathan close so they could attack him
        - But Jonathan recognizes this means the Lord is granting victory
        - So he goes up by himself and when he reaches the top, he begins to kill the enemy in hand-to-hand combat
        - And his armor bearer follows and manages to kill more soldiers himself
    - Between the two of them they kill about 20 men in a small field
        - This is an impressive victory for two men by itself
        - But it's just the beginning

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- At that moment, the ground began to tremble
  - The earthquake unnerved the Philistines so that they would lose heart or interest in a battle
  - And instead, they would flee for their lives
  - Clearly the Lord is working to bring a victory for Jonathan
- And it's at about this time that men in Saul's army notice the commotion in the Philistine garrison
  - And the scene that follows is an example of the fog of war

1Sam. 14:16 Now Saul's watchmen in Gibeah of Benjamin looked, and behold, the multitude melted away; and they went here and there.
1Sam. 14:17 Saul said to the people who were with him, "Number now and see who has gone from us." And when they had numbered, behold, Jonathan and his armor bearer were not there.
1Sam. 14:18 Then Saul said to Ahijah, "Bring the ark of God here." For the ark of God was at that time with the sons of Israel.
1Sam. 14:19 While Saul talked to the priest, the commotion in the camp of the Philistines continued and increased; so Saul said to the priest, "Withdraw your hand."
1Sam. 14:20 Then Saul and all the people who were with him rallied and came to the battle; and behold, every man's sword was against his fellow, and there was very great confusion.
1Sam. 14:21 Now the Hebrews who were with the Philistines previously, who went up with them all around in the camp, even they also turned to be with the Israelites who were with Saul and Jonathan.
1Sam. 14:22 When all the men of Israel who had hidden themselves in the hill country of Ephraim heard that the Philistines had fled, even they also pursued them closely in the battle.
1Sam. 14:23 So the Lord delivered Israel that day, and the battle spread beyond Beth-aven.

- Saul has been killing time with his 600 body guards in Gilbeah, which is only about 1.5 miles away
  - His watchmen detect confusion in the Philistine camp
    - Philistine warriors are in distress
    - Many are fleeing the camp
    - The ground is shaking
  - When Saul learns this, he recognizes he has a chance to seize the day
    - But Saul's approach to entering battle is very different than his son's

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        - Saul's first step was to number his forces
        - He orders a count of all his men so he can decide whether he has enough to enter into battle
        - And in the course of the count he discovers that Jonathan and his armor bearer are gone
    - By comparison, Jonathan wasn't worried about numbers at all
        - He said that the Lord didn't care about numbers
        - He could bring victory with many or with few
- Secondly, Saul wants the Lord's favor in the fight, so he calls for the ark of the Lord to be brought out for battle
    - My English Bible says ark, but a number of manuscripts including the Septuagint indicate Saul called for the ephod not the ark
        - The ephod was an elaborate robe worn by the high priest
        - It held the Urim and the Thummim stones used to discern God's will
        - Saul calls for the priest and robe because he understands he must seek the Lord's will before entering into the fight
        - The priest could ascertain the will of God by throwing the stones
    - But notice in v.19 that Saul notices the commotion in the camp was growing stronger as the enemy melted away after the earthquake
        - Saul's dying to join the battle and win a victory while the opportunity presents itself
        - So he tells the priest "withdraw your hand"
        - In other words, Saul tells the high priest to withdraw his hand from the pouch that contained the stones
        - Saul doesn't need the priest to throw the stones after all
        - He already knows what he wants to do…he's going into battle
    - In fact, the sense of the wording is that Saul doesn't want to hear God's answer, lest the Lord refuse Saul his desire
        - Saul is determined to press forward while the victory seems certain
        - He's not willing to wait on the Lord
        - One commentator remarked that when Saul should have been acting he was waiting, and when he should have been waiting, he was acting
- By contrast, Jonathan followed his heart as his armor bearer said
    - Following the heart means remaining sensitive to the leading of the Spirit from moment to moment
        - The Lord was fully capable of speaking to Jonathan even without the stones
        - And Jonathan was confident he would hear from the Lord
        - So he acted in confidence that the Lord would direct His steps

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- The key difference is Jonathan wanted to do the Lord's will
  - While Saul wanted to do his own will
  - Saul is acting out of selfishness and self-centeredness
  - And his heart is going to cause trouble for the people

- At this point Saul leads his men into the battle but they do nothing at all
  - Before Saul can act, the Lord causes the Philistines to turn on one another in confusion
    - Neither Jonathan nor Saul needs to fight the Philistines
    - They are fighting each other
    - In fact, even those Jewish traitors that were within the Philistine camp saw the writing on the wall and turned sides
    - This tells us that the confusion the Lord brought only impacted the Gentiles among the Philistines
    - The Jews retained their senses
  - Finally, the Jews in Ephraim hiding in caves over fear of the Philistines emerged when they realized the Philistine garrison was being routed
    - They began to pursue Philistines as well
    - So virtually everyone in the nation, other than Saul and his men, had a hand in the victory
    - Even the traitors could claim some measure of the victory
    - But Saul and his company did nothing except join the chase
- At this point, Saul's pride and ego are becoming enflamed and are threatening to impede sound judgment
  - Saul noticed that he was not leading the battle or even the chase that followed
    - So he contrived a plan to slow down the chase and extend the battle for a time
    - By hampering his own people from chasing and winning the battle too fast, Saul will give the enemy a chance to recover, regroup and set up a decisive battle
    - And in that decisive battle, Saul intends to lead the final charge where he can claim the credit for the victory
  - It's a cynical, selfish strategy that reveals this man's deteriorating heart
    - And Saul's prideful scheming has severe, unintended consequences

1Sam. 14:24 Now the men of Israel were hard-pressed on that day, for Saul had put the people under oath, saying, "Cursed be the man who eats food before evening, and until I have avenged myself on my enemies." So none of the people tasted food.
1Sam. 14:25 All the people of the land entered the forest, and there was honey on the ground.

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1Sam. 14:26 When the people entered the forest, behold, there was a flow of honey; but no man put his hand to his mouth, for the people feared the oath.
1Sam. 14:27 But Jonathan had not heard when his father put the people under oath; therefore, he put out the end of the staff that was in his hand and dipped it in the honeycomb, and put his hand to his mouth, and his eyes brightened.
1Sam. 14:28 Then one of the people said, "Your father strictly put the people under oath, saying, 'Cursed be the man who eats food today.'" And the people were weary.
1Sam. 14:29 Then Jonathan said, "My father has troubled the land. See now, how my eyes have brightened because I tasted a little of this honey.
1Sam. 14:30 "How much more, if only the people had eaten freely today of the spoil of their enemies which they found! For now the slaughter among the Philistines has not been great."

- Saul's men were hard-pressed we're told
  - The Hebrew word for hard-pressed is the same word we find in Exodus 3 to describe the taskmaster Moses killed in self-defense
    - It describes someone who drives others harshly
    - Saul was driving his people under harsh condition
    - Saul had ordered his army to observe a fast until Saul himself has met the enemy in battle
    - There is an old saying that an army moves on its stomach, because fighters need a lot of food to maintain their effectiveness
  - So it's clear to everyone that Saul's order is counterproductive to the effectiveness of the army…but no one can understand why he wants this
    - The people enter into the forest pursuing the enemy
    - There was honey available to feed the troops, food that would sustain them in battle right when they most needed it
    - But because of Saul's order, the men don't dare eat
    - Eating would have meant death
  - Jonathan didn't know about Saul's order, so he gladly ate of the honey and was strengthened for the chase
    - But others warned him telling that Saul said the one who eats would be cursed
    - A curse in scripture is a death sentence
    - There is no recovery from a curse; once God affirms a curse, the end is sure
- Jonathan says nothing about the curse that fell upon him, but he does comment on the foolishness of his father's edict
  - Jonathan remarks that the honey has been good for him and it would have been good for everyone

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        - The people were faint with hunger which wasn't helping them fight
        - And as a result, they hadn't managed to kill many of the enemy today
        - And if the enemy survived, then they would live to fight another day
    - In this moment, the Lord uses Saul's sin to exact a revenge for his impetuousness
        - And as only God can, He also finds a just way to remove Saul's son from receiving the throne
        - Saul's own words bring a curse upon his son
        - And as a result of that curse, his son will die with him in battle, bringing an end to Saul's dynasty
- Saul's sin had even wider consequences among God's people
    - It lead the people into sin

1Sam. 14:31 They struck among the Philistines that day from Michmash to Aijalon. And the people were very weary.
1Sam. 14:32 The people rushed greedily upon the spoil, and took sheep and oxen and calves, and slew them on the ground; and the people ate them with the blood.
1Sam. 14:33 Then they told Saul, saying, "Behold, the people are sinning against the Lord by eating with the blood." And he said, "You have acted treacherously; roll a great stone to me today."
1Sam. 14:34 Saul said, "Disperse yourselves among the people and say to them, 'Each one of you bring me his ox or his sheep, and slaughter it here and eat; and do not sin against the Lord by eating with the blood.'" So all the people that night brought each one his ox with him and slaughtered it there.
1Sam. 14:35 And Saul built an altar to the Lord; it was the first altar that he built to the Lord.

- The Israelites moved ahead with the fight despite their hunger and weakness
    - In one day's time, they fight and pursue the enemy a distance of 15 miles in rough hill country
        - This would have been a difficult trek on a full stomach in peaceful circumstances
        - But they're moving on empty stomachs under duress
    - But eventually, by God's grace, the people win the battle
        - And as they come into the camp of the fleeing Philistines they are so hungry that they fall on the captured animals
        - They butcher the animals quickly and without following the rules in the Law requiring that the blood be drained first
        - The result is that the people have been driven into sin by Saul's selfish and

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senseless restrictions

- When the word is passed to Saul that the people are sinning in this manner, he intervenes
  - But once again, he intervenes in an entirely self-serving way
  - He commands the people to bring the animals to him
  - And then Saul would slaughter the animals for the people and distribute the meat to them personally
- It's obvious Saul is seeking to place himself in the center of the action again
  - The people will be giving him the animals so that he can return them
  - It makes him appear to be a generous king handing out the meals

- To accomplish this task, Saul builds an altar on which to conduct the sacrifices
  - Throughout scripture we see godly men building altars to sacrifice to the Lord in thanks and worship
    - But Samuel wants us to understand that this is the first time that Saul has ever bothered to make such an altar
    - He's making one now because it's convenient to his selfish purpose
    - Not because he had a genuine desire to worship the Lord
  - Everything about this period of Saul's rule has revealed a man slipping further and further from worshipping and following the Lord
    - Instead, he's becoming accustomed to the role of king
    - And he seems determined to receive all the glory
    - Rather than using his position to lead Israel to worshipping the Lord
    - So that is the purpose of the king, just as it was the purpose of judges before
    - But Saul's rash behavior hasn't ended yet

1Sam. 14:36 Then Saul said, "Let us go down after the Philistines by night and take spoil among them until the morning light, and let us not leave a man of them." And they said, "Do whatever seems good to you." So the priest said, "Let us draw near to God here."
1Sam. 14:37 Saul inquired of God, "Shall I go down after the Philistines? Will You give them into the hand of Israel?" But He did not answer him on that day.
1Sam. 14:38 Saul said, "Draw near here, all you chiefs of the people, and investigate and see how this sin has happened today.

- In v.36, Saul is ready to run down the hills and attack the Philistines by night to take the rest of the spoils
  - He seems drunk with the prospect of capturing more booty
    - His motives have shifted from existential concerns of preserving God's people to

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goals of personal gain
        - It's becoming clear that the overriding force driving Saul is pride and selfishness
        - Which is appropriate, since he was chosen according to the flesh and now he's acting according to the flesh
    - Before he can begin to attack, the high priest, who has accompanied Saul in the battle suggests they consult the Lord before launching another attack
        - In v.37 he says "let's draw near to the Lord"
        - That phrase means, let's worship the Lord for the purpose of seeking His favor in the battle
        - Don't you get the feeling that the priest was saying, "Saul, haven't you forgot something???"
        - At which point Saul reluctantly agrees to engage in a moment of worship
- Then Saul inquired of the Lord concerning this attack
    - But the Lord did not answer Saul
        - Now Saul is stuck
        - Having consulted the Lord for permission to attack and having received no reply, Saul can't order his troops to the fight
        - So he's mad
    - And Saul looks for an explanation for the Lord's silence, but he doesn't think to blame himself
        - Instead, Saul assumes that someone has violated his order to fast
        - And therefore, that person must be to blame for upsetting God
        - We must remember that Saul's order was not God's order, nor was it required by God's law
        - This was Saul's rule
    - In v.38 Saul demands an accounting from the people concerning the "sin" that caused the Lord's silence
        - This rule was issued from the king, so it would have been wrong to intentionally disobey it
        - But it wasn't a sin against the Lord and His commands
        - And it certainly wasn't sin to unknowingly violate the king's rule
        - In fact, given that Saul's rule prevented Israel from defeating the Philistines, we could say that his rule was counter to the Lord's desire
- So Saul sets out to uncover the wrongdoer

1Sam. 14:39 **"For as the Lord lives, who delivers Israel, though it is in Jonathan my son, he shall surely die." But not one of all the people answered him.**
1Sam. 14:40 **Then he said to all Israel, "You shall be on one side and I and Jonathan**

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my son will be on the other side." And the people said to Saul, "Do what seems good to you."
1Sam. 14:41 **Therefore, Saul said to the Lord, the God of Israel, "Give a perfect lot." And Jonathan and Saul were taken, but the people escaped.**
1Sam. 14:42 **Saul said, "Cast lots between me and Jonathan my son." And Jonathan was taken.**
1Sam. 14:43 **Then Saul said to Jonathan, "Tell me what you have done." So Jonathan told him and said, "I indeed tasted a little honey with the end of the staff that was in my hand. Here I am, I must die!"**
1Sam. 14:44 **Saul said, "May God do this to me and more also, for you shall surely die, Jonathan."**
1Sam. 14:45 **But the people said to Saul, "Must Jonathan die, who has brought about this great deliverance in Israel? Far from it! As the Lord lives, not one hair of his head shall fall to the ground, for he has worked with God this day." So the people rescued Jonathan and he did not die.**

- Saul makes another rash declaration
  - He swears by the name of the Lord that whoever has violated this rule will die, even if it were his own son Jonathan
    - Saul doesn't realize it, but he's speaking prophetically to confirm Jonathan's eventual death
    - His foolish pride and selfish ego have placed his son in this situation
    - Saul speaks in these broad and absolute terms cursing people and swearing on the name of the Lord
    - He binds himself to severe actions without considering the implications or even having all the facts
  - We're seeing more and more of the dramatic character change taking place inside this man
    - If he was a humble and reasonable man in the beginning, he's now a brash tyrant lacking self control
    - One of the most puzzling things about the story of Saul is his dramatic descent into madness
    - But notice this descent isn't a fall off a cliff
    - It's a series of steps driven by the flesh, fueled by pride and ungoverned by a desire to please the Lord
  - Saul is the Bible's most dramatic character study in a man of God gone wrong
    - He began with a tender heart and the Spirit of God
    - But he favored living in his flesh and chose to seek for his own desires
    - The Bible warns us that when we take that turn, it has the power to warp our character and distance us from God

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        - And it has eternal consequences, as Hebrews warns

Heb. 10:26 For if we go on sinning willfully after receiving the knowledge of the truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins,
Heb. 10:27 but a terrifying expectation of judgment and the fury of a fire which will consume the adversaries.
Heb. 10:28 Anyone who has set aside the Law of Moses dies without mercy on the testimony of two or three witnesses.
Heb. 10:29 How much severer punishment do you think he will deserve who has trampled under foot the Son of God, and has regarded as unclean the blood of the covenant by which he was sanctified, and has insulted the Spirit of grace?
Heb. 10:30 For we know Him who said, "Vengeance is mine, I will repay." And again, "The Lord will judge His people."
Heb. 10:31 It is a terrifying thing to fall into the hands of the living God.

- In vs.40-42 Saul asks the people to tell him who violated the rule he set, but no one wants to say anything
    - That's not surprising for two reasons
        - First, they would be exposing the king's son, which doesn't seem like a wise career move
        - Secondly, the people were opposed to Saul's dumb rule and sympathetic with Jonathan's situation
        - They knew he ate without realizing the rule existed and he needed the energy to execute the battle
    - So when he doesn't get an answer, Saul decides to throw lots to determine where to place the blame
        - Throwing lots means using die to receive direction from the Lord concerning a yes or no question
        - So Saul begins by placing himself and his son on one side, and all other soldiers on the other side and throwing the lot
        - Saul must have been surprised when the lot chose him and Jonathan over the people
        - Saul throws the lot again and it indicates Jonathan over Saul, which means Jonathan is to blame
    - The Lord is answering Saul according to the question posed, which was who violated the rule Saul set
        - The Lord is not agreeing with Saul's perspective however
        - Saul created this situation by speaking rashly, and now the Lord is simply pointing out the consequences of Saul's foolishness
        - So now Saul is on the spot to carry out the verdict

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- Saul is the one who set the terms of this situation
  - He decided the rule, he decided the punishment in advance and he has now demanded a public accounting of the violation
    - So everything that's happened has been as a result of the king's actions
    - None of this was ordered by the Lord
    - Therefore, the king could reverse anything he's done
    - A king can make rules and change rules
  - And if there was ever a moment for Saul to step back from the brink of madness, confess his sin and repent, this would have been the perfect moment
    - He could have declared that the Lord has revealed his sin to him
    - That he sees the error of his ways and reverse his edict
    - Then Jonathan could have been spared and the people relieved to see their king hearing from God and doing His will
  - But Saul disappoints again
    - Instead, he presses the case against his own son asking Jonathan to confess his crime
    - Jonathan explains that he ate a little honey
    - And then he says I must die
  - It's not clear from the text if Jonathan is speaking sincerely or with sarcasm
    - He could be announcing his willingness to die in order to obey the king
    - That would be in keeping with Jonathan's upright character
    - Or he could be speaking sarcastically to highlight the ridiculousness of his father's actions
- Finally, Saul's pride pushes him to once again invoke the name of the Lord in declaring that Jonathan must surely die
  - Notice in v.44 Saul declares that the Lord must kill Saul if Jonathan doesn't die
    - Interestingly, it will happen that Saul and Jonathan will die in the same battle
    - It seems the Lord held Saul to his rash vows taking both his life and Jonathan's life according to Saul's words
  - But for now, Jonathan receives a reprieve, made possible by the people, who refuse to carry out the penalty against Jonathan
    - The people declare to the king that Jonathan was responsible for the victory
    - Therefore, it was ridiculous to think that he would be killed for eating a little honey
    - The madness of the king has become apparent to everyone
  - Yet by challenging Saul's decision, they plant a seed of paranoia in Saul's heart which will grow to consume him over time

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        - Saul's great downfall was failing to submit to the Lord's authority as he ruled Israel
        - Instead, he did what was right in his own eyes
- In a sense, Saul was an extension of the time of Judges, in the sense that he acted independently of God
    - His dynasty was cut off because he failed to serve the Lord
        - In his place God will raise up a man after God's own heart
        - Which means David was a man determined to serve God even though he sinned as well

1Sam. 14:46 Then Saul went up from pursuing the Philistines, and the Philistines went to their own place.
1Sam. 14:47 Now when Saul had taken the kingdom over Israel, he fought against all his enemies on every side, against Moab, the sons of Ammon, Edom, the kings of Zobah, and the Philistines; and wherever he turned, he inflicted punishment.
1Sam. 14:48 He acted valiantly and defeated the Amalekites, and delivered Israel from the hands of those who plundered them.

- Since the Lord didn't give Saul permission to battle the Philistines, Saul disengages from the battle
    - Essentially, the Philistine garrison was removed from the hill country of Ephraim but the cities remained on the coast
        - Nevertheless, Saul and his armies continued to battle Israel's enemies on all sides
        - And he would inflict great damage on his enemies thus keeping Israel defended
        - But notice Saul isn't vanquishing these enemies…he is merely a caretaker

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- The Lord is ready to put Saul's wavering heart to the test
  - Tests brought by God are intended to reveal what's in a person's heart
    - God knows our heart already, of course
    - But when the Lord wants to expose the inner motives and thinking of a man, He will construct a test, a trial
    - The test offers the Lord's servant an opportunity to obey and receive the Lord's praise
    - But there is equal opportunity for the person to disobey and fall into ruin
  - We can find examples in scripture of men who passed such tests
    - For example, the Lord allowed Job to be tested severely by the enemy to reveal Job's heart for the Lord
    - Despite the severity of God's trial, Job steadfastly maintained his devotion to the Lord
    - And Abraham passed a test by his willingness to sacrifice his son Isaac
    - And Joseph, Hezekiah, and David all exhibited faithfulness of one kind or another in the midst of testing
  - But we can also find plenty of examples of men who failed such tests
    - Peter failed his test when he denied Christ three times
    - And virtually the entire generation of Israel who left Egypt failed ten tests in grumbling against Moses and the Lord
  - In all cases, the Lord knew the heart of each person before He brought the test
    - But by observing these tests, we learn an important spiritual principle
    - The motives of our hearts are best revealed by how we respond to a command from God
- In chapter 15, Saul will receive a test from God
  - Even before the test comes, we have seen Saul's deteriorating walk with the Lord
    - He's increasingly prideful, arrogant
    - He's determined to receive glory for himself rather than giving it to the Lord
    - And just to make sure we don't miss Saul's descent into conceit, the Lord brings a test to reveal it
  - The Lord has already declared that Saul's dynasty can't last
    - And now with this test, Saul will be personally disqualified from serving as king
    - Soon, the Lord will anoint Saul's successor even as Saul remains on the throne a while
    - The Lord will withdraw His Spirit from Saul even though Saul continues to rule
    - And the Lord will bring an evil Spirit to terrorize Saul during his final years on the throne to reveal His jealous heart

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- The test of chapter 15 is important to explaining why and how Saul's reign comes to an end
  - Then in Chapter 16 the Lord selects Saul's replacement
  - A king according to the Lord's choice who will become a contrast to the one the people selected
- But first we finish up chapter 14 with Samuel's summary of Saul's reign

1Sam. 14:49 Now the sons of Saul were Jonathan and Ishvi and Malchi-shua; and the names of his two daughters were these: the name of the firstborn Merab and the name of the younger Michal.

1Sam. 14:50 The name of Saul's wife was Ahinoam the daughter of Ahimaaz. And the name of the captain of his army was Abner the son of Ner, Saul's uncle.

1Sam. 14:51 Kish was the father of Saul, and Ner the father of Abner was the son of Abiel.

1Sam. 14:52 Now the war against the Philistines was severe all the days of Saul; and when Saul saw any mighty man or any valiant man, he attached him to his staff.

- It was common in ancient records to highlight a king's accomplishments by summarizing his family line and his military victories
  - So Samuel offers that summary of Saul here
    - At this point in Saul's reign, his family consisted of three sons and two daughters
    - One son we know, Jonathan
    - The second, Ishvi, (going by his other name, Ishbosheth) becomes an important character in 2Samuel
    - Malchi-shua is third
    - Not all Saul's sons are mentioned here, but all but one will die violent deaths
    - The captain of Saul's army is also mentioned because he plays a large role in the rebellion against Saul's anointed successor
  - Then Samuel mentions Saul's military service to the nation, commanding standing armies in Israel for the first time in their history
    - He fought principally against the Philistines who were Israel's strongest opponent in these years

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        - Nevertheless, the Philistines were a severe enemy all the days of Saul's reign
        - And Saul was constantly recruiting new warriors to serve him
        - When he came across a valiant or mighty man, Saul would conscript him into the army
    - This summary paints a picture of a failed and wasted monarchy
        - Saul's posterity was ignominious
        - He fathered only a few sons, all of whom died violent deaths
        - His trusted advisor becomes a traitor
        - His military success was hollow, since he never defeats the Philistines, barely keeping them under control
        - And he can't seem to inspire and attract men to serve him, since he has to conscript them
- This is a picture of failed leadership and wasted opportunities
    - That summary sets up chapter 15, where Saul's reign is judged by God

1Sam. 15:1 **Then Samuel said to Saul, "The Lord sent me to anoint you as king over His people, over Israel; now therefore, listen to the words of the Lord.**

1Sam. 15:2 **"Thus says the Lord of hosts, 'I will punish Amalek for what he did to Israel, how he set himself against him on the way while he was coming up from Egypt.**

1Sam. 15:3 **'Now go and strike Amalek and utterly destroy all that he has, and do not spare him; but put to death both man and woman, child and infant, ox and sheep, camel and donkey.'"**

- **Samuel is sent to Saul to announce the Lord's purpose to punish one of Israel's adversaries**
    - Samuel prefaces his announcement with an important comment
        - Samuel reminds Saul that the Lord sent him to anoint Saul as king over His people
        - Saul wasn't king because he earned it or even inherited it
        - The monarchy of Israel was dropped in Saul's lap
    - The implication? Saul should have kept that fact in mind to keep his heart humble before the Lord
        - Yet we know this is not what Saul did
        - He has become arrogant

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- Secondly, Samuel reminds Saul he rules over *God's* people, Israel
  - Israel didn't belong to Saul
  - Much like the judges, Saul was appointed a caretaker working under the authority of God
  - Yet Saul has been ruling the nation like it was his private kingdom
- And finally, Samuel directs Saul to listen to the words of the Lord
  - This is a thinly veiled rebuke of Saul's unwillingness to listen to the Lord
  - We've already seen one episode of Saul ignoring the instructions of God and His prophet
  - And we're about to see another in this chapter

- The instructions Saul receives are to utterly destroy the Amalekites and their king
  - The Amalekites were descendants of Esau who lived in the southern Negev and Sinai
    - As Samuel mentions in v.2, the Amalekites tried to destroy Israel by a sneak attack upon the people when they were walking out of Egypt
    - In Exodus, Moses needed help holding up his arms so Israel would win the battle
    - After that battle, the Lord declared in Deut 25 that one day He would bring the Amalekite people to an end
    - And now He's offered Saul the honor to fulfill that prophecy and bring about the end for one of Israel's main enemies
  - But the Lord's instructions are very specific
    - Saul is to show no mercy
    - He must utterly destroy every man, woman and child, including the king
    - And every animal of the Amalekites would be destroyed
    - And the people of Israel may not take any spoil from the city
  - In scripture, this is called being under the ban
    - To be placed under the ban meant that every person, beast and all possessions must be destroyed without mercy or exception
    - Nothing survives or carries forward
    - Just to emphasize that the Lord was clear on His expectations, Samuel repeats the word *utterly* seven times in this account
- Why did the Lord order such a complete destruction?
  - In short, to make a point
    - In ordinary warfare, a conquering army would destroy the men in a city since they posed a threat
    - But women and children would usually be spared so they could become slaves of the conquering army

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        - And the choice livestock and precious materials would be kept as war booty
    - But the Lord isn't taking Saul to war to enrich Israel with slaves and war booty
        - By putting the Amalekites under the ban, the world will know God was fulfilling His promise to destroy an adversary Israel
        - Therefore, all the credit for the victory will belong to the Lord alone
- Now if Saul obeys the Lord's command, naturally Saul himself would receive a measure of glory for the victory
    - This is always the pattern for those who serve the Lord
        - The Lord does great things *through* His people
        - By working with Him, we have opportunity to share in His reflected glory Just as Moses's shining face reflected the glory of God
        - We receive a measure of reflected glory and praise for what God accomplishes in and through us when we obey Him
        - And we also understands that all credit for the result belongs to the Lord
    - This is the test for Saul's heart
        - Heed the word of the Lord
        - Defeat the city, take nothing
        - And forgo any opportunity to become enriched by the victory
        - Don't seek personal credit for the victory
        - And ensure the world understands God keeps His promises
- And with that commission from Samuel, Saul goes out to battle the Amalekites

1Sam. 15:4 **Then Saul summoned the people and numbered them in Telaim, 200,000 foot soldiers and 10,000 men of Judah.**

1Sam. 15:5 **Saul came to the city of Amalek and set an ambush in the valley.**

1Sam. 15:6 **Saul said to the Kenites, "Go, depart, go down from among the Amalekites, so that I do not destroy you with them; for you showed kindness to all the sons of Israel when they came up from Egypt." So the Kenites departed from among the Amalekites.**

1Sam. 15:7 **So Saul defeated the Amalekites, from Havilah as you go to Shur, which is east of Egypt.**

1Sam. 15:8 **He captured Agag the king of the Amalekites alive, and utterly destroyed all the people with the edge of the sword.**

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- Saul musters a large force to attack and he prepares to ambush the city
  - An ambush was traditionally understood to be a less honorable way of prosecuting war
    - But it was the Amalekites who had ambushed the Israelites in Moses' day
    - So turnaround now was fair play for Saul
  - Living among the Amalekites were another people descended from Esau, the Kenites
    - The Kenites descended from Abraham through his third wife Keturah
    - Unlike the Amalekites, the Kenites had been kind to Israel when they wandered through the desert
    - So to repay their history of kindness, Saul allows the Kenites to flee before the attack
  - Following the departure of the Amalekites, Saul's army rolls over the city
    - This was no small victory, as the Amalekites were powerful
    - But God delivered the victory to Saul as He promised
    - Saul defeated the people throughout the region of the Sinai
    - And Saul killed all the inhabitants of the city as God directed
- Well, all except the king, which he captured alive and brought back into Israel

1Sam. 15:9 **But Saul and the people spared Agag and the best of the sheep, the oxen, the fatlings, the lambs, and all that was good, and were not willing to destroy them utterly; but everything despised and worthless, that they utterly destroyed.**

- After capturing Agag, the king of the Amalekites, Saul lets him live
  - Nevermind that Saul is directly disobeying the Lord's command, why would Saul even want his enemy to live?
  - There is no reason given in scripture, but we might suppose Saul was keeping his adversary as a trophy
  - To keep an opposing king alive as a prisoner or slave humiliated the king
  - Regardless of Saul's purposes, it was sin
- Furthermore, Saul's heart was taken in by the prospect of enlarging his personal fortune
  - He took one look at the good herds of Agag and decided it would be a waste to kill them
  - So he took them as well destroying only what he didn't want

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- Every decision Saul made was calculated for his own benefit
- Obeying the Lord wasn't on his mind
- Both those Saul killed and those he let let live served his selfish purposes

- Saul failed God's test, just as the Lord knew he would
  - Twenty-five years have passed since Samuel first declared that Saul's dynasty would not stand
  - And since then, we've been watching Saul's heart move in this direction
  - Now having failed this final test, the Lord is going to reject Saul personally as king

1Sam. 15:10 **Then the word of the Lord came to Samuel, saying,**

1Sam. 15:11 **"I regret that I have made Saul king, for he has turned back from following Me and has not carried out My commands." And Samuel was distressed and cried out to the Lord all night.**

1Sam. 15:12 **Samuel rose early in the morning to meet Saul; and it was told Samuel, saying, "Saul came to Carmel, and behold, he set up a monument for himself, then turned and proceeded on down to Gilgal."**

- In the climactic verse of the chapter, we're told "the word of the Lord came to Samuel"
  - This phrase appears only three times in all 1 & 2 Samuel
    - Each time it, it is followed by a word of judgment from God to the king
    - It's a solemn and eternal declaration
  - The Lord tells Samuel He regrets making Saul king
    - This phrase inevitably causes some confusing for Bible students
    - To regret (or the KJV says repent of) something implies that God's mind has been changed by events He didn't anticipate beforehand
    - As if He didn't realize all that would happen in Saul's reign
    - So it's confusing to consider that the God Who is the same yesterday, today and forever, is changeable, lacking omniscience
  - Well, the Spirit anticipated our confusion, and so later in this very chapter we see an important clarifying statement
    - Glance down the page briefly to read v.29

1Sam. 15:29 **"Also the Glory of Israel will not lie or change His mind; for He is not a man that He should change His mind."**

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- Despite the wording of v.11, Samuel makes clear that God doesn't change His mind
- Moreover, God is not like a man in that new information could come to His attention or that His judgments or opinions change
- God knew Saul before the foundations of the earth
  - And He knew exactly what would happen when Saul became king
  - In fact, Samuel warned the people on two occasions that bad things would come upon them if they called for a king
  - So there is no surprises here for God
- So why are we told God regretted Saul's reign?
  - In the few times you find a statement of this kind, it's always in the context of someone failing a test of the heart
    - When the sinful, unfaithful, disobedient heart is exposed by a test, the Lord expresses regret at the discovery
    - It's regret in the sense of sorrow, not remorse
    - Our sin and disobedience grieves God's heart, but they don't surprise Him
    - God's sorrow was for Saul turning back from obeying God's commands to destroy the city properly
  - As Samuel learns the news, his heart is broken as well
    - Now Samuel isn't mourning the discovery that Saul disobeys God's commands
    - He's also seen that before
    - His distress is over the coming consequence because of the Lord's anger
  - Samuel understood that God will not be mocked nor will He overlook sin forever
    - If the king of the people is disobedient and receives God's discipline, then the people of God will suffer too
    - Moreover, it's a principle of scripture that what God delights in, we should approve
    - And what grieves God's heart should also grieve our hearts
    - Samuel is grieving with God over the sin of Saul

• As Samuel comes to meet Saul following the victory, someone retells Saul's exploits

- Saul traveled north from the Negev desert about 25 miles to a town called Carmel
  - In Carmel, he erects a monument to himself
  - He doesn't erect an altar or place of worship to honor the Lord, as other men have done following great victories in the past
  - Instead Saul wants to glorify *his* great victory
  - Following his victory lap, Saul goes back to Gilgal

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- We remember that it was at Gilgal that the Lord rejected Saul's dynasty some 25 years earlier
  - Saul had decided to perform a sacrifice on his own and the Lord said his family could not have the throne after him
  - Now we're back to Gilgal again, where now the Lord will reject Saul as king
- Samuel confronts Saul in Gilgal

1Sam. 15:13 Samuel came to Saul, and Saul said to him, "Blessed are you of the Lord! I have carried out the command of the Lord."

1Sam. 15:14 But Samuel said, "What then is this bleating of the sheep in my ears, and the lowing of the oxen which I hear?"

- The first one to speak is Samuel, which is similar to way their previous confrontation in Gilgal began
  - In chapter 13 Saul had become impatient and sacrificed without Samuel
    - When Saul learned Samuel had arrived in Gilgal after all, Saul rushed out to meet him
    - You're left with the impression Saul felt guilty at begin caught sacrificing, so he tried to put the best face on the situation
  - Now it appears Saul is up to something similar again
    - He sinned with his eyes wide open
    - And his guilty conscience is showing
- Saul declares to Samuel without a trace of irony that Samuel should feel blessed because Saul has carried out the command of the Lord
  - The pride and arrogance of Saul's heart seems to know no limit at this point in his life
    - He is lying and knows it
    - And he has audacity to cover his sin with a baldfaced lie
  - Samuel, knowing all he had learned from the Lord and what he had heard about Saul's monument, reacts in disgust
    - He points out the king's hypocrisy to his face
    - And in the process, Samuel utters one of the more memorable lines in scripture
  - Samuel asks Saul if Saul had accomplish all the Lord commanded, why then does Samuel hear the bleating of sheep and lowing of oxen?
    - He's pointing out the obvious
    - Not all the animals died, which is in violation of the Lord's commands

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        - Given how easy it was to see Saul's disobedience, it was utterly ridiculous for Saul to claim he did as the Lord commanded!
- So how does Saul defend himself?

1Sam. 15:15 **Saul said, "They have brought them from the Amalekites, for the people spared the best of the sheep and oxen, to sacrifice to the Lord your God; but the rest we have utterly destroyed."**

- First, notice Saul speaks in the third person referring to the people and to what "they've" done
    - Saul didn't make a mistake...the people had a mind of their own
    - Saul is passing the buck, pure and simple, deflecting blame rather than taking responsibility
    - This shows us there is no repentance in his heart
- Secondly, Samuel says he had godly reasons to take the animals
    - He was going to sacrifice them to the Lord
    - There is no better cover up for sin than to claim we did it for God
    - It's like defending bank robbing by claiming you were going to give the money to charity
    - It's a lie and an excuse claiming a sinful act was actually a righteous act
- In reality, Saul was selfishly preserving the best animals for himself
    - Now that he's been caught, he's trying to rewrite history to avoid the wrath of God
        - Even if we were to assume Saul truly intended to sacrifice all the animals, he would still have been disobeying the Lord
        - And any act that isn't consistent with God's will is sin, regardless of how good it appears
    - This has become Saul's pattern
        - His will rules his heart, not the Lord's
        - As we've said, the Lord intended to rule His people, whether through judges or through a king
        - The king existed to carry out the Lord's instructions
        - But Saul shows no interest in serving the Lord, only himself
    - As Saul is sinning his yarn, he forgets that Samuel has direct access to the God with all the facts
        - God Himself gave Samuel the true story
        - A reminder that lying to a prophet of God is a dumb idea

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1Sam. 15:16 Then Samuel said to Saul, "Wait, and let me tell you what the Lord said to me last night." And he said to him, "Speak!"

1Sam. 15:17 Samuel said, "Is it not true, though you were little in your own eyes, you were made the head of the tribes of Israel? And the Lord anointed you king over Israel,

1Sam. 15:18 and the Lord sent you on a mission, and said, 'Go and utterly destroy the sinners, the Amalekites, and fight against them until they are exterminated.'

1Sam. 15:19 "Why then did you not obey the voice of the Lord, but rushed upon the spoil and did what was evil in the sight of the Lord?"

- **Samuel interrupt Saul and telling him to "wait"**
  - In Hebrew, the word for wait means cease or let it go
    - Samuel is having none of Saul's pathetic excuses
    - So he tells Saul stop digging the hole he's standing in
    - And instead Samuel says let me tell you what the Lord has already told me
    - To which Saul responds tell me, faking interest in the Lord's word
  - Samuel starts by reminding Saul where Saul came from
    - Before the Lord elevated him to king, Saul knew he was the least among the least tribe of Israel
    - He had a humble – but more importantly – a realistic self-image
  - Having been anointed as king of Israel, the Lord turned to the one He raised up, to the one He called to serve Him and gave a command
    - Now we might think that a man plucked from obscurity
    - And elevated to an unexpectedly grand position beyond anything he could have imagined would have gladly served God
    - That's Samuel's point...Saul has lost all perspective on who he is and who God is
  - Obedience to the Lord is always directly related to the accuracy of our self-image in relationship to our view of God
    - The more we understand our humble, undeserving, sinful nature
    - And the more we appreciate God's power, judgment and wrath
    - The more likely we will value His mercy and obey His commands
  - But when we get those two perspectives reversed, we're headed for a fall

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        - That's Saul in a nutshell
        - Samuel nails Saul's true reason for leaving the allowing the livestock to survive
        - Saul simply wanted the spoils of war for himself
        - The choice animals were too good to pass up
        - Saul could only think of the wealth he would receive
        - Forgetting he owed everything to the Lord who granted him such riches
- In response to Samuel's rebuke, Saul double-downs on his lie

1Sam. 15:20 **Then Saul said to Samuel, "I did obey the voice of the Lord, and went on the mission on which the Lord sent me, and have brought back Agag the king of Amalek, and have utterly destroyed the Amalekites.**

1Sam. 15:21 **"But the people took some of the spoil, sheep and oxen, the choicest of the things devoted to destruction, to sacrifice to the Lord your God at Gilgal."**

- Saul seems to have lost all sense of shame at this point
    - He repeats his lie claiming to have obeyed the Lord when in fact he didn't
        - And again he points to the people as the real villains
        - But be sure to notice again Saul's word choice
        - He speaks of "your" God not his God
        - Saul was living so far from God that he has stopped seeing God from a personal standpoint
- Then Samuel responds in poetic language

1Sam. 15:22 **Samuel said,**

"Has the Lord as much delight in burnt offerings and sacrifices

As in obeying the voice of the Lord?

Behold, to obey is better than sacrifice,

And to heed than the fat of rams.

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1Sam. 15:23 **"For rebellion is as the sin of divination,**

And insubordination is as iniquity and idolatry.

Because you have rejected the word of the Lord,

He has also rejected you from being king."

- Why does Samuel respond in rhyme? This isn't "Saul: The Musical"
  - When a prophet speaks in poetic structures, it's an indication that his words are spoken under inspiration
    - Obviously, all scripture is inspired
    - But this indicates that Samuel's speech in that moment was coming directly from the Lord to Saul
    - The Lord says He delights in obedience even more than pious acts of sacrifices
    - He prefers a heart desiring to please the Lord than one that performs rituals
  - While sacrifices were themselves acts of obedience to the Law, the need for sacrifice was itself a result of prior disobedience
    - Said another way, if there were no disobedience in the first place, there would be not need for sacrifice either
    - Had Saul killed all the animals in obedience, then by definition there would be no sacrifice of any animals needed
- In v.23 the Lord compares disobedience to the command of God to divination
  - Divination is the sin of appealing to demonic power to control the future
    - When we seek to do our will rather than God's will, we inevitably seek to control the future in place of God
    - When you disobey the Lord, you align with Satan's purposes
  - And insubordination is equal to sin and idolatry
    - Insubordination is defiance of authority or a refusal to obey orders
    - It's attempting to put another in God's place, as Saul did here
    - Therefore, it's a form of idolatry
- And with that, the Lord declares that because Saul rejected the word of the Lord, the Lord has rejected him
  - This a cause-and-effect outcome for Saul
    - He wasn't going to have a dynasty, but might have reigned in peace and security all the days of his life

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        - He might have achieved great things as a king
        - Assuming Saul obeyed the Lord
    - But those days are over for Saul now
        - And he's brought it upon himself
        - And the word of the Lord has gone forth and cannot be changed
- Now that he's pressed into a corner, Saul expresses regret

1Sam. 15:24 **Then Saul said to Samuel, "I have sinned; I have indeed transgressed the command of the Lord and your words, because I feared the people and listened to their voice.**

1Sam. 15:25 **"Now therefore, please pardon my sin and return with me, that I may worship the Lord."**

- Finally, under pressure and facing the consequences, Saul acknowledges he has sinned
    - This isn't repentance...this is merely regret
    - Saul says he has transgressed the command of the Lord
    - But in the Hebrew, the word is better translated overlooked
    - Saul's saying he overlooked a small detail in the overall command God gave Saul
- When you put these two thoughts together you realize that Saul was speaking in a dismissive tone
    - He was saying, "Oh, I guess I sinned...if you count those small details I overlooked in God's plan..."
    - Hardly the words of a repentant heart
- Then Saul goes the extra step of pulling a page from Aaron's playbook
    - He blames the people for making him do it, just as Aaron did with the golden calf
    - He says their greed and desire forced his hand
    - Nevermind, Saul is the king and can do whatever he wants...
- In v.25 he asks Samuel for forgiveness, but this kind of confession can't gain forgiveness
    - Moreover, Saul is asking the wrong person, isn't he?
        - Samuel is just the messenger
        - Saul's words remind me of Simon in Acts 8, who asked the apostles to pray to God on his behalf when he was told he had sinned
        - Those who have strayed from God (or have never known Him) are uncomfortable speaking to Him personally

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        - So they ask religious people to intervene on their behalf
    - Finally, and perhaps worst of all, Saul says he needs Samuel's forgiveness so he can worship the Lord
        - This is a purely cynical move on his part
        - He is no more interested in truly worshipping the Lord than he was obeying the Lord
        - In fact, scripture tells us that true worship is obedience
        - Saul is merely doing eye service in an attempt to ingratiate himself to Samuel and to God if that were possible
- Next we find Samuel's response

1Sam. 15:26 **But Samuel said to Saul, "I will not return with you; for you have rejected the word of the Lord, and the Lord has rejected you from being king over Israel."**

1Sam. 15:27 **As Samuel turned to go, Saul seized the edge of his robe, and it tore.**

1Sam. 15:28 **So Samuel said to him, "The Lord has torn the kingdom of Israel from you today and has given it to your neighbor, who is better than you.**

1Sam. 15:29 **"Also the Glory of Israel will not lie or change His mind; for He is not a man that He should change His mind."**

- Samuel refuses to participate in Saul's charade
    - Samuel refuses to accompany Saul to worship in Gilgal
        - And Samuel reiterates that the Lord's rejection was final and not subject to negotiation
        - This is a central truth of scripture
    - As the Lord determines to do, He will do
        - As we said earlier, nothing changes God's mind
        - Because God already had all the information when He made His decision the first time
        - In fact, God is the author of all history, so all that transpires happens according to His will
        - And all that happens is according to His eternal plan which was established before the foundations of the earth

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        - So it is literally impossible for God to change His mind, as His mind is arrived at the perfect outcome from the beginning
- Samuel turns to leave, and in a moment of great irony, Saul reaches out, grab's Samuel's cloak to stop him, and rips the garment
    - Saul is losing grip on power and on reality
        - And so he desperately reaches out to grab hold of God's mercy, as it were
        - Seeking something by his might that he could only find in faith and obedience
        - And as he rips the garment, Saul is watching the rule of Israel being rent from his hands
    - Samuel then informs Saul that a better man has been found and will be anointed in his place
        - This knowledge will torment Saul in the final 15 years of his reign
        - And it will become a test for Saul's successor

Finally, the chapter ends with Samuel tying up loose ends

1Sam. 15:30 **Then he said, "I have sinned; but please honor me now before the elders of my people and before Israel, and go back with me, that I may worship the Lord your God."**

1Sam. 15:31 **So Samuel went back following Saul, and Saul worshiped the Lord.**

1Sam. 15:32 **Then Samuel said, "Bring me Agag, the king of the Amalekites." And Agag came to him cheerfully. And Agag said, "Surely the bitterness of death is past."**

1Sam. 15:33 **But Samuel said, "As your sword has made women childless, so shall your mother be childless among women." And Samuel hewed Agag to pieces before the Lord at Gilgal.**

1Sam. 15:34 **Then Samuel went to Ramah, but Saul went up to his house at Gibeah of Saul.**

1Sam. 15:35 **Samuel did not see Saul again until the day of his death; for Samuel grieved over Saul. And the Lord regretted that He had made Saul king over Israel.**

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- Samuel honors the office of king by agreeing to accompany him to worship
  - To do otherwise would have dishonored the king in the eyes of the people, which Samuel won't do
    - His willingness to honor the office of king foreshadows David's own behavior
    - Honoring those God has raised up is our duty
    - And we do so regardless of whether the individual deserves the honor personally
  - Finally, Samuel finishes the job Saul should have done
    - He calls for the king of the Amalekites and beheads him
    - Samuel might be old, but he could swing a sword
  - In v.33, Samuel tells Agag why he must die
    - The Amalekites attacked the Israelites of the Exodus by ambushing the stragglers at the rear
    - Naturally, those in the rear ranks were mostly the children
    - So when the Amalekites attacked Moses and the people, they made many women childless
    - It was a cowardly act deserving of God's retribution
    - And now Agag and his people have paid the price
- This was the last time Samuel saw Saul, though Saul rules for another 15 years

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- We've reached the halfway point in the book
  - And appropriately, we also move into Part 2 of Samuel's story
    - The first half of our study has been focused on the rebellious state of the nation
    - Their propensity to follow after idols, their failure to hear and heed the Lord's word
    - And their fleshly desire for a king who will defend them from their enemies
  - They rejected the Lord's rule over them in favor of a king that suited their desires
    - But the Lord never stopped ruling His people
    - He rules through a king no different than a judge
  - But a king has some serious handicaps that judges didn't have
    - First, the king didn't hear directly from the Lord
    - The Lord revealed His word through prophets, not kings
    - Secondly, the king could be easily tempted by his unrivaled power among men
    - Absolute power corrupts absolutely, and so kings are more likely to fall into temptation, pride, arrogance, etc.
    - And when they fall, the people will fall too
- As the first half ended, the king Israel had selected, Saul, had fallen before the Lord
  - He fell victim to exactly the temptations Samuel warned would lead the nation astray
    - So the Lord disqualified Saul's family from continuing in the rule
    - And later the Lord rejected Saul as King
    - Which means the Lord will anoint another in his place
  - And that brings us to the second half of the book, a story of the rise of David as the next king
    - But Saul isn't gone yet
    - So really it's a story of David and Saul
    - Or we might say David vs. Saul because the story becomes one of David defending himself from the king who feels the threat of a successor
- But even above these storylines, the main idea running through 1 & 2 Samuel and into the books of Kings is the Lord's sovereignty in raising up Israel's leaders
  - Kings come and go according to the Lord's purposes
    - But these men always live to serve the Lord's purposes
    - Both the good and bad is a part of God's plan
    - So we strive to understand everything that takes place from that perspective
  - As we enter Chapter 16, Saul has been ruling for about 25 years or so
    - He will rule for a total of 40 years

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        - So he still has 15 years or so of time remaining
    - Yet the Lord has already rejected him
        - Therefore, Saul's time on the throne is merely a matter of waiting for God's convenience
        - During these fifteen years the Lord prepares the heart and strength of Israel's next king
    - Meanwhile, Saul will weaken as the Lord allows his wandering heart to take the man deeper into destruction
        - As long as he lives, he is the Lord's anointed, because the gifts and calling of God are irrevocable
        - Nevertheless, the Lord is already preparing to anoint the next man

1Sam. 16:1 Now the Lord said to Samuel, "How long will you grieve over Saul, since I have rejected him from being king over Israel? Fill your horn with oil and go; I will send you to Jesse the Bethlehemite, for I have selected a king for Myself among his sons."
1Sam. 16:2 But Samuel said, "How can I go? When Saul hears of it, he will kill me." And the Lord said, "Take a heifer with you and say, 'I have come to sacrifice to the Lord.'
1Sam. 16:3 "You shall invite Jesse to the sacrifice, and I will show you what you shall do; and you shall anoint for Me the one whom I designate to you."
1Sam. 16:4 So Samuel did what the Lord said, and came to Bethlehem. And the elders of the city came trembling to meet him and said, "Do you come in peace?"
1Sam. 16:5 He said, "In peace; I have come to sacrifice to the Lord. Consecrate yourselves and come with me to the sacrifice." He also consecrated Jesse and his sons and invited them to the sacrifice.

- This chapter is framed by Samuel as two parts by itself
    - Notice that v.1 and v.13 both mention a horn of oil while v.14 and v.23 both mention the departing of the Spirit
        - These markers help anchor the beginning and end of the two parts
        - The first part of the chapter emphasizes the rise of David to success and adoration
        - While the second part emphasizes the beginning of Saul's slide into madness and torment
    - In v.1, we find Samuel having a pity party
        - We're told he's grieving because the Lord has rejected Saul
        - Why is Samuel so distraught?
        - Probably because he's worried for what this change means for him

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        - When the time comes to anoint another king, Samuel will be committing an act of treason from Saul's point of view
        - So Samuel's concern is at least in part for his own skin
- We see that reflected in his response to the Lord
    - The Lord asks Samuel how long he's going to delay in his grieving
        - It's time to go to the family of Jesse to anoint one of his sons
        - Samuel's answer confirms he's worried for himself
        - He says if people ask why he's come to them and they learn he's arrived to anoint Saul's successor, then word will get back to Saul
        - And then Saul will seek to kill Samuel
    - So the Lord gives Samuel a fascinating answer
        - The Lord tells Samuel to take a female cow and tell the people he is come to sacrifice to the Lord
        - At first, it sounds like this is a story intended to deceive
        - Could it be the Lord is asking Samuel to lie?
    - In case you're struggling to find the answer, let me help you: no
        - Notice the Lord says that Samuel will, in fact, conduct a sacrifice to the Lord
        - And moreover, he will invite Jesse, a man living in Bethlehem, to attend the sacrifice with him
        - Then in the course of conducting the sacrifice, the Lord will reveal the rest of the plan
        - So if someone asks Samuel what he's doing, he can answer absolutely honestly
        - The Lord has told him to come to Bethlehem to sacrifice
- As Samuel enters the city, the elders of the city take note of Samuel's arrival
    - Samuel's reputation preceded him into this small town
        - He had delivered the word of the Lord for decades
        - He had anointed the nation's king
        - And he killed the king of Ammon by his own hand
        - So Samuel always gains attention at his arrival
    - In fact, his killing of Agag apparently gave Samuel the reputation of a warrior or executioner
        - Which is why the elders ask him if he's coming in peace
        - They wonder if someone is about to hacked to death
        - They probably frisked Samuel too
    - Samuel responds he came in peace to sacrifice to the Lord
        - In the process, Samuel consecrated Jesse and his sons

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        - In other words, Samuel calls the family out separately to stand before him at the sacrifice

1Sam. 16:6 When they entered, he looked at Eliab and thought, "Surely the Lord's anointed is before Him."
1Sam. 16:7 But the Lord said to Samuel, "Do not look at his appearance or at the height of his stature, because I have rejected him; for God sees not as man sees, for man looks at the outward appearance, but the Lord looks at the heart."
1Sam. 16:8 Then Jesse called Abinadab and made him pass before Samuel. And he said, "The Lord has not chosen this one either."
1Sam. 16:9 Next Jesse made Shammah pass by. And he said, "The Lord has not chosen this one either."
1Sam. 16:10 Thus Jesse made seven of his sons pass before Samuel. But Samuel said to Jesse, "The Lord has not chosen these."

- By this point Samuel has revealed his mission to the family
    - So proudly, the father, Jesse, brings each of his sons before Samuel for anointing
        - Naturally, he begins with the first born, which is the normal and logical place to start in a patriarchal culture
        - In fact, it was so expected that even Samuel falls victim to this bias
        - He takes one look at Eliab and concludes this must be the guy
    - We can assume that this guy looked similar to Saul as a young man
        - Tall, handsome, strong
        - He must have been another poster child for king candidates
    - But now we see the Lord opposing the course of men, driven by the flesh
        - The Lord is not about to select a warrior that fits the part externally
        - It would be spiritually damaging if He were to reinforce the faulty notion that external appearance is a good measure of godliness
        - Men do not have insight into the character of a person
        - And if when we have indications that a person has bad character, our flesh celebrates the "bad" boys
        - Especially if they have movie star good looks
- So the Lord is going to pass over all those sons who do not have the heart to know and follow the Lord
    - And the Lord has already prepared one son in this family to have that kind of heart
        - It won't be the oldest son
        - It won't be the next oldest
        - In fact, Samuel proceeds through seven sons without finding the one the Lord

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desires

- The number seven certainly tells us that this is a process under the Lord's providence

- Samuel sees only seven sons, so he is perplexed by the outcome
  - The Lord sent him here to anoint a son, but there are no more sons!
  - So now what?

1Sam. 16:11 And Samuel said to Jesse, "Are these all the children?" And he said, "There remains yet the youngest, and behold, he is tending the sheep." Then Samuel said to Jesse, "Send and bring him; for we will not sit down until he comes here."
1Sam. 16:12 So he sent and brought him in. Now he was ruddy, with beautiful eyes and a handsome appearance. And the Lord said, "Arise, anoint him; for this is he."
1Sam. 16:13 Then Samuel took the horn of oil and anointed him in the midst of his brothers; and the Spirit of the Lord came mightily upon David from that day forward. And Samuel arose and went to Ramah.

- Samuel asks Jesse the obvious question, "Do you have more sons?"
  - Jesse says there is one more, the youngest, who is tending sheep
    - Children typically were expected to tend sheep
    - The work didn't require much strength or maturity
    - And it was considered demeaning in any case
    - So boys as young as 10 or 12 might be found with the sheep all day and even overnight
  - Seeing David as the youngest child and as a shepherd fits two important Biblical themes
    - God is commonly seen selecting men who are the opposite of those the world would select
    - In the days of the patriarchs, the Lord routinely selected the younger son
      - Isaac, not Ishmael; Jacob, not Isaac
- God's purpose was always to draw a distinction between the natural way and the redemption of the Lord
  - The natural way of man is sin, rebellion, and death
    - And in the natural way of men, the older is the superior
    - The older son must be given preference over the younger
    - In fact, notice that when Samuel told Jesse to get his sons and bring them to sacrifice, he neglected to include David

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        - To Jesse, David was not even a consideration for an anointing as king
        - Similar to the way that Abraham disagreed with the Lord when told that Ishmael wasn't the chosen son
    - By contrast, the mercy of God brings redemption, hope and life to those least likely to expect it
        - As Paul taught, the Lord uses the weak things to shame the wise
        - So He sought to raise up the younger son in each case to make clear He was in control, acting to reverse the natural course
        - And He's doing it again here
    - Secondly, the Bible uses shepherding as a theme to represent the loving care of God's people
        - Shepherds spent time with the sheep
        - They fed them, kept them from wandering, defended them
        - God's people are to be cared for as a shepherd cares for his sheep
        - Which is why Jesus is called the Good Shepherd
- And Jesse's youngest son is clearly a type of Christ
    - As we'll see in many instances in this book, David pictures the coming Messiah in details big and small
        - We've already seen that David comes from Bethlehem, the city where Jesus will be born
        - They share this same town because the seed line of the Messiah passes through David
        - And like David, Jesus is called a shepherd of His people
    - As David enters the room, he's not an unattractive young man, but he's not what Samuel was expecting
        - He's probably around the age of 15 or so
        - Not old enough or seasoned enough to even be considered for the role of king, much less assume the throne
        - So Samuel must been wondering how the Lord intended to use this boy to lead an entire nation
    - When the Lord indicates that David is His man, Samuel gets up and anoints David right there before his brothers
        - It was undoubtedly a dramatic moment
        - And it included the coming of the Spirit upon David for the rest of his life
        - We remember that the start of Christ's public ministry is also accompanied by the arrival of the Spirit
        - It represented the start of a time of service to the Lord
- David is the most important biblical character after Christ Himself

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- More is said about David in the Bible than anyone else
  - He is the subject of 66 chapters of the Old Testament
  - And he is mentioned 59 more times in the New Testament
  - To say nothing of his authorship of most of the Psalms
- David's name means roughly beloved of the Lord, and he will be called a man after God's own heart
  - Chuck Swindoll described being a man after God's heart this way:

What does it mean to be a person after God's own heart? Seems to me, it means that you are a person whose life is in harmony with the Lord. What is important to Him is important to you. What burdens Him burdens you. When He says, 'Go to the right,' you go to the right. When He says, 'Stop that in your life,' you stop it. When He says, 'This is wrong and I want you What does it mean to be a person after God's own heart? Seems to me, it means that you are a person whose life is in harmony with the Lord. What is important to Him is important to you. What burdens Him burdens you. When He says, 'Go to the right,' you go to the right. When He says, 'Stop that in your life,' you stop it. When He says, 'This is wrong and I want you.

- It doesn't mean never sinning
  - For we know David will sin greatly
- It means having a heart that mourns over its own sin as much as the Lord does
- After David is caught with Bathsheba, this is the psalm he writes

Psa. 51:1 Be gracious to me, O God, according to Your lovingkindness;
According to the greatness of Your compassion blot out my transgressions.
Psa. 51:2 Wash me thoroughly from my iniquity
And cleanse me from my sin.
Psa. 51:3 For I know my transgressions,
And my sin is ever before me.
Psa. 51:4 Against You, You only, I have sinned
And done what is evil in Your sight,
So that You are justified when You speak
And blameless when You judge.
Psa. 51:5 Behold, I was brought forth in iniquity,
And in sin my mother conceived me.
Psa. 51:6 Behold, You desire truth in the innermost being,
And in the hidden part You will make me know wisdom.
Psa. 51:7 Purify me with hyssop, and I shall be clean;
Wash me, and I shall be whiter than snow.

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Psa. 51:8 Make me to hear joy and gladness,
Let the bones which You have broken rejoice.
Psa. 51:9 Hide Your face from my sins
And blot out all my iniquities.
Psa. 51:10 Create in me a clean heart, O God,
And renew a steadfast spirit within me.
Psa. 51:11 Do not cast me away from Your presence
And do not take Your Holy Spirit from me.
Psa. 51:12 Restore to me the joy of Your salvation
And sustain me with a willing spirit.
Psa. 51:13 Then I will teach transgressors Your ways,
And sinners will be converted to You.
Psa. 51:14 Deliver me from bloodguiltiness, O God, the God of my salvation;
Then my tongue will joyfully sing of Your righteousness.
Psa. 51:15 O Lord, open my lips,
That my mouth may declare Your praise.
Psa. 51:16 For You do not delight in sacrifice, otherwise I would give it;
You are not pleased with burnt offering.
Psa. 51:17 The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit;
A broken and a contrite heart, O God, You will not despise.

- This is the kind of man the Lord has raised up
- Earlier, I said that the Lord has prepared David's heart to be the man God desired
    - By this I mean, that David was marked out from the womb to know and follow the Lord obediently, which is another picture of Christ
        - In the Psalms David describes his own beginning

Psa. 22:1 My God, my God, why have You forsaken me?
Far from my deliverance are the words of my groaning.
Psa. 22:2 O my God, I cry by day, but You do not answer;
And by night, but I have no rest.
Psa. 22:3 Yet You are holy,
O You who are enthroned upon the praises of Israel.
Psa. 22:4 In You our fathers trusted;
They trusted and You delivered them.
Psa. 22:5 To You they cried out and were delivered;
In You they trusted and were not disappointed.
Psa. 22:6 But I am a worm and not a man,
A reproach of men and despised by the people.
Psa. 22:7 All who see me sneer at me;
They separate with the lip, they wag the head, saying,

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Psa. 22:8 **"Commit yourself to the Lord; let Him deliver him;**
Let Him rescue him, because He delights in him."
Psa. 22:9 **Yet You are He who brought me forth from the womb;**
You made me trust when upon my mother's breasts.
Psa. 22:10 **Upon You I was cast from birth;**
You have been my God from my mother's womb.

- Like Jesus, David was made to trust the Lord while upon his mother's breasts
- He was cast from birth upon the Lord
- So David's preparation for service to the Lord began long before this moment
- Now at the midpoint in the chapter, the Spirit of the Lord has come upon David
  - And if the Spirit had come upon David for service to the Lord, then what about the Spirit's work with Saul?
    - The Spirit is moving from one to the other
    - And in His place comes something very different

1Sam. 16:14 **Now the Spirit of the Lord departed from Saul, and an evil spirit from the Lord terrorized him.**

- The Lord removes His Spirit from Saul
  - The Lord has rejected Saul for his sinful, rebellious heart
  - Saul wasn't willing to serve the Lord by allowing the Lord to rule His people through Saul's leadership
  - Instead, Saul sought to serve only himself
  - So now that the Lord has anointed his successor, the Lord's Spirit departs from Saul
- Remember, the departure of the Spirit from an individual is not unprecedented in the times before the New Covenant
  - It doesn't suggest the person has "lost" their salvation
  - But it does mean the Lord has removed His empowerment from the person
  - They no longer work with His supernatural wisdom and favor
  - The Lord can still work through them
  - But they themselves will not have divine enablement
- The even more interesting part is the second half of v.14 where we're told the Lord sends an evil Spirit to Saul
  - So many things about this statement are intriguing to me
    - First, the idea of God using the demonic world for His purposes never fails to fascinate

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        - We know the Lord put Satan to use at various times in history including in the Garden, in Job's life and in Judas' actions
        - And here we see that demons can be sent specifically to torment a person
    - How does this actually happen? We know the demons do not desire to do God's bidding, since they rebelled in the first place
        - What does rebellion mean if a demon can be "sent" to do God's will and then seems to gladly complete the mission?
        - The best we can conclude is that demons must act in predictable ways
        - They desire to destroy God's work and seek to undermine his people and never vary in their desire to complete this objective
        - When given a chance to torment a child of God, like Saul, a demon will relish the opportunity and seize upon it every time
        - Therefore, the Lord can employ demons when their evil desires suit His divine purposes
    - Secondly, demons must be blind to how their actions support the Lord's purposes in the end
        - Otherwise, why would Satan have acted to put Jesus to death?
        - Or why would he have played into the Lord's hand with Job?
        - Demons are not omniscient, and therefore they can't see the future
        - So they can be enticed to act against their own best interests
- Why did the Lord feel it necessary to bring this evil spirit to torment Saul in the first place? Why wasn't taking away His Spirit sufficient response to Saul's sin?
    - While taking away the Spirit would have been sufficient, it didn't suit God's purposes in raising Saul up in the first place
        - Remember, Saul was from the wrong tribe and wasn't God's selection
        - So when the Lord allowed Saul to be the king, we knew it couldn't last
        - Nevertheless, the Lord raised him up for two principle reasons
    - The only reason Saul has been raised up is to serve as a negative example to Israel and to all history
        - Saul's ignominious end will forever testify of what happens when the flesh rules over the Spirit
        - When love of self exceeds love for the Lord
        - When outward man takes precedence over the inner man
    - So for the final fifteen years of Saul's reign, the Lord intends to exhibit Saul's failure
        - The evil Spirit will provoke and tempt Saul's flesh
        - This torment will bring out the worst in Saul
        - So that everyone will understand the folly of depending on the flesh
- Secondly, the king after God's heart, David, is a man the Lord approves

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- And since the Lord loves David, He will reprove David
  - As the writer of Hebrews says

Heb. 12:5 and you have forgotten the exhortation which is addressed to you as sons,
"My son, do not regard lightly the discipline of the Lord,
Nor faint when you are reproved by Him;
Heb. 12:6 For those whom the Lord loves He disciplines,
And He scourges every son whom He receives."

Heb. 12:10 For they disciplined us for a short time as seemed best to them, but He disciplines us for our good, so that we may share His holiness.
Heb. 12:11 All discipline for the moment seems not to be joyful, but sorrowful; yet to those who have been trained by it, afterwards it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness.

- Since the Lord loves David, He will bring David trials to discipline him
- And discipline prepares David to share in the Lord's holiness
- The David we know from 2 Samuel and the Psalms is the David God molded in adversity
- And who was the source of that adversity? Saul
  - As Saul is tormented by the evil Spirit, he is increasingly prone to bouts of paranoia and rage against David
  - Saul's pursuits of David will test the young king-in-waiting severely
  - And over 10 years David will be seasoned as God intended
- David's life is a wonderful reminder that the bad things in our lives are God-directed events intended to mold us into someone better
  - We may not understand how the two are connected
  - But we can be sure that nothing we've experienced was outside His control or intended to harm us
  - Nevertheless, the question is are we taking those challenges and tests and turning them into the benefit God intended?
  - Or are we finding ways to escape the trial or test so that we never learn the lesson God intended?
- And right away, we see how the Lord uses this evil Spirit to ensure that a lowly shepherd boy might find an opportunity to associate with the king

1Sam. 16:15 Saul's servants then said to him, "Behold now, an evil spirit from God is terrorizing you.
1Sam. 16:16 "Let our lord now command your servants who are before you. Let

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them seek a man who is a skillful player on the harp; and it shall come about when the evil spirit from God is on you, that he shall play the harp with his hand, and you will be well."
1Sam. 16:17 **So Saul said to his servants, "Provide for me now a man who can play well and bring him to me."**
1Sam. 16:18 **Then one of the young men said, "Behold, I have seen a son of Jesse the Bethlehemite who is a skillful musician, a mighty man of valor, a warrior, one prudent in speech, and a handsome man; and the Lord is with him."**
1Sam. 16:19 **So Saul sent messengers to Jesse and said, "Send me your son David who is with the flock."**

- As Saul suffers under the affliction of the evil spirit, it causes the servants of Saul to take note
  - We wonder what they saw and how they understood the cause
    - I wonder if we don't see this in our day as well
    - We attribute strange behaviors to other causes, never stopping to consider whether the behavior is the result of demonic influence
    - We need to leave room in our personal theology for supernatural explanations like this when confronting inexplicable and evil behavior
  - And recognize that Saul is a believer, yet God brought this evil spirit
    - So it's possible for the demon world to influence the thinking and behavior of a believer who is living in the flesh
    - According to the New Testament, it's not possible for a believer to be indwelled or possessed by an evil spirit
    - But there is still great potential for an evil spirit to act on our thoughts and emotions if we are not walking closely with the Spirit of God
- In this day, strange behavior was attributed almost universally to one of two causes: alcohol or demons
  - The idea of mental illness as a separate category was not considered
    - Even if a biological cause could be identified, they just assumed that the condition itself was the product of spiritual agents
    - In many ways, this thinking is closer to the truth than our enlightened scientific views today
    - As Paul said, we don't war against flesh and blood but rather against spiritual forces
    - And that war includes the war with our own bodies at times
    - The source of many mental, emotional and even physical ailments may be spiritual forces working to weaken us
    - And therefore, we must consider the need for spiritual solutions to spiritual problems

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- In this case, the cause is correctly diagnosed as demons
  - For this is what the Lord intended
  - By sending Saul this evil spirit, He set in motion circumstances that would ultimately bring David and Saul together
  - He needs them to meet so that David can be prepared to assume the position as king
  - And so He can use the tension between these two men in training up David

- Saul's fits of terror and deteriorating mental state leads the servants to propose to call for a skilled musician to soothe Saul
  - I assume this idea came to them by way of the Spirit of God so that they would ultimately call for David to enter the court
    - Saul likes the idea and one of the young men in the court give a suggestion
    - The man knows David to be skilled musician, a warrior and prudent, not to mention nice looking
    - They call him a warrior despite his youth because David has already gained a reputation for killing lions and bears that attacked his sheep (Chapter 17)
  - And though we often think of David as a warrior, remember he was first a shepherd and a musician – a true renaissance man
    - The Lord gifted David in these ways knowing the work ahead
    - The Lord knew David would be called to lead armies
    - That he would write songs and poems of praise
    - And he would lead the people with wisdom and patience
- Saul calls for David to leave the flocks and serve the royal court

1Sam. 16:20 **Jesse took a donkey loaded with bread and a jug of wine and a young goat, and sent them to Saul by David his son.**
1Sam. 16:21 **Then David came to Saul and attended him; and Saul loved him greatly, and he became his armor bearer.**
1Sam. 16:22 **Saul sent to Jesse, saying, "Let David now stand before me, for he has found favor in my sight."**
1Sam. 16:23 **So it came about whenever the evil spirit from God came to Saul, David would take the harp and play it with his hand; and Saul would be refreshed and be well, and the evil spirit would depart from him.**

- Jesse must have been a man of some means to afford a donkey for transportation
  - But it doesn't mean David's family was prominent, since scripture tells us otherwise later in Chapter 18
  - Rather, it may simply indicate he was upper middle class
  - And when his son is called personally by the king to serve in the court, Jesse wants

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his sons to arrive in style
    - So he lets David borrow the Cadillac for the evening
- David's arrival bears some resemblance to Christ's arrival at least in terms of the symbols Jesus evokes in describing Himself
    - He rides a donkey
    - He carries bread and wine
    - He has a goat for a sacrifice
- And we're told that Saul takes to David immediately
    - He loves David and for a little while their relationship is quite good
    - Though later in Chapter 17 Saul has to ask who David's father was, which suggests Saul's mental state becomes quite debilitated, which ultimately destroys their fellowship
    - During this time David also forms a strong relationship with Saul's son, Jonathan, who was considerably older than David
    - Yet the two become very close especially as Saul begins to turn on David
- Finally, we see the grace of God at work in the way He grants Saul relief from time to time when David plays music for Saul
    - Is the music the cause of the demon's departure? Do demons just hate classical music?
        - No…we must conclude that the Lord is bringing and removing the demon in keeping with David's presence
        - It appears the Lord is working to give Saul good reason to keep David close as we said earlier
    - This is a measure of grace for Saul and I believe it's a tendency of God to use one person to comfort another for similar reasons
        - He draws together members of His body by placing a need in one that only another can address
        - And in doing so, the Lord causes us to give regard for one another and for the Spirit in each of us
        - He grows us spiritually, teaching us about Himself in the process

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- David is anointed and Saul has been afflicted
  - The Lord has brought these two rivals together for a time to season one and chastise the other
    - As David's prominence and strength and notoriety increases
    - Saul's fear, jealousy and paranoia will as well
    - This is all according to God's will, as it brings about the transition of the monarchy from one to the other
  - David's rise began with his time serving Saul as a musician in the court of the king
    - David was a skillful musician who could soothe Saul's anguish from the tormenting of the evil spirit
    - The Lord would drive the evil spirit away whenever David played
    - Creating a strong bond between the two men
  - In addition to playing music, David continued to tend sheep for his father Jesse
    - He's still relatively young
    - So the people, Saul included, don't give David much thought beyond his musical ability
    - But the Lord has great plans for David
    - And what the Lord knows of David's heart He's ready to expose to the people as well
    - He just needs an adversary mighty enough to gain the people's notice
- Today David meets that adversary: Goliath
  - One survey of the most recognized stories of the Bible placed the story of David and Goliath as second only to the account of Jesus' birth
    - Virtually any child that's spent any time in church has heard the story
    - Virtually every culture in the world uses the phrase "David and Goliath" to describe victory by an underdog of an overmatched opponent
    - It's a story of triumph over impossible odds that never grows tired or loses its appeal
  - But in the Bible, the story is much more than one of thrill of victory and the agony of defeat
    - It's a miracle done to validate the anointing of a future king
    - And a test for Saul's heart
    - And the story begins with a stalemate…

1Sam. 17:1 Now the Philistines gathered their armies for battle; and they were gathered at Socoh which belongs to Judah, and they camped between Socoh and Azekah, in Ephes-dammim.
1Sam. 17:2 Saul and the men of Israel were gathered and camped in the valley of

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Elah, and drew up in battle array to encounter the Philistines.
1Sam. 17:3 **The Philistines stood on the mountain on one side while Israel stood on the mountain on the other side, with the valley between them.**
1Sam. 17:4 **Then a champion came out from the armies of the Philistines named Goliath, from Gath, whose height was six cubits and a span.**
1Sam. 17:5 **He had a bronze helmet on his head, and he was clothed with scale-armor which weighed five thousand shekels of bronze.**
1Sam. 17:6 **He also had bronze greaves on his legs and a bronze javelin slung between his shoulders.**
1Sam. 17:7 **The shaft of his spear was like a weaver's beam, and the head of his spear weighed six hundred shekels of iron; his shield-carrier also walked before him.**

- The enemy God raises up comes from among the Philistines
  - These people occupied the coastal plains of Israel
    - They lived predominantly in five cities which we learned about when the ark was captured
    - They stayed in the plains for the most part
    - But they were constantly warring with the Jews, seeking to occupy their high ground
    - From the time of Judges to now, the Lord has used the Philistines' threat as a means of punishing Israel
  - And once again they are encroaching into the hill country of Judah
    - They gathered near Socoh, in the Elah valley
    - Socoh was a town at the eastern end of the valley, while Azekah was at the western end of the valley
    - The Philistines are camped in the middle of the valley between these cities
- Saul brings his forces into the valley to stop the Philistines from moving further through the valley toward Socoh and into the rest of Judah
  - And the two armies soon become entrenched in a stalemate
    - Armies always seek high ground upon which to gain an advantage over an enemy in combat
    - So the Philistines ran up the mountain on one side of the valley
    - Naturally, the Israelites didn't want to be remain vulnerable by remaining in the valley below
    - So they ran up the mountain on the opposite side of the valley
  - Now the two armies stood on hillsides opposite one another with the valley between them
    - Neither was willing to yield the high ground in order to advance into combat for

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fear of losing the advantage
        - So a stalemate resulted
        - Both armies stood on their respective hillsides within shouting distance of one another
        - But neither was willing to advance against the other
    - The Philistine people were of Greek origin, so they followed Greek traditions in warfare
        - One of these Greek practices was to settle such stalemates by conducting a single fight between champions
        - Each army would select a man who would engage in a fight to the death
        - Whichever man won the fight would determine the winning army for the entire battle
        - Homer recorded this tradition in the *Illiad* when Hector and Achilles battle
        - In fact, the word translated "champion" in v.4 is actually the Hebrew word for "man"
        - Yet the translators for the NASB chose to use the word champion there to acknowledge the Greek tradition
- So the champion for the Philistines was a man named Goliath
    - His name means "to be made a captive" which is prophetic for where this battle is headed
        - More importantly, he is a ringer
        - Goliath is literally a giant among men
        - He stands over 9 ft (2.75 m) tall, though the Septuagint and Dead Sea Scrolls say 6 ft 6 in (~2 m)
        - His armor weighed 125 lbs (56.6 kg), the weight of an average man
        - His spearhead alone weighed about 15 lbs (6.8 kg), or about the weight of a shot put
    - Samuel gives us this extended description of Goliath to ensure we get the full picture of what Israel was facing
        - This man is a freak of nature
        - He's not some supernatural creation, as if a remnant of the Nephilim, for they were destroyed in the flood
        - He's simply an outlier genetically
        - If he were alive today, he would be the guy who gets drafted by the NBA
        - Or travels with the circus
    - Only this is no game…this is warfare, and this guy is easily capable of killing anyone who challenged him
        - Which is why the Philistines trot him out into the valley to challenge the

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Israelites

1Sam. 17:8 He stood and shouted to the ranks of Israel and said to them, "Why do you come out to draw up in battle array? Am I not the Philistine and you servants of Saul? Choose a man for yourselves and let him come down to me.
1Sam. 17:9 "If he is able to fight with me and kill me, then we will become your servants; but if I prevail against him and kill him, then you shall become our servants and serve us."
1Sam. 17:10 Again the Philistine said, "I defy the ranks of Israel this day; give me a man that we may fight together."
1Sam. 17:11 When Saul and all Israel heard these words of the Philistine, they were dismayed and greatly afraid.

- In keeping with the Greek tradition, Goliath walks down the mountain side and across the valley toward the Israelite army to challenge them
  - He asks the army, why is everyone preparing to enter battle?
    - Do you not see I have come out to settle this war one-on-one?
    - I will represent the Philistines so send someone who will represent Saul's army, he says
  - Then he promises that if he dies, the Philistines' army will become slaves of Israel and vice versa
    - Either way, only one man has to die
    - The rest can live, albeit as slaves
    - That's the offer on the table
  - We know this initial offer was met with silence among the ranks of Israel, because Goliath has to repeat his challenge in v.10
    - In v.10 it says he defied the ranks of Israel
    - The word defy in Hebrew means insult
    - So Goliath was hurling insults at Israel, daring them to send someone down to fight him
    - He was trying to provoke the fight because he was so confident he could beat anyone they sent his way
- Standing in among the troops of Israel's army is Saul himself
  - We remember from Samuel's description of Saul that the king stood a full head taller than any other Jew in Israel
    - So imagine an army gathered with one guy standing 6-8 inches above the rest
    - So if there was one guy in the army who should be sent out to fight a 9 ft giant, it would have been Saul
    - And Saul knew it

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        - Never mind the fact that Saul was the king and a warrior who had defeated stronger enemies in the past
    - But the problem this time is Saul lacks the Spirit of God
        - So Saul has no courage or confidence to enter this battle
        - Nor does he have any reason to think the Lord will grant him the victory
        - He's living in his flesh, so all he sees is a superior foe taunting him
        - He's feeling the pressure to rise to the challenge, yet he knows he won't survive so he shrinks back
    - So Saul is dismayed and frightened we're told
        - And if the king is frightened into paralysis, then certainly the troops are even more so
        - The army of Israel just stands their ground without taking up the challenge, looking foolish
        - And by association, the God of Israel appears to cower in the face of the threats of a pagan
- The army is stuck…they won't attack, but they can't retreat
    - But they can't stay there forever either…with Goliath taunting them

1Sam. 17:12 Now David was the son of the Ephrathite of Bethlehem in Judah, whose name was Jesse, and he had eight sons. And Jesse was old in the days of Saul, advanced in years among men.
1Sam. 17:13 The three older sons of Jesse had gone after Saul to the battle. And the names of his three sons who went to the battle were Eliab the firstborn, and the second to him Abinadab, and the third Shammah.
1Sam. 17:14 David was the youngest. Now the three oldest followed Saul,
1Sam. 17:15 but David went back and forth from Saul to tend his father's flock at Bethlehem.
1Sam. 17:16 The Philistine came forward morning and evening for forty days and took his stand.
1Sam. 17:17 Then Jesse said to David his son, "Take now for your brothers an ephah of this roasted grain and these ten loaves and run to the camp to your brothers.
1Sam. 17:18 "Bring also these ten cuts of cheese to the commander of their thousand, and look into the welfare of your brothers, and bring back news of them.
1Sam. 17:19 "For Saul and they and all the men of Israel are in the valley of Elah, fighting with the Philistines."
1Sam. 17:20 So David arose early in the morning and left the flock with a keeper and took the supplies and went as Jesse had commanded him. And he came to the circle of the camp while the army was going out in battle array shouting the

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war cry.
1Sam. 17:21 **Israel and the Philistines drew up in battle array, army against army.**
1Sam. 17:22 **Then David left his baggage in the care of the baggage keeper, and ran to the battle line and entered in order to greet his brothers.**
1Sam. 17:23 **As he was talking with them, behold, the champion, the Philistine from Gath named Goliath, was coming up from the army of the Philistines, and he spoke these same words; and David heard them.**

- Once again, Samuel introduces us to David as the son of Jesse
  - Jesse is a man of eight sons and he is an old man nearing the end of his life
    - Samuel gives us this detail to explain why David is still working with the flock at home
    - Because earlier we were told that David had become an armor bearer for Saul, so we might expect he would have been in the battle
    - But Jesse is old and his three oldest sons were already gone into battle
    - Therefore the family needed David's help
  - So while Saul was away at battle, David went back to his father's home in Bethlehem to serve the family
    - Meanwhile, for forty days the taunting of Goliath continues
    - Forty days is a very long time to remain encamped in the same place under the threat of war
    - It had to be a miserable situation for the army, made all the worse by Goliath's taunting
    - And of course, the army needs to be fed while they sit on the side of this mountain
- So the people of Israel are mobilized to support the troops (they put yellow ribbons on the trees and bumper stickers on their cars…)
  - Out of concern for his sons, Jesse asks David to go to the troops with grain, bread and cheese
    - Basically, he's sending cheese sandwiches to the troops
    - Once again, David is seen as a servant bringing bread to the king
    - And Jesse wants David to return with news of the stalemate
  - As David arrives on this day, the army is moving into a battle array, preparing to attack
    - Apparently, Saul had tired of the stalemate and decided it was better to forfeit his position than withstand the taunting
    - His troops were positioning for the fight and likewise the Philistines were arrayed for battle
    - And into this tense situation, David arrives with grilled cheese sandwiches

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    - Seeing the armies preparing to fight, David runs to the front lines without any hesitation
        - This is a first indication of David's fearlessness
        - He seems completely at ease with the prospect of encountering God's enemies despite the obvious danger
        - It's seems the Holy Spirit upon David gives him a courage that transcends human understanding
- As David reaches the front lines, he hears the taunting of Goliath for the first time, and he's aghast at what he hears

1Sam. 17:24 When all the men of Israel saw the man, they fled from him and were greatly afraid.
1Sam. 17:25 The men of Israel said, "Have you seen this man who is coming up? Surely he is coming up to defy Israel. And it will be that the king will enrich the man who kills him with great riches and will give him his daughter and make his father's house free in Israel."
1Sam. 17:26 Then David spoke to the men who were standing by him, saying, "What will be done for the man who kills this Philistine and takes away the reproach from Israel? For who is this uncircumcised Philistine, that he should taunt the armies of the living God?"
1Sam. 17:27 The people answered him in accord with this word, saying, "Thus it will be done for the man who kills him."

- Having watched the Jewish army demoralized for 40 days by Goliath's taunts, the Philistines shuffle Goliath to the front of the army in preparation for the battle
    - They assume correctly that seeing and hearing Goliath leading the attack will break Israel's will to fight
        - Sure enough, the sight of Goliath leads the men of Israel to break ranks and begin to flee
        - They explain their actions by pointing to Goliath and saying "Have you seen this guy???"
    - And then some repeat an offer Saul must have circulated among the army at some earlier point
        - That if someone would defeat this man, Saul would bestow riches upon the man and give him a daughter
        - Also the man's house would be made free, which means they would live tax free in Israel the rest of their days
        - Nevertheless, Saul's offer hadn't been enough to motivate any man to battle Goliath
    - David knows nothing of the offer, but he assumes that there must some reward for killing the Philistine

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        - It's an indication of David's maturity and wisdom that he thought to ask about the reward
        - More importantly, it shows us that David was already thinking he could defeat Goliath
        - You don't ask about a reward unless you are seriously considering taking up the challenge
        - So we know this young boy is ready to fight a giant warrior
- David's confidence comes not from bravado or pride, which motivated Saul at all times, but from a boasting in the Lord
    - David says this Philistines is bringing reproach upon Israel
        - Reproach is shame or disapproval before an audience of others
        - Israel is suffering shame before the nations of the world because of their seeming impotence before this Gentile enemy
    - David knew Israel was in covenant with the Living God
        - To be in covenant means that the one party is pledged to protect the other
        - To give a life for the other if necessary
        - So when Israel is to be attacked by Gentiles, the Lord is obligated to defend Israel
    - It's David's faith in the promises of God that leads him to have such confidence in the face of a superior enemy
        - The enemy may be superior to Israel, but no enemy is superior to Israel's God
        - And God is in covenant with Israel
- When David asks about the reward, the men around him in the ranks explain what Saul had promised
    - But David's questioning angers his brothers, who were probably eating the sandwiches David brought them

1Sam. 17:28 Now Eliab his oldest brother heard when he spoke to the men; and Eliab's anger burned against David and he said, "Why have you come down? And with whom have you left those few sheep in the wilderness? I know your insolence and the wickedness of your heart; for you have come down in order to see the battle."
1Sam. 17:29 But David said, "What have I done now? Was it not just a question?"
1Sam. 17:30 Then he turned away from him to another and said the same thing; and the people answered the same thing as before.

- David's oldest brother, Eliab, burned with anger against David, so he chastises his brother for asking his questions
    - He accuses David of abandoning his post with the sheep

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        - But probably the comment was meant to demean David in the sight of the soldiers since shepherding was a role for children
        - But Eliab goes a step further accusing his brother of insolence and wickedness
        - Insolence means not showing respect where it's deserved
        - Presumably Eliab is still smarting over Samuel's selection of David instead of him, being the oldest in the family
        - As is often the case, the sins someone believes he sees in another is actually an accurate assessment of himself
    - David was innocent; it was Eliab who was wicked and disrespectful
        - David asks what have I done? I just asked a question
        - David's question poured salt in the wound of the army
        - By contemplating out loud about the reward, he was implying that the challenge could be easily met
        - Since this army had been paralyzed in fear for 40 days, David's question had the effect of implying the army were cowards
        - I'm sure hearing the taunts of Goliath for that long would make anyone's nerves raw, and David just steps all over them
    - In reality, David isn't calling the army cowards; he's pointing out their lack of faith
        - David's confidence comes from having a heart after God, one God has placed in David so he would glorify the Lord
        - He knows God's power, God's promises and God's desire to glorify Himself under impossible circumstances
        - It's the story of the Exodus, of Joshua in the land and of the judges
        - And David is expecting to see it again now
        - So David asks again to be sure he understands the terms
- David's interest in obtaining Saul's reward catches everyone's attention, and the word gets back to Saul that someone was ready to take up the challenge

1Sam. 17:31 **When the words which David spoke were heard, they told them to Saul, and he sent for him.**
1Sam. 17:32 **David said to Saul, "Let no man's heart fail on account of him; your servant will go and fight with this Philistine."**
1Sam. 17:33 **Then Saul said to David, "You are not able to go against this Philistine to fight with him; for you are but a youth while he has been a warrior from his youth."**
1Sam. 17:34 **But David said to Saul, "Your servant was tending his father's sheep. When a lion or a bear came and took a lamb from the flock,**
1Sam. 17:35 **I went out after him and attacked him, and rescued it from his mouth; and when he rose up against me, I seized him by his beard and struck him and**

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killed him.
1Sam. 17:36 **"Your servant has killed both the lion and the bear; and this uncircumcised Philistine will be like one of them, since he has taunted the armies of the living God."**
1Sam. 17:37 **And David said, "The Lord who delivered me from the paw of the lion and from the paw of the bear, He will deliver me from the hand of this Philistine." And Saul said to David, "Go, and may the Lord be with you."**

- Saul hears that David is visiting and wishing to claim the reward, so Saul summons him
  - David enters the king's presence and immediately declares that no one need worry, he would fight the battle for the army
    - He sounds like "Have no fear, Underdog is here!"
    - I doubt David's pronouncement would have been any less convincing if he actually were Underdog
  - Saul loses all heart at the sight of David
    - He says you are not able to go against Goliath
    - You are a child, he is a warrior trained since youth
    - Obviously, Saul is thinking entirely in human terms
    - This is Saul's pattern at every turn
    - He moves from relying on the Lord to relying on flesh
    - Later he moves further away from the Lord, turning from his flesh to cultic powers seeking deliverance
  - The Lord knew that this moment would come, and so He prepared David with experiences David could use to convince Saul the Lord was with him
    - He tells Saul he has already battled lions and bears and won
    - In these days, lions and bears were still indigenous to Palestine
    - And lions being carnivores and bears being omnivores, sheep were often on the menu for both
  - Once when a lion or bear would come to attack the flock, David would grab the animal by the main or hide and kill him
    - It's hard to imagine a young boy managing this task without supernatural intervention
    - And that's who David credits when he relates the story
    - And that's his point
    - If the Lord was working to help him kill wild beasts in that way, then certainly David knew the Lord would be with him in battling a man
    - Goliath was just another predator threatening God's flock
- David's story sheds some light on how his relationship and understanding of the Lord

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developed

- As we read last week in the Psalms, David was prepared by the Lord from birth with a special heart
  - David knew the Lord from birth
  - And he was being prepared to follow the Lord in a special way through experiences like this
- That's the only explanation for why a young boy would even consider to engage in a fight with a lion or bear
  - Any normal preteen or even teenager would flee in terror from such a scenario
  - But David engaged in the battle in confidence, not once but twice at least
  - This is a man with a very special understanding of God and his power in life
  - His thinking in reflected in Psalm 138

Psa. 138:1 I will give You thanks with all my heart;
I will sing praises to You before the gods.
Psa. 138:2 I will bow down toward Your holy temple
And give thanks to Your name for Your lovingkindness and Your truth;
For You have magnified Your word according to all Your name.
Psa. 138:3 On the day I called, You answered me;
You made me bold with strength in my soul.
Psa. 138:4 All the kings of the earth will give thanks to You, O Lord,
When they have heard the words of Your mouth.
Psa. 138:5 And they will sing of the ways of the Lord,
For great is the glory of the Lord.
Psa. 138:6 For though the Lord is exalted,
Yet He regards the lowly,
But the haughty He knows from afar.
Psa. 138:7 Though I walk in the midst of trouble, You will revive me;
You will stretch forth Your hand against the wrath of my enemies,
And Your right hand will save me.
Psa. 138:8 The Lord will accomplish what concerns me;
Your lovingkindness, O Lord, is everlasting;
Do not forsake the works of Your hands.

- David lived with a confidence that the Lord would answer Him when he called, as the Lord promised
  - It's that confidence that drives so many of David's psalms
    - Saul must have sensed that confidence in David
    - So he tells David to go ahead into battle for Israel

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- But Saul doesn't have the kind of walk with the Lord that David knows
  - He's not capable of seeing the supernatural possibilities even now
  - Saul fears Goliath, while David fears the Lord
  - Therefore, Saul still believes he needs to help the odds a little by equipping David for the battle

1Sam. 17:38 Then Saul clothed David with his garments and put a bronze helmet on his head, and he clothed him with armor.
1Sam. 17:39 David girded his sword over his armor and tried to walk, for he had not tested them. So David said to Saul, "I cannot go with these, for I have not tested them." And David took them off.
1Sam. 17:40 He took his stick in his hand and chose for himself five smooth stones from the brook, and put them in the shepherd's bag which he had, even in his pouch, and his sling was in his hand; and he approached the Philistine.

- In a somewhat comical moment, Saul attempts to dress David in his battle garments and armor
  - Remembering Saul's height and David's youth, we can only imagine that David was swimming in Saul's clothing
    - Once more, Saul trusts in armor more than the Lord
    - Even to the point that he would handicap David's movements in battle
    - Robert Gordon said that Saul tried to turn David into an armadillo, hiding him behind the armor
  - Out of respect for the king, David gives a try at wearing the ridiculous outfit
    - But quickly, he says I can't go to battle with these
    - He says they aren't "tested" which means he hasn't learned to use the equipment
    - It was a polite way of dismissing them without stating the obvious…they didn't fit
- Instead of a sword or armor, David chose to go to battle with something he had tested well: a sling and a few stones
  - And no doubt David traveled with his sling everywhere since it was a primary weapon of defense for shepherds
  - He collects five smooth stones
    - Along one side of the valley runs a small brook that turns dry most of the year
    - The Jewish army occupied the side of the valley where the river ran
    - So David simply dropped back a short distance from the army to collect his stones
    - We don't know why David collected five, since he only uses one

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        - But the number 5 in scripture is the number for grace, which suggest the Lord is working to grant His favor upon David
    - It's unclear exactly the size of these stones though most of us assume smallish river stones
        - Archaeologists who have studied shepherd's slings used in this period of history tell us the stones were more likely the size of baseballs
        - And the speed of the stone thrown by a sling approached the speed of a big league pitch (80 mph or 128 kph)
        - So getting hit by such a stone would leave quite an impression
    - A sling of this day is nothing like the one sold to children today
        - In David's time, a sling was a long piece of tanned leather doubled over with a pouch attached at the fold
        - A large stone could be placed in the pouch
        - Then the shepherd held both ends of the strap in one hand while swinging it rapidly to gain speed
        - At just the right moment, the shepherd released one end of the strap launching the stone at high speed
    - Experienced shepherds could send stones flying hundreds of feet with great accuracy
        - They used slings to control the sheep, scare off predators or defend against thieves
        - No doubt David was very accomplished in using his sling against moving targets at great distance (like sheep)
        - So the prospect of hitting a large, stationary target like Goliath would be child's play for David
- Then David enters battle

1Sam. 17:41 Then the Philistine came on and approached David, with the shield-bearer in front of him.
1Sam. 17:42 When the Philistine looked and saw David, he disdained him; for he was but a youth, and ruddy, with a handsome appearance.
1Sam. 17:43 The Philistine said to David, "Am I a dog, that you come to me with sticks?" And the Philistine cursed David by his gods.
1Sam. 17:44 The Philistine also said to David, "Come to me, and I will give your flesh to the birds of the sky and the beasts of the field."
1Sam. 17:45 Then David said to the Philistine, "You come to me with a sword, a spear, and a javelin, but I come to you in the name of the Lord of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom you have taunted.
1Sam. 17:46 "This day the Lord will deliver you up into my hands, and I will strike you down and remove your head from you. And I will give the dead bodies of

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the army of the Philistines this day to the birds of the sky and the wild beasts of the earth, that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel,
1Sam. 17:47 **and that all this assembly may know that the Lord does not deliver by sword or by spear; for the battle is the Lord's and He will give you into our hands."**
1Sam. 17:48 **Then it happened when the Philistine rose and came and drew near to meet David, that David ran quickly toward the battle line to meet the Philistine.**
1Sam. 17:49 **And David put his hand into his bag and took from it a stone and slung it, and struck the Philistine on his forehead. And the stone sank into his forehead, so that he fell on his face to the ground.**
1Sam. 17:50 **Thus David prevailed over the Philistine with a sling and a stone, and he struck the Philistine and killed him; but there was no sword in David's hand.**
1Sam. 17:51 **Then David ran and stood over the Philistine and took his sword and drew it out of its sheath and killed him, and cut off his head with it. When the Philistines saw that their champion was dead, they fled.**

- David went out and Goliath met him, but he took one look at David and became insulted
  - The Jewish army had sent out a young boy to defeat Goliath
    - Even worse, they sent a pretty boy
    - In this case, the point is that David was not a hardened warrior
    - And it's clear David hadn't even been a participant in the encampment, since he didn't show the wear of a 40-day encampment
  - Goliath says, do you think I'm like a dog that needs to be disciplined with a stick?
    - And then Goliath, in his anger at being dismissed so disrespectfully, begins to curse David by the Philistine gods
    - Finally, he taunts David promising to kill him easily and leave his body as food for birds
  - This is prideful bravado, of course, but it's very similar to Saul's perspective too
    - Earthly, fleshly, entirely devoid of any consideration for the God of Israel and His power
    - The taunt is important because it offers David an opportunity to respond in defense of the God of Israel
- David begins in v.45 emphasizing he has the greater weapon
  - While Goliath has brought swords and the like
    - But David has the Lord fighting on his side
    - And the Lord of Israel is an army unto Himself
    - And when you taunt Israel, you taunt the Living God as well
    - He may not always choose to act, at least not right away

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        - But rest assured the Lord will defend Israel in His day
    - This is still a truth today
        - Israel remains God's people in covenant
        - They are disobedient and are suffering under His judgment for a time
        - But in the end the Lord will defend His people
        - And to taunt Israel is to taunt the Living God to your own destruction
    - Then David proclaims his confidence that the Lord is about to deliver a victory to him
        - Moreover, David will remove his head
        - Finally, the army of the Philistines will be defeated as well
        - And all of them will become food for wild animals so that the world knows the God of Israel
- This statement is a brief summary of David's entire life
    - He leads a nation of God's people by covenant into battle before the nations so that the world may know the God of Israel
        - He does so in confidence that the Lord will deliver a victory
        - And he relies on the Spirit
        - He doesn't do it perfectly, of course
        - But he brings the people into greatness
        - Including giving them the city of Jerusalem and a temple mount
    - Secondly, David becomes an example within Israel
        - As he declared to Goliath, David will win this victory to remind the people that they serve a God who delivers by His own hand
        - The nation has emerged from a time of judges and now Saul with an almost complete disregard for the Lord's word
        - They have forgotten who they serve
        - They give little regard for the Lord's ability to deliver them
        - They are living in the flesh, relying on themselves
        - And David is going to remind them they serve a living God
- At this point, David displays even more courage, running into the battle rather than waiting for the battle to come to him
    - He takes the first stone out of his pouch, slings it and it hits the Philistine in the forehead
        - The stone goes into his skull, knocking him out
        - The penalty in Israel for blaspheming the Lord was stoning
        - So in this case, Goliath is judged rightly according to God's law

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- The stone knocks Goliath to the ground, but many overlook a detail in the story… the stone only knocked Goliath out
  - It may have been a mortal wound in the end, but David doesn't wait to find out
  - Notice in v.51 says David kills Goliath by cutting off his head with his own sword
- When the Philistines saw this result, they fled in terror
  - So much for becoming slaves of the Jews
  - You can't trust a Philistine

- David's victory brings a rout for Israel

1Sam. 17:52 The men of Israel and Judah arose and shouted and pursued the Philistines as far as the valley, and to the gates of Ekron. And the slain Philistines lay along the way to Shaaraim, even to Gath and Ekron.
1Sam. 17:53 The sons of Israel returned from chasing the Philistines and plundered their camps.
1Sam. 17:54 Then David took the Philistine's head and brought it to Jerusalem, but he put his weapons in his tent.

- The Philistines retreat to the two nearest Philistine cities
  - But many were killed along the way by the chasing Israelites
  - Eventually the army turns back and plunders the Philistine encampment
- David takes the head of Goliath and brings it back to Jerusalem
  - This is a curious reference since at this time the city was a Jebusite city and David lived in Bethlehem
  - Samuel may be referring to the later day when David moved into Jerusalem, meaning David kept Goliath's head as a trophy
  - He also kept Goliath's sword, which eventually was placed in Nob
- Next time, we move into the effects of this victory on David's life and relationship with Saul

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- David has defeated Goliath and saved Saul's army
  - At the end of Chapter 17 we learned that the victorious David kept Goliath's head and sword
    - Later in his life David will keep Goliath's head in Jerusalem as a trophy
    - So obviously, this victory made a significant impact on David
  - And so it should
    - David just defeated an enemy so strong that no one else in Israel would dare even engage with him
    - David ran out onto the field of battle without so much as a moment of hesitation
    - He was already calculating his reward at the first he learned of the bounty
  - More importantly, this moment defined David for the rest of his life
    - Forevermore David was known as the giant-slayer
    - He was the fearless one who saved Saul's army
- But in this victory the seeds of future conflict were planted
  - I doubt David could have even imagined the years of trouble that were in store for him as a result of this victory and all that came from it
    - Because not only did David take note of this victory, but so did Saul and the people
    - Saul knew David already, but this victory caused Saul to take a closer look at this young man
  - Earlier in Chapter 17 David stepped forward to fight Goliath, and Saul sized him up
    - Saul took one look at him and declared that David had no chance of winning
    - So in a ridiculous effort to even the odds, Saul put his armor on David

1Sam. 17:38 **Then Saul clothed David with his garments and put a bronze helmet on his head, and he clothed him with armor.**
1Sam. 17:39 **David girded his sword over his armor and tried to walk, for he had not tested them. So David said to Saul, "I cannot go with these, for I have not tested them." And David took them off.**

- In that moment, when Saul put his own royal armor on David, he was symbolically crowning David in his place
  - David has already been anointed by Samuel
  - The only thing standing between David and the throne is its current occupier, Saul
  - So it was highly significant that Saul places his armor on David
- But even more significant, notice David's response
  - He cannot wear the armor because he says he had not tested them

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- But the original Hebrew could be translated "I have not been tested"
- In other words, David is prophetically declaring he was not yet ready to assume the role of king
- Before he can take that position from Saul, David must be tested by God so he can be prepared and proven to be ready

- And ironically, the course of that testing will be Saul himself, as the king becomes increasingly paranoid that David will take his throne away

1Sam. 17:55 Now when Saul saw David going out against the Philistine, he said to Abner the commander of the army, "Abner, whose son is this young man?" And Abner said, "By your life, O king, I do not know."
1Sam. 17:56 The king said, "You inquire whose son the youth is."
1Sam. 17:57 So when David returned from killing the Philistine, Abner took him and brought him before Saul with the Philistine's head in his hand.
1Sam. 17:58 Saul said to him, "Whose son are you, young man?" And David answered, "I am the son of your servant Jesse the Bethlehemite."

- Saul inquires who is this young man after all
  - We know Saul called for David to soothe him with music in the court, so why does Saul fail to recognize David?
    - One answer is that Saul never really took a close look at David in the court
    - He was like any other servant to Saul perhaps, such that Saul could overlook him later
  - Saul inquires of his commander, Abner, who doesn't know either, probably for the same reason
    - So Abner is told to bring the young man to the king
    - And when David appears holding Goliath's head, Saul asks him his name
    - And David answers he is the son of Jesse the Bethlehemite
- After Saul won his first victory for Israel, the response from the people was as you might expect
  - The vast majority supported Saul as leader though a few initially rejected him
    - In time even those who had rejected Saul came to support him out of necessity
    - Now that David has won his victory, he will enjoy a similar response, though it will be far more complicated
  - And this begins in Chapter 18

1Sam. 18:1 Now it came about when he had finished speaking to Saul, that the soul of Jonathan was knit to the soul of David, and Jonathan loved him as himself.

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1Sam. 18:2 Saul took him that day and did not let him return to his father's house.
1Sam. 18:3 Then Jonathan made a covenant with David because he loved him as himself.
1Sam. 18:4 Jonathan stripped himself of the robe that was on him and gave it to David, with his armor, including his sword and his bow and his belt.
1Sam. 18:5 So David went out wherever Saul sent him, and prospered; and Saul set him over the men of war. And it was pleasing in the sight of all the people and also in the sight of Saul's servants.

- At the conclusion of the battle and of David's appearance before Saul, we're told the soul of Jonathan is knit to David
  - The story of David and Jonathan is a favorite for many Bible students
    - It's a beautiful and meaningful story of self-sacrifice and humility
    - Of pure, godly love of one for another
  - Jonathan, of course, is the son of Saul and the heir apparent for the throne of Israel
    - Were Saul to die, Jonathan would be expected by the people to take Saul's place and rule
    - But we know that God's plan is for David to be the next king
    - So under normal, human circumstances we would expect these two men to be rivals and fierce enemies
- But instead, we're told they form a close and abiding relationship
  - Notice we're told that the soul of Jonathan is knit to David
    - Samuel's choice of words stands out
    - Souls aren't knitted together just every day
  - The word for knit is *qashar*, and the word simply means to bind together for a common purpose
    - The word can also be used in a negative sense to describe conspirators
    - Once again, though, it's describing two people joined together in a common purpose
  - More interestingly, Samuel says it was the soul of Jonathan that was bound together with David
    - The Hebrew word for soul can also be translated life or person
    - So the sense of v.1 is that Jonathan's life was united with David's life
  - Notice also the specific way this union is happening
    - First, the Hebrew verb indicates that neither Jonathan nor David were the actors causing the union
    - The cause is outside either David or Jonathan
    - Secondly, notice the direction of the union

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        - Jonathan is united to David, not the other way around
        - This is important because it tells us that Jonathan was placing David above himself in this relationship
- We can see the one-way nature of this movement more clearly when we look at what Samuel writes next
    - First we're told that Jonathan loved David as he loved himself
        - Jonathan is being drawn selflessly toward David by his love for the man
        - He loves David with the kind of love the New Testament would call agape love
    - Some have perverted this verse to claim this was homosexual love
        - But the clear intent of the text is describing a selfless devotion of one man to another without any sexual implication
        - In fact, the Hebrew word for love in this verse is never used in the Bible to describe homosexual love
        - The love Jonathan felt for David is akin to the love a son has for his father or a disciple for his master
        - Jonathan's love is all the more striking when you remember that Jonathan was about 30 years older than David
        - Clearly, God was supernaturally drawing Jonathan to David
- Next we see Jonathan made a covenant with David because of his love for David
    - A covenant was a life-long unbreakable commitment to defend the other
        - There were several types of covenants
        - Some depended on each party to keep certain terms
        - Other covenants were one-way and only depended on the faithfulness of the one granting the covenant
    - In this case, Jonathan makes a one-way covenant with David
        - In v.3 Samuel says clearly that Jonathan is making the covenant with David
        - They didn't make a covenant together nor did David make one with Jonathan
        - Jonathan made one with David
    - Secondly, notice that the giving of the covenant was a result of Jonathan's love for David
        - The love in Jonathan's heart prompted him to grant David this covenant
        - We can say it was an act of love
    - Finally, Jonathan seals the covenant by placing his royal robe and armor on David
        - This is the most significant moment
        - Jonathan is the heir apparent
        - But he just transferred that to David
        - He signifies that David is the next king

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- And he gives David his armor
  - This signifies David's leadership of the army
  - And with that came the authority to kill any who oppose his rule
  - So Jonathan is abdicating the throne
  - Joyce Baldwin asks:

"In our political world, where power plays such an important role, what would be thought of a prince who voluntarily renounced his throne in favor of a friend whose character and godly faith he admired?"

- So we have to ask what would cause Jonathan to do such a thing?
  - The answer is back in v.1
    - Jonathan's soul was united in love with David
    - And of course, we know the Lord was the One holding the knitting needles
    - So the Lord produced in Jonathan a love for David that triggered in Jonathan the desire to submit to David's authority
  - And why was the Lord creating this strong, loving bond between David and Jonathan?
    - The answer should be clear: so that Jonathan won't oppose David's rise to power
    - In fact, Jonathan has now pledged to support David as king against his own personal interest
  - Jonathan could have tried to hold onto the throne of Israel
    - But instead, he willingly gave it up to the one who rightfully deserved it
    - Ironically, Jonathan would never have had the throne anyway
  - As Spurgeon wrote

Jonathan's was a singular love, because of the pureness of its origin. Jonathan loved David out of great admiration of him. When he saw him come back with the head of Goliath in his hand, he loved him as a soldier loves a soldier, as a brave man loves another brave man. He felt that there was the right kind of metal in that young man and though Jonathan was the king's son, and heir-apparent to the throne, we find that he, "stripped himself of the robe that was upon him, and gave it to David, and his garments, even to his sword, and to his bow, and to his belt." He felt that such a hero, who could so trust his God, and so expose his life, and come off so victorious, deserved his utmost love. It did not begin in self-interest—it did not begin in relationship—but it began in the likeness that Jonathan saw between his own nature and that of David. It was one brave man loving another brave man.

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Jonathan's love proved, also, to be most intense. It is said that, "he loved him as his own soul." He would at any moment have sacrificed his life to preserve the life of David. In fact, I do not doubt that Jonathan thought David's life much more valuable than his own and that he was quite willing to expose himself to peril that David might be preserved. Jonathan's was a very intense love. May we see more of this kind of love among Christian men! May they love each other for Christ's sake and because of the love of God which they see in one another—and may they be intense in their affection!

- This is God preparing the way for David by causing the house of Saul to move out of the way
  - Of course Saul himself isn't willing to make that move
  - But Jonathan will forever be David's ally
- In v.5 we're told that David goes wherever Saul sends him as a captain over the army and David prospered
  - The literal meaning of the Hebrew word for prospered is "to act wisely"
    - So we should read in v.5 that David went everywhere Saul asked and acted wisely so that he accomplished good things
    - And of course the people celebrated David's success
    - David is killing Philistines left and right, and everyone in Israel is giddy with the prospect of being freed from this scourge
  - But David's success opens a wound in Saul

1Sam. 18:6 **It happened as they were coming, when David returned from killing the Philistine, that the women came out of all the cities of Israel, singing and dancing, to meet King Saul, with tambourines, with joy and with musical instruments.**
1Sam. 18:7 **The women sang as they played, and said,**
"Saul has slain his thousands,
And David his ten thousands."
1Sam. 18:8 **Then Saul became very angry, for this saying displeased him; and he said, "They have ascribed to David ten thousands, but to me they have ascribed thousands. Now what more can he have but the kingdom?"**
1Sam. 18:9 **Saul looked at David with suspicion from that day on.**

- As it happened, on one occasion as David is returning from battle, he is met by crowds cheering his victory from city to city
  - The crowds are principally women because men were engaged in work in the fields during the day while the women worked closer to the home
    - The women dance and sing with joy over his victories

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        - And as they cheer him, the women sing a song that draws a comparison between Saul and David
    - At first we might wonder why the women decided to draw a comparison between Saul and David
        - Couldn't they have simply lauded David without mentioning Saul?
        - Yes, but in Jewish culture songs and poetry are typically formed as comparisons
        - Jewish people use metaphors, figures of speech and parables all the time
        - So comparisons are natural
    - In fact, Hebrew poetry doesn't depend on rhyme but on repetition and comparison
        - So to create a song lyric the Hebrew women search for something with which to compare David's bravery
        - The logical comparison would be to Saul's actions as captain of the army
        - So they acknowledge Saul's accomplishments
        - And then in typical form, they magnify the comparison in the second line when mentioning David's accomplishments
- In fact, it's doubtful that David's accomplishments in battle were literally ten fold greater than Saul's, but that's not the point
    - The Lord inspired this song to ensure one particular outcome
        - The Lord is provoking Saul's pride and paranoia
        - Saul is going to serve as the thorn in David's side to help prepare David to rule Israel
        - And here we see the Lord preparing the conflict
    - To be clear, the Lord is not the author of Saul's sin
        - The Lord is simply exposing it
        - The song lead Saul to act in sin by showing his pride
    - Saul hears the song and becomes angry over being the lessor in this comparison
        - Immediately Saul asks what more can David take from me than the kingdom?
        - He means that his honor has been taken, so all that's left is the kingdom
    - His question is prophetic, though he doesn't know it
        - Yes David will have the kingdom one day
        - But for now, Saul's conclusion is ridiculous, of course
        - The fact that a bunch of women granted David a superior position in their song means nothing
        - It's not as though Israel voted for their king
        - And even if David had public approval, that doesn't mean David was seeking to displace Saul
        - On the contrary, David will defend and protect the king's honor, even after Saul

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dies

- But from this day forward, Saul's attitude toward David was vastly different
  - Saul immediately switches from seeing David as a powerful servant to a dangerous rival
    - And this changes David's life dramatically as well

1Sam. 18:10 Now it came about on the next day that an evil spirit from God came mightily upon Saul, and he raved in the midst of the house, while David was playing the harp with his hand, as usual; and a spear was in Saul's hand.
1Sam. 18:11 Saul hurled the spear for he thought, "I will pin David to the wall." But David escaped from his presence twice.
1Sam. 18:12 Now Saul was afraid of David, for the Lord was with him but had departed from Saul.
1Sam. 18:13 Therefore Saul removed him from his presence and appointed him as his commander of a thousand; and he went out and came in before the people.
1Sam. 18:14 David was prospering in all his ways for the Lord was with him.
1Sam. 18:15 When Saul saw that he was prospering greatly, he dreaded him.
1Sam. 18:16 But all Israel and Judah loved David, and he went out and came in before them.

- As v.10 indicates, the Lord doesn't waste time in His plan, because on the next day the Lord raises the tension even further
  - The evil spirit that is working to torment Saul is given freedom to disturb Saul greatly
    - So Saul is in an especially bad state
    - Like one of those days at work when people tell you the boss is in a bad mood
    - Well, Saul is in a very bad mood…and he's armed
  - David is doing his usual task of trying to soothe the king with music, but the Lord is choosing not to remove the evil spirit when David plays as He has before
    - Instead, the spirit leads Saul to murderous thoughts
    - So that even as David is playing nearby, Saul heaves his spear at David
    - This is a lethal weapon, especially at close distance
    - And somehow, but the grace of God, David dodges Saul's spear
  - The cause for Saul's rage is the recognition that God's Spirit was with David but not with him
    - He begins to see his most loyal subject as his greatest enemy
    - But he correctly recognizes that the Spirit of the Lord is working in David
    - And David's prosperity leads Saul to fear David

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- Earlier in v.5 we're told that Saul sent David out time and again
  - It suggests that Saul sent David away because David's presence in the court only served to enrage Saul further
- Remembering that Saul knew the Lord, we have to see his actions in light of what Paul says in Romans 7 about the nature of man
  - There's a battle taking place in Saul, like a civil war
    - He recognizes that the Lord has withdrawn his Spirit from him
    - And he knows that David is now receiving the Lord's blessing
    - But Saul can't embrace that fact or even accept the Lord's will
    - Because Saul's flesh, enflamed by the enemy, is crying out for satisfaction
    - And as Saul feeds his flesh, he becomes more and more ungodly
  - This is something the Lord is working with to suit his purposes
    - The man Saul isn't the man prepared from the heart to serve Him
    - He's a man operating in the flesh
    - And very quickly we begin to see the folly of men working in their own power, their own flesh, to serve God
- But the most amazing part of this story is that David escaped from Saul's attack twice
  - In v.11 we see that word "twice" and wonder what led David to hang around after the first experience with the spear
    - It's our first clue to understand David's loyalty and devotion to the king
    - He respected Saul so much that after Saul tried to kill David once, nevertheless David stayed at his post
    - Saul must have had a second episode at a later time
    - But still David was there serving Saul
  - We can see a glimpse of Christ in this behavior
    - David is the rightful king
    - But nevertheless he subjects himself to the whims and rage of a man of authority
    - Just as Christ was the rightful king yet He subjected Himself for a time to those in power who persecuted Him
    - Even after He was brutally attacked, Christ didn't retaliate but asked the Father to forgive
- In v.13 we're told Saul sent David out to minimize his dread
  - Where before David's presence comforted Saul, now David's presence troubles Saul
    - But the effect is still to bless David
    - As he goes out, David gains more exposure among the people of Israel
    - Which in turn only serves to earn David more praise before the people

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- When the Lord is determined to bless someone, that blessing will come regardless of which way circumstances turn
  - When David was serving in the court, he was blessed
  - Now that he has been sent outside the court, he's blessed
  - It wasn't the circumstances that blessed David
  - It was the Lord
- And Saul couldn't stop it
  - In fact, the more Saul did to minimize David, the more David's stature grew
  - This is an object lesson in Romans 8:31

Rom. 8:31 What then shall we say to these things? If God is for us, who is against us?

- God was for David, so Saul's opposition could not stop the blessing God intended to deliver to David's life
  - Even Saul's wrath against David served to contribute to David's blessing
  - Much to the disappointment of Saul
- In fact, Saul conceives a plan to bring David's downfall, yet once again David's faithfulness turns the table on Saul

1Sam. 18:17 Then Saul said to David, "Here is my older daughter Merab; I will give her to you as a wife, only be a valiant man for me and fight the Lord's battles." For Saul thought, "My hand shall not be against him, but let the hand of the Philistines be against him."

1Sam. 18:18 But David said to Saul, "Who am I, and what is my life or my father's family in Israel, that I should be the king's son-in-law?"

1Sam. 18:19 So it came about at the time when Merab, Saul's daughter, should have been given to David, that she was given to Adriel the Meholathite for a wife.
1Sam. 18:20 Now Michal, Saul's daughter, loved David. When they told Saul, the thing was agreeable to him.
1Sam. 18:21 Saul thought, "I will give her to him that she may become a snare to him, and that the hand of the Philistines may be against him." Therefore Saul said to David, "For a second time you may be my son-in-law today."
1Sam. 18:22 Then Saul commanded his servants, "Speak to David secretly, saying, 'Behold, the king delights in you, and all his servants love you; now therefore, become the king's son-in-law.'"

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1Sam. 18:23 So Saul's servants spoke these words to David. But David said, "Is it trivial in your sight to become the king's son-in-law, since I am a poor man and lightly esteemed?"
1Sam. 18:24 The servants of Saul reported to him according to these words which David spoke.
1Sam. 18:25 Saul then said, "Thus you shall say to David, 'The king does not desire any dowry except a hundred foreskins of the Philistines, to take vengeance on the king's enemies.'" Now Saul planned to make David fall by the hand of the Philistines.
1Sam. 18:26 When his servants told David these words, it pleased David to become the king's son-in-law. Before the days had expired
1Sam. 18:27 David rose up and went, he and his men, and struck down two hundred men among the Philistines. Then David brought their foreskins, and they gave them in full number to the king, that he might become the king's son-in-law. So Saul gave him Michal his daughter for a wife.
1Sam. 18:28 When Saul saw and knew that the Lord was with David, and that Michal, Saul's daughter, loved him,
1Sam. 18:29 then Saul was even more afraid of David. Thus Saul was David's enemy continually.

- Since Saul wasn't successful in killing David by his own hand, he devises a way to kill David indirectly
  - The plan is for the Philistines to kill David in battle, and Saul would provide the bait to cause David to enter into the fight rashly
    - Ironically, David pulls a similar stunt later in his time as king
    - First, Saul offers David one of his daughters in marriage
    - The idea is that once David became the king's son-in-law, he would be a greater target in battle
  - But David's humility and respect for Saul thwarts Saul's plan
    - When David learns of the offer, he expresses disbelief that he could accept the king's daughter
    - He asks, who is he that he should marry a king's daughter?
    - David is referring to his inability to pay a sufficient price for the bride
  - In this day marriages were business deals between families
    - Sons and daughters both had worth to a family
    - Sons were future heirs and workers in the family business
    - Daughters produced offspring to extend the family's strength
    - A son remained with a family and a daughter was given to another family
  - So the family of the groom paid the family of the bride for taking the daughter away

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from her family

- The price paid for the daughter was a statement of her worth in the eyes of the family she joined
- If a groom offered too little for a bride, it was an insult to the bride and her family
- And David understands that he doesn't have the funds to pay an appropriately high price for the daughter of a king
- Anything David could offer would have been viewed as an insult to a princess

- David isn't saying no to Saul's offer, but he is making clear that he doesn't have the means to pay the bride price
  - So he's working to avoid embarrassing or humiliating the bride by his inability to offer the right price
  - His motives are pure and his humility is genuine
    - It would be easy for him or anyone in his position to exhibit false humility
    - To say, "Oh no, I couldn't…" but then to move ahead anyway
    - To gain the credit for having been humble but then also claim the benefit of the offer
  - But David sincerely doesn't view himself worthy of the honor
    - This is a rare quality and something we should cultivate in ourselves
    - Not false humility, designed to impress men
    - But sincere appreciation for our unworthiness
    - So that as the Lord desires to bless us, we may receive those blessings entirely unexpectedly
    - And then our testimony will be of a sinner saved by grace, blessed by the generosity of a Lord Who gives good gifts
- But Saul doesn't respond to David's humility with grace
  - Instead, Saul gives her to another man
    - Apparently, Saul expected David to respond by asking what he could do to earn the daughter
    - To which Saul would have given David some dangerous mission intended to result in David's death
  - When David didn't play along, Saul went against his own word
    - Saul had pledged his daughter to David but in the end he didn't keep his word
    - Normally, this would have been enough for any man to dismiss the king as untrustworthy, but David continues to have respect for Saul
- Another daughter of Saul had genuine love for David
  - This daughter, Michal, is the second of Saul's children to love David
    - It's a clear sign of God's grace that even as He brought an evil spirit to Saul, He

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was working to ensure that members of Saul's household loved David
        - Not only did Jonathan love David but so did Michal
    - But Michal becomes Saul's next opportunity to trap David
        - Saul decides that this time he will offer David the wife and use others to help convince David to pursue her
        - Saul commands his servants to persuade David to pursue Saul's daughter
    - David's interest in Michal is not wrong, but this episode foreshadows a sinful weakness in David's character
        - He has an eye for the ladies…especially naked ones on rooftops
        - And they have an eye for him
        - Later this weakness will lead to the saddest episode in David's life
- David's response to the servants is similar to his earlier response, saying he isn't worthy of the bride price
    - But Saul is ready with a response this time
        - Saul directs his servants to tell David that a hundred foreskins of Philistines would suffice
        - Since we can safely assume that no Philistine would willingly contribute his foreskin to David's dowry, we know Saul was asking David to kill 100 Philistines
        - For David, this sounds like a plausible way to marry the king's daughter
    - But for Saul, it's a plan designed to get David killed
        - Attacking an enemy was always dangerous
        - But engaging in an uncoordinated, unplanned attack at the spur of the moment was virtual suicide
        - So Saul is hoping that David dies in battle
    - But the Lord is with David, so he succeeds in the battle
        - In fact, David delivers twice as many foreskins as a sign of his love
        - Nothing says love like 200 Philistines foreskins
        - This time Saul has no choice but to honor his promise, so David is married to Michal
    - But Saul is all the more afraid of David, because he realizes that the only way someone kills 200 Philistines in this way is if the Lord is with him
        - And this causes Saul to have all the more dread
        - Saul is experiencing the fear of the Lord
        - It's a fear driven by sin
        - Saul knows he's seeing the Lord move against him
        - But it's a slow, steady drip rather than a sudden quick flood
        - And the slowness is driving Saul mad

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        - And that's what God intends
- From this day forward, even though David was Saul's son-in-law, Saul treats David as his enemy
    - There is no turning point now
        - David is effectively Saul's captain of the army and his most loyal subject
        - Nevertheless, Saul is going to treat David as if he were leading a coup against Saul
        - In doing so, Saul is opposing the Lord
    - And so the die is cast for the Lord to produce the testing in David that David himself acknowledged was missing
        - David can't assume the position of king until the Lord has tested him
        - Testing is a process of refining impure materials until the impurities are removed
        - And only the precious, pure, true things remain
    - Testing requires pressure, heat, stress
        - And those qualities don't come from peaceful circumstances
        - They require the turmoil of opposition
        - Saul is that catalyst to produce opposition for David
        - And through that friction the Lord will produce a good outcome in preparing David for service as king
        - And in the midst of that trial, David will have cause to write the unparalleled poetry of the Psalms
- Meanwhile, David continues to do as God called, remaining blameless before men

1Sam. 18:30 **Then the commanders of the Philistines went out to battle, and it happened as often as they went out, that David behaved himself more wisely than all the servants of Saul. So his name was highly esteemed.**

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- Our story of Saul and David is going to start reading like a Coyote and Roadrunner cartoon script
  - Saul is fast becoming obsessed with finding some way to get rid of David
    - Whether by hook or crook…or exploding bomb or catapult
    - Somehow Saul has to rid himself of David's tormenting presence
  - And what is it about David that bothers Saul so much?
    - Putting aside the supernatural causes (like the tormenting spirit)
    - The main reason is David's continued rise to prominence and widespread appeal
    - No matter what Saul does to David, David prospers
    - And to make matters worse, David's so annoyingly humble about it all
  - But we know what's behind the tension truly
    - The Lord is bringing these two men together so He can use one to school the other
    - Saul is David's tutor, though neither appreciate it that way
    - David will be seasoned over ten difficult years before becoming a king
    - And Saul will provide the seasoning through his paranoia and jealousy
- But of course the Lord can't allow Saul to get the upper hand on David
  - Just as every Roadrunner cartoon must end with the hapless Coyote falling from the cliff or flattened by his own contraptions, so it must be for Saul
    - David will prevail, for this is the Lord's intent
    - But it's not the outcome that's important to this story so much as the mayhem that leads us there
    - Each time Saul tries to put an end to David, the Lord ultimately blocks His path
  - Yet He allows Saul just enough room to operate so that he places David in a position where he must react
    - He must run
    - He must hide
    - He must raise likeminded soldiers, find allies, cry out to the Lord and deal with temptations to put an end to his enemy
    - And through it all, he grows and matures and learns

1Sam. 19:1 **Now Saul told Jonathan his son and all his servants to put David to death. But Jonathan, Saul's son, greatly delighted in David.**
1Sam. 19:2 **So Jonathan told David saying, "Saul my father is seeking to put you to death. Now therefore, please be on guard in the morning, and stay in a secret place and hide yourself.**

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1Sam. 19:3 "I will go out and stand beside my father in the field where you are, and I will speak with my father about you; if I find out anything, then I will tell you."
1Sam. 19:4 Then Jonathan spoke well of David to Saul his father and said to him, "Do not let the king sin against his servant David, since he has not sinned against you, and since his deeds have been very beneficial to you.
1Sam. 19:5 "For he took his life in his hand and struck the Philistine, and the Lord brought about a great deliverance for all Israel; you saw it and rejoiced. Why then will you sin against innocent blood by putting David to death without a cause?"
1Sam. 19:6 Saul listened to the voice of Jonathan, and Saul vowed, "As the Lord lives, he shall not be put to death."
1Sam. 19:7 Then Jonathan called David, and Jonathan told him all these words. And Jonathan brought David to Saul, and he was in his presence as formerly.

- Saul's first attempt on David's life is rather unimaginative
  - Saul abandons any pretense of working in David's best interests and tells his son, Jonathan, and all his servants to kill David
    - And now we see why the Lord knit Jonathan's heart to David's heart in the earlier chapter
    - Now that this man is in covenant with David, he is bound by his own life to protect David's life
    - So not only can Jonathan not carry out the king's orders, he must stop anyone else from killing David either
  - Samuel says Jonathan greatly delighted in David, so we know he was personally motivated to protect David as well
    - But Jonathan is also called to honor his father and the king
    - So we see him working very hard here to find a solution to preserve his allegiance to both men
  - He begins by warning David that others might be trying to kill him since the king had given this order
    - I doubt David was very surprised by Saul's orders
    - After the spear throwing episodes, David probably had a suspicion that Saul didn't like him
    - But Jonathan knows that the order had gone out to have David killed so the servants would have been coming after him too
  - Furthermore, Jonathan said he would try to learn more of his father's plans
    - It seems he arranged for David to hide in a place near where Saul was staying
    - He did this so that once he won his father over, he could orchestrate a quick reconciliation

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        - Time was of the essence here, because the word had gone out that David should be killed
        - Jonathan needed to get Saul to change his mind and then get David back in the king's presence quickly so that no one might kill David before the reconciliation
- Jonathan is successful, as we see, based on the argument that David was innocent
    - David had done great things for Saul, so killing David would be unjust
        - David killed Philistines
        - David served Saul honorably
        - The people rejoiced over David and so did Saul
    - It's this last part that probably made Jonathan's argument convincing to Saul
        - Saul remembers how the people perceive David
        - I wonder if he considered the ramifications of killing a popular man who everyone knew to be innocent
        - For whatever reason, Saul vows not to kill David after all
    - But it doesn't take him long to break this vow

1Sam. 19:8 When there was war again, David went out and fought with the Philistines and defeated them with great slaughter, so that they fled before him.
1Sam. 19:9 Now there was an evil spirit from the Lord on Saul as he was sitting in his house with his spear in his hand, and David was playing the harp with his hand.
1Sam. 19:10 Saul tried to pin David to the wall with the spear, but he slipped away out of Saul's presence, so that he stuck the spear into the wall. And David fled and escaped that night.
1Sam. 19:11 Then Saul sent messengers to David's house to watch him, in order to put him to death in the morning. But Michal, David's wife, told him, saying, "If you do not save your life tonight, tomorrow you will be put to death."
1Sam. 19:12 So Michal let David down through a window, and he went out and fled and escaped.
1Sam. 19:13 Michal took the household idol and laid it on the bed, and put a quilt of goats' hair at its head, and covered it with clothes.
1Sam. 19:14 When Saul sent messengers to take David, she said, "He is sick."
1Sam. 19:15 Then Saul sent messengers to see David, saying, "Bring him up to me on his bed, that I may put him to death."
1Sam. 19:16 When the messengers entered, behold, the household idol was on the bed with the quilt of goats' hair at its head.
1Sam. 19:17 So Saul said to Michal, "Why have you deceived me like this and let my enemy go, so that he has escaped?" And Michal said to Saul, "He said to me, 'Let me go! Why should I put you to death?'"

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- Now we see Saul's fourth attempt to put David to death, and once again the Lord will use a member of Saul's household to save David
  - The continual war with the Philistines goes hot again, and again David is sent out into battle
    - Though Saul secretly hopes that the battles will put an end to David, the Lord continues to ensure David's success
    - He slaughters the Philistines in great number
    - And they retreated again into the costal plains
    - Another impressive victory for David
  - David's victory reminds Saul of all the reasons he's ready to see David's end
    - With the evil spirit stirring up Saul's hatred and paranoia, he grabs his spear again
    - And once more, he tries to pin David to the wall
    - This phrase emphasizes the force with which Saul threw the spear
  - With that throw, David realized that Saul was not a man to keep his vow
    - Of course, David has seen this before
    - Saul didn't keep his vow for the reward for killing Goliath
    - And now it's clear that Saul is going back on his promise not to kill David
- With that understanding, David leaves the court knowing that there is no chance of survival if he stays around Saul
  - From this point forward, David will be a fugitive from Saul
    - He will live on the lam about ten years
    - David will never be free from living this way until Saul dies
  - He first flees to his home and wife, probably because he didn't know where else to go
    - David's wife, Michal, gives him sound but certainly difficult advice
    - She tells her own husband to run away to save his life
    - This was very self-sacrificial on her part
  - David escapes through a window to avoid being seen and chased
    - And Michal prepares a rouse to delay the servants of Saul
    - She constructs a dummy in his bed from goat hair and the household idol
    - Once again it's Saul's child that devises the plan and directs David for his own good
- What should we conclude by the fact that there was an idol in David's house?
  - Most readers of 1 Samuel conclude that the idol belonged to Michal, not David
    - This is likely because household idols were usually the property of the heir of a family and were proof of the inheritance right

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        - You may remember Rachel taking Laban's household idols when she and Jacob were leaving
        - This greatly bothered Laban because it gave Jacob right to return some day and claim Laban's inheritance
    - So it's likely that these were Saul's household idols given to Michal, perhaps at the wedding
        - Either way, it troubles us that David has not addressed the presence of an idol in his home
        - Since we don't know why he decided to hold on to them, we can only assume that Saul's negative influence is moving into the next generation
        - And though David should have stopped it, he hadn't
        - Later, we'll see that this wife will prove to be a disappointment to David in other ways
- When the servants came for David, Michal pointed to the quilt of goat hair and told them David was in bed sick, so they left
    - Interestingly, the Septuagint translates the Hebrew word for quilt of goat hair differently
        - That ancient version translates it as goat liver, not hair
        - The sense is that Michal put a goat liver *under* the quilt
        - So that when she stroked the quilt like she was rubbing her husband's back, the liver would undulate like a person breathing
    - Whatever she did, it was convincing to the point that the servants retreat
        - They go back to tell Saul that David is taking a sick day from the court
        - Saul said what any harsh boss would say…"go back and pick up his bed and bring him back"
        - So I can kill him
    - When they return and discover they have been tricked by Michal, they turn their attention to her
        - She has committed a high crime, and she has to think fast to save her skin
        - And she does
        - Michal declares that David threatened to kill her if she didn't do what she did
        - It's a lie, of course, but it works
- Michal is in a covenant with David also, a marriage covenant
    - This covenant made her one flesh with David, and as such she was expected to give her loyalties to David over all others
        - Still, her choice to go against the king was dangerous
        - And her decision to lie was punishable by death
    - We can't excuse her sin in protecting David

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- But clearly the Lord was working through her sin to accomplish good things for David
- David too recognized that the Lord was at work to protect him, as he wrote in Psalm 59

Psa. 59:0 For the choir director; set to Al-tashheth. A Mikhtam of David, when Saul sent men and they watched the house in order to kill him.
Psa. 59:1 Deliver me from my enemies, O my God;
Set me securely on high away from those who rise up against me.
Psa. 59:2 Deliver me from those who do iniquity
And save me from men of bloodshed.
Psa. 59:3 For behold, they have set an ambush for my life;
Fierce men launch an attack against me,
Not for my transgression nor for my sin, O Lord,
Psa. 59:4 For no guilt of mine, they run and set themselves against me.
Arouse Yourself to help me, and see!
Psa. 59:5 You, O Lord God of hosts, the God of Israel,
Awake to punish all the nations;
Do not be gracious to any who are treacherous in iniquity. Selah.
Psa. 59:6 They return at evening, they howl like a dog,
And go around the city.
Psa. 59:7 Behold, they belch forth with their mouth;
Swords are in their lips,
For, they say, "Who hears?"
Psa. 59:8 But You, O Lord, laugh at them;
You scoff at all the nations.
Psa. 59:9 Because of his strength I will watch for You,
For God is my stronghold.
Psa. 59:10 My God in His lovingkindness will meet me;
God will let me look triumphantly upon my foes.
Psa. 59:11 Do not slay them, or my people will forget;
Scatter them by Your power, and bring them down,
O Lord, our shield.
Psa. 59:12 On account of the sin of their mouth and the words of their lips,
Let them even be caught in their pride,
And on account of curses and lies which they utter.
Psa. 59:13 Destroy them in wrath, destroy them that they may be no more;
That men may know that God rules in Jacob
To the ends of the earth. Selah.
Psa. 59:14 They return at evening, they howl like a dog,
And go around the city.
Psa. 59:15 They wander about for food

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And growl if they are not satisfied.
Psa. 59:16 **But as for me, I shall sing of Your strength;**
Yes, I shall joyfully sing of Your lovingkindness in the morning,
For You have been my stronghold
And a refuge in the day of my distress.
Psa. 59:17 **O my strength, I will sing praises to You;**
For God is my stronghold, the God who shows me lovingkindness.

- So now that David is on the run, where does he go? To the only person stronger than Saul

1Sam. 19:18 **Now David fled and escaped and came to Samuel at Ramah, and told him all that Saul had done to him. And he and Samuel went and stayed in Naioth.**
1Sam. 19:19 **It was told Saul, saying, "Behold, David is at Naioth in Ramah."**
1Sam. 19:20 **Then Saul sent messengers to take David, but when they saw the company of the prophets prophesying, with Samuel standing and presiding over them, the Spirit of God came upon the messengers of Saul; and they also prophesied.**
1Sam. 19:21 **When it was told Saul, he sent other messengers, and they also prophesied. So Saul sent messengers again the third time, and they also prophesied.**
1Sam. 19:22 **Then he himself went to Ramah and came as far as the large well that is in Secu; and he asked and said, "Where are Samuel and David?" And someone said, "Behold, they are at Naioth in Ramah."**
1Sam. 19:23 **He proceeded there to Naioth in Ramah; and the Spirit of God came upon him also, so that he went along prophesying continually until he came to Naioth in Ramah.**
1Sam. 19:24 **He also stripped off his clothes, and he too prophesied before Samuel and lay down naked all that day and all that night. Therefore they say, "Is Saul also among the prophets?"**

- Samuel reappears in the story
  - The last time we saw Samuel, he was anointing David
    - And he's refused to see Saul since that episode in Gilgal, when Saul decided to keep some of Agag's possessions
    - Now he's David's best hope in the face of Saul's expected attack
    - David finds Samuel in his home barely an hour's walk from Saul's home in Ramah
    - Samuel seems to be running a school for prophets
  - Saul learns David has taken refuge there and sends servants to arrest David

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        - These servants come in three waves
        - And each wave arrives to do Saul's bidding only to end up doing the Lord's bidding
        - Each group begins to prophesy
        - We don't know what they were saying, but it would make sense they were speaking about David and the Lord's anointing on David
    - The fact that Saul sent servants three times is telling
        - It demonstrates that Saul wasn't listening to the Lord nor interested in obeying Him
        - If he had, then he couldn't have helped but notice the Lord's supernatural rebuff of his orders to capture David
- Finally, in an act of hubris and pride, Saul decides he will come to Naoith, the abode of the prophets at Ramah, to take David himself
    - But as with his servants, the Spirit of the Lord comes upon Saul
        - He prophesies as well
        - More than that, Saul is moved to strip himself of his clothes
        - He lays naked before Samuel prophesying all day and night
    - A king determined by his own authority to kill the Lord's anointed is now prostrate naked before the Lord's prophet serving the Lord by speaking prophecy
        - His nakedness is a symbolic picture of the Lord stripping him of his royal authority and honor
        - And his posture indicates his submission to the anointing of Samuel
    - The passage ends with a repetition of the phrase that marked Saul's rise to power
        - His prophesying caused some to wonder if Saul was now among the prophets
        - This phrase was uttered once before when the Lord's Spirit first came upon Saul
        - Now it's being uttered again as the Spirit has returned to Saul temporarily to create this scene
    - It's as if to remind the reader that Saul began as a man under the influence of the Spirit, but it's never seemed a natural fit
        - Every time Saul has spoken the word of the Lord under the Spirit's influence, the people have wondered aloud
        - In the first case, it was a surprise because Saul was an unknown
        - And no one had ever seen him show any interest in the things of God prior
    - This time the surprise comes from having a full knowledge of Saul's character
        - The nation knew their king was trying to kill the very man who had saved them from the Philistines on multiple occasions
        - And they must have known that he was acting in crazy and unpredictable ways
        - So the phrase that first became a source of praise for Saul has become a phrase

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of derision

- After this episode, David is able to leave Ramah safely, but of course this is just one episode in the ongoing saga
  - And David is searching for a way to put an end to the chase, so he returns to Jonathan for answers

1Sam. 20:1 Then David fled from Naioth in Ramah, and came and said to Jonathan, "What have I done? What is my iniquity? And what is my sin before your father, that he is seeking my life?"
1Sam. 20:2 He said to him, "Far from it, you shall not die. Behold, my father does nothing either great or small without disclosing it to me. So why should my father hide this thing from me? It is not so!"
1Sam. 20:3 Yet David vowed again, saying, "Your father knows well that I have found favor in your sight, and he has said, 'Do not let Jonathan know this, or he will be grieved.' But truly as the Lord lives and as your soul lives, there is hardly a step between me and death."
1Sam. 20:4 Then Jonathan said to David, "Whatever you say, I will do for you."
1Sam. 20:5 So David said to Jonathan, "Behold, tomorrow is the new moon, and I ought to sit down to eat with the king. But let me go, that I may hide myself in the field until the third evening.
1Sam. 20:6 "If your father misses me at all, then say, 'David earnestly asked leave of me to run to Bethlehem his city, because it is the yearly sacrifice there for the whole family.'
1Sam. 20:7 "If he says, 'It is good,' your servant will be safe; but if he is very angry, know that he has decided on evil.
1Sam. 20:8 "Therefore deal kindly with your servant, for you have brought your servant into a covenant of the Lord with you. But if there is iniquity in me, put me to death yourself; for why then should you bring me to your father?"
1Sam. 20:9 Jonathan said, "Far be it from you! For if I should indeed learn that evil has been decided by my father to come upon you, then would I not tell you about it?"
1Sam. 20:10 Then David said to Jonathan, "Who will tell me if your father answers you harshly?"
1Sam. 20:11 Jonathan said to David, "Come, and let us go out into the field." So both of them went out to the field.

- David confronts Jonathan and asks the obvious question, what did I do to Saul?
  - Of course this question can never have an acceptable answer
    - David didn't do anything
    - Saul isn't acting rationally
    - And the Lord is working to accomplish something in David's life

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- I think every Christian should remember David's question and bring it to mind when things are going horribly and unfairly wrong
  - David asked what did I do wrong, knowing he was innocent
  - And he assumes that if one is innocent, then nothing bad should happen
  - And yet here it was happening nonetheless
- Similarly, we need to remember that just because we're "innocent" that doesn't mean the Lord isn't just when He allows us to suffer in various ways
  - That suffering is still just if it serves His good purposes in our life
  - And suffering is a powerful way for the Lord to grow us
  - David doesn't understand yet what the Lord is doing so he's looking for ways to escape his predicament
  - But we should learn from his experience to realize even in the midst of our circumstances that bad things happen to good people for good reasons

- Jonathan is the friend David desperately needed
  - He reassures David that Saul will not be successful in taking David's life
    - In fact, Jonathan tells David he will always know what Saul is planning before Saul does it
    - Therefore, he can assure David that they will stay one step ahead of Saul
  - But David isn't so optimistic
    - He says won't Saul anticipate that Jonathan is helping David and withhold details?
    - Therefore, David returns to the pessimistic, woe-is-me attitude
    - This is certainly not the David that walked out onto that field against Goliath, is it?
    - Just for a moment I think we see why the Lord wants to strengthen David through this trial
- If David was a bit too pessimistic, then Jonathan was certainly overly optimistic
  - So Jonathan tells David, tell me what to do to reassure you
    - David decides that the upcoming new moon festival was the right occasion to show Jonathan Saul's heart
    - New moons in Israel began a new month, and it was marked with a sacrificial meal
    - The king held a special feast meal and a high-ranking commander like David would be expected to attend
  - Obviously, if Saul was actively trying to kill David, he would be angry if David wasn't there
    - So David tells Jonathan to make an excuse for him to test Saul's heart
    - David will avoid the meal by hiding in the field and Jonathan will say that David

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went to Bethlehem for an annual family feast (like a reunion)

- David was lying, and in the early days of his running from Saul, he seems to rely on lying or other tricks to get his way
- But as his time on the lam goes on, he rests more and more in the Lord for protection, as the Psalms indicate
- His trials were a source of purification as scripture promises

- Saul's response to this news will tell David and Jonathan where Saul's heart truly is
  - If Saul could accept the story of David's absence without concern, then it would indicate he wasn't planning to kill David, since the reason was understandable
    - But if Saul was upset, it would tip his hand
    - He would be showing he was intending to kill David and was upset at missing his chance
  - Jonathan likes the plan and decides to act on it
    - He helps hide David in the field
    - And he goes to the dinner
    - David is hiding in the field instead of actually going to Bethlehem or elsewhere probably because he doesn't trust anyone else at this point

1Sam. 20:12 Then Jonathan said to David, "The Lord, the God of Israel, be witness! When I have sounded out my father about this time tomorrow, or the third day, behold, if there is good feeling toward David, shall I not then send to you and make it known to you?
1Sam. 20:13 "If it please my father to do you harm, may the Lord do so to Jonathan and more also, if I do not make it known to you and send you away, that you may go in safety. And may the Lord be with you as He has been with my father.
1Sam. 20:14 "If I am still alive, will you not show me the lovingkindness of the Lord, that I may not die?
1Sam. 20:15 "You shall not cut off your lovingkindness from my house forever, not even when the Lord cuts off every one of the enemies of David from the face of the earth."
1Sam. 20:16 So Jonathan made a covenant with the house of David, saying, "May the Lord require it at the hands of David's enemies."
1Sam. 20:17 Jonathan made David vow again because of his love for him, because he loved him as he loved his own life.
1Sam. 20:18 Then Jonathan said to him, "Tomorrow is the new moon, and you will be missed because your seat will be empty.
1Sam. 20:19 "When you have stayed for three days, you shall go down quickly and come to the place where you hid yourself on that eventful day, and you shall remain by the stone Ezel.
1Sam. 20:20 "I will shoot three arrows to the side, as though I shot at a target.

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1Sam. 20:21 **"And behold, I will send the lad, saying, 'Go, find the arrows.' If I specifically say to the lad, 'Behold, the arrows are on this side of you, get them,' then come; for there is safety for you and no harm, as the Lord lives.**
1Sam. 20:22 **"But if I say to the youth, 'Behold, the arrows are beyond you,' go, for the Lord has sent you away.**
1Sam. 20:23 **"As for the agreement of which you and I have spoken, behold, the Lord is between you and me forever."**

- Jonathan promises David that once he has determined his father's true intent concerning David, he will communicate it honestly to David
  - If Saul shows kindness to David, then Jonathan will call for David to return to the king's court
    - But if the king desires to do harm to David, then Jonathan will let David know that as well
    - He is taking a considerable risk in either case
  - So Jonathan goes a step further and asks David for another covenant with the Lord as his witness (v.12)
    - The first covenant was a suzerainty covenant in which Jonathan pledged his love to David unconditionally
    - Now this time Jonathan is proposing a parity covenant for different purposes
    - Jonathan on his part will divulge his father's intent toward David, thus saving David's life
  - And David on his part will pledge to protect Jonathan's house forever
    - Jonathan knew that David was anointed to be the next king
    - So that meant that David's house would consider Saul's house to be potential rivals and enemies
    - Therefore, Jonathan has good reason to worry that he and his family might be in jeopardy when David assumes the throne
  - So Jonathan wants David's assurance in a covenant that he would treat Jonathan's family with lovingkindness (a covenant term) forever
    - Even after David's enemies are completely gone from the earth, David should continue to show favor to Jonathan's household
    - This is a parity covenant because it depends on performance on both parties
    - And yet it is a lifelong covenant binding until death
- Both men vow, so a second covenant is struck between them
  - Now Jonathan begins to enact the plan
    - He's concerned about how to get word to David without giving away David's position
    - He devises a plan of using arrows

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- Jonathan will come out to the field to shoot arrows after the dinner is concluded
  - He will bring a servant with him to retrieve the arrows
  - He will shoot three arrows
  - If he shoots so they land near David, then he is signaling that all is clear for David to return to the court
  - If Jonathan shoots the arrows far over David's head, then it's a sign that David run away from Saul
- But Jonathan adds that the agreement they struck is forever lasting
  - Later in 2 Samuel we see the outworking of this covenant in David's life
  - As king, he calls for any servants of Jonathan he should show kindness to in response to his covenant with Jonathan
  - And a crippled son of Jonathan, Mephibosheth, is found and given a place at the king's table
  - David is faithful to this covenant even after Jonathan's death

- We first hear about Mephibosheth in Chapter 4 of 2 Samuel

2Sam. 4:4 **Now Jonathan, Saul's son, had a son crippled in his feet. He was five years old when the report of Saul and Jonathan came from Jezreel, and his nurse took him up and fled. And it happened that in her hurry to flee, he fell and became lame. And his name was Mephibosheth.**

- So this young man is crippled
  - And David calls for this descendent of Jonathan to appear before him
    - Now imagine yourself Mephibosheth
    - Due to his crippled nature, Mephibosheth can't stand before the king
    - He lies prostrate on the ground
  - And what must have been going through his mind?
    - He probably doesn't know about the covenant between David and Jonathan
    - All he knows is that he is the last living male heir to the house of Saul
    - And his grandfather's rival has called for him to appear
  - He must assume the worst
    - He must assume that he will be killed any minute
    - But instead, look what David does

2Sam. 9:7 **David said to him, "Do not fear, for I will surely show kindness to you for the sake of your father Jonathan, and will restore to you all the land of your grandfather Saul; and you shall eat at my table regularly."**

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2Sam. 9:8 Again he prostrated himself and said, "What is your servant, that you should regard a dead dog like me?"
2Sam. 9:9 Then the king called Saul's servant Ziba and said to him, "All that belonged to Saul and to all his house I have given to your master's grandson.
2Sam. 9:10 "You and your sons and your servants shall cultivate the land for him, and you shall bring in the produce so that your master's grandson may have food; nevertheless Mephibosheth your master's grandson shall eat at my table regularly." Now Ziba had fifteen sons and twenty servants.
2Sam. 9:11 Then Ziba said to the king, "According to all that my lord the king commands his servant so your servant will do." So Mephibosheth ate at David's table as one of the king's sons.

- David recognizes Mephibosheth's fear
  - And David understands why he's afraid
    - But David says don't worry, because I called you here to show kindness upon you
    - And why?
    - Because Mephibosheth deserved it?
    - Did David show kindness because of something Mephibosheth did?
    - No
  - And Mephibosheth knows he is receiving something he shouldn't receive
    - He asks a rhetorical question…why are you showing regard for a dead dog like me?
    - David was giving lovingkindness on account of Jonathan
    - The word lovingkindness is *chesed*
    - It means a special kind of underserved faithfulness

Ex. 34:6 Then the Lord passed by in front of him and proclaimed, "The Lord, the Lord God, compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in lovingkindness and truth;

- This is same kind of kindness David was prepared to show Jonathan's son on account of his father's covenant
  - We have another word for this special kind of kindness
  - We call it grace…unmerited favor
  - It was the basis for David's actions
  - David was willing to restore Mephibosheth to the king's table on the basis of another's act of faithfulness

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- Not on the basis of Mephibosheth's own worthiness
- But on the basis of an agreement the king made with Mephibosheth's father, Jonathan

- And look at the favor Mephibosheth received
  - Mephibosheth inherited the property that had been his grandfather's
    - And he had the benefit of servants to feed him
    - And he dined with the king at the king's table
  - He went from a dead dog, a worthless person in the eyes of all of Israel
    - To become as a son of the king
    - Eating at the kings table continually
  - Many of us probably already know this, but David is a type of Christ
    - And it's easy to see that type revealed through this story
    - In this story of David, we have a king showing grace – unmerited favor – upon an unworthy man
    - And more than that, a man who would be considered an enemy of David
  - Yet, on the basis of a covenant of faithfulness that the king made earlier with the ancestor of this poor dead dog of a man
    - The king can now bestow grace upon this man
    - And he will enjoy the riches of the King's palace, like dining at the king's table
- This is exactly the way our king, Jesus Christ, looked upon you and I
  - Before we were drawn to Him, we were dead in our trespasses
    - We were like that poor Mephibosheth, dead as dogs and unable to stand in the king's presence in our own power
    - But by the grace of the king we are made to stand
  - And what exactly did we do again to deserve God's favor?
    - In a word nothing
    - It was grace. Unmerited favor
    - And it was on the basis of an earlier covenant
  - Mephibosheth was a descendent of Jonathan, a man in covenant with the king
    - His relationship to the one who was in covenant with the King meant he participated in the blessings of that covenant
    - Likewise, by our faith, God makes us members of Abraham's family
    - Therefore we receive the same blessings from our King Christ as a result of our family relationship with the covenant holder, Abraham
  - The scriptures speak of David as a man after God's own heart
    - That like Christ, David was faithful to keep his covenant and to forgive those

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who were his enemies

- Likewise, our Lord is such a king
- We can be confident in that assurance
- As a child of the living God, we will always be welcome at his table
- Having been renewed by His Spirit and reconciled by His Son's sacrifice

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- Jonathan and David are now allies against Jonathan's father, Saul
  - They are joined by two covenants
    - In the first covenant, Jonathan pledged to give his throne to David
    - He made this promise unconditionally to David because he recognized David had the Lord's anointing
    - Which told us Jonathan was a man who recognized and respected the movement of the Lord
    - The Lord moved Jonathan's heart to enter into this covenant, to ensure David would have the legal right within Israel to receive the throne
  - Secondly, Jonathan and David jointly entered into a parity covenant last week
    - In this covenant, both men agreed to protect each other
    - Jonathan agreed to protect David from his father Saul
    - While David agreed to protect Jonathan's descendants after taking the throne
    - Jonathan knew that David would have to destroy his enemies to hold the throne
    - Nevertheless, he didn't want David to count Jonathan's descendants among his enemies
  - The Lord's purpose in this covenant was two-fold
    - He provided to David a man in Jonathan who would blunt Saul's attack and ensure David's survival
    - Secondly, he creates a vivid picture of David's prefiguring of Christ at his second coming
    - That is all who are in covenant with the Lord will have the right to dine at the king's table, just as Mephibosheth did
- Now we return to the story just as Jonathan and David have agreed to the covenant and are about to enact the plan to rescue David

1Sam. 20:24 So David hid in the field; and when the new moon came, the king sat down to eat food.
1Sam. 20:25 The king sat on his seat as usual, the seat by the wall; then Jonathan rose up and Abner sat down by Saul's side, but David's place was empty.
1Sam. 20:26 Nevertheless Saul did not speak anything that day, for he thought, "It is an accident, he is not clean, surely he is not clean."
1Sam. 20:27 It came about the next day, the second day of the new moon, that David's place was empty; so Saul said to Jonathan his son, "Why has the son of Jesse not come to the meal, either yesterday or today?"
1Sam. 20:28 Jonathan then answered Saul, "David earnestly asked leave of me to go to Bethlehem,
1Sam. 20:29 for he said, 'Please let me go, since our family has a sacrifice in the

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city, and my brother has commanded me to attend. And now, if I have found favor in your sight, please let me get away that I may see my brothers.' For this reason he has not come to the king's table."

- Jonathan leaves David in the field and joins Saul at the new moon festival as the plan expected
  - Around the king's table, the honored guests had assigned seats
    - We see that Saul sat in the most honored place
    - He is at the head of the table and against the wall
    - Remember, people reclined on cushions on the ground leaning on the left elbow
    - Saul's left side was against the wall, meaning he was positioned at the far left end of the table, which is the most honored place
    - Abner was the next most honored position next to Saul
  - David had an assigned place as well, and his place was empty
    - So his absence was immediately noticeable
    - But Saul didn't say anything in the room
    - Instead, he just thought to himself that David was gone because he had become unclean somehow
    - It's clear that Saul is hoping his guess is true
    - For if it were, then Saul could have expected David to return the next day after having washed ritually
- But the next day David still isn't there
  - New months were timed by lunar events
    - And the precise moment of a lunar event can be hard to detect, especially if it occurs in the daylight hours
    - So these feasts were two day events to ensure the exact moment was captured
  - On this second day, Saul is enraged because he knows that David is avoiding the dinner and foiling his plan to kill him
    - He asks Jonathan where David has gone
    - In v.27 he refers to David as "the son of Jesse" rather than by name
    - This is a mild insult of David, showing Saul's contempt for him
  - Then Jonathan tells the lie that he and David prepared
    - For the second time a member of Saul's family lies to Saul to protect David
    - While we can agree that a lie is always sin, we must also say that these lies are the product of Saul's own sin
    - Saul, the father in the family, is acting unreasonably and rashly in sinning against the Lord's anointed

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        - And his sin is leading his children to sin in response as an attempt to right their father's wrong for David's sake
        - So say what you will about Michal's and Jonathan's choice to lie, but it would never have happened had Saul done the right thing
    - This fact is at the core of Paul's admonition that fathers not exasperate their children

Col. 3:21 **Fathers, do not exasperate your children, so that they will not lose heart.**

Eph. 6:4 **Fathers, do not provoke your children to anger, but bring them up in the discipline and instruction of the Lord.**

- The Greek word for exasperate means to stir up to anger
- So in both verses Paul is advising fathers not to drive their children into rebellious anger
- What drives a child there? Strict rules? Stern discipline? No, not if applied consistently and fairly in love
    - Children generally grow up respecting this kind of treatment
        - But Paul says children will grow angry and resentful when they receive unfair, unloving treatment
        - They will become exasperated by parents who set hypocritical examples demanding perfect obedience while sinning themselves
        - Or who receive unnecessarily harsh penalties for common mistakes
    - Saul is bringing his children into anger – righteous anger – and leading them to rebel to protect the innocent
        - Not all childhood rebellion is good or right, of course
        - But in some cases, that rebellion is the product of parenting choices that stir up anger and resentment
        - I think it's fair to conclude that Saul's children were backed into a corner by their father until they had little choice but to lie
- Jonathan's answer provokes Saul

1Sam. 20:30 **Then Saul's anger burned against Jonathan and he said to him, "You son of a perverse, rebellious woman! Do I not know that you are choosing the son of Jesse to your own shame and to the shame of your mother's nakedness?**
1Sam. 20:31 **"For as long as the son of Jesse lives on the earth, neither you nor your kingdom will be established. Therefore now, send and bring him to me, for he must surely die."**
1Sam. 20:32 **But Jonathan answered Saul his father and said to him, "Why should**

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he be put to death? What has he done?"
1Sam. 20:33 **Then Saul hurled his spear at him to strike him down; so Jonathan knew that his father had decided to put David to death.**
1Sam. 20:34 **Then Jonathan arose from the table in fierce anger, and did not eat food on the second day of the new moon, for he was grieved over David because his father had dishonored him.**

- Saul has listened to Jonathan's explanation for David's absence, but it wasn't convincing
  - The story was probably too perfect and I doubt Jonathan was a good liar
    - So Saul erupts at Jonathan
    - He calls Jonathan a "son of a perverse woman" referring to Jonathan's mother
    - Both then as now, it was a low blow to refer to a person's mother in this way
    - In fact, the translation of these words varies significantly depending on your translation
    - The Today's English Version translates it "You bastard!"
    - The New English Translation notes that Saul should be understood to have said "You son of a bitch"
  - Then Saul says Jonathan's friendship with David was to Jonathan's shame
    - In Saul's view it was to Jonathan's shame because it would result in Jonathan losing the throne
    - For an heir to not receive what he was owed is a shame
    - But of course that inheritance was promised to another and Jonathan knew it
  - Finally, he says that Jonathan's actions are to the shame of his mother's nakedness
    - Saul is referring to the moment of birth when a woman was exposed like no other time
    - And that shame of nakedness was wasted if Jonathan's life didn't amount to becoming king
    - Saul is being the ultimate hypocrite in defending the honor of Jonathan's mother, having just insulted her
- Obviously, all this strong language is an indication of the deteriorating nature of Saul's heart
  - Saul sees Jonathan as a traitor to his own family
    - He knows Jonathan is David's closest friend, so he assumes Jonathan is hiding David
    - Then Saul explains the obvious that if David lives, Jonathan won't have the throne
  - In that phrase Saul reveals everything that's going on in his heart

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        - He has one goal on his mind
        - Holding on to the throne
        - He wants this despite having heard from the Lord through Samuel that the throne has been taken away and given to David
        - And he wants to get his way so badly that he even wants to ensure his children hold the throne after him
    - He's not interested in obeying the Lord's will, but of course Saul's goal is complete folly
        - God's will cannot be frustrated
        - Saul is guaranteed to lose that fight
        - Meanwhile, because he's resisting the will of the Lord, he's risking much more than the throne
- So Saul demands Jonathan present David to him so David could be put to death to ensure Jonathan's inheritance, but of course Jonathan refuses
    - Jonathan asks why the innocent must die
        - It's not only a refusal to obey Saul
        - But it's also an indictment of the king's judgment
    - For this Saul throws a spear at Jonathan as well
        - Thankfully for Jonathan, Saul missed
        - Ironically, Saul told Jonathan that David would prevent him from receiving the throne, but it was Saul who almost brought about that end for Jonathan by his murderous heart
        - This moment makes clear who the real threat to David and Jonathan is: Saul
        - And with that Jonathan now knows that Saul's desire to kill David cannot be changed
        - Saul is determined to see David as a threat that can only be corrected with David's death
    - So Jonathan leaves the meal without eating and in disgust at his father's treatment of the Lord's anointed
        - Jonathan has a different heart
        - His desire was that God's plan might succeed and he was directed at ensuring it would
        - He wanted God's desires to win out more than he wanted his own personal interests to win out
        - That's the heart of someone who loves the Lord
        - They want what God wants
- Then in a tender scene Jonathan fulfills his covenant promise to David

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1Sam. 20:35 Now it came about in the morning that Jonathan went out into the field for the appointment with David, and a little lad was with him.
1Sam. 20:36 He said to his lad, "Run, find now the arrows which I am about to shoot." As the lad was running, he shot an arrow past him.
1Sam. 20:37 When the lad reached the place of the arrow which Jonathan had shot, Jonathan called after the lad and said, "Is not the arrow beyond you?"
1Sam. 20:38 And Jonathan called after the lad, "Hurry, be quick, do not stay!" And Jonathan's lad picked up the arrow and came to his master.
1Sam. 20:39 But the lad was not aware of anything; only Jonathan and David knew about the matter.
1Sam. 20:40 Then Jonathan gave his weapons to his lad and said to him, "Go, bring them to the city."
1Sam. 20:41 When the lad was gone, David rose from the south side and fell on his face to the ground, and bowed three times. And they kissed each other and wept together, but David wept the more.
1Sam. 20:42 Jonathan said to David, "Go in safety, inasmuch as we have sworn to each other in the name of the Lord, saying, 'The Lord will be between me and you, and between my descendants and your descendants forever.'" Then he rose and departed, while Jonathan went into the city.

- David has spent a couple of nights in the field waiting for Jonathan's return
  - When he does come back, he executes the warning plan as they agreed
    - He shoots arrows over David and calls for the boy to retrieve them
    - The boy was quite young, probably chosen by Jonathan to ensure the boy wouldn't ask any questions of the matter
  - Eventually Jonathan sends the boy away to give him and David a chance to say goodbye
    - The original plan had been for David to leave on the basis of the arrows alone
    - But Jonathan finds a way for a face-to-face goodbye
  - David fell to his face and gave Jonathan, the king's son, the proper respect
    - They kiss and wept in recognition that their earthly friendship was coming to an ending
    - Saul's determination to kill David made it impossible for them to be together from this point forward
    - But their covenant would be everlasting, as they repeat the vows here
  - Jonathan has chosen to favor his supposed enemy over his father, and he did so in confidence because he was in covenant with David
    - That covenant did away with the enmity between Jonathan and David
    - And it created enmity between Jonathan and Saul

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- In that sense, Jonathan becomes a picture of every believer, while David is again a picture of Christ
  - As Paul says:

Eph. 2:1 And you were dead in your trespasses and sins,
Eph. 2:2 in which you formerly walked according to the course of this world, according to the prince of the power of the air, of the spirit that is now working in the sons of disobedience.

- **Like every unbeliever, Jonathan was initially a part of a household that was an enemy of God's anointed**

James 4:4 You adulteresses, do you not know that friendship with the world is hostility toward God? Therefore whoever wishes to be a friend of the world makes himself an enemy of God.

- But after entering into a covenant, Jonathan became an enemy of his former master and a friend to his new king
  - Just as we must turn our backs on the world to enter into a covenant with Christ

1John 5:5 Who is the one who overcomes the world, but he who believes that Jesus is the Son of God?

- And after that we have a life-long friendship with the King
- This is the last time these two see each other alive, but as we saw last week David keeps his promise to Jonathan's household
  - Over the next ten chapters, David will be in flight from Saul
    - He will grow increasingly stronger
    - His maturity will grow in leaps and bounds
    - His tactics will graduate from deception to dependence on the Lord
  - Meanwhile, Saul will grow weaker and weaker
    - His paranoia grows
    - His mental state deteriorates
    - Eventually he's consulting the occult for help
  - So as David depends more and more on the Lord, Saul moves to making appeals of the enemy
    - Here again, David pictures Christ's willingness to suffer deprivation before ascending to His throne

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        - He was willing to wait for the Father to promote him into a promised position without seeking it before the appointed time
- First, David flees to someone he hopes will facilitate his escape, Ahimelech the priest

1Sam. 21:1 Then David came to Nob to Ahimelech the priest; and Ahimelech came trembling to meet David and said to him, "Why are you alone and no one with you?"
1Sam. 21:2 David said to Ahimelech the priest, "The king has commissioned me with a matter and has said to me, 'Let no one know anything about the matter on which I am sending you and with which I have commissioned you; and I have directed the young men to a certain place.'
1Sam. 21:3 "Now therefore, what do you have on hand? Give me five loaves of bread, or whatever can be found."
1Sam. 21:4 The priest answered David and said, "There is no ordinary bread on hand, but there is consecrated bread; if only the young men have kept themselves from women."
1Sam. 21:5 David answered the priest and said to him, "Surely women have been kept from us as previously when I set out and the vessels of the young men were holy, though it was an ordinary journey; how much more then today will their vessels be holy?"
1Sam. 21:6 So the priest gave him consecrated bread; for there was no bread there but the bread of the Presence which was removed from before the Lord, in order to put hot bread in its place when it was taken away.

- Nob is a town on the present day Mt Scopus and housed a compound of priests
    - Since the high priest, Ahimelech, was living here, we must assume the tabernacle had been moved to this place at some point
        - As Saul's general, David was a man to be feared
        - So as David approaches the priest, Ahimelech wonders if David has been sent on a mission to harm him
        - So he trembles at the sight of David approaching by himself
        - By this time, David has collected some men to follow him, as the text indicates
    - But David tells the priest a lie that Saul has sent him on a secret mission
        - Here again, at the outset of David's flight he is demonstrating his spiritual immaturity
        - He's of the mind that he must bend the rules to ensure the outcome he wants, forgetting that God can move mountains
        - If he obeyed the Lord and trusted the Lord to respond properly, great things would happen
    - It appears that David and his men have been hiding for some time, to the point that

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they're quite hungry

- Hungry enough to invent this ruse to get food from the priest
- He asks for five loaves of bread
- The priest replies that the only bread available in Nob was the showbread from the tabernacle

- In the Law, the tabernacle had loaves of bread placed in the Holy Place every Sabbath
  - After the week, the old bread was removed and given to the priest to eat
    - Only the priests were supposed to eat this bread according to the instructions of God in the Law
    - But now David appeals to the priest for mercy to give him food to sustain him in the work he was doing in obedience to God
  - The priest stipulated that David and his men must not be ritually unclean, but otherwise he was willing to break the rules to grant his request
    - Why were the priests willing to go against the Law in this case?
    - Even more puzzling, Jesus declares in the Gospels that their actions were justified

Matt. 12:1 At that time Jesus went through the grainfields on the Sabbath, and His disciples became hungry and began to pick the heads of grain and eat.
Matt. 12:2 But when the Pharisees saw this, they said to Him, "Look, Your disciples do what is not lawful to do on a Sabbath."
Matt. 12:3 But He said to them, "Have you not read what David did when he became hungry, he and his companions,
Matt. 12:4 how he entered the house of God, and they ate the consecrated bread, which was not lawful for him to eat nor for those with him, but for the priests alone?
Matt. 12:5 "Or have you not read in the Law, that on the Sabbath the priests in the temple break the Sabbath and are innocent?

- Jesus refers to this situation when He defends the disciples eating heads of grain on the Sabbath
  - In Jesus' situation it is even easier to understand
    - The disciples weren't doing anything the law prohibited
    - But the Pharisees had contrived excessive rules governing behavior
    - So they had outlawed eating grain in this way on the Sabbath
  - To refute their self-made laws, Jesus asks them to explain how David could have been allowed to eat the showbread?
    - Which Jesus Himself said was unlawful
    - And He goes a step further and reminds them that the priests did work in the

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temple on the Sabbath but were innocent

- Jesus is explaining that obedience to the Lord is never sin
  - When the priests served in the tabernacle, they were obeying the law also
  - Yet that obedience appeared to come into conflict with other laws concerning the Sabbath
  - But all law comes from the Law Giver, and all law was given to men to reveal their unrighteousness
  - So when when two laws are in opposition, the higher law prevails
- Jesus sums this up by declaring that Jesus is the Lord of the Sabbath
  - Honoring the Lord is higher than honoring His Sabbath, so always give preference to Jesus over the a Law given to men
  - Likewise, honoring the Lord's anointed, David, was a higher goal than honoring the showbread or priesthood requirements of the Law
  - Since Jesus is Lord of the showbread and Lord of the priests
  - This was further evidence that David's anointing as king was evident to many in Israel including this priest

- But all was not well in Nob

1Sam. 21:7 Now one of the servants of Saul was there that day, detained before the Lord; and his name was Doeg the Edomite, the chief of Saul's shepherds.

- Samuel includes this reference to a spy of Saul so he can set up the events of Chapter 22
  - This man must have been on an errand to Nob for the king
  - While he's there, he sees David arrive and will later report what he saw
- The fact that he's identified as an Edomite is intended to tell us that Saul has men in his employment who are not of Israel and not pleasing to God
  - This man will later become a harsh lesson to David that he must trust the Lord during this time
  - He can't take matters into his own hands without devastating consequences
  - It will take David a little longer to appreciate this lesson

1Sam. 21:8 David said to Ahimelech, "Now is there not a spear or a sword on hand? For I brought neither my sword nor my weapons with me, because the king's matter was urgent."
1Sam. 21:9 Then the priest said, "The sword of Goliath the Philistine, whom you killed in the valley of Elah, behold, it is wrapped in a cloth behind the ephod; if you would take it for yourself, take it. For there is no other except it here." And David said, "There is none like it; give it to me."

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- After spotting Doeg, David turns back to the king and asks for a weapon, maybe a sword
  - The priest mentions Goliath's sword, which has been stored here
    - David remembers it and asks for it knowing it's special
    - So David has relied on lies and now he intended to rely on weapons to save himself
  - Finally, he decides to rely on his enemy

1Sam. 21:10 Then David arose and fled that day from Saul, and went to Achish king of Gath.
1Sam. 21:11 But the servants of Achish said to him, "Is this not David the king of the land? Did they not sing of this one as they danced, saying,
'Saul has slain his thousands,
And David his ten thousands'?"
1Sam. 21:12 David took these words to heart and greatly feared Achish king of Gath.
1Sam. 21:13 So he disguised his sanity before them, and acted insanely in their hands, and scribbled on the doors of the gate, and let his saliva run down into his beard.
1Sam. 21:14 Then Achish said to his servants, "Behold, you see the man behaving as a madman. Why do you bring him to me?
1Sam. 21:15 "Do I lack madmen, that you have brought this one to act the madman in my presence? Shall this one come into my house?"

- David's next stop was a city of the Philistines, Gath
  - We might assume that David chose to go to a Philistine city because of the old adage, "An enemy of my enemy is my friend"
    - Perhaps he thought he would be embraced as a fellow enemy of Saul
    - Or maybe he just thought he would blend into Philistine society and be forgotten
  - Apparently, the Philistines hadn't heard that saying
    - They take one look at David in the city and ask why is he here?
    - Chuck Swindoll once remarked that David's attempt to be inconspicuous in Gath was like Dolly Parton trying to blend in within a convent
    - The people even repeat the famous song of David remarking on his amazing ability to kill Philistines
  - Obviously, David realizes that he's found out and he worries for his life
    - The Philistines would have naturally assumed David was there as a spy or in preparing for an attack
    - Even more worrisome for David, they seem to know David is the king of the land

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        - On the one hand, it's a confirmation that the word of David's anointing is everywhere
        - But on the other hand, it reflects the great danger David is in right now
        - Nothing would please the Philistines more than killing the king of their enemy
- So in a spur of the moment idea, David decides to act like an insane person, hoping the people would take pity on him or lose interest in him
    - He adopts erratic behavior, writes nonsense on the doors of the city gate and drools on himself
        - Today, this kind of behavior might get you elected
        - But in that day, it was a useful defense
        - The king assumes that the insane David has come to Gath because Saul sent him there to be a burden
        - So he decides to ignore him, since he won't be of any use
    - In the meantime, David has made a fool of himself before the enemy of Israel
        - It saves his life but it diminishes him
        - This is the second time David has used deception to save himself in this chapter, and each time has a negative consequence for him
    - All in all, David has tried deception, weapons and now foolishness to save himself from Saul
        - Obviously, none of these instruments are the solution to his trouble
        - He's demonstrating more immaturity
        - But he's about to embark on a ten-year journey of spiritual maturity
        - And he's very much an example to all believers in this regard
- We all start somewhere
    - Abraham started as Abram, Israel started as Jacob
        - These men began as someone with limited abilities to hear, follow and trust in the Lord
        - Certainly, they trusted in the Lord so as to be declared righteous
        - But they weren't accustomed to following him especially in times of distress
    - Abraham went to Egypt, Jacob lied to his father and now David has employed similar tactics
        - But each man experienced his own trials and testing
        - Abraham took Isaac to the mountain
        - Jacob wrestled with the Lord
        - And David is going to spend 10 years in the wilderness
        - And these experiences will grow him into a man ready to assume leadership in the kingdom

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- Remember that the times we experience the greatest pressures are opportunities to become more Christ like
  - And when you discover yourself resorting to less-than faithful means to prevail in your circumstances, you'll understand why the Lord felt you needed the trial
  - When you trust in Him entirely to deliverance, then you will have passed your trial

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- The testing of David begins
  - He's fleeing a madman who almost killed his own son
    - And he's unsafe in his own country
    - He has nowhere to escape, since Israel is surrounded by enemies
    - David is confined to Israel while the king of the nation is determined to kill him
    - Surely the Lord has placed David in a pressure cooker
  - He's left his best friend, Jonathan, and now he's headed into the countryside with no one to receive him
    - Last week he visited the priests for a little bread
    - And he had some men following him
    - And now we learn where he goes
  - As we observe his flight, let's take note of how the Lord works to accomplish something great in this man
    - The Lord carefully balances trial with relief
    - Threat with rescue
    - David's fears balanced with the encouragement of friends
- After visiting the priest, David headed to the Philistines, which was a near disaster
  - Now David gains his senses and realizes he can't depend on Israel's enemies or on his own tricks
    - He must stay on the run and rely on the Lord
    - So he leaves Gath and returns east into Israel toward an area of large caves

1Sam. 22:1 So David departed from there and escaped to the cave of Adullam; and when his brothers and all his father's household heard of it, they went down there to him.

- David ends up in a cave called Adullam
  - What should we assume about a cave significant to have a name?
    - Certainly, the cave is large
    - This cave exists in a region just south of the Elah Valley where David killed Goliath
    - It's a region of limestone cliffs with many very large caverns
    - These caves can easily accommodate 400 or more men
  - David flees here in fear and utter despair
    - He has left his life, his power, his family, his best friend
    - He has made a fool of himself in front of Israel's enemies

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- And he has no plan, no resources and no idea of how he will survive in the face of a determined enemy with all the power of a nation
- And in this mindset David writes one of his first psalms

Psa. 142:0 Maskil of David, when he was in the cave. A Prayer.
Psa. 142:1 I cry aloud with my voice to the Lord;
I make supplication with my voice to the Lord.
Psa. 142:2 I pour out my complaint before Him;
I declare my trouble before Him.
Psa. 142:3 When my spirit was overwhelmed within me,
You knew my path.
In the way where I walk
They have hidden a trap for me.
Psa. 142:4 Look to the right and see;
For there is no one who regards me;
There is no escape for me;
No one cares for my soul.
Psa. 142:5 I cried out to You, O Lord;
I said, "You are my refuge,
My portion in the land of the living.
Psa. 142:6 "Give heed to my cry,
For I am brought very low;
Deliver me from my persecutors,
For they are too strong for me.
Psa. 142:7 "Bring my soul out of prison,
So that I may give thanks to Your name;
The righteous will surround me,
For You will deal bountifully with me."

- This psalm is called a prayer, because that's what David is doing in this cave…he's praying
  - He's planned ways to avoid Saul
  - He's schemed with the priests
  - He's made his escape into the enemy's land
- He's like so many of us if we were brought through this trial
  - When life comes crashing down, at first we think we have it under control
  - We try to manage it ourselves, planning, scheming, even making a fool of ourself
  - Not realizing that the whole time the Lord is bringing these circumstances for good purpose
  - And all our scheming is just delaying the process of growth the Lord has planned for

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our sake

- Then eventually we come to the end of ourselves
  - None of our plans work
  - All our scheming comes to nothing
  - We see the foolishness of our feeble efforts
  - And more importantly, we come to recognize that the Lord has brought these events into our life to test our faith
  - And in that moment, we turn to Him
- It's confirmation of the old adage that prayer is our last resort when it should be our first response
  - It's fair to say this was David's pattern as well
  - It's confirmation that he's in the beginning of his testing
  - We see the very immaturity that the Lord wants to expose and correct
- And so David prays for relief, and in response the Lord sends David support
  - As v.1 told us David is met by a collection of men from his tribe and immediate household
    - This must have been a great encouragement to David
    - He's sitting in a huge empty cave, fearing for his life and feeling abandoned by the world
    - And then a group of brothers appear and bring him great relief
  - Until he notices who shows up

1Sam. 22:2 **Everyone who was in distress, and everyone who was in debt, and everyone who was discontented gathered to him; and he became captain over them. Now there were about four hundred men with him.**

- If you were picking a kickball team, these guys would all be picked last
- They are guys with nothing to lose
- Samuel says they are in distress, debt and discontented
- In other words, these guys are as wanted as David
- So when they hear that the future king of Israel is on the run, they say to themselves, this is my kind of king
  - This collection of rejected, despised have-nots of society have found their refuge with a man who shares their shame
  - Such a beautiful picture of Christ as Paul wrote, speaking of those who find refuge in Christ:

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1Cor. 1:26 For consider your calling, brethren, that there were not many wise according to the flesh, not many mighty, not many noble;
1Cor. 1:27 but God has chosen the foolish things of the world to shame the wise, and God has chosen the weak things of the world to shame the things which are strong,
1Cor. 1:28 and the base things of the world and the despised God has chosen, the things that are not, so that He may nullify the things that are,
1Cor. 1:29 so that no man may boast before God.

- The Lord appears to be giving David cause for encouragement, yet He's doing it in such an odd way
  - It seems a perfect plan for encouraging a future king yet without giving opportunity for his pride to get in the way
    - Remember that Saul's downward spiral was propelled by self-importance and pride
    - But the Lord won't give David any room to make that same mistake
    - His palace is a cave
    - And his subjects are deadbeats and malcontents
    - Not much opportunity for pride under these circumstances
  - Ironically, though, it's this odd group that becomes the nucleus of support that eventually leads to his crowning as king
    - God will turn this mustard seed of support for David into a kingdom
    - But there's years of time still to pass and a battle that must be fought
    - Their enemy will seem quite strong for a time
    - But his defeat is assured from the beginning
    - I'm sure you can draw your own parallel between David and Christ
- Now that David has his modest army, he decides to leave the caves and be on the move again, for if these men could find him, so could Saul

1Sam. 22:3 And David went from there to Mizpah of Moab; and he said to the king of Moab, "Please let my father and my mother come and stay with you until I know what God will do for me."
1Sam. 22:4 Then he left them with the king of Moab; and they stayed with him all the time that David was in the stronghold.
1Sam. 22:5 The prophet Gad said to David, "Do not stay in the stronghold; depart, and go into the land of Judah." So David departed and went into the forest of Hereth. David and his men go to Moab, the enemy of Israel directly to the east.

- Since there was no safe place in Israel for an enemy of Saul, it makes sense that David

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would escort his family out of the country

- The Moabites might have still had some affinity for his family in light of that connection
- David's great grandmother was a Moabite (Ruth)
- And the country of Moab is also the sensible place to take them
- David might have also sought refuge in Moab, but notice he has no interest in joining his parents there
  - He says he is is seeking to understand what the Lord will do with him
  - In other words, David seems to understand that the Lord is working in these circumstances and David must submit to it
- For as long as David remained in Mitzpah, the stronghold, his parents were with him
  - But eventually, the prophet Gad comes to David and encourages him to return
  - Gad was a contemporary prophet with Samuel
  - But we have no Bible book by this prophet
  - We know of him because Samuel writes of him
  - He appears periodically during the life of David in support of his reign

- So already we see the Lord raising up a support structure for David, but it's the kind of structure that leaves no room for boasting
  - Meanwhile, the man who has no trouble boasting is raving over David's escape

1Sam. 22:6 **Then Saul heard that David and the men who were with him had been discovered. Now Saul was sitting in Gibeah, under the tamarisk tree on the height with his spear in his hand, and all his servants were standing around him.**
1Sam. 22:7 **Saul said to his servants who stood around him, "Hear now, O Benjamites! Will the son of Jesse also give to all of you fields and vineyards? Will he make you all commanders of thousands and commanders of hundreds?**
1Sam. 22:8 **"For all of you have conspired against me so that there is no one who discloses to me when my son makes a covenant with the son of Jesse, and there is none of you who is sorry for me or discloses to me that my son has stirred up my servant against me to lie in ambush, as it is this day."**
1Sam. 22:9 **Then Doeg the Edomite, who was standing by the servants of Saul, said, "I saw the son of Jesse coming to Nob, to Ahimelech the son of Ahitub.**
1Sam. 22:10 **"He inquired of the Lord for him, gave him provisions, and gave him the sword of Goliath the Philistine."**

- Samuel moves back and forth between the story of David and the story of Saul to drive home the contrast
  - As David is humbly submitting to the Lord's will, enduring deprivation and taking

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shelter with Israel's enemies, Saul is doing the opposite
    - He's sitting securely in his home
    - Under a tree, resting with his attendants surrounding him
    - But rather than being at peace with his situation, he's frantic
  - Saul hears David has followers in the desert now, and he begins to mock David and the song that enraged him so much
    - Unlike David, Saul has an endless number of loyal subjects
    - But it's Saul making accusations that his followers are conspiring against him
    - He blames them for not revealing that Jonathan and David were in covenant
    - That covenant was struck in secret, so it's unlikely the servants were hiding anything
    - But Saul's paranoia doesn't care about the facts
  - At the end of v.8, Saul is having a full-blown pity party
    - Once again, if anyone in this story had reason to sit on the ground and pout, it should have been David
    - But it's Saul who's in despair at this point
- At this point, the character from the last chapter returns
  - Doeg, the Edomite, the one who noticed David hanging around the priests in Nob
    - Doeg tells Saul he knows that the priests gave David support
    - He got food and a weapon
    - The way he tells the story makes it sound worse than it was
    - It wasn't as though the priests were seeking to assist David so much as they were fooled by David's lie
  - And by betraying David, Doeg wins points with Saul and that's his desire
    - As Doeg expected, Saul reacts in anger to the news

1Sam. 22:11 Then the king sent someone to summon Ahimelech the priest, the son of Ahitub, and all his father's household, the priests who were in Nob; and all of them came to the king.
1Sam. 22:12 Saul said, "Listen now, son of Ahitub." And he answered, "Here I am, my lord."
1Sam. 22:13 Saul then said to him, "Why have you and the son of Jesse conspired against me, in that you have given him bread and a sword and have inquired of God for him, so that he would rise up against me by lying in ambush as it is this day?"
1Sam. 22:14 Then Ahimelech answered the king and said, "And who among all your servants is as faithful as David, even the king's son-in-law, who is captain over your guard, and is honored in your house?

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1Sam. 22:15 **"Did I just begin to inquire of God for him today? Far be it from me! Do not let the king impute anything to his servant or to any of the household of my father, for your servant knows nothing at all of this whole affair."**
1Sam. 22:16 **But the king said, "You shall surely die, Ahimelech, you and all your father's household!"**
1Sam. 22:17 **And the king said to the guards who were attending him, "Turn around and put the priests of the Lord to death, because their hand also is with David and because they knew that he was fleeing and did not reveal it to me." But the servants of the king were not willing to put forth their hands to attack the priests of the Lord.**

- The king demands the High Priest appear before him along with his whole household and all the priests of Nob
  - Saul confronts him for supporting David
    - He accuses the priest of conspiring with "the son of Jesse" against him
    - He mentioned the bread and sword but then concludes these materials would be used to allow David to ambush Saul
    - Of course, nothing like this was planned, but Saul is simply imagining the worst in his state of paranoia
  - And the priest is as confused as Saul is paranoid
    - He first reacts incredulously at the idea that David would oppose Saul
    - He says no one is more loyal to Saul than David, the captain of his army
    - But as far as these matters, the priest says he knows nothing of them, which was true
    - He was acting under the deception David spoke to him
  - Saul isn't convinced and orders the soldiers to kill the priests of Israel
    - The soldiers hear the command but take no action
    - They weren't convinced there was good reason to take the lives of God's anointed priests
    - These men had too much respect for the priesthood, so much that they felt Saul's orders could be ignored
    - Clearly, they saw the command to respect the priesthood to be equal or greater than the requirement to respect the king
- So what does a Jewish king need when he wants to act contrary to a Jewish law?
  - He needs someone who has no respect nor concern for that Law: a Gentile
    - And in this case, Saul happens to have that Gentile standing by
    - Doeg, the Edomite

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1Sam. 22:18 Then the king said to Doeg, "You turn around and attack the priests." And Doeg the Edomite turned around and attacked the priests, and he killed that day eighty-five men who wore the linen ephod.
1Sam. 22:19 And he struck Nob the city of the priests with the edge of the sword, both men and women, children and infants; also oxen, donkeys, and sheep he struck with the edge of the sword.

- Doeg has no problem killing the priests
  - Or for that matter, the women, children, even infants, oxen and the rest
  - There is no indication that the king expected this response
  - Nor does it appear Saul was upset either
  - Rather, it seems Doeg went well beyond the call of duty, either out of hatred for Jews or simply to impress the king
- The Septuagint indicates that Doeg killed not 85 but rather 385
  - Josephus also wrote that Doeg killed 300 priests and prophets in Nob
  - It would seem that he wiped out the family of the high priest and the city of Nob
  - Ironically, Saul was unwilling to wipe out the Gentile enemies of Israel, the Amalekites, as God directed
  - But he was all too willing to sin against the Lord by allowing a Gentile to wipe out the Jewish priesthood
- But one member of the family survives to perpetuate the priesthood

1Sam. 22:20 But one son of Ahimelech the son of Ahitub, named Abiathar, escaped and fled after David.
1Sam. 22:21 Abiathar told David that Saul had killed the priests of the Lord.
1Sam. 22:22 Then David said to Abiathar, "I knew on that day, when Doeg the Edomite was there, that he would surely tell Saul. I have brought about the death of every person in your father's household.
1Sam. 22:23 "Stay with me; do not be afraid, for he who seeks my life seeks your life, for you are safe with me."

- The priesthood of Eli is doomed to come to an end one day in the future during Solomon's reign
  - But for now, it continues through Eli's family by means of this one refugee
  - Abiathar escapes from Doeg and makes his way to David
  - He must have figured that he would be a hunted man like David, so he might as well align with David
- Now we can see the wisdom of the Lord in allowing Doeg to attack the priests

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- This is an example of the Lord turning all things to good for those who love him
- Because of Saul's sin and the sin of this Edomite, the only priest remaining in the line of the high priests is with David, not Saul
- David has become the protector of the priesthood and so it will forever be with David
- And of course, the Lord is using David and Saul to extinguish the line of Eli as He promised to do

- Nevertheless, David is distraught at the thought he was responsible for the death of the priests
  - David's blaming himself and though we might be tempted to say he's overreacting, it's not far from the truth
    - His decision to go to the priests was a mistake
    - And when he saw Doeg, he admits he knew this man would report what he saw
    - So at the very least he should have stopped Doeg from returning
  - Nevertheless, David isn't directly to blame for Saul's actions
    - Saul is a man in full rebellion to God
    - And more than that, he's psychologically and emotionally unhinged as a result
  - When Paul says the wages of sin is death, he is speaking broadly about the condition of our soul
    - When a person lives in persistent sin against the Lord, eventually the wages (i.e., the return) on that lifestyle take their toll
    - And death is the result
    - A person suffers a slow death socially, psychologically, physically and even spiritually
  - If a person has saving faith, then God's grace will preserve them from the ultimate penalty of their sin, that is the Second Death
    - But nevertheless, they may still suffer the side effects of sin in this life
    - This is the state of Saul, a man earning the wages of sin including a deteriorating psyche willing to murder the innocent to obtain what he desires
- As David reflected on these circumstances, he wrote another Psalm

Psa. 52:0 For the choir director. A Maskil of David, when Doeg the Edomite came and told Saul and said to him, "David has come to the house of Ahimelech."
Psa. 52:1 Why do you boast in evil, O mighty man?
The lovingkindness of God endures all day long.
Psa. 52:2 Your tongue devises destruction,
Like a sharp razor, O worker of deceit.
Psa. 52:3 You love evil more than good,
Falsehood more than speaking what is right. Selah.

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Psa. 52:4 You love all words that devour,
O deceitful tongue.
Psa. 52:5 But God will break you down forever;
He will snatch you up and tear you away from your tent,
And uproot you from the land of the living. Selah.
Psa. 52:6 The righteous will see and fear,
And will laugh at him, saying,
Psa. 52:7 "Behold, the man who would not make God his refuge,
But trusted in the abundance of his riches
And was strong in his evil desire."
Psa. 52:8 But as for me, I am like a green olive tree in the house of God;
I trust in the lovingkindness of God forever and ever.
Psa. 52:9 I will give You thanks forever, because You have done it,
And I will wait on Your name, for it is good, in the presence of Your godly ones.

- Now the story returns to David for a time, once again contrasting the increasing rebellion of Saul with the increasing obedience of David

1Sam. 23:1 Then they told David, saying, "Behold, the Philistines are fighting against Keilah and are plundering the threshing floors."
1Sam. 23:2 So David inquired of the Lord, saying, "Shall I go and attack these Philistines?" And the Lord said to David, "Go and attack the Philistines and deliver Keilah."
1Sam. 23:3 But David's men said to him, "Behold, we are afraid here in Judah. How much more then if we go to Keilah against the ranks of the Philistines?"
1Sam. 23:4 Then David inquired of the Lord once more. And the Lord answered him and said, "Arise, go down to Keilah, for I will give the Philistines into your hand."
1Sam. 23:5 So David and his men went to Keilah and fought with the Philistines; and he led away their livestock and struck them with a great slaughter. Thus David delivered the inhabitants of Keilah.

- We assume David returned from Moab to the large cave of Adullam
  - From there he learns that the Philistines have attacked a Jewish town called Keilah
    - This town is only about 2.5 miles south of David's cave, so he recognizes an opportunity to help his Jewish brothers
    - The Philistines were raiding the grain storage of the Jews living in the surround area of the Shephelah
    - So David asks the Lord whether he should assist in the defense of the city
  - Notice David starts with an inquiry of the Lord in prayer, asking for direction

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        - This is the first of four times David seeks the Lord's counsel in this matter
        - Interestingly, David's inquiry of the Lord was by means of the ephod of the high priest who now accompanied him
    - The ephod of the priest contained two special stones called Urim and Thummim, which means lights and perfection or truth
        - These stones could be used to divine the will of God
        - The priest could ask a yes/no question of God and then throw the stones
        - The stones would then reveal the answer in some way
- Obviously, this was a supernatural provision God made available to Israel so that they might seek His will
    - These stones had been in possession of Saul's priests, so Saul could have inquired of God at any time
        - But Saul made no effort to know God's will
        - Because he had no interest in following it
        - The loss of the priests made little difference to Saul
        - But the arrival of this priest has now become the means for David to operate with the guidance and direction of God
    - When he asks the Lord whether to proceed into the city, the Lord says go
        - So David tells his men of the plan, but they object to the sense of it
        - They say they fear for their lives enough already, so why take the added risk of going to this battle with the Philistines?
        - At this point, David could have argued the point, but instead he returns to the counsel of the Lord to be sure
        - And once more the Lord confirms His earlier order
    - David's approach to this situation and to these men is a great example of godly and humble leadership
        - Of course, the first step for every man or woman who leads or ministers to others is to know you are in the will of God yourself
        - And that requires that we ask Him to direct our hearts, which He will do by His Spirit
        - You may be tempted to think those rocks would make that process easier
    - But in reality you have an even greater access to God's will by His Spirit
        - The Spirit can inform us beyond merely yes and no answers
        - And He speaks to us continually, not merely in special moments when we seek Him
        - The only question is do we listen?
- So David models the importance of seeking God's guidance as we lead others, followed next by communicating the orders of the Lord to others

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- We share what God reveals so that His will is manifest to others
  - And more importantly, so that we are on the record with others
  - Accountability to the will of God goes up exponentially when you share with others what the Lord has told you
  - Keep his will a secret, and you are more likely to forget it yourself
- But then as we share the will of God, we might encounter resistance
  - Perhaps our spouse or parents or friends will question the plan
  - At that point, we may be tempted to argue in God's favor
  - This response might seem like a demonstration of faith, but it can just as easily be the result of pride
  - Perhaps their counsel is truly God's will correcting our assumptions or selfish desires?
- So we need to have the humility to seek the Lord again for confirmation
  - This isn't an indication that we lack faith
  - It's simply a reasonable precaution to avoid falling into the pride of mistaking our own voice for God's

- Then once we have confirmation, we move out and call upon those who look up to us to follow in support
  - For if we're sure the Lord has spoken, then we must also have confidence He will bring the rest of the plan together
    - Spiritual leadership is often a matter of persevering in spite of opposition from God's people, to say nothing of the enemy
    - David's men need inspiration to overcome their fears and step out in faith
    - And David provided that inspiration without resorting to pride or bravado
    - Humility is an admirable and inspiring quality in any leader
  - Finally, David doesn't let his men pout in self-pity
    - He tells them it's time to get busy saving others
    - Nothing inspires us to serve and obey God better than focusing on the needs of others before our own
    - Ironically, when we live a self-centered lifestyle, we are unlikely to obtain the spiritual blessing we seek
    - But when we make serving others the goal, the Lord will take care of those needs
    - As Jesus promised

Matt. 6:33 **"But seek first His kingdom and His righteousness, and all these things will be added to you.**
Matt. 6:34 **"So do not worry about tomorrow; for tomorrow will care for itself.**

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Each day has enough trouble of its own.

- Sure enough, as David and his men obey the Lord, the Lord brings a great victory
  - Just four hundred poorly armed men were able to defeat a Philistine army of unknown number
    - They take away the livestock of the army
    - And they free the city from the attackers
    - So not only has David won a great victory that endears him to the people
    - But in the process the Lord has made a provision for him with the livestock
    - What a great example of seeking first for the righteousness of God and having all the other needs met in the process
  - Now that David has made a big splash in defending the city, word is going to reach back to Saul who is still search frantically for David

1Sam. 23:6 **Now it came about, when Abiathar the son of Ahimelech fled to David at Keilah, that he came down with an ephod in his hand.**
1Sam. 23:7 **When it was told Saul that David had come to Keilah, Saul said, "God has delivered him into my hand, for he shut himself in by entering a city with double gates and bars."**
1Sam. 23:8 **So Saul summoned all the people for war, to go down to Keilah to besiege David and his men.**
1Sam. 23:9 **Now David knew that Saul was plotting evil against him; so he said to Abiathar the priest, "Bring the ephod here."**
1Sam. 23:10 **Then David said, "O Lord God of Israel, Your servant has heard for certain that Saul is seeking to come to Keilah to destroy the city on my account.**
1Sam. 23:11 **"Will the men of Keilah surrender me into his hand? Will Saul come down just as Your servant has heard? O Lord God of Israel, I pray, tell Your servant." And the Lord said, "He will come down."**
1Sam. 23:12 **Then David said, "Will the men of Keilah surrender me and my men into the hand of Saul?" And the Lord said, "They will surrender you."**
1Sam. 23:13 **Then David and his men, about six hundred, arose and departed from Keilah, and they went wherever they could go. When it was told Saul that David had escaped from Keilah, he gave up the pursuit.**
1Sam. 23:14 **David stayed in the wilderness in the strongholds, and remained in the hill country in the wilderness of Ziph. And Saul sought him every day, but God did not deliver him into his hand.**

- Samuel reminds us that when David went to the battle, the priest Abiathar accompanied him with the ephod

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- This shows us that David intended to continue consulting the Lord throughout his movements
  - And that proves to be a wise move on David's part
  - Because he will need to consult the Lord again concerning what do to next
- David has entered this city after the battle and is wondering if this might be a safe haven for him to defend himself against Saul
  - He's pretty confident that Saul's army can't penetrate the elaborate walls of the city
  - But that's true only if the inhabitants of the city take David's side in the battle
  - Because David will need their help to defend the city from Saul's attack
- Saul also recognizes the opportunity
  - He realizes this city could be David's prison
  - And he trusts that if he sieges the city, the inhabitants will give David up rather than rebel against the king
  - So then the question is, who is right in this matter?
  - Will the city defend David or side with Saul?

- So David seeks clarity with the Lord by means of the ephod again
  - He first asks if Saul will come to attack this city
    - And the Lord responds by means of the ephod that yes, Saul is coming to attack
    - This is probably what David assumed would happen
  - So then David asks the more important question
    - What will happen in the attack?
    - Will the people betray David or protect him?
    - And the Lord tells David that if he stays, the people will betray him to Saul
  - In other words, the Lord is telling David he must flee to save himself
    - This city is not to become a refuge for David
    - It was God's will that David remain on the run from Saul
    - So David leaves the city
- This is an important footnote on our earlier analysis of David's godly leadership
  - It would be natural to assume too much about this victory
    - That since God sent David up against this city and delivered a great victory that therefore the Lord was also prepared to defend David against Saul
    - David could have made that assumption without even seeking the Lord's counsel
    - After all, why would the Lord have produced such a great victory only to let Saul destroy David in the end?

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- But that's exactly what would have happened had David made that assumption
  - Which illustrates that we can't ever assume we have the full picture of God's will
  - We must continually return to know our next step in His plan
  - Just because He delivers us under one set of circumstances doesn't mean He intended to grant us victory in everything we face
  - Sometimes, the defeats we encounter in life are the result of walking away from God's counsel rather than God turning His back on us
- The Lord is certainly prepared to defend and protect David, but only according to His plan
  - Therefore, David models for us the importance of never getting ahead of the Lord
  - Never presuming too much about the Lord's willingness to rescue us, whether from life and death or just some temptation into sin

- In vs.13-14 Samuel tells us that Saul gave up his pursuit once he learned that David had escaped
  - Further confirmation that as David moved according to the Lord's will, he would see protection
    - Nevertheless, he was living under harsh and uncomfortable circumstances
    - He was moving around in a harsh wilderness in the hill country
    - Living on the run like this is never easy
    - But at least David's men had some provision now
  - Remember David's plight when someone tells you that those who lack comfort or material riches are suffering due to a lack of faith
    - David's story is proof that such teaching is false
    - David was living in depravation precisely because he was in God's will
    - This was God's will for his life, that he would experience this hardship for a time
    - And by this experience, he would grow closer to the Lord

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- David is fresh off his victory in defending the city of Keilah
  - He patiently sought the Lord's counsel after the battle
    - So the Lord warned David not to retreat into the city
    - The people would give him up to the king
    - And therefore, David and his men must keep moving
  - Israel isn't a very large place
    - So David's flight from Saul is like a gang of men trying to hide from the police in Central Park
    - If you're smart, you can manage it, but you have to stay on the run and you're never out of danger
    - Such was David's flight in Israel
  - Meanwhile, Samuel has constructed his narrative to contrast David's increasing obedience with Saul's increasing rebellion
    - And that contrast will only grow as we move forward
    - Next we find David seeking a new refuge
    - And now we find Jonathan seeking out David again in the wilderness

1Sam. 23:15 **Now David became aware that Saul had come out to seek his life while David was in the wilderness of Ziph at Horesh.**
1Sam. 23:16 **And Jonathan, Saul's son, arose and went to David at Horesh, and encouraged him in God.**
1Sam. 23:17 **Thus he said to him, "Do not be afraid, because the hand of Saul my father will not find you, and you will be king over Israel and I will be next to you; and Saul my father knows that also."**
1Sam. 23:18 **So the two of them made a covenant before the Lord; and David stayed at Horesh while Jonathan went to his house.**

- After leaving Keilah, David fled 12 miles southeast to the wilderness of Ziph into a town by the same name
  - This is a town in the tribe of Judah, yet as we'll see it's not particularly friendly to David
    - So once again, the Lord sends David encouragement in the form of a member of Saul's family
    - Jonathan travels from Gilbeah to Horesh
    - It's interesting that Jonathan located David while his father couldn't
    - We can only assume that the Lord allowed – even sent – Jonathan to find David
  - This will be the final meeting of David and Jonathan, and during this meeting Jonathan speaks words to reassure David

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        - He tells David that Saul will not find him
        - Moreover, Jonathan affirms that David will one day be king
        - And when that day happens, Jonathan will be at his side in support
        - Finally, Jonathan says his father also knows this to be true
        - Which is to say, not even Saul has confidence he can stop the plan of God, which explains his paranoia
- Consider Jonathan's words carefully and you land on several observations
    - At first, it seems as though Jonathan is speaking prophetically, as if the Lord had given him these words to speak to David concerning the future
        - But this cannot be so, since Jonathan's testimony is not entirely accurate
        - Jonathan is correct, of course, that David will take the throne one day and Saul can't stop that
        - But Jonathan is incorrect when he says he will be next to David
        - In Hebrew Jonathan literally says he will be David's double which probably means he will be David's right hand man in leading Israel
    - Jonathan seems to think he will be in David's government
        - That the house of Saul and the house of David would be united in leadership
        - But this is simply not true
        - Jonathan is going to die before David becomes king
        - More importantly, this is not the plan God has for Saul's house
        - Saul's family will have no part in the monarchy of Israel
    - So then it would seem that Jonathan is speaking in optimistic and hopeful terms yet without specific revelation from the Lord
        - Jonathan did not understand the Lord's intention to replace Saul's family with David's family
        - And he certainly didn't know of his own untimely death
        - Jonathan's words are simply a statement of faith and trust in the promises of God concerning David
        - Jonathan was speaking in agreement with the revealed word of the Lord
        - And in faith he was certain that God's word would come to pass, and on that basis he offered his encouragement to David
- This is a good example of the differences between inspired prophecy and simple encouragement
    - Jonathan had not received a specific revelation from the Lord concerning David
        - Nevertheless, he spoke with great earnestness convinced he had something to offer David
        - But sincerity isn't a substitute for accuracy nor does it guarantee that someone's word can be trusted

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        - More often they are simply presuming too much about what God intends to do
    - People still fall prey to this error today believing they have received a divine revelation when it was merely optimistic encouragement
        - If someone simply repeats previously revealed promises of God to us, this does not make them a prophet
        - Jonathan and David both knew that God had said David would be king… Jonathan was merely repeating this truth
        - But he mixed God's revealed word with his own assumptions and presented it as certain fact
    - Just because someone speaks with certainty does not ensure they speak accurately
        - The best we can say about such speech is that is a personal demonstration of faith in God's word
        - And of course it can serve as a source of encouragement
        - But as people make predictions of your future, take those words with a large dose of skepticism
- After Jonathan's words of encouragement, he and David enter into another covenant
    - There is some debate over whether this is a new covenant or the reaffirming of an existing covenant
        - While it could be a reaffirming of the original covenant of friendship, I believe this is something new
        - I believe this was a covenant to formalize Jonathan as David's right-hand man in the future government of Israel
        - David is promising to grant Jonathan this position, while Jonathan is promising to support David's rule as before
        - David might have been willing to make this covenant in response to Jonathan's willingness to take great personal risk in seeking David out in the wilderness
    - Once again they separate, and they will never meet again in this life
        - And in the end, Jonathan's death will prevent this covenant from ever being put into force
        - As Paul teaches in Romans 7, the death of one party dissolves a covenant
- Returning back to Saul, he's still seeking to locate David
    - And he's depending on a word of David's whereabouts from informers
        - We remember that earlier when David was seeking to know whether to stay in Keilah, he sought the Lord's counsel
        - But in contrast, Saul is seeking the counsel of men
        - It's telling that we never see Saul seek counsel from the Lord concerning anything he does in this situation
        - He is depending entirely on the wisdom of men
    - Moreover, he's only seeking men who will affirm his existing opinions concerning

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David

- Can you imagine what Saul might have done to someone who suggested that his pursuit of David was misguided
- To say nothing of a suggestion that Saul should step aside and allow David to have the throne
- Saul would have heard nothing of it

- Paul speaks of a similar problem in the last days, when many in the church won't listen to counsel that contradicts their preferred notions
  - And in the place of the Bible, men and women will seek for earthly wisdom
  - They will seek out teachers who say what they want to hear
  - As a result, false teaching will grow and with it, biblical ignorance

- Then Saul gets his informer

1Sam. 23:19 Then Ziphites came up to Saul at Gibeah, saying, "Is David not hiding with us in the strongholds at Horesh, on the hill of Hachilah, which is on the south of Jeshimon?
1Sam. 23:20 "Now then, O king, come down according to all the desire of your soul to do so; and our part shall be to surrender him into the king's hand."
1Sam. 23:21 Saul said, "May you be blessed of the Lord, for you have had compassion on me.
1Sam. 23:22 "Go now, make more sure, and investigate and see his place where his haunt is, and who has seen him there; for I am told that he is very cunning.
1Sam. 23:23 "So look, and learn about all the hiding places where he hides himself and return to me with certainty, and I will go with you; and if he is in the land, I will search him out among all the thousands of Judah."

- The Ziphites decide to turn in David to Saul
  - We can imagine numerous sensible reasons for them to make this decision
    - Perhaps they worried Saul would do to them what he did to the priests when he discovered they were harboring a fugitive
    - Or maybe they wanted to receive the king's favor
    - Or maybe they didn't think very well of David's band of men
  - In any case, they send representatives to Saul and tell him of David's hiding place
    - Their desire to get on Saul's good side seems to have worked
    - He says they are blessed of the Lord for this action
  - Here we see the corollary to our earlier observation about encouraging speech
    - Saul tells these people they are "blessed" for what they did
    - In reality, there would be no blessing for seeking to destroy the Lord's anointed

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        - Once again showing that just because someone uses the words doesn't mean they are speaking with the heart of God
        - God is the source of all blessing, and He blesses those who seek to please Him
        - As Jesus said:

Luke 11:28 But He said, "On the contrary, blessed are those who hear the word of God and observe it."

- Then Saul begins to scheme with the people on how to locate and trap David
    - Notice in his instructions the repetition of action verbs
        - He says "Go, make sure, investigate, see, look, learn, return…"
        - For all this activity and effort there is no thought to turn to the Lord, which is Samuel's point here
        - Saul is focused on human effort while David has been content to seek only the Lord, for that is the only counsel he has
    - Furthermore, Saul says David is cunning
        - This is not a compliment, obviously
        - It suggests a person who schemes and devises trickery to get his way
        - Yet David is the opposite of cunning
        - He's relying only on the Lord's direction
        - It's Saul who is obviously being cunning in his plans to kill David
    - He sends the people to carry out his plan and to report back with what they learn
        - Saul doesn't want another goose chase
        - And so they return

1Sam. 23:24 Then they arose and went to Ziph before Saul. Now David and his men were in the wilderness of Maon, in the Arabah to the south of Jeshimon.
1Sam. 23:25 When Saul and his men went to seek him, they told David, and he came down to the rock and stayed in the wilderness of Maon. And when Saul heard it, he pursued David in the wilderness of Maon.
1Sam. 23:26 Saul went on one side of the mountain, and David and his men on the other side of the mountain; and David was hurrying to get away from Saul, for Saul and his men were surrounding David and his men to seize them.
1Sam. 23:27 But a messenger came to Saul, saying, "Hurry and come, for the Philistines have made a raid on the land."
1Sam. 23:28 So Saul returned from pursuing David and went to meet the Philistines; therefore they called that place the Rock of Escape.
1Sam. 23:29 David went up from there and stayed in the strongholds of Engedi.

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- The men of the city return and report that David was in the wilderness of Maon, which was a few miles south of Ziph
  - So Saul departs to intercept David there
    - But sympathizers of David get word to him so he can escape Saul again
    - Unfortunately, David didn't really have somewhere to run
    - This is a wide open wilderness, such that if David took off across open land, Saul would have had no problem chasing him down
  - So instead, David and his men hide behind a large hill
    - The text says "mountain" but the word can also be used to describe a smaller hill
    - In this region there are many wadis that run up from the Dead Sea to the high cliffs on the either side
    - It's probably one of these wadis that conceals David
    - And Saul is closing in on both sides of the wadi
- But then we see the Lord move to protect David
  - A messenger comes to report that the Philistines are raiding Jewish land
    - In another clear display of God's sovereignty, Israel's enemies are put to the task of attacking Israel to distract Saul
    - The Lord directed that attack and ensured a messenger would make his way to Saul in just the right time to stop the attack on David
    - Stories like this are a real encouragement to every believer to trust in the Lord's protection
  - What was David thinking at the time? Did he assume that the Lord would automatically save him? Was he just resting assuming it would all work out?
    - No, he was praying fervently that the Lord would do something
    - We read that prayer in Psalm 54

Psa. 54:0 For the choir director; on stringed instruments. A Maskil of David, when the Ziphites came and said to Saul, "Is not David hiding himself among us?"
Psa. 54:1 Save me, O God, by Your name,
And vindicate me by Your power.
Psa. 54:2 Hear my prayer, O God;
Give ear to the words of my mouth.
Psa. 54:3 For strangers have risen against me
And violent men have sought my life;
They have not set God before them. Selah.
Psa. 54:4 Behold, God is my helper;
The Lord is the sustainer of my soul.
Psa. 54:5 He will recompense the evil to my foes;

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Destroy them in Your faithfulness.
Psa. 54:6 **Willingly I will sacrifice to You;**
I will give thanks to Your name, O Lord, for it is good.
Psa. 54:7 **For He has delivered me from all trouble,**
And my eye has looked with satisfaction upon my enemies.

- Notice in that Psalm David's tone seems to shift
  - At first he's sounding fearful and desperate
  - And then it turns to thankfulness
  - It seems like the prayer was changing even as the Lord was answering
- The result is an escape for David and a new hiding place in Engedi, a wadi near present-day Masada
  - The Engedi wadi has a fresh supply of water from a flowing spring
    - It still flows today
    - Tourists can walk up and stand in the same waterfalls that David and his men would have found refreshing
  - Perhaps David was here in this partial cave of Engedi when he wrote Psalm 57

Psa. 57:0 **For the choir director; set to Al-tashheth. A Mikhtam of David, when he fled from Saul in the cave.**
Psa. 57:1 **Be gracious to me, O God, be gracious to me,**
For my soul takes refuge in You;
And in the shadow of Your wings I will take refuge
Until destruction passes by.
Psa. 57:2 **I will cry to God Most High,**
To God who accomplishes all things for me.
Psa. 57:3 **He will send from heaven and save me;**
He reproaches him who tramples upon me. Selah.
God will send forth His lovingkindness and His truth.
Psa. 57:4 **My soul is among lions;**
I must lie among those who breathe forth fire,
Even the sons of men, whose teeth are spears and arrows
And their tongue a sharp sword.
Psa. 57:5 **Be exalted above the heavens, O God;**
Let Your glory be above all the earth.
Psa. 57:6 **They have prepared a net for my steps;**
My soul is bowed down;
They dug a pit before me;
They themselves have fallen into the midst of it. Selah.
Psa. 57:7 **My heart is steadfast, O God, my heart is steadfast;**

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I will sing, yes, I will sing praises!
Psa. 57:8 **Awake, my glory!**
Awake, harp and lyre!
I will awaken the dawn.
Psa. 57:9 **I will give thanks to You, O Lord, among the peoples;**
I will sing praises to You among the nations.
Psa. 57:10 **For Your lovingkindness is great to the heavens**
And Your truth to the clouds.
Psa. 57:11 **Be exalted above the heavens, O God;**
Let Your glory be above all the earth.

- As we now move into Chapter 24, we begin a three chapter story of David's spiritual growth
  - You may remember I said that David's flight would be a time when the Lord schooled him on righteousness
    - The time David spent in the wilderness fleeing Saul would expose David to many trials
    - And as David contended with these situations, he grew to rely more and more on the Lord, which was the purpose
  - In Chapter 24, David will have opportunity to kill Saul
    - He will refrain from doing so, yet he still commits a sin against the Lord's anointed
    - Afterward, David will sense the conviction of the Holy Spirit
    - Then in the next chapter, the Lord will put David in a similar situation again though this time with a different antagonist
    - As David moves to sin again, the Lord will bring godly counsel to David through an unlikely source
    - David will learn his lesson and repent
  - Then in Chapter 26, the Lord will once more put David in a position to kill Saul
    - David spears Saul's life again
    - But this time he also refuses to dishonor the Lord's anointed
    - Leading the Lord to take vengeance on behalf of David, which was the lesson the Lord was trying to teach David
- So let's study the first chapter of this three-part drama

1Sam. 24:1 **Now when Saul returned from pursuing the Philistines, he was told, saying, "Behold, David is in the wilderness of Engedi."**
1Sam. 24:2 **Then Saul took three thousand chosen men from all Israel and went to seek David and his men in front of the Rocks of the Wild Goats.**

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1Sam. 24:3 He came to the sheepfolds on the way, where there was a cave; and Saul went in to relieve himself. Now David and his men were sitting in the inner recesses of the cave.
1Sam. 24:4 The men of David said to him, "Behold, this is the day of which the Lord said to you, 'Behold; I am about to give your enemy into your hand, and you shall do to him as it seems good to you.'" Then David arose and cut off the edge of Saul's robe secretly.
1Sam. 24:5 It came about afterward that David's conscience bothered him because he had cut off the edge of Saul's robe.
1Sam. 24:6 So he said to his men, "Far be it from me because of the Lord that I should do this thing to my lord, the Lord's anointed, to stretch out my hand against him, since he is the Lord's anointed."
1Sam. 24:7 David persuaded his men with these words and did not allow them to rise up against Saul. And Saul arose, left the cave, and went on his way.

- Engedi is a narrow canyon that moves up from the desert floor of the Dead Sea to the mountain range on the West
  - It is rocky and difficult to traverse as you wind through the canyon
    - Running down the wadi is a stream created by a spring at the mountain
    - Along either side of this canyon are caves of various sizes worn out of the limestone hills
    - And mountain goats can be seen throughout this region even to this day
  - Saul has come here with three thousand men to find and kill David
    - This gives Saul a considerable advantage in numbers if not skill
    - David and his men are essentially trapped in this wadi
    - So David decides to hide in one of the caves used as sheepfold along the side
  - As it turns out, Saul decides to enter one of these caves to relieve himself as we're told
    - He just happens to select the very cave David and some of his men are occupying
    - They had hoped Saul would have moved up the wadi, discovered no one waiting and retreated without searching every cave
    - Instead, they are staring at back of the king in the dark
- David's men see their opportunity and counsel David that this was a day the Lord gave him to destroy his adversary
  - They are encouraging David to rise up and kill the king and be done with this trial
    - And they tell David these circumstances were orchestrated by the Lord for that purpose
    - Here again we see someone speaking falsely yet as if with godly insight

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        - In reality they are projecting their own desires upon God and interpreting their circumstances to their own benefit
    - The truth is the Lord placed Saul in that cave for David but these circumstances were intended as a test of David's trust in the Lord
        - It was not to be an opportunity for David to rebel against the Lord's anointed
        - Would David do the right thing by resisting his desire to take matters into his own hands?
        - And to make matters worse, his men are encouraging him to go down the wrong path
    - In response to their suggestion, David declined to take Saul's life
        - He understood that Saul was the Lord's anointed and therefore, he did not kill the king
        - Nevertheless, he wanted to send Saul a message about what might have happened
        - Saul's robe would have been removed and set aside so that he could attend to his business
        - While that robe was lying on the floor of the cave, David cuts a piece of the hem off
    - In the ancient East the hem of a robe held special significance
        - We may remember how the woman following Jesus touched the hem of his garment and was healed
        - The hem was a symbol for the social standing of the person, which is why Pharisees decorated their hems in ornate ways
        - In the case of a king, his hem would have been particularly special and symbolic
        - So cutting it off represented cutting off the king's rule and authority
- David's choice seemed like a smart play under these circumstances
    - I'm sure he felt he was demonstrating admirable restraint yet he succeeded in sending a message to Saul
        - But this was just his pride
        - David failed the Lord's test
        - And immediately the Spirit of the Lord brought David conviction
    - Though David took a measured step against Saul, the problem was he was still attacking rather than depending on the Lord
        - The degree of offense doesn't matter
        - That's something we tell ourselves to feel better about our sin
        - "I could have killed Saul, but I only cut off his robe…"
        - "I could have robbed a bank, but I only kept the extra change I received at the cash register"

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- But from God's point of view, sin is sin
  - The Lord set up this circumstance so that David would discipline his flesh to do the right thing
  - But David listened to the voice of his men rather than seeking the voice of the Lord, as he had been doing
- Having been convicted of his sin, David confesses it to his men
  - His act of cutting the hem was a moment of rebellion against the Lord's anointed, however minor it might have been
  - And in that moment, David lowered himself to Saul's level
  - Up to this point David has been blameless
  - But now he has sinned against the king and could justly be condemned for his offense
- This change of heart causes David to become Saul's protector
  - Now he knows he must not permit his anger at Saul turn to sin against him
  - Let Saul do as Saul will, but David must remain obedient to the Lord
  - The Lord brought Saul near David to test David's heart of obedience
  - David failed the test because he tried to take matters into his own hands

- Having confessed his sin to himself and to his men, it now stands for David to confess his sin to the one he offended, Saul

1Sam. 24:8 **Now afterward David arose and went out of the cave and called after Saul, saying, "My lord the king!" And when Saul looked behind him, David bowed with his face to the ground and prostrated himself.**
1Sam. 24:9 **David said to Saul, "Why do you listen to the words of men, saying, 'Behold, David seeks to harm you'?**
1Sam. 24:10 **"Behold, this day your eyes have seen that the Lord had given you today into my hand in the cave, and some said to kill you, but my eye had pity on you; and I said, 'I will not stretch out my hand against my lord, for he is the Lord's anointed.'**
1Sam. 24:11 **"Now, my father, see! Indeed, see the edge of your robe in my hand! For in that I cut off the edge of your robe and did not kill you, know and perceive that there is no evil or rebellion in my hands, and I have not sinned against you, though you are lying in wait for my life to take it.**
1Sam. 24:12 **"May the Lord judge between you and me, and may the Lord avenge me on you; but my hand shall not be against you.**
1Sam. 24:13 **"As the proverb of the ancients says, 'Out of the wicked comes forth wickedness'; but my hand shall not be against you.**
1Sam. 24:14 **"After whom has the king of Israel come out? Whom are you pursuing? A dead dog, a single flea?**
1Sam. 24:15 **"The Lord therefore be judge and decide between you and me; and**

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may He see and plead my cause and deliver me from your hand."

- After Saul has returned to his army in the bottom of the wadi, David stands at the mouth of the cave on the side of the mountain and puts himself in God's hand
  - He calls out to the king and professes his faithfulness to his authority
    - He bows and lies prostrate in a sign of submission to the king
    - Obviously, little prevented the king and his men from charging up the cliffside to attack David
    - David is trusting the Lord in whatever happened
    - His attitude is that if it were the Lord's will that Saul defeat David here and now as punishment for David's offense, then so be it
    - For David, the Lord's will be done
  - Nevertheless, David hopes to turn the king's heart with a passionate argument combined with a little shock
    - He begins by telling Saul that he has been mislead to think David is his enemy
    - David is no threat
    - He will respect Saul's leadership as king until the day Saul dies
  - And to prove his argument, David holds up the piece of Saul's hem as evidence he will not harm Saul
    - Obviously, anyone who could cut his robe could have killed Saul with a single blow
    - So the hem is proof that David didn't intend to kill Saul
  - Ironically, the hem was a small symbol of rebellion, however
    - The Lord installed Saul and it was the Lord alone who had the right to remove Saul in the day the Lord chose
    - For David to accelerate that plan was sin
- David needed to learn that he must wait on the Lord to avenge David's enemies
  - Whatever happened in the meantime was a part of God's plan to train David
    - David is learning this lesson through these circumstances
    - Notice in v.12 David asks the Lord to judge between him and Saul
    - David promises he will not take matters into his own hands
    - Because out of wickedness comes only wickedness
    - The more we sin – even in cases where we think we're doing some good – will eventually produce more sin
  - Instead, David is saying he's so sure of his innocence in this matter, he will willingly submit himself to God's judgment
    - He won't fight his own battle

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        - He won't oppose Saul
        - He will let the Lord judge his sin and Saul's sin
        - We'll see who the Lord favors…Daivd has confidence that he's on the right side of the matter
- David ends his argument highlighting how disproportionate Saul's anger is in light of David's degree of threat
    - David compares himself to a dead dog, a flea
        - How much threat are such things to a king?
        - Yet here's Saul with 3,000 of his best men trying to eradicate a flea
    - David's statements are well-reasoned and demonstrate a degree of repentance for his mistake in cutting the hem
        - But when you fail a test, the Lord will make you retake the exam
        - So David must see this circumstances once more before the Lord grants him a respite from the oppression of Saul
        - For now, the Lord will grant David temporary relief

1Sam. 24:16 When David had finished speaking these words to Saul, Saul said, "Is this your voice, my son David?" Then Saul lifted up his voice and wept.
1Sam. 24:17 He said to David, "You are more righteous than I; for you have dealt well with me, while I have dealt wickedly with you.
1Sam. 24:18 "You have declared today that you have done good to me, that the Lord delivered me into your hand and yet you did not kill me.
1Sam. 24:19 "For if a man finds his enemy, will he let him go away safely? May the Lord therefore reward you with good in return for what you have done to me this day.
1Sam. 24:20 "Now, behold, I know that you will surely be king, and that the kingdom of Israel will be established in your hand.
1Sam. 24:21 "So now swear to me by the Lord that you will not cut off my descendants after me and that you will not destroy my name from my father's household."
1Sam. 24:22 David swore to Saul. And Saul went to his home, but David and his men went up to the stronghold.

- Saul responds to David with a disingenuous reply calling him "my son"
    - Saul's weeping is probably a mixture of relief and personal conviction
        - It's hard to tell at this point in Saul's life how much he is hearing from his conscience
        - Certainly, the Lord has provoked him into this chase, as we've already seen
        - And that provocation was intended to produce good outcomes in David's life

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- Still, many wonder about what lies in the heart of this man at this point
  - He's certainly been deceived and is paranoid
  - But he still appears to have some sense of right and wrong at least in moments like this
  - Which is proof that he hasn't completely lost touch
- Like David, Saul recognizes that the Lord has been in control of everything that's happening
  - This is the primary effect of confession and repentance
  - While it mends relationships and softens rebellion, the primary outcome is a recognition of God's sovereign will
  - We come to see that our will has been in conflict with the Lord
  - Moreover, we come to appreciate that our present negative circumstances are the result of the Lord pressing upon us
- That's Saul's feeling here…he recognizes that his moment in the cave was God getting his attention
  - And David, whom Saul counts as his enemy, did something unexpected in saving his life
  - From the shock of that revelation, Saul enters into a moment of clarity and transparency
  - He declares that David will one day be king after all
  - And he asks, much like Jonathan, that his descendants not be cut off
  - David agrees because he has already made a covenant with Jonathan to that effect

- With that Saul departs, but neither man expects this to be the end of the conflict
  - For all that I've observed about Saul's demeanor, don't fall for his crocodile tears too quickly
    - Although Saul felt some regret at pursuing David, more likely he's just saving face among his men
    - His enemy had a perfect chance to kill him but chose to show mercy
    - Under those circumstances, Saul would have appeared to lack honor had he then attacked David
    - So Saul has no honorable choice but to retreat under these circumstances
    - Therefore, both men know that there will be another day to come
  - Meanwhile the first part of our three part story has come to an end
    - Since David failed his test to honor the Lord's anointed, the Lord will give David a second chance to pass it
    - But before that, the Lord is going to show David what honoring an evil man truly looks like

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- And he's going to deliver that message with an exceptionally godly and humble servant

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- Today we move to the second chapter of the three-part account of David's spiritual growth
  - In Chapter 24, David had opportunity to kill Saul
    - Though he refrained from doing so, David still committed a sin against the Lord's anointed when he cut off the hem of Saul's robe
    - Afterward David felt the conviction of the Holy Spirit, so he repented, confessed to his men and to Saul, and he pledged to protect Saul
    - David even promised to protect Saul's descendants and reputation when he assumed the throne
  - But this was still a failure on David's part, so the Lord wants to teach David about depending upon the Lord rather than taking matters into his own hands
    - Which brings us to Chapter 25
    - Because the Lord loves David and has great plans for him, the Lord is going to place David in a set of circumstances to test his heart and develop his trust
    - The Lord will expose David's weakness, his tendency to take matters into his own hand much like Saul
    - And the Lord uses a most unlikely hero to accomplish this work
- So let's move into the second act of our three-act play

1Sam. 25:1 **Then Samuel died; and all Israel gathered together and mourned for him, and buried him at his house in Ramah. And David arose and went down to the wilderness of Paran.**

- Act 2 begins with the death of Samuel
  - Since this book and its sequel are named after Samuel, we naturally ask who was writing the book at this point in the narrative?
    - General opinion views Samuel as the author of at least chapters 1-24 of 1 Samuel
    - But other writer(s) must have completed the rest of the books later
    - The Jewish Talmud credits Nathan and Gad with finishing 1 & 2 Samuel, in which case Gad would have a book in scripture after all
  - The Lord raised up Samuel to bless Israel all the days of his life, as we learned earlier
    - Considering the evil behavior of Eli and Saul, it's fair to say that Samuel was the only bright spot among leadership in Israel
    - Were it not for Samuel the nation would have been without any godly leadership during this time
    - But now this man is gone, so where will godly leadership come from?
  - Obviously, David becomes the next man to serve God in this way for the sake of Israel

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        - And that's why Samuel's death features prominently in the text at this point
        - It emphasizes that it's time for David to assume the place of godly protector of the people
        - And he still has some things to learn before he's ready to assume this responsibility
- The timing of Samuel's death raises an interesting possibility
    - Samuel ruled as Israel's only judge after Eli's death
        - So Samuel was Israel's judge for 12 years until Saul became king
        - And then Samuel continued as judge in contrast to Saul's evil rule for the next 18 years
        - This means that Samuel was the righteous judge over Israel for 30 years, a number that indicates God's sovereignty
    - So if God intended Samuel to rule for thirty years and then David would assume the role of righteous leader over Israel, what about Saul?
        - Perhaps the Lord is showing us what could have been for Israel?
        - Had the nation not demanded a king prematurely, perhaps the lord would have raised up David at the point of Samuel's death
        - Instead, the nation brought Saul into power delaying David's arrival and creating great suffering for the people in the meantime
    - If so, then perhaps this serves as another picture of Jesus' first and second coming to Earth
        - Jesus is pictured by David according to scripture
        - And when Jesus came to bring the kingdom to Israel the first time, He was rejected because the people had a different kind of king in mind
        - Just as Israel rejected God's appointed leader, Samuel, in favor of Saul who looked the part
        - This rejection created a delay and suffering for the people
        - Only after a delay will the people of Israel eventually receive their Messiah
- It's unlikely David attended Samuel's burial at Ramah, since Saul would have been there too
    - Instead, David retreats into the desert of the Sinai, called Paran
        - While he's there, we must expect he was depressed and worried
        - The one man who could check Saul's power was now gone
        - Yet David is still on the run and living under difficult circumstances
    - But then things begin to look up just a little

1Sam. 25:2 **Now there was a man in Maon whose business was in Carmel; and the man was very rich, and he had three thousand sheep and a thousand goats. And**

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it came about while he was shearing his sheep in Carmel
1Sam. 25:3 **(now the man's name was Nabal, and his wife's name was Abigail. And the woman was intelligent and beautiful in appearance, but the man was harsh and evil in his dealings, and he was a Calebite),**
1Sam. 25:4 **that David heard in the wilderness that Nabal was shearing his sheep.**

- The writer introduces us to a man living in Maon named Nabal who possessed a large sheep herding business in nearby Carmel (not the same the Carmel of 1 Kings 18)
  - Maon and Carmel are only about 15 miles due west of Engedi, which has been David's homebase of late
    - Nabal's name means fool, and it's a prophetic reflection of his character
    - Scripture defines a "fool" as someone who does not give regard to God
  - Despite his foolishness, Nabal is very rich, possessing huge flocks of sheep and goats
    - The reason for his success is explained by his heritage: he is a Calebite
    - Caleb along with Joshua were the faithful members of the scouting party who first entered the Promised Land
    - As a result, Caleb was awarded a large track of land near Hebron
    - And his decedents were blessed with the riches of the land
- The writer reports Nabal has 3,000 sheep and 1,000 goats
  - Besides indicating Nabal's wealth, the number of his sheep is important for another reason
    - If you look back to the beginning of this three-chapter story, you find Saul sending three thousand men to capture David
    - At that time David failed the Lord's test of obedience when he took matters into his own hands by cutting Saul's robe
    - So we said God was going to make David take this test again
  - Then in Chapter 26, David gets a second opportunity to pass the Lord's test
    - In that third part of this story, Saul is seeking David's life again
    - And once again, Saul will come with three thousand men
  - And between those two chapters we have this story of Nabal, a man who possesses 3,000 sheep
    - So in each chapter we have the number three thousand featured prominently
    - The author wants us to understand that the events of this chapter are connected with the other two
    - Nabal is a proxy for Saul
    - In fact, we will see numerous narrative analogies between this story and the story of Saul and David
    - These connections help us recognize how the Lord uses this experience to teach

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David

- Nabal's wife, Abigail, is a striking contrast to her husband
  - Abigail is a beautiful and intelligent while her husband was apparently not
    - She was also kind and generous and most important, godly
    - While Nabal is harsh, ungodly, foolish and without a concern for the will or presence of God
    - Abigail's name is even a contrast of Nabal, since it means my father rejoicing
  - So Nabal is Saul's counterpart in this story, and his wife is a counterpart to David
    - And therefore, she serves as an example of how a godly servant of God responds to an ungodly superior
    - David failed this challenge in Chapter 24
    - And it's the lesson David needs to pass in Chapter 26
- So after Samuel's death, David hears that Nabal is shearing his sheep
  - This event is newsworthy because of Nabal's wealth
    - The person who owns 4,000 grazing animals was the Bill Gates of his day
    - A man with that many animals needed a tremendous range of land for grazing so many animals in such an arid climate
  - Since Carmel was only 15 mile west of Engedi, we know that Nabal's shepherds would have crossed paths with David and his men from time to time
    - Therefore David would have been aware of Nabal's wealth
    - So when David hears that it's shearing season, he takes note
    - He believes this is his opportunity to gain some much-needed relief for him and his men
  - Shearing time was the point in the year when sheep were brought into the pens and the wool was shaved off
    - The shearing took place over a number of days or weeks depending on the size of the flock
    - And sheep shearing was a time of celebration because this was the moment the master cashed in his crop
  - So after each day of shearing, the laborers would share in the master's reward with a feast each evening
    - There was plenty of food and drink available for everyone
    - And David believes he and his men have a right to share in this celebration
- So he sends messengers to Nabal to explain why he believes he has earned the right to join the feast celebration

1Sam. 25:5 **So David sent ten young men; and David said to the young men, "Go up to Carmel, visit Nabal and greet him in my name;**

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1Sam. 25:6 and thus you shall say, 'Have a long life, peace be to you, and peace be to your house, and peace be to all that you have.
1Sam. 25:7 'Now I have heard that you have shearers; now your shepherds have been with us and we have not insulted them, nor have they missed anything all the days they were in Carmel.
1Sam. 25:8 'Ask your young men and they will tell you. Therefore let my young men find favor in your eyes, for we have come on a festive day. Please give whatever you find at hand to your servants and to your son David.'"

- First, David tells his men to greet Nabal by name
  - This was a sign of respect and recognition
    - David wanted to communicate to Nabal that they were not strangers but rather associated together
    - Also notice in v.8 that David refers to himself as Nabal's "son"
    - This indicated that David placed himself in a position of service or submission to Nabal
    - Here again is another comparison to Saul, who called David "my son"
  - Secondly, David tells his men to declare a blessing upon Nabal and his house and all that Nabal possessed
    - This statement made clear David was not Nabal's enemy or a competitor in the land
    - On the contrary, David's desire was to see Nabal strengthened and prosperous
- Then having heard of the shearing David reminds Nabal of what his men did to support Nabal's operation
  - As Nabal's shepherds led their flocks in the wilderness, David's men protected them
    - David's men showed Nabal's shepherds respect and allowed them to graze
    - More than that, David says Nabal's shepherds lost not a single sheep during this time
  - This is a remarkable thing
    - David isn't saying that they never stole any of Nabal's sheep, because that wouldn't be a basis for reward
    - In fact, that would have been a threat of extortion (i.e., "pay me or something might happen to your sheep")
  - Rather, David is saying that his men prevented a loss
    - Not a single sheep was taken by wild animals or thieves
    - Even the occasional sheep that wandered off was returned safe
    - Under normal circumstances a flock of 3,000 sheep would have experienced at least a few losses over the year

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        - But David's men had acted as a personal protection army for Nabal's sheep
    - Therefore, David has come to claim his reward for that effort
        - He's not asking for charity
        - He's expecting to be paid for his services in protecting Nabal's flock
        - And therefore, Nabal is obligated by honor to do the right thing in response to David's request
        - David played a part in ensuring the success of Nabal's business and that hard work is worthy of compensation
- David is even making a specific demand beyond the opportunity to participate in the evening feasts that all workers enjoyed
    - This would have been a great source of joy and encouragement to David's men, who probably haven't enjoyed a real meal in some time
        - But when Nabal receives this reasonable request, he behaves in a most unreasonable way

1Sam. 25:9 When David's young men came, they spoke to Nabal according to all these words in David's name; then they waited.
1Sam. 25:10 But Nabal answered David's servants and said, "Who is David? And who is the son of Jesse? There are many servants today who are each breaking away from his master.
1Sam. 25:11 "Shall I then take my bread and my water and my meat that I have slaughtered for my shearers, and give it to men whose origin I do not know?"

- David's men approach Nabal expecting a proper answer
    - But Nabal surprised them with his dishonorable answer
        - First, he rebuffs David's attempt to recognize an existing relationship
        - While David has his men call Nabal by name, Nabal asks who is David?
        - In other words, he is saying on what basis do I have to trust David?
    - Furthermore, he asks who is the son of Jesse?
        - Nabal goes a step farther and questions David's right to have even the throne of Israel
        - By this point everyone in Israel knew that Samuel had anointed the son of Jesse as the next king of Israel
        - Yet Nabal has the gall to suggest that David's claim to the throne was not legitimate
        - This too is similar to the way Saul refused to acknowledge that David had a legitimate claim to the throne of Israel
    - And then Nabal's proposed his own reason for why Saul was pursuing David
        - Nabal says many servants are breaking away from their masters

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        - Nabal suggests David had selfish reasons to challenge Saul's rule and therefore David was to blame for his circumstances
    - Finally, Nabal asks why he should take his wealth and hand it out to men he doesn't know?
        - Nabal is denying David's men have earned compensation
        - He's indicating they are seeking charity

1Sam. 25:12 So David's young men retraced their way and went back; and they came and told him according to all these words.
1Sam. 25:13 David said to his men, "Each of you gird on his sword." So each man girded on his sword. And David also girded on his sword, and about four hundred men went up behind David while two hundred stayed with the baggage.

- David responds to Nabal's rebuff by preparing to defend his honor and the honor of his men by killing Nabal and all his household
    - On the one hand, David's response is not surprising given the expectations of the day
        - When a man was dishonored in this way, he would typically be expected to avenge his honor
        - Death was the usual penalty and the culture would have likely let the judgment stand
    - On the other hand, God has made it clear to David not to resist evil in his own power
        - Instead, David is supposed to depend on the Lord for vengeance
        - This was the mistake he made in assaulting Saul in the cave
        - Now here again David is challenged by a foolish man, and once again he's preparing to take matters into his own hands
- So David travels the 15 miles or so back to Nabal that very night to kill Nabal and his household
    - We can see David operating in his pride and anger
        - He doesn't pause long enough to even seek the Lord's counsel
        - If he had, then he would have received different direction
    - David wasn't the only one to be shocked by Nabal's answer
        - Nabal's shepherds learned of Nabal's response, so now they are seriously concerned

1Sam. 25:14 But one of the young men told Abigail, Nabal's wife, saying, "Behold, David sent messengers from the wilderness to greet our master, and he scorned them.

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1Sam. 25:15 **"Yet the men were very good to us, and we were not insulted, nor did we miss anything as long as we went about with them, while we were in the fields.**
1Sam. 25:16 **"They were a wall to us both by night and by day, all the time we were with them tending the sheep.**
1Sam. 25:17 **"Now therefore, know and consider what you should do, for evil is plotted against our master and against all his household; and he is such a worthless man that no one can speak to him."**

- Nabal's shepherds rush to Abigail and inform her that Nabal has scorned David
  - They confirm for us they had good reason to expect an attack from David's men
    - The servants also seemed to understand that Abigail was a person they could reason with under these circumstances
    - They explain to her that David's men had done the right thing by Nabal
    - Notice in v.16 they report that David's men even took turns guarding the flock at night when it was most vulnerable
    - Essentially, David's men were working as shepherds for Nabal for free, so they deserved pay
  - But notice also in v.17 they say "evil" is preparing an attack
    - They expect David's anticipated revenge
    - They called David's actions good in one case but evil in another
    - David was good to help the shepherds but he is about to commit evil if he prosecutes this attack
    - Seven times in this chapter the words good and evil are paired, indicating that this contrast is a focus of the chapter
- So after hearing the report, Abigail springs into action to save her husband

1Sam. 25:18 **Then Abigail hurried and took two hundred loaves of bread and two jugs of wine and five sheep already prepared and five measures of roasted grain and a hundred clusters of raisins and two hundred cakes of figs, and loaded them on donkeys.**
1Sam. 25:19 **She said to her young men, "Go on before me; behold, I am coming after you." But she did not tell her husband Nabal.**
1Sam. 25:20 **It came about as she was riding on her donkey and coming down by the hidden part of the mountain, that behold, David and his men were coming down toward her; so she met them.**
1Sam. 25:21 **Now David had said, "Surely in vain I have guarded all that this man has in the wilderness, so that nothing was missed of all that belonged to him; and he has returned me evil for good.**
1Sam. 25:22 **"May God do so to the enemies of David, and more also, if by morning**

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I leave as much as one male of any who belong to him."

- She grabs two hundred loaves of bread and jugs of wine and large quantities of grain, raisins, and cakes of figs
  - These materials were available because they had likely been prepared for the nightly shearing feasts
    - So Abigail is simply bringing David's men exactly what they requested
    - Though she isn't bringing enough for all of David's men
    - Instead she's bringing the most she could carry on her donkey
  - To get a sense of this woman's bravery, imagine a solitary woman riding a donkey laden with valuable goods headed into a desert alone to face an approaching army of bloodthirsty men
    - She was placing herself entirely at David's mercy
    - There was at least an equal chance she might have been killed or worse
  - Why doesn't she send a servant in her place?
    - Because in doing so she would likely have condemned that servant to death one way or another
    - If David didn't kill the servant, Nabal would certainly have disciplined any servant who gave away his possessions without permission
    - But the wife had authority in the house to act in this way
    - Therefore, she was the only one who could survive the consequences
- Before she meets David, the writer shows us what was in David's heart according to David's own words
  - He is fuming at Nabal
    - David declares that he has been wronged by Nabal, which is true
    - David took good care of Nabal, and Nabal returned the favor by dishonoring David
  - Then David declares that should he fail to kill every male in Nabal's household, then may the Lord complete the task for him
    - In other words, David suggests he will be doing the Lord's work as he vanquishes Nabal's household
    - David's words aren't prophetic, obviously
    - David is acting in the flesh but assuming God was on his side
    - In fact, he sounds a little like Saul, thinking that what he wanted was automatically what God wanted
  - This entire situation is very similar to one David has been facing for some time
    - David worked hard in support of Saul
    - He defended Saul's army and respected Saul's authority

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        - He simply expected Saul to show David the proper respect in return
        - Instead, Saul was evil and unjust against David
        - Nevertheless, the Lord didn't permit David to raise his hand against the anointed king of Israel
    - Clearly, David didn't learn the lesson God was trying to teach him in Chapter 24
        - David was supposed to rely on the Lord to protect and defend him
        - Only the Spirit's conviction led David away from making an even worse mistake
        - Now he's about to repeat that mistake
- So this conflict with Nabal becomes an opportunity for the Lord to teach David the correct way he should respond to those who oppose him
    - And the Lord chose an unlikely and humbling hero to make His point

1Sam. 25:23 **When Abigail saw David, she hurried and dismounted from her donkey, and fell on her face before David and bowed herself to the ground.**
1Sam. 25:24 **She fell at his feet and said, "On me alone, my lord, be the blame. And please let your maidservant speak to you, and listen to the words of your maidservant.**
1Sam. 25:25 **"Please do not let my lord pay attention to this worthless man, Nabal, for as his name is, so is he. Nabal is his name and folly is with him; but I your maidservant did not see the young men of my lord whom you sent.**
1Sam. 25:26 **"Now therefore, my lord, as the Lord lives, and as your soul lives, since the Lord has restrained you from shedding blood, and from avenging yourself by your own hand, now then let your enemies and those who seek evil against my lord, be as Nabal.**
1Sam. 25:27 **"Now let this gift which your maidservant has brought to my lord be given to the young men who accompany my lord.**
1Sam. 25:28 **"Please forgive the transgression of your maidservant; for the Lord will certainly make for my lord an enduring house, because my lord is fighting the battles of the Lord, and evil will not be found in you all your days.**
1Sam. 25:29 **"Should anyone rise up to pursue you and to seek your life, then the life of my lord shall be bound in the bundle of the living with the Lord your God; but the lives of your enemies He will sling out as from the hollow of a sling.**
1Sam. 25:30 **"And when the Lord does for my lord according to all the good that He has spoken concerning you, and appoints you ruler over Israel,**
1Sam. 25:31 **this will not cause grief or a troubled heart to my lord, both by having shed blood without cause and by my lord having avenged himself. When the Lord deals well with my lord, then remember your maidservant."**

- As Abigail approaches David, she bows and immediately places all the blame on herself
    - She isn't suggesting that she is responsible for what happened

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        - David knows she had nothing to do with the situation
        - Rather, she's asking that David transfer her husband's blame upon her
        - She says had she known David's men had come, she would have stepped in earlier to ensure they received what they deserved
        - So now she is working to make things right after her husband ruined the situation
    - Abigail forms a distant picture of Christ by her behavior
        - She is riding a donkey as Jesus did when he entered Jerusalem
        - She is giving herself up freely to her enemies as Jesus did with the Romans
        - She was innocent but nevertheless she assumes the blame for a guilty party
        - She offers payment for the sins of the foolish, those who do not acknowledge God
- Abigail asks David to pay no attention to her husband, whom she calls worthless and worthy of his name
    - Obviously, Abigail knows her husband well
        - She testifies to David that his behavior in this matter is characteristic of his nature overall
        - As his name indicates, he is a fool, so therefore he acts like one
        - She's saying he couldn't help himself
        - Therefore, she asks David to overlook her husband's mistake
    - Perhaps at this point, we begin to wonder if Abigail has crossed the line in her behavior as Nabal's wife?
        - Can a godly wife say such things about her husband and still honor him?
        - Shouldn't she be more supportive of her husband?
        - Or at the very least, shouldn't she remain silent and refrain from insulting him publicly?
        - And what about her decision to bring the food to David…isn't that disobeying her husband's wishes?
- If we focus only on these details, we will draw the wrong conclusion about Abigail's actions and judge her unfairly
    - Consider the entire set of circumstances and take note of Abigail's desires concerning her husband
        - In Genesis 2 the Bible says a wife is to be a helper to her husband because she is one flesh with him
        - Under these circumstances preserving her husband's honor isn't the highest priority
    - Ladies, imagine a situation where a robber breaks into your home at night, ties up your husband and points a gun at his head

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        - The robber demands your husband give up the keys to his new sports car but your husband stubbornly refuses
        - Now you know where he keeps his keys
        - And you know your foolish husband is about to die if you don't act quickly to save him.
    - So what do you do? How do you honor him?
        - Some wives might reply, "I would keep quiet, collect his life insurance and buy another sports car…"
        - Obviously, the most honoring thing to do under those circumstances is to act in your husband's best interests by giving up the keys to save his life
        - You haven't directly disobeyed his instructions
        - You're just acting to compensate for his foolishness, which is in keeping with your role as helper
    - This is what Abigail is doing
        - Abigail's first concern must be saving Nabal's life from David and his men
        - And if Abigail hadn't taken this extreme course of action, Nabal's own foolishness would have resulted in his destruction
        - And she might have died as well
    - Furthermore, Abigail isn't violating any specific order from her husband
        - Her husband never forbade Abigail from acting
        - In fact, she didn't even talk to Nabal before going on this mission
        - Obviously, she probably suspected he would stop her if he knew
        - But here again, she was acting shrewdly to compensate for his foolishness
- As she appeals to David's mercy, Abigail wisely invokes David's relationship to the Lord
    - In fact, throughout this important speech Abigail frequently refers to David's relationship with the Lord
        - She acknowledges the Lord's anointing of David as the future king
        - She affirms that the Lord will always defend David
    - Then she wisely asks David to consider how he will feel once he becomes king should he go through with his plan?
        - How will he feel when he remembers that he wrongly took the lives of an entire household because of one man's foolishness?
        - Especially since David already knows the Lord will defend David from all enemies without requiring he sin in this way
        - Won't David be ashamed?
        - Won't he view his actions were unnecessary?
    - It's easy to see the Lord speaking through Abigail directly to David's heart

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        - She skillfully speaks to David's conscience by pointing him back to his relationship with the Lord
        - This was the lesson the Lord wanted David to understand
        - In Chapter 24, David took a step of revenge in defense of himself against a foolish man, Saul
        - Here he was ready to do the same again
        - So the Lord sends a woman to teach David what he already knew
        - And to stop David from sinning against the Lord
    - Finally, Abigail knew her audience well, because in v.29 she used a metaphor especially appealing to shepherds
        - Shepherds carried two bundles while tending the sheep
        - One bundle held the food that would sustain the shepherd's life while out with the sheep
        - The second bundle were stones used with a sling to fend off thieves and wild animals
        - She reminds David that his life is assured because he is bound with the Lord
        - While David's enemies are like stones to be flung away by a sling
- David hears Abigail and his heart is touched by her appeal

1Sam. 25:32 **Then David said to Abigail, "Blessed be the Lord God of Israel, who sent you this day to meet me,**
1Sam. 25:33 **and blessed be your discernment, and blessed be you, who have kept me this day from bloodshed and from avenging myself by my own hand.**
1Sam. 25:34 **"Nevertheless, as the Lord God of Israel lives, who has restrained me from harming you, unless you had come quickly to meet me, surely there would not have been left to Nabal until the morning light as much as one male."**
1Sam. 25:35 **So David received from her hand what she had brought him and said to her, "Go up to your house in peace. See, I have listened to you and granted your request."**

- First, David recognizes that Abigail was sent by the Lord for his sake
    - This is the first step in recognizing the discipline of the Lord in our own lives
        - When the Lord disciplines his children, the Bible says He does so for our good
        - And that discipline usually comes through other people
        - Most often through our spouse
        - But other times through our children or friends or even a stranger like Abigail
        - Obviously, not every critique we receive is from the Lord or even appropriate
    - But when someone offers criticism or makes a suggestion or maybe they merely

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model righteousness before us and we experience conviction, we'll know it's the Lord

- What happens next will determine whether we'll learn the lesson
- Do we react defensively, do we make excuses, do we run away?
- Then we missed the chance to recognize the Lord sent us a messenger to correct our heart
- For his part, David immediately knew this woman was speaking with the heart of God
- So David received her as from the Lord

- Next David blessed Abigail for her discernment and her bravery for stepping into a dangerous situation to stop David from sinning
  - This is the second step in receiving the discipline of the Lord
    - Bless the person who acted obediently to deliver the Lord's message
    - Abigail took a tremendous step of faith to serve the Lord's purpose in David's life
    - She was in this position because of David's prospective sin
    - So when David recognized the Lord working through her to his own benefit, he blessed her in return
  - This is the opposite of shooting the messenger
    - Next time someone tries to rescue you from yourself, recognize they are working on your behalf, so return the blessing
    - They might not even know the Lord was working through them
    - So encourage their heart by acknowledging how they served God's purpose in your life
    - David tells Abigail that had she not obeyed the Lord, surely terrible things would have happened
    - And David would have been far worse off
- So David agreed to her request and determined not to attack Nabal
  - But what of David's honor?
    - Well, because David was willing to step aside and let the Lord fight his battles, the Lord showed Himself faithful

1Sam. 25:36 **Then Abigail came to Nabal, and behold, he was holding a feast in his house, like the feast of a king. And Nabal's heart was merry within him, for he was very drunk; so she did not tell him anything at all until the morning light.**
1Sam. 25:37 **But in the morning, when the wine had gone out of Nabal, his wife told him these things, and his heart died within him so that he became as a stone.**
1Sam. 25:38 **About ten days later, the Lord struck Nabal and he died.**

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- Abigail returns and fittingly she finds her husband, the fool, drunk that night
  - He was completely unaware of what was coming his way
  - He and his men were sitting ducks that evening, but the faithful wife saved his life
  - Nabal reminds us again of Saul who lived by the flesh and operated as if he was invincible over his empire
- In the morning, at the first opportunity, Abigail reports what happened
  - The writer makes a pun in v.37 using Nabal's name
  - The Hebrew word *nebel* means wine sack
  - So the writer says Nabal (the wine sack) ran out of wine…
  - An empty wine sack is worthless, and so was Nabal when he was sober
- Notice Abigail didn't deceive Nabal at any point
  - She told him the whole story at the first opportunity, once the emergency was over
  - And at that point the heart of Nabal went dead
  - It means he lost all courage when he realized how close he came to death
  - But it also pictures Saul becoming hardhearted as sin took hold in his life
- Finally, the Lord brings the vengeance David deserves because David refrained from acting on his own behalf
  - Notice Nabal's death came about ten days later
    - About means not exactly ten, as in something between nine and ten
    - The number nine means judgment in scripture
    - While the number ten means testimony
  - So Nabal's death was a judgment of God in defense of David's honor
    - And the entire episode was a testimony
    - It was a testimony of the wickedness of Nabal, the faithfulness of Abigail and the repentance of David

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- It's time to finish the third part of the story of David's testing
  - Chapters 24-26 tell the story of how David's weakness was revealed and corrected by the Lord
    - In Chapter 24, David employed tactics more in keeping with Saul's heart than for a man after god's own heart
    - So in Chapter 25, the Lord gave David a vivid demonstration of how trusting the Lord is done, using a remarkable heroine
    - Now in Chapter 26 David gets to retake the test a second time
  - Specifically, the Lord will now place David in a situation similar to the one he encountered in Chapter 24 with Saul chasing him
    - But this time David will have learned the proper way to address Saul's sin
    - And in the process, David grows closer to the man God desires him to be as he prepares to lead Israel following Saul's reign
- But first, we need to conclude our story of David and Abigail with a little romantic twist that serves as a foreboding of things to come

1Sam. 25:38 About ten days later, the Lord struck Nabal and he died.
1Sam. 25:39 When David heard that Nabal was dead, he said, "Blessed be the Lord, who has pleaded the cause of my reproach from the hand of Nabal and has kept back His servant from evil. The Lord has also returned the evildoing of Nabal on his own head." Then David sent a proposal to Abigail, to take her as his wife.
1Sam. 25:40 When the servants of David came to Abigail at Carmel, they spoke to her, saying, "David has sent us to you to take you as his wife."
1Sam. 25:41 She arose and bowed with her face to the ground and said, "Behold, your maidservant is a maid to wash the feet of my lord's servants."
1Sam. 25:42 Then Abigail quickly arose, and rode on a donkey, with her five maidens who attended her; and she followed the messengers of David and became his wife.
1Sam. 25:43 David had also taken Ahinoam of Jezreel, and they both became his wives.
1Sam. 25:44 Now Saul had given Michal his daughter, David's wife, to Palti the son of Laish, who was from Gallim.

- We read v.38 last time noting how the Lord defended David's honor concerning Nabal by taking Nabal's life after ten days
  - The number ten represents testimony
    - It indicates David's willingness to trust the Lord for his defense became a testimony of his faithfulness
    - And in response the Lord took Nabal's life to emphasize Nabal opposed God, not just David

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- Nabal's end is a reminder to us that the Lord may at times end a person's life as a specific response to sin
  - Obviously, Nabal was going to die someday somehow
  - But the Lord chose to end his life in a specific way to make a point
  - And as our Creator, this is God's prerogative
  - If our lives don't glorify the Lord, then He may use our death to glorify Himself
- You notice in v.39 that when David heard the news of Nabal's sudden death, he got the point
  - David knew the Lord had done that work on David's behalf
  - And in that moment David learned his lesson
  - He considered what might have happened had he carried out his mission against Nabal
  - But because he was patient and waited on the Lord, he got to see the other path and realized it was much better

- That should be the goal of our own walk with Christ
  - When we face a moment of decision for how to respond to our circumstances, we always have the fleshly option and a godly option
    - When you take the fleshly option, you'll never know what might have happened if you had followed Christ instead
    - How would He have come to your defense or aid?
    - What miracle did you miss? What lesson didn't you learn?
  - But when you take the road of obedience, you will get to see the Lord working to reward your obedience
    - That should be the goal of your life in obedience to the Lord
    - You should be jealous for the opportunity to see the Lord working in your defense or to provide or to heal, etc.
    - Resist the temptation to take matters into your own hands, to jump the gun rather than waiting for the Lord to act
    - Don't miss out on the lessons the Lord wants to teach His children
- David then turns his attention back to Abigail and sends his men to her with a proposal for marriage
  - When Abigail hears the proposal, she is overjoyed and probably relieved
    - Being a widow wasn't an easy life in that day
    - Nabal's property was probably inherited by one of his sons, not his wife
    - And so Abigail's prospects were uncertain
  - Abigail accepts the offer, though it's unclear if she truly had a choice in the matter
    - But if she did have a choice, then she should have refused to marry David

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        - Because though Abigail was eligible to marry David, since Nabal had died
        - David was *not* eligible to marry
        - As Samuel points out in his foreboding footnote to the story in vs.43-44, David was already married
    - In fact, David had married twice already
        - He was married to Saul's daughter, Michal
        - But in light of his continuing conflict with Saul, Saul has taken his daughter away from David
        - And he gave Michal to another man
        - Saul probably did this to move David farther away from the throne, since David would no longer be a son-in-law of the king
    - But David had already married a second woman before this point
        - After Michal, David married Ahinoam of Jezreel
        - Perhaps David married this woman because he lost Michal
        - But now that he has her, he shouldn't be looking for more wives
        - In fact, later David will reclaim Michal despite being married to Ahinoam and Abigail
        - And when he does, she will become a snare to him in opposing the will of the Lord
- So we can see Samuel including this bit about David's wives to emphasize that David still has challenges in following the Lord
    - David learned one lesson in avoiding the sin of killing Nabal but he still has sin
        - In particular, David is prone to one sin above others: lust
        - David's love for women will follow him all his days
        - And later as king it will lead to a severe penalty from God
    - But for the time being, all is looking up for David
        - He has come through the lessons of Chapter 25 well
        - Now all that remains is to pass the test he failed in Chapter 24

1Sam. 26:1 Then the Ziphites came to Saul at Gibeah, saying, "Is not David hiding on the hill of Hachilah, which is before Jeshimon?"
1Sam. 26:2 So Saul arose and went down to the wilderness of Ziph, having with him three thousand chosen men of Israel, to search for David in the wilderness of Ziph.
1Sam. 26:3 Saul camped in the hill of Hachilah, which is before Jeshimon, beside the road, and David was staying in the wilderness. When he saw that Saul came after him into the wilderness,
1Sam. 26:4 David sent out spies, and he knew that Saul was definitely coming.

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1Sam. 26:5 **David then arose and came to the place where Saul had camped. And David saw the place where Saul lay, and Abner the son of Ner, the commander of his army; and Saul was lying in the circle of the camp, and the people were camped around him.**

- I mentioned earlier that the test God constructed in Chapter 24 would be repeated in Chapter 26, and now we see how that test will come
  - Once again Saul is chasing David and David must resist Saul without sinning
    - But there are differences between the two situations
    - And a key difference is David is on the offensive
  - In Chapter 24, David was on the defensive, constantly reacting to Saul's moves
    - This placed him in a position of fear and uncertainty, from which the temptation to act in his own defense was greatest
    - In this chapter David dictates the events
    - And instead of being an aggressor, David is his defender while accusing others of doing Saul wrong
- It begins in a similar way, though, with Saul hearing that David is in a particular place, in this case on the hill of Hachilah in the wilderness of Ziph
  - Once again, we see the reference to 3,000 men, reminding us that this chapter is linked with the previous two
    - As Saul sets out, David's watchmen know that Saul is setting out with his army
    - David sends out spies to confirm Saul was coming for him
    - This is the first indication that David is working with a confidence and strength he lacked earlier
  - Then David goes to Saul's encampment
    - Again, this is a reversal of the previous story
    - In the previous story, Saul found David's encampment
    - Now David is chasing down Saul
  - And as David and his men arrive at night, they find Saul and his army asleep with apparently no one awake guarding the king
    - Lying next to Saul is Abner, the commander of the army
    - Presumably, Abner was the man assigned to protect Saul
    - But he's fallen asleep on duty

1Sam. 26:6 **Then David said to Ahimelech the Hittite and to Abishai the son of Zeruiah, Joab's brother, saying, "Who will go down with me to Saul in the camp?" And Abishai said, "I will go down with you."**
1Sam. 26:7 **So David and Abishai came to the people by night, and behold, Saul lay**

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sleeping inside the circle of the camp with his spear stuck in the ground at his head; and Abner and the people were lying around him.
1Sam. 26:8 **Then Abishai said to David, "Today God has delivered your enemy into your hand; now therefore, please let me strike him with the spear to the ground with one stroke, and I will not strike him the second time."**
1Sam. 26:9 **But David said to Abishai, "Do not destroy him, for who can stretch out his hand against the Lord's anointed and be without guilt?"**
1Sam. 26:10 **David also said, "As the Lord lives, surely the Lord will strike him, or his day will come that he dies, or he will go down into battle and perish.**
1Sam. 26:11 **"The Lord forbid that I should stretch out my hand against the Lord's anointed; but now please take the spear that is at his head and the jug of water, and let us go."**
1Sam. 26:12 **So David took the spear and the jug of water from beside Saul's head, and they went away, but no one saw or knew it, nor did any awake, for they were all asleep, because a sound sleep from the Lord had fallen on them.**

- Once again, David goes on the offensive
  - He determines to go down into the camp and sneak among the men
    - David's not hiding in a cave
    - He's out in the open risking his life
    - But doing it for a noble purpose, which is to convince the king of his loyalty above all other men Saul trusts
  - So he asks for a volunteer to accompany him into the camp
    - David asks a Hittite named Ahimelech
    - And he asks Abishai, who was David's nephew by David's sister Zeruiah
    - Abishai agrees to go, indicating his bravery
    - That bravery must have run in the family, because Abishai's brother, Joab, later becomes David's commander of the army
- And so David and Abishai take the brave step of creeping down the hill into the camp of Saul
  - They find the camp asleep with Saul next to his weapon
    - Saul had stuck his spear into the ground not far from his head for quick access should he have need of it
    - Quick thinking Abishai sizes up the situation and decides this is the perfect moment to put an end to the conflict
    - This is exactly the same kind of moment we saw in Chapter 24 in the cave
  - And like the cave, David knows better than to allow his men to kill Saul, the king
    - David warns his friend that the one who strikes down God's anointed will certainly be guilty before God

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        - David said as much the first time in the cave
    - But notice what has changed from the last time
        - David also tells his men that Saul will see the Lord's discipline just as David has
        - If the Lord was willing to discipline the future anointed king
        - Then how much more will the Lord discipline the present anointed king?
        - David doesn't know how Saul will come to his end, but after watching the Lord deal with Nabal, David knows it will happen
- This is the fruit of David's testing
    - He has gone into essentially the same situation
        - But this time, he's thinking about the Lord and the Lord's power to defend him
        - It's not merely David's actions that are different
        - It's his heart and mind concerning the Lord's role in these matters
    - When you face trials and experience the spiritual growth the Lord intended, you will see the fruit most clearly in how you think of God
        - Where before you thought only of yourself and your circumstances
        - In the future, you begin to consider the Lord's purposes in what happens around you
        - And you see the world with eyes for eternity, from God's vantage point as it were
    - Like David, you realize that things aren't as they seem
        - What may seem like good fortune is actually a test of your heart
        - An option that looks like the perfect opportunity to solve your problems is actually a trap leading you into bigger problems
        - And what seems like a foolish alternative may actually be the obedience the Lord is demanding
        - Learning to see the world with godly eyes informed by the love and truth of the Lord is the ultimate reward of trials and the spiritual growth trials bring
- So David ends with the conclusion that he could never raise his hand (again) against the Lord's anointed
    - Where before David objected only to killing the king, now he objects to any show of insubordination or disrespect
        - So if David is not intent on dishonoring Saul, what can he do to make an impression upon Saul?
        - David shifts his target away from Saul and toward one of Saul's most trusted aides
    - David orders Abishai to take Saul's spear and Saul's personal canteen of water and they departed the area
        - Samuel explains David's ability to move so easily within the camp without

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waking anyone
        - The Lord had brought a deep sleep upon the men in the camp to aid David in the task
        - Where before David's course of action brought the conviction of the Spirit, now it brings the Lord's assistance and approval
    - The lesson is obvious to everyone
        - As we hear the Lord and walk in His counsel, He gives us the strength, wisdom and even supernatural assistance to serve Him
        - But for the one who takes matters into his own hands, the results will disappoint
        - Moreover, we will know the conviction of the Spirit as we recognize we are working outside the Lord's counsel
        - Experience one often enough and you'll begin to yearn for the other
- What did taking Saul's equipment accomplish? We soon find out

1Sam. 26:13 Then David crossed over to the other side and stood on top of the mountain at a distance with a large area between them.
1Sam. 26:14 David called to the people and to Abner the son of Ner, saying, "Will you not answer, Abner?" Then Abner replied, "Who are you who calls to the king?"
1Sam. 26:15 So David said to Abner, "Are you not a man? And who is like you in Israel? Why then have you not guarded your lord the king? For one of the people came to destroy the king your lord.
1Sam. 26:16 "This thing that you have done is not good. As the Lord lives, all of you must surely die, because you did not guard your lord, the Lord's anointed. And now, see where the king's spear is and the jug of water that was at his head."

- David reaches a safe distance, with a large gap between them, so that once Saul wakes, he won't be in a position to pursue David
    - And then David calls out to the people to wake them
        - And he directs his call to Abner the king's captain
        - He dares Abner to respond
        - Of course, Abner isn't sure who is calling him by name in this wilderness
        - So he answers reluctantly
    - And then David lowers the boom
        - He asks are you not a man?
        - And is there anyone in Israel like you?
        - His point is that Abner is an important, powerful man with an important job to protect the king

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        - And yet he failed in that job
    - David says one of the people came to destroy the king, referring to Abishai's offer to kill the king
        - Literally, if it hadn't been for David, Saul would have been dead
        - And Abner would have failed to protect the king's life as expected
        - David isn't being dramatic here…he's speaking in literal terms
- David is making a point to Saul that he has placed his trust in the wrong men
    - Paranoid Saul was obviously willing to place his trust in Abner to protect his life
        - Meanwhile, Saul believes that David is intending to take his life
        - And so David is not trying to embarrass the king or threaten his rule
        - The point of the exercise was to embarrass Abner
        - But in the process, David hoped Saul would recognize that he should be trusted over even Saul's closest confidents
    - David presses his case a little farther by pointing out that Saul's men should be put to death for allowing their king to be so vulnerable
        - Once again, David's words are literally true
        - This was the usual penalty for failing a king in this way
        - But Saul will not carry out such a penalty, and I expect David knew that
        - So David is merely making a point that if Saul wished to pursue his adversaries, he should pursue these men, not David
    - Finally, David offers proof of his accusations by producing the things he took from the camp
        - In the last episode, David held up the piece of hem of Saul's robe, which had the effect of embarrassing the king
        - It communicated that David was willing to do Saul harm but held back
        - Though David claimed the hem was proof he wouldn't hurt the king, it was actually a symbol of the opposite
        - This time David holds up even more threatening items, but his point is clearly different
        - He's indicting Abner, not threatening Saul
- And then just as before, David and Saul exchange words from a distance

1Sam. 26:17 Then Saul recognized David's voice and said, "Is this your voice, my son David?" And David said, "It is my voice, my lord the king."
1Sam. 26:18 He also said, "Why then is my lord pursuing his servant? For what have I done? Or what evil is in my hand?
1Sam. 26:19 "Now therefore, please let my lord the king listen to the words of his servant. If the Lord has stirred you up against me, let Him accept an offering;

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but if it is men, cursed are they before the Lord, for they have driven me out today so that I would have no attachment with the inheritance of the Lord, saying, 'Go, serve other gods.'
1Sam. 26:20 **"Now then, do not let my blood fall to the ground away from the presence of the Lord; for the king of Israel has come out to search for a single flea, just as one hunts a partridge in the mountains."**
1Sam. 26:21 **Then Saul said, "I have sinned. Return, my son David, for I will not harm you again because my life was precious in your sight this day. Behold, I have played the fool and have committed a serious error."**
1Sam. 26:22 **David replied, "Behold the spear of the king! Now let one of the young men come over and take it.**
1Sam. 26:23 **"The Lord will repay each man for his righteousness and his faithfulness; for the Lord delivered you into my hand today, but I refused to stretch out my hand against the Lord's anointed.**
1Sam. 26:24 **"Now behold, as your life was highly valued in my sight this day, so may my life be highly valued in the sight of the Lord, and may He deliver me from all distress."**
1Sam. 26:25 **Then Saul said to David, "Blessed are you, my son David; you will both accomplish much and surely prevail." So David went on his way, and Saul returned to his place.**

- Like before, Saul calls David his "son"
  - That term is even more disingenuous this time, since Saul has taken away David's wife
    - It was David's marriage to Saul's daughter that made David a son of Saul
    - But Saul ended that relationship
    - Nevertheless, he continues to call David son
  - In response, David asks the king why he's pursuing David, and what offense has David committed
    - Of course, there is no answer to that question
    - Saul has no offense in mind
    - He's simply acting out of jealousy, paranoia, fear and pride
  - Next, David speaks wisdom to Saul
    - He begins by acknowledging that the Lord is the One acting behind the scenes in this conflict
    - He tells Saul if the Lord is stirring up Saul, then let David and Saul make an offering to appease the Lord's anger
    - But if men have led Saul to think badly of David, then David says they are cursed since they act against the Lord's anointed
    - Either way, he argues that Saul has no reason to fear David

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- Finally, David appeals to Saul for mercy, asking that his blood not be allowed to be spilled away from the presence of the Lord
  - David is referring to dying as a fugitive away from the tabernacle
    - It's a subtle way of asking that he be allowed to die at home as an old man, which implies peace between David and Saul
    - And he ends with a repetition of the statement that he is but a flea compared to Saul
  - Saul responds in much the same way as before, acknowledging that David is a better man
    - This time, Saul goes a step further and promises to stop seeking for David's life
    - But David doesn't believe he will ever be safe around Saul
    - The two men go their own way, though David knows better than to put himself in a position where Saul can attack again
    - At least David has blunted Saul's attack in this case as he did before
- When you compare David's words here to what he said previously, you can immediately detect the difference in David's attitude and heart
  - For example, listen again to David in his first encounter with Saul

1Sam. 24:10 **"Behold, this day your eyes have seen that the Lord had given you today into my hand in the cave, and some said to kill you, but my eye had pity on you; and I said, 'I will not stretch out my hand against my lord, for he is the Lord's anointed.'**
1Sam. 24:11 **"Now, my father, see! Indeed, see the edge of your robe in my hand! For in that I cut off the edge of your robe and did not kill you, know and perceive that there is no evil or rebellion in my hands, and I have not sinned against you, though you are lying in wait for my life to take it.**
1Sam. 24:12 **"May the Lord judge between you and me, and may the Lord avenge me on you; but my hand shall not be against you.**
1Sam. 24:13 **"As the proverb of the ancients says, 'Out of the wicked comes forth wickedness'; but my hand shall not be against you.**
1Sam. 24:14 **"After whom has the king of Israel come out? Whom are you pursuing? A dead dog, a single flea?**

- Can you detect the marked difference in David's tone?
  - In the first encounter, David speaks in arrogance while issuing veiled threats against the king
  - He shows off the hem of the robe and then has the audacity to claim he has no rebellion in his heart
  - He claims Saul was lying in wait for David yet it was David who crept up on an unsuspecting Saul

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- And the tone of David's speech is very different as well
  - He asks that the Lord avenges David upon Saul
  - And preaches a proverb to Saul about wickedness, which implies that David viewed Saul as acting wickedly
  - In everything he's saying, David is actually portraying the opposite
  - The impression we're left with is that of arrogance, pride and defiance
- But when we look at David's words to Saul now, the tone has changed completely and the words are much softer
  - He makes no accusations against Saul, he issues no threats
    - Instead, David makes a heartfelt appeal for Saul's mercy
    - And he looks to other causes for Saul's anger, whether the Lord or Saul's men
  - When he speaks of the Lord, David doesn't ask for revenge but rather for recompense
    - Rather than wanting the Lord to punish Saul for his unrighteous behavior, David asks the Lord to reward his righteous behavior
    - Finally, notice David's appeal is not to Saul
    - In v.24 David makes his appeal to the Lord for protection
  - The overall tone is positive toward Saul, respectful, and directed at his trust and dependence upon the Lord
    - In short, David's heart and mind are focused on his relationship with the Lord, not his relationship with Saul
    - David's approach is a good example of Ephesians 6

Eph. 6:12 **For our struggle is not against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the powers, against the world forces of this darkness, against the spiritual forces of wickedness in the heavenly places.**

- By taking time to observe carefully the differences in David's commentary, we can see the growth in him
  - What at first sounds like an identical speech is actually a world apart from David's earlier moment
  - David knows that Saul is acting irrationally, and yet David no longer holds it against Saul
  - David is resting in the Lord to defend him
- David's experience reminds us that repentance can be hard to see in others if we aren't paying attention to subtle cues in a person's words and attitude
  - For every dramatic "Paul on the road to Damascus" repentance moment we encounter in life, there will be many more subtle "David speaking with Saul" repentance examples

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        - Our friends, family members or even our own heart often respond to the conviction of the Spirit in subtle ways, especially in the beginning of our walk
        - Our word choices may change, our attitudes begin to shift even if our behaviors don't move in radical ways
        - Eventually, these smaller steps begin to add up to larger more obvious changes
    - Have you ever run into an old high school friend many years later and noticed they were much different than you remembered them to be?
        - Perhaps they looked different, sounded different
        - They expressed different political views, they were engaged in entirely new hobbies
        - From that experience you can see how small changes over time can add up to a big difference in the end
        - This is how sanctification works in all of us
- So we need to be prepared to recognize and encourage those around us who are making strides by recognizing the work of the Spirit in them
    - Don't wait for the full change to take hold before recognizing their progress
        - Acknowledge good changes as you see it, though do it in a positive way of course
        - We don't need to tell people, "You aren't nearly as mean and selfish as you used to be."
        - Find the right way to acknowledge their efforts
    - Encouragement can put the sanctification progress into overdrive
        - Each small step of obedience in a person's life becomes a bridge to the next moment
        - As over time as a person's heart is softened and their will yields to the Holy Spirit
    - But remember that progress can be slow, so we have to be looking for it
        - It may just be a withholding of critique where before critique was commonplace
        - Or refrain from gossip or are quicker to forgive
        - We may miss these steps if we are too busy remembering the past or unwilling to consider that real change is possible
    - And sometimes we can miss our own progress for the same reason, which may discourage us in our walk or give room for the enemy to make accusations
        - Remember how similar David's two speeches were and consider how subtle your own progress may be from week to week
        - Then remind yourself that progress takes time
        - Don't allow that fact to become license for further sin
        - But at the same time, don't overlook that small changes are still evidence of the Spirit at work

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- Both in yourself and in others

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- Over the past few lessons, we've studied David's testing
  - He offended the Lord by sinning against the Lord's anointed
    - So the Lord gave David a lesson in humility and what a servant's heart looks like
    - And David learned that lesson
    - And when the time came to show what he learned, David passed the test
    - He defended Saul and appealed to the Lord for his own protection
    - Though in the process, David showed his weakness for women by taking another wife in Abigail
  - So since David has passed his test, it's time for the Lord to move David into the position God has prepared for him
    - It's time for David to become king
    - But first, the Lord must orchestrate Saul's departure
    - So in the last section of this book, Chapters 27-31, we follow how Saul's reign comes to an end
  - But we also see that David's heart still has doubts and weaknesses
    - So the Lord will orchestrate circumstances to correct and strengthen David
    - Even as He moves to bring David into power
- And to illustrate that point, the story begins with David returning to hide among the Philistines

1Sam. 27:1 Then David said to himself, "Now I will perish one day by the hand of Saul. There is nothing better for me than to escape into the land of the Philistines. Saul then will despair of searching for me anymore in all the territory of Israel, and I will escape from his hand."
1Sam. 27:2 So David arose and crossed over, he and the six hundred men who were with him, to Achish the son of Maoch, king of Gath.
1Sam. 27:3 And David lived with Achish at Gath, he and his men, each with his household, even David with his two wives, Ahinoam the Jezreelitess, and Abigail the Carmelitess, Nabal's widow.

- David decides that he must once again flee from Jewish territory and hide among Israel's enemies in Philistia
  - He knows that Saul cannot move freely in the territory of the Philistines
    - So he goes with his 600 men to Achish, the leader of the Philistine city of Gath
    - David and his men take their families, who have been with them in their flight
  - Why would the Philistines open their doors to David at all?
    - The simple answer is that the enemy of my enemy is my friend
    - Anything that weakened Saul was to the advantage of the Philistines

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        - David was the best military leader Saul had, so they were only too glad to take David away from Saul
        - Just as when a sports team tries to recruit a top player away from a rival team
    - Secondly, the Philistines plan to enlist David in battles against Israel
        - Once David fights for the Philistines, the Jews will never take him back
        - So this is a calculated move to weaken the monarchy in Israel
- Perhaps the more important question for us is was David right to escape to the Philistine city?
    - Was this move something God inspired for David's benefit?
        - We can answer the question by observing some details carefully
        - And then by remembering the purpose in David's flight
    - First, looking at the details, we see things that indicate David was not acting with the Lord's approval
        - First, in v.1 were told David "said to himself"
        - This phrase is very specific and stands in contrast to previous moments
        - In the past when David faced difficult decisions, we've noted how David was faithful to go to the Lord in prayer seeking guidance
        - David's tendency to pray was in marked contrast with Saul's tendency to seek no one's counsel or even worse
    - But this time David seeks no one's counsel except his own
        - In fact, there is no mention of God in this entire chapter
        - David seems to be acting entirely without consideration for the Lord's will
    - Furthermore, David's reasoning for this flight is that he won't live unless he finds sanctuary in Gath
        - And yet David has received assurances from multiple sources that he will in fact be king
        - From Samuel to Jonathan to Saul himself David has heard that one day he will be king
        - And yet he's convinced that the Lord might allow Saul to kill him before that day comes
        - Clearly this is a lack of confidence on David's part
    - And then there's the comment at the end in v.3 that David was traveling with his multiple wives
        - Samuel is implying that David is paying the price of assuming the burden of these women
        - He's so concerned for their welfare that he compromises his walk
        - As a family man, he choses to live safely among Israel's enemies than fulfill his calling to contend with Saul

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- Finally, and most importantly, David's stepping away from the fight God wants him to experience
  - David's trial in fleeing Saul was something the Lord purposed for David's good
    - David is being pursued by Saul so that he might be strengthened and matured for service as king
    - God is using these circumstances for David's benefit, but David is tired and tied down
    - So he opts for an escape from persecution
    - Yet that persecution is exactly what the Lord wanted David to experience
  - So all information points to David acting in disobedience in his flight to Gath
    - He has not sought the Lord's counsel
    - He is running for the wrong reasons
    - And he has forgotten that the difficulty of his circumstances are intended for good in God's purposes
    - So by fleeing, David is escaping the training he needs
- Thankfully, our mistakes can't ruin God's plans
  - One way or another, the Lord gets His way
    - By our disobedience, we may alter the playbook of our life
    - But not the outcome
    - So David's escape becomes opportunity for the Lord to simply work in a different way to achieve His goal
    - The Lord will work through the Philistines to continue David's training
  - And at the same time, the Lord will use these circumstances for a second good purpose
    - He will work through the Philistines to bring Saul's rule to an end
    - And David will play a central role in that process

1Sam. 27:4 Now it was told Saul that David had fled to Gath, so he no longer searched for him.

- David's plan works to stop Saul's attack
  - Saul couldn't prosecute his attack against David without taking on the entire Philistine army
    - And he's clearly unwilling to do that
    - So David is safe for now
    - And it appears that David intends to remain in Philistine territory until Saul dies
  - But this is a tricky plan

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        - The Philistines aren't going to allow David to hide out just so he can return to rule Israel when it's convenient
        - David must convince them he is defecting from Israel
        - He's brought his men and their families, so it appears he's coming to stay
    - But eventually, the Philistines will insist on a sign of loyalty from David
        - But David is anticipating this too
        - So he has a plan

1Sam. 27:5 Then David said to Achish, "If now I have found favor in your sight, let them give me a place in one of the cities in the country, that I may live there; for why should your servant live in the royal city with you?"
1Sam. 27:6 So Achish gave him Ziklag that day; therefore Ziklag has belonged to the kings of Judah to this day.
1Sam. 27:7 The number of days that David lived in the country of the Philistines was a year and four months.
1Sam. 27:8 Now David and his men went up and raided the Geshurites and the Girzites and the Amalekites; for they were the inhabitants of the land from ancient times, as you come to Shur even as far as the land of Egypt.
1Sam. 27:9 David attacked the land and did not leave a man or a woman alive, and he took away the sheep, the cattle, the donkeys, the camels, and the clothing. Then he returned and came to Achish.

- David's plan begins with proposing to become a vassal of King Achish
    - David, quite deceptively, refers to himself as the servant of Achish
        - And then he proposes that he go rule over one of the cities of the Philistines
        - The king likes where this is going, so he gives David the city of Ziklag
        - So David took control of that city
    - The location of Ziklag was perfectly suited to the rest of David's plan
        - It was in the extreme south of the Philistines territory at the edge of the hill country
        - The Philistine kings lived miles north, so David and his men could come and go and conduct themselves without being observed
        - This was the opportunity David wanted
    - For sixteen months David lives in this town, and as the writer says kings of Judah never relinquished control of this town once David gained it
        - And immediately David begins to lead military excursions against the common enemies of the Philistines and Israel
        - The people were the descendants of the Canaanites living in the southern desert that separated Israel from Egypt

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        - David was attacking the same people groups that Joshua told Israel to defeat when they first entered the land
        - Because Israel disobeyed, they remained even until David's day
- So David does exactly as the Lord had commanded Israel
    - He utterly destroys the inhabitants of the land so that the land could become Israel's
        - He leaves no one alive, which was the Lord's command
        - Notice in v.8 that these people included the descendants of Amalek
        - And Amalek and his descendants have been under a curse from God, though Israel failed to carry it out

Deut. 25:17 "Remember what Amalek did to you along the way when you came out from Egypt,
Deut. 25:18 how he met you along the way and attacked among you all the stragglers at your rear when you were faint and weary; and he did not fear God.
Deut. 25:19 "Therefore it shall come about when the Lord your God has given you rest from all your surrounding enemies, in the land which the Lord your God gives you as an inheritance to possess, you shall blot out the memory of Amalek from under heaven; you must not forget.

- David achieves these impressive victories with only 600 misfits
    - By now though, they are hardened soldiers
    - Nevertheless, his success only proves that Israel could have accomplished the same in earlier days
    - The people stop trying
    - The Lord didn't stop awarding victories
- David's raids are serving the purpose of clearing land for David's future kingdom
    - But they also become an opportunity for David to convince the Philistines that he is on their side

1Sam. 27:10 Now Achish said, "Where have you made a raid today?" And David said, "Against the Negev of Judah and against the Negev of the Jerahmeelites and against the Negev of the Kenites."
1Sam. 27:11 David did not leave a man or a woman alive to bring to Gath, saying, "Otherwise they will tell about us, saying, 'So has David done and so has been his practice all the time he has lived in the country of the Philistines.'"
1Sam. 27:12 So Achish believed David, saying, "He has surely made himself odious among his people Israel; therefore he will become my servant forever."

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- David and King Achish meet again back in Gath
  - Josephus says that David brought spoils from the victories to Achish as a tribute
    - And of course Achish asks David where he was raiding to obtain the spoils
    - David responds that he was raiding in the Negev of Judah and surrounding areas
  - Technically, David is telling the truth, since the region where he battled is part of the Negev desert
    - But he deceives Achish by indicating that the target of his raid were members of Judah living in that area
    - In reality, David attacked only the Canaanites in the region
  - And David knew what he intended to do in the end, which is why he utterly destroyed all the inhabitants
    - David wanted to destroy the evidence
    - There would be no one left alive to contradict his version of the events
- David's actions certainly achieve a measure of benefit for Israel but nevertheless he was wrong to enter the Philistines' territories
  - And every indication we have tells us that David was wrong to set about all that he is doing among the Philistines
    - David seems to be back to his old tricks of deception to get what he wants
    - He stepped into the Philistine territory without consulting the Lord
    - He has devised a plan of his own making thinking he was securing a victory for Israel
    - In the end he was substituting one set of dangers for another and sinning in the process
  - Later in Chapter 30 we will see the full effect of his sin in this situation
    - The Lord will teach David yet another lesson about taking matters into his own hands
    - As a result, David will grow another step in dependence on the Lord
  - Meanwhile, David's deception is working with King Achish
    - Achish is convinced that David has been fighting Jews in the south
    - And as a result, David has made himself a pariah, and so he must forever remain with the Philistines
- But Chapter 27 is merely set up for what's coming in the next several chapters as we work toward the end of Saul's reign

1Sam. 28:1 **Now it came about in those days that the Philistines gathered their armed camps for war, to fight against Israel. And Achish said to David, "Know assuredly that you will go out with me in the camp, you and your men."**

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1Sam. 28:2 **David said to Achish, "Very well, you shall know what your servant can do." So Achish said to David, "Very well, I will make you my bodyguard for life."**

- After about 16 months, the time had come for the Philistines to mount their latest attack against the nation of Israel
  - So the army is assembling by the tens of thousands and David and his men are called to join as well
    - When King Achish sees David, he determines that David's men will March near the rear with King Achish
    - They will be his personal bodyguards
  - When the king tells David of the idea, David responds in a cryptic manner
    - He says "You know what I can do"
    - Achish's ears heard that as a promise that David could kill his own brethren
    - Once again, it's deception by omission
    - David knows how the king will hear him, though David means it in an entirely different way
- Meanwhile, back in Gilgal Saul is panicking at the prospect of a massive Philistine invasion
  - We can tell how distressed Saul was because he seeks the Lord's counsel, something we haven't seen him do much if at all

1Sam. 28:3 **Now Samuel was dead, and all Israel had lamented him and buried him in Ramah, his own city. And Saul had removed from the land those who were mediums and spiritists.**
1Sam. 28:4 **So the Philistines gathered together and came and camped in Shunem; and Saul gathered all Israel together and they camped in Gilboa.**
1Sam. 28:5 **When Saul saw the camp of the Philistines, he was afraid and his heart trembled greatly.**
1Sam. 28:6 **When Saul inquired of the Lord, the Lord did not answer him, either by dreams or by Urim or by prophets.**
1Sam. 28:7 **Then Saul said to his servants, "Seek for me a woman who is a medium, that I may go to her and inquire of her." And his servants said to him, "Behold, there is a woman who is a medium at En-dor."**

- At this point we're reminded that Samuel was gone and that Saul had previously removed all the mediums and spiritists in the land of Israel
  - Samuel was the prophet of Israel during Saul's reign
    - With Samuel gone Saul has no reliable source to consult for God's word
    - Of course, he didn't spend much time listening when he had the chance

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- Secondly, in one of his better moments Saul obeyed the Law when he acted to remove all mediums and spiritists in the land of Israel
  - Both groups are closely related in power and function
  - A medium is one who claims to communicate with the dead
  - A spiritist is a person who communicates with evil spirits
  - In both cases, they are tapping into demonic power
- Therefore, the Law given to Israel prohibits God's people from accessing such individuals
  - These people were to be put to death in Israel, according to the Law
  - And at some point Saul had done this very thing
  - But now Saul begins to regret it

- Saul appeals to the Lord for wisdom on how to defeat the Philistines, but the Lord is observing radio silence
  - When Saul had the opportunity to hear the Lord's counsel through Samuel he didn't listen
    - So now the Lord refuses to listen to Saul
    - Saul received no dreams from the Lord
    - And the prophets of the day had no answer for Saul
  - Saul even went to his replacement high priest asking for a reading from the Urim and Thummim stones found in the ephod
    - Since we know David took the true high priest and ephod with him, then we know Saul can't have the true stones of God
    - Therefore, he must have had a new set made, which the Lord did not honor with an answer
  - This detail tells us that the stones must have behaved in a supernatural way
    - They couldn't have operated in a natural way like ordinary dice
    - Otherwise, Saul could have made a counterfeit and posed a question and received an "answer" though a false one
    - But the text says Saul got no answer from his Urim stone
    - So there must have been some way to know that the Lord was speaking in the result
- So Saul resorts to asking his servants if they could direct him to a medium anywhere in the land
  - We've just heard that Saul removed the medium and spiritists of the land, yet he was hoping he missed one somewhere
    - So his servants direct him to a woman in En-dor
    - En-dor is located on the Hill of Moreh in the Jezreel valley
    - As it turns out, this town sits on the opposite side of the mountain where the

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Philistine army is gathering

- So Saul goes to visit this woman seeking divine wisdom on how to fight the approaching Philistine army

1Sam. 28:8 Then Saul disguised himself by putting on other clothes, and went, he and two men with him, and they came to the woman by night; and he said, "Conjure up for me, please, and bring up for me whom I shall name to you."
1Sam. 28:9 But the woman said to him, "Behold, you know what Saul has done, how he has cut off those who are mediums and spiritists from the land. Why are you then laying a snare for my life to bring about my death?"
1Sam. 28:10 Saul vowed to her by the Lord, saying, "As the Lord lives, no punishment shall come upon you for this thing."
1Sam. 28:11 Then the woman said, "Whom shall I bring up for you?" And he said, "Bring up Samuel for me."

- Saul prepares to see this woman by disguising himself in other clothes
  - Saul had previously destroyed all such people, but now he was hypocritically seeking this woman's help
    - If she recognized him as king, she would never have agreed to perform her magic for him
    - So Saul is now forced to disguise himself and travel by night to obtain what he wants
    - The nighttime scene also serves to reinforce the evil in Saul's actions
  - Despite his efforts to conceal his identity, the woman remains suspicious of the men and asks for reassurances
    - So Saul goes the next step of entering into a covenant with this woman
    - He vows that she will never receive punishment for this act
    - This goes hand in hand with Saul's previous actions
    - He wants to be seen as someone who upholds the Law but he is willing to go against the Law whenever it suits him
- Saul's request of the woman is to "bring up Samuel"
  - As we said earlier, a medium was a person who claimed to have the power to bring up the dead so loved ones could communicate
    - In reality, a medium never conjured up dead people
    - The spirits of the dead are held by God and cannot be brought up except by that same power
  - Instead, mediums were always communicating with evil spirits who impersonated a dead person
    - The evil spirits were willing to play this charade because it accomplished their

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purpose in trapping people in the occult
        - By what they communicated, the evil spirit could influence the thoughts of people to suit their destructive purposes
        - Obviously, knowing how these occult practices work reinforces the truth of God's word when it warns us to stay far away from such things
    - Presumably, many mediums were equally fooled by these experiences thinking they actually possessed the power to raise the dead
        - Or in other cases, perhaps the medium was in on the trick
        - Maybe some understood that they were just toying with the spirit world and not speaking with the actual dead person
        - But either way, so long as their clients were fooled, the mediums were successful in business
- So Saul asks for the medium to bring up Samuel, because Saul wants to hear a word from Samuel concerning the coming battle
    - Saul knows that Samuel has been a reliable source of intel
        - Ironically, when Samuel lived, Saul didn't take advantage of Samuel's knowledge
        - And other times he flat out disobeyed the word of the Lord
        - But now that he is worried about his own skin, Saul is determined to know what God has to say
    - And of course the greatest irony is that Saul would consider doing so through a clearly ungodly method
        - Why would Saul suppose the Lord would honor him with a new word when Saul is acting so contrary to God's existing word?
        - This shows the warped thinking of a man who has descended so far into his sin nature
        - He is so ruled by his sinful flesh that he can construct such contradictory logic and believe it will work
- So then the medium begins her act for Saul

1Sam. 28:12 When the woman saw Samuel, she cried out with a loud voice; and the woman spoke to Saul, saying, "Why have you deceived me? For you are Saul."
1Sam. 28:13 The king said to her, "Do not be afraid; but what do you see?" And the woman said to Saul, "I see a divine being coming up out of the earth."
1Sam. 28:14 He said to her, "What is his form?" And she said, "An old man is coming up, and he is wrapped with a robe." And Saul knew that it was Samuel, and he bowed with his face to the ground and did homage.

- In an instant, a vision of Samuel appears catching the woman completely by surprise

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- She alone sees Samuel and it shocks her
  - In the process, it seems that the vision of Samuel names Saul in the room
  - Which leads the woman to turn to her client in anger knowing she was tricked
- The woman's response to this vision confirms for us that this was not the normal experience for her
  - In the past, she had communicated with evil spirits which must have followed a certain pattern she knew well
  - But clearly this experience is proceeding in a very unexpected manner
  - She is so scared that Saul has to calm her down
- Furthermore, notice that the text never indicates that the woman "called up" Samuel
  - It seems Saul named Samuel's name first
  - And then at that same moment a vision of Samuel appeared to the woman, catching her by surprise
  - She hadn't even the chance to begin her incantations

- So then what is happening here with Samuel?
  - The Lord brought the woman a vision of Samuel
    - The medium didn't call Samuel up from the dead
    - She didn't possess the power to do so
    - We can see by her response that she wasn't in control of what was happening
    - The Lord brought her a vision of Samuel to teach Saul a lesson
  - I keep saying a "vision" of Samuel because I believe that's what the woman experienced
    - I don't believe Samuel's spirit was actually withdrawn from Sheol and brought into this room
    - Rather, I think the woman's experience was comparable to the experiences that Isaiah had or that the Apostle John had in Revelation
  - In those cases, the men saw something, but their vision didn't require they were physically transported
    - For example, John saw the world destroyed while standing in Heaven, but we know it didn't actually happen in John's day
    - Likewise, the woman saw and heard from Samuel
    - But her experience was a vision provided by the Lord
- As Saul sees the medium's fear, he asks her to describe what she sees
  - She describes a "divine" being coming out of the earth
    - The Hebrew word for divine is *elohim*, which refers to God
    - This is further proof that the woman is seeing something very different than in

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past times
        - This spirit seems like God to her, not like the demons she normally speaks to
    - And then as Saul presses for more detail, she describes Samuel's appearance, and Saul knows it's him
        - And in another act of hypocritical piety, Saul bows to the ground
        - Obviously, Saul never gave Samuel any such consideration while he was alive, so we know his gesture is completely self-serving
        - More importantly, it was inappropriate in any case, because we don't direct our worship to men
        - Saul's heart is a hot mess at this point
- Then through this vision, the Lord gives Saul a judgment for his time of rebellion and sin

1Sam. 28:15 **Then Samuel said to Saul, "Why have you disturbed me by bringing me up?" And Saul answered, "I am greatly distressed; for the Philistines are waging war against me, and God has departed from me and no longer answers me, either through prophets or by dreams; therefore I have called you, that you may make known to me what I should do."**
1Sam. 28:16 **Samuel said, "Why then do you ask me, since the Lord has departed from you and has become your adversary?**
1Sam. 28:17 **"The Lord has done accordingly as He spoke through me; for the Lord has torn the kingdom out of your hand and given it to your neighbor, to David.**
1Sam. 28:18 **"As you did not obey the Lord and did not execute His fierce wrath on Amalek, so the Lord has done this thing to you this day.**
1Sam. 28:19 **"Moreover the Lord will also give over Israel along with you into the hands of the Philistines, therefore tomorrow you and your sons will be with me. Indeed the Lord will give over the army of Israel into the hands of the Philistines!"**

- Samuel asks Saul why he summoned him
    - Saul answers that he is afraid of the Philistines and that he can't get God to answer him, so he wants Samuel's advice
        - It's significant that Saul doesn't ask Samuel why the Lord has stopped responding
        - That would be the more important question
        - Saul may be afraid of what the Philistines will do to his body
        - But what he should be worried about is what the Lord will do to his soul
    - Samuel responds by giving Saul sobering news about the Lord's plans
        - First, the Lord speaks through the vision of Samuel to give Saul the answer to the question he never asked

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        - That the Lord's silence is a result of the withdrawal of the Spirit
        - And the Lord has become Saul's adversary rather than a source of blessing
        - Samuel's point to Saul is why should he expect a prophet to tell him anything if the Lord was not inclined to speak?
        - The prophet simply says what the Lord tells him to say, so that if the Lord is silent, so will the prophets be silent
    - This is the central issues in Saul's life, but it's the thing he never gives any attention
        - He has set himself against the Lord and against the Lord's word
        - As a result, Saul was only going to know silence and frustration at each turn
        - There was no way for Saul to go around this barrier apart from repentance
        - And once Saul crossed the line, the Lord withdrew His Spirit and Saul's authority to act as His representative
        - As Samuel reminds Saul, the kingdom has been taken from him…it's only a matter of time before the end comes
- In fact, Samuel reveals that day is coming sooner than Saul expects
    - This massing of Philistines will be the instrument the Lord will use to put an end to Saul's dynasty
        - Not only will Saul die tomorrow in battle but so will his son Jonathan
        - Jonathan was to die as well so that the house of Saul would come to an end as the Lord promised
    - Samuel's statement in v.19 raises several interesting points
        - First, the fact that Saul and Jonathan die at the same time reflect the truth that bad things happen to both bad and good people
        - The Lord is choosing to end Saul's life on this day as a result of his sin
        - But his godly son, a friend of David, will die too, also because of Saul's sin
        - This is not a punishment against Jonathan
        - Jonathan is a victim of his father's sin
    - Nevertheless, the Lord is not unjust to take Jonathan's life too
        - First, the Lord was going to take Jonathan's earthly life one day, one way or another
        - So you can't judge God for the timing nor manner of Jonathan's death
        - Furthermore, sin has consequences for us and others, and these are the consequences of Saul's sin
        - Jonathan cannot live on to interfere with David's rise to power
- Then v.19 also provides us with the conclusive proof we've been seeking concerning the disposition of Saul's heart
    - So often we've puzzled at Saul's decisions, and in particular we've wondered at his ungodliness

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        - Could Saul truly be a saint and do the things he did?
        - And I've taught along the way that Saul's life is an archetype for the carnal believer
        - And now we have our proof
    - Samuel tells Saul that at the end of the next day, Saul and Jonathan will both be where Samuel is
        - Notice Samuel says both the disobedient Saul and the obedient Jonathan will join the prophet Samuel
        - So whatever you think of Saul, you must think the same of the other two and vice versa
        - Had Saul been destined to occupy a different place, I doubt Samuel would have phrased his response this way
        - By connecting both both Saul and Jonathan to Samuel, the implication is they share the same eternal fate
- Finally, v.19 confirms the coming defeat of the army of Israel in the battle
    - This will not mean the end of the nation, certainly
        - But it does show that the people's fate is closely connected to the fate of their king
        - Saul's disobedience has produced consequences for the nation as a whole
    - Next week we'll pick up here with the rest of the story

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- We drop back into the moment when Saul's paranoia, pride and arrogance has driven him to seek the counsel of a medium
  - Saul met with a woman who practiced speaking with the dead
    - In reality, those practitioners never actually made contact with dead spirits
    - Instead, they were simply encountering evil spirits who impersonated the dead spirits
    - It was a charade the demons used to control those who sought such counsel
    - Men like Saul…
  - Or in this case, the Lord took over the moment to present Saul with exactly what he was looking for: an encounter with Samuel
    - A vision of Samuel's spirit is presented to Saul so he can hear Samuel's counsel
    - And that counsel was appropriately harsh
    - Samuel told Saul he was sinning to seek counsel from the Lord through him
    - That in fact the Lord was not interested in speaking to Saul
  - And then Samuel declared that Saul was destined for the grave by the next day
    - Saul had the kingdom ripped from his family's hands
    - It was to be David's now
    - So not only would Saul find himself with Samuel, but so would Saul's son, Jonathan
  - Samuel's words to Saul were clearly stunning and unexpected
    - And the next section of the chapter reveals just how concerned he has become
    - And at the same time, we see another ironic roll reversal that 1 & 2 Samuel are so well known for

1Sam. 28:20 **Then Saul immediately fell full length upon the ground and was very afraid because of the words of Samuel; also there was no strength in him, for he had eaten no food all day and all night.**
1Sam. 28:21 **The woman came to Saul and saw that he was terrified, and said to him, "Behold, your maidservant has obeyed you, and I have taken my life in my hand and have listened to your words which you spoke to me.**
1Sam. 28:22 **"So now also, please listen to the voice of your maidservant, and let me set a piece of bread before you that you may eat and have strength when you go on your way."**
1Sam. 28:23 **But he refused and said, "I will not eat." However, his servants together with the woman urged him, and he listened to them. So he arose from the ground and sat on the bed.**
1Sam. 28:24 **The woman had a fattened calf in the house, and she quickly slaughtered it; and she took flour, kneaded it and baked unleavened bread from it.**

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1Sam. 28:25 She brought it before Saul and his servants, and they ate. Then they arose and went away that night.

- At hearing of his judgment from Samuel, Saul falls stiff to the ground in fear and distress
  - Whatever view you may have of this man and of what he has done to deserve this outcome, still it's hard not to feel some pity for him here
    - He has heard that he will die
    - Moreover he knows his son will die too
    - And he has been given the reason for that outcome: his sin
  - By his faith, Saul was saved from judgment in eternity
    - But sometimes the Lord will permit the consequences of a person's sin to rest upon them while we're still alive
    - He does this to chastise them, to correct them in the hope it will lead to better things for them
    - But in the worst cases, the Lord may bring a person to the end of their earthly life as a consequence for extreme sin
  - That's the situation Saul finds himself in at this point
    - And it must be a hard thing indeed to know the Lord has determined to bring this particular judgment
    - To know you will die the next day
    - And even worse to know that your son will die with you
  - This was devastating news for Saul, and the worst part for him was knowing in advance
    - And of course, he bought that upon himself
    - Had he not gone against the commandments of the Lord in seeking the advice of this medium, he wouldn't have known
    - The outcome would have been the same
    - But in knowing in advance, Saul suffered all the more
- In fact, his suffering is so acute it leaves him on the floor for some time, or so it seems, because it says he ate no food that day or all that night
  - So it seems as the night was ending, the woman wanted to help Saul leave her home
    - And in another reversal of roles, now the medium is comforting Saul
    - A king of Israel should have had this woman executed for doing what she did
    - Instead, she is ministering to him, indicating how far from God Saul is at this point
    - He can be refreshed by a woman more familiar with demons than God
- Now the woman speaks using words very similar to those Samuel used a moment earlier, though reversed again

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    - Samuel had just said that because Saul hadn't obeyed, the Lord would do something to Saul – that is, take his life
    - Now this woman says because I have obeyed you in performing this service, I want you to do something for me
    - Throughout this book, we see these kind of reversals of roles, particularly in the life of Saul
- The meaning of this pattern in Saul's case is that he is operating 180 degrees from the commandments of God
    - Saul is living in opposite world
    - That's a phrase that describes the world perfectly in that everything the world celebrates is the opposite of what is godly
    - Made so because the world is under the influence of the Father of Lies
- In v.22 the woman reminds Saul of his obligation in keeping with the covenant he made earlier
- So she insists he eats, probably for the reason that it would facilitate his departure from her home
    - But in a great moment of irony in Saul's life, he refuses to honor this woman's request
    - In other words, Saul was violating this covenant just as he did the one he had with the Lord
- This is a reflection of his heart, that he makes promises he never intends to keep
    - How many times have we seen him make promises to David but then turn against him the next moment?
    - And now he does it even to this woman trying to help him
- Ultimately, the woman with the help of Saul's servants convince him to eat something
    - In fact, she's so determined to get him out of the house, she is willing to kill a fatted calf and feed Saul what will be his last meal
    - She may have gone to such trouble to ensure the covenant was official
    - A meal of this kind would have been the normal convention when entering into a covenant
    - With that, Saul leaves the woman in Endor and goes out to prepare for that day's coming battle
- Returning to David's situation with the Philistines, we find him preparing to advance into battle on the side of Israel's enemy, but with a plan
- But before he can enact his battle plan, the commanders of the Philistines object to his presence on the battlefield

1Sam. 29:1 Now the Philistines gathered together all their armies to Aphek, while the Israelites were camping by the spring which is in Jezreel.

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1Sam. 29:2 **And the lords of the Philistines were proceeding on by hundreds and by thousands, and David and his men were proceeding on in the rear with Achish.**
1Sam. 29:3 **Then the commanders of the Philistines said, "What are these Hebrews doing here?" And Achish said to the commanders of the Philistines, "Is this not David, the servant of Saul the king of Israel, who has been with me these days, or rather these years, and I have found no fault in him from the day he deserted to me to this day?"**
1Sam. 29:4 **But the commanders of the Philistines were angry with him, and the commanders of the Philistines said to him, "Make the man go back, that he may return to his place where you have assigned him, and do not let him go down to battle with us, or in the battle he may become an adversary to us. For with what could this man make himself acceptable to his lord? Would it not be with the heads of these men?**
1Sam. 29:5 **"Is this not David, of whom they sing in the dances, saying,**
'Saul has slain his thousands,
And David his ten thousands'?"

- The Philistines are amassing in Aphek, a town in the north of Philistine territory near the Jezreel Valley
  - The mention of Aphek brings us full circle in the story of 1 Samuel
    - The first mention in this book of Israel battling with the Philistines happened in Chapter 4
    - And the place the Philistines were amassing then was also Aphek
    - That connection seems to emphasize that 40 years of Saul's reign have done nothing to advance Israel's security
  - As we heard a couple of chapters ago, David and his men are marching into battle with the Philistines at the rear of Achish's formation
    - We don't know exactly what David was planning
    - But we can safely assume David was going to turn on Achish in the midst of battle
    - Certainly, that's what Achish's fellow commanders assumed
  - They object to David's presence, asking why are there Hebrews in our midst?
    - It's really a very comical moment
    - These men are preparing to kill as many Hebrews as they can, when they look up and see Hebrews standing among them
    - It's like a football team discovering a player from the other team standing in their huddle
  - So naturally they object, and Achish, who David has deceived, comes to David's aid
    - He asks is this not David?

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        - By that he means, isn't this the David who has served me faithfully (or so he thinks) for 16 months?
    - But the commanders use Achish's own words against him asking is this not David?
        - Then they repeat the well-known song that emphasizes David's propensity to kill lots of Philistines
        - And it highlights that Saul and David are united in purpose and goals
        - And they ask Achish exactly what could someone like David do to ever make him acceptable to Achish?
        - Therefore, they mock Achish's naiveté at thinking David has suddenly become a traitor to his own people
        - They know how dangerous it is to have him in their midst in battle
- Now Achish must deliver this bad news to David

1Sam. 29:6 Then Achish called David and said to him, "As the Lord lives, you have been upright, and your going out and your coming in with me in the army are pleasing in my sight; for I have not found evil in you from the day of your coming to me to this day. Nevertheless, you are not pleasing in the sight of the lords.
1Sam. 29:7 "Now therefore return and go in peace, that you may not displease the lords of the Philistines."
1Sam. 29:8 David said to Achish, "But what have I done? And what have you found in your servant from the day when I came before you to this day, that I may not go and fight against the enemies of my lord the king?"
1Sam. 29:9 But Achish replied to David, "I know that you are pleasing in my sight, like an angel of God; nevertheless the commanders of the Philistines have said, 'He must not go up with us to the battle.'
1Sam. 29:10 "Now then arise early in the morning with the servants of your lord who have come with you, and as soon as you have arisen early in the morning and have light, depart."
1Sam. 29:11 So David arose early, he and his men, to depart in the morning to return to the land of the Philistines. And the Philistines went up to Jezreel.

- Achish has to work to convince David to return to his home in the south
    - Achish acknowledges that David has done nothing wrong in the 16 months he has served this king
        - Furthermore, Achish has been pleased with David's support
        - He probably appreciated receiving the booty David secured from the Amalekites in the south
    - Nevertheless, Achish says his fellow lords are not pleased with David, so David must depart

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        - David asks what he's done to deserve this treatment
        - He says he only wants to fight against the enemies of David's lord, the king
        - We can only assume David is still working to deceive Achish
        - When he says "my lord the king" David is referring to Saul, not Achish
        - But of course David wanted Achish to think he was talking about him
    - In v.9 Achish vindicates David for the third time, having already done so in v.3 and v.6
        - Nevertheless, David must go back
        - Achish is treating David unfairly despite testifying three times that David has done nothing to deserve this treatment
        - In this small detail we find a picture of Christ, in the way that Pilate denied finding fault with Christ three times yet still condemned Him
- The whole scene is a bit odd in that David seems to be working very hard to become part of something he likely couldn't have controlled in the end
    - He may have had a plan for how he would ultimately turn against the Philistines and support Israel
        - But what if that plan hadn't worked out as he expected?
        - In the fog of war, there are an infinite number of ways that things don't go as planned
        - In fact, it's probably more likely that David would find himself in dangerous and uncontrollable circumstances than that things would work out as he hoped
    - What's David forgetting in his scheming? He's working without the counsel of the Lord
        - If the Lord had orchestrated this plan, then David could have moved forward in confidence that the Lord had already worked out the details
        - That's been David's experience with the Lord in previous battles
    - But the difference this time is that David hasn't sought the Lord
        - As we observed last week, David has not prayed to the Lord nor sought His counsel at any point in the time he spends among the Philistines
        - In fact, God's name doesn't appear in Chapter 27
        - And the only mention in this chapter comes from Achish who uses it merely to mollify David
        - In other words, David is operating on his own, and he's dangerously close to making a serious mistake
    - But then the Lord's invisible hand steps in to protect David from himself
        - David is being prevented from going into this battle by the Lord
        - Even as David is resisting the Lord's will, nevertheless the Lord is going to get His way with David

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- I love seeing the Lord working this way with David because it gives all of us hope that even in our worst moments, the Lord doesn't stop blessing us
  - He acts like a good and perfect Father would
    - He steps in to rescue us when necessary so we don't run with scissors or play in the street, spiritually speaking
    - The Lord knows David is trying to use his situation to Saul's benefit, but he's going about it the wrong way
  - The Lord not only wants us to serve His purposes and goals, He wants us to do so according to His plan
    - There may be multiple ways to achieve something according to God's purposes
    - But that doesn't mean all means are equally valid and godly
    - To say it another way, the ends do not justify the means in serving God
  - He wants us to seek His goals by following His plan
    - We can know His goals and purposes by reading scripture
    - But we can only know His specific plan for how we must achieve those outcomes through prayer and taking note of His responses
    - He will close some doors while opening other doors in our life
    - He will convict us of one thing while encouraging us in another
    - David was being pushed away from this battle because he was working the wrong plan even though he had the right goal
- Next we discover why the Lord wanted David to return to Ziklag rather than enter into this battle

1Sam. 30:1 Then it happened when David and his men came to Ziklag on the third day, that the Amalekites had made a raid on the Negev and on Ziklag, and had overthrown Ziklag and burned it with fire;
1Sam. 30:2 and they took captive the women and all who were in it, both small and great, without killing anyone, and carried them off and went their way.
1Sam. 30:3 When David and his men came to the city, behold, it was burned with fire, and their wives and their sons and their daughters had been taken captive.
1Sam. 30:4 Then David and the people who were with him lifted their voices and wept until there was no strength in them to weep.
1Sam. 30:5 Now David's two wives had been taken captive, Ahinoam the Jezreelitess and Abigail the widow of Nabal the Carmelite.
1Sam. 30:6 Moreover David was greatly distressed because the people spoke of stoning him, for all the people were embittered, each one because of his sons and his daughters. But David strengthened himself in the Lord his God.

- The circumstances of this chapter serve a couple of purposes in the larger story of David's ascent and Saul's fall

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- First, we're seeing the consequences of David's sin of entering the Philistines territories
  - David moved into Ziklag without the Lord's approval
  - He avoided the fight with Saul, which was intended to grow him
  - And he resorted to deception again to get his way
  - So there will be a reckoning now
- But the Lord is good to those who love Him, and so the Lord will ultimately turn these circumstances to good for David and Israel
  - This is probably the most important comparison between David and Christ throughout the books of 1 & 2 Samuel
  - Tragedy turns to victory for David
  - Sorrow leads to joy
  - Just as Christ's death lead to salvation

- As the circumstances unfold, David's absence with the Philistines gave opportunity for the Amalekites to avenge David's attacks
  - They came up into the city and burned the city and took the women and children captive
    - Obviously, David and his men are greatly distressed by what they find
    - They weep until they are exhausted
  - And it leads David's men to consider stoning him for his poor leadership
    - Obviously, if he hadn't made the decision to enter the Philistine territory or attack the Amalekites, this wouldn't have happened
    - Ironically, David made this move as a means of seeking safety
    - But in the process, he put his men at greater risk
  - The safest place for us to be is in the will of God
    - That may not place us in the most peaceful circumstances
    - But it will assures us the greatest protection from the world
    - David is learning that lesson now
- And then at the end of v.6, we find a phrase we've been waiting to see for three chapters
  - David strengthened himself in the Lord
    - This isn't merely a reference to David finding physical revival or even spiritual resolve
    - It indicates the moment that David returns to seeking the Lord's will rather than following his own plans
    - It's the mention of God that's been missing for too long
  - At this moment, we have the clearest distinction between David and Saul
    - When Saul faced great distress and the end of his life, he sought demonic

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counsel in the face of a silent God
    - When David entered this crisis, he responded by seeking the Lord
    - If there was a single lesson of 1 Samuel, this is it: seek the Lord
- This is also a powerful illustration of how every child experiences a walk with the Lord, moving in and out of His will at times
    - We may walk closely with Him for a time finding strength and joy and a measure of spiritual fruit
        - But for whatever reason, we may begin to feel confidence in ourselves thinking we know what we're doing
        - Then we step outside His will in some area of our life
        - Just as David had experienced victory after victory over Saul in the wilderness, but then ran for protection among the Philistines
    - When we step outside the Lord's will, He doesn't forget us or leave us
        - Instead, He works patiently in the background
        - First, He may give us time to experience the foolishness of our decision
        - He may let our situation play out for a time, letting us collect a few scars along the way
    - But even during our rebellion, the Lord watches over us, protecting us from the worst of our mistakes and turning our mistakes to good
        - Just as He stopped David from going into a battle he had no business entering and couldn't control
        - Likewise, the Lord will protect us from destruction even as He sends us counselors, friends, or other correction to prompt repentance
        - And then as we repent, returning to Him, He delights to pick us up and move us forward
- Just as we see the Lord doing with David now

1Sam. 30:7 **Then David said to Abiathar the priest, the son of Ahimelech, "Please bring me the ephod." So Abiathar brought the ephod to David.**
1Sam. 30:8 **David inquired of the Lord, saying, "Shall I pursue this band? Shall I overtake them?" And He said to him, "Pursue, for you will surely overtake them, and you will surely rescue all."**

- David returns to consulting the Lord for guidance
    - You can almost hear a Hollywood soundtrack beginning to play soaring, victorious music at this point
        - This is the climatic turning point in David's ascent to the throne
        - He has passed the final test of his time in the wilderness

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        - This crises cements David's trust in the Lord
    - David goes back to the High Priest, and asks him to inquire of the Lord concerning what they should do next
        - This is no small thing when you consider what was at stake
        - Obviously, every member of that community is determined to retrieve their family members
        - They are angry and ready to kill David
        - Can you imagine what would have happened if David had told them not to pursue the Amalekites?
    - Yet that was the risk David was taking in this moment
        - He asks the Lord if they should pursue, taking the risk that the answer might have been no
        - This is a dramatic example of submission to the Lord's will
        - David won't move to recover his own wives unless and until the Lord grants him permission
        - This is one of the high points in all scripture of a man submitted to the will of the Lord
- Of course, the Lord grants David the permission he sought, and gave David confidence of victory in the process
    - While Saul desperately desired to hear the Lord's counsel but couldn't, David receives an answer to his question
        - The difference between David and Saul is an important one
        - Both men knew the Lord, both had the Lord's anointing
        - And both men sinned at times, as do all men
    - But when Saul sinned and the Lord brought correction, Saul's heart was hardened to correction and fought back against it
        - As that process took hold, Saul moved further away from the Lord
        - And at a point, the Lord confirmed Saul's place outside His counsel
        - This is a devastating place for any believer to find him or herself
        - The writer of Hebrews warns us to stay away from such a place in our relationship with the Lord

Heb. 3:7 **Therefore, just as the Holy Spirit says,**
"Today if you hear His voice,
Heb. 3:8 **Do not harden your hearts as when they provoked Me,**
As in the day of trial in the wilderness,
Heb. 3:9 **Where your fathers tried Me by testing Me,**
And saw My works for forty years.
Heb. 3:10 **"Therefore I was angry with this generation,**

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And said, 'They always go astray in their heart,
And they did not know My ways';
Heb. 3:11 **As I swore in My wrath,**
'They shall not enter My rest.'"
Heb. 3:12 **Take care, brethren, that there not be in any one of you an evil, unbelieving heart that falls away from the living God.**
Heb. 3:13 **But encourage one another day after day, as long as it is still called "Today," so that none of you will be hardened by the deceitfulness of sin.**

- The writer draws a comparison between believers who act in unbelieving ways and those in Israel during the Exodus
  - Those Israelites saw and heard from the Lord in many dramatic ways and yet they continued to go astray
    - Their error illustrates the danger of taking for granted God's activity and revelation in our life
    - The Israelites were granted unique and power revelations of God
    - But it was for nothing in the end, since they made no good use of it
    - Instead, they squandered that grace and turned against the Lord time and time again
  - Similarly, the believer can find himself or herself becoming hardened by repeatedly turning away from the Lord
    - Sin is deceitful in that it lies to us
    - Sin lies by convincing us that to obey our own desires is a better course than obeying God
    - And it lies by convincing us we can live in open rebellion to the Lord with impunity
    - That since consequences haven't come so far, then they will never come
  - Saul's heart was hardened by the deceitfulness of his sin
    - He sinned long enough that he came to believe there was no other way to be
    - And as he went, his heart lost its capacity to receive God's rebuke or to be sensitive to the consequences of his errors
    - His heart became hardened, such that the tools God uses to bring repentance were no longer effective
    - And once Saul reached that place, there was no way back
  - Meanwhile, David made some similar mistakes and saw similar consequences
    - But when he experienced the negative impacts of his decisions, he chose to change his path
    - His heart remained sensitive to the Lord's rebuke, and so he returned to the Lord seeking something better

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        - And the Lord was there waiting for him
    - The story of Saul and David isn't one of a sinful king and a righteous king
        - It's a story of a hardened heart and a faithful heart
        - Of one man deceived by his sin
        - And another man corrected by his sin
- After the Lord gives permission, David takes his 600 men and begins his pursuit, though not sure where he's going
    - But because he's following the Lord's counsel, he has confidence that the Lord will take care of the details
        - And so He does

1Sam. 30:9 So David went, he and the six hundred men who were with him, and came to the brook Besor, where those left behind remained.
1Sam. 30:10 But David pursued, he and four hundred men, for two hundred who were too exhausted to cross the brook Besor remained behind.
1Sam. 30:11 Now they found an Egyptian in the field and brought him to David, and gave him bread and he ate, and they provided him water to drink.
1Sam. 30:12 They gave him a piece of fig cake and two clusters of raisins, and he ate; then his spirit revived. For he had not eaten bread or drunk water for three days and three nights.
1Sam. 30:13 David said to him, "To whom do you belong? And where are you from?" And he said, "I am a young man of Egypt, a servant of an Amalekite; and my master left me behind when I fell sick three days ago.
1Sam. 30:14 "We made a raid on the Negev of the Cherethites, and on that which belongs to Judah, and on the Negev of Caleb, and we burned Ziklag with fire."
1Sam. 30:15 Then David said to him, "Will you bring me down to this band?" And he said, "Swear to me by God that you will not kill me or deliver me into the hands of my master, and I will bring you down to this band."

- David and men go south as far as the brook Besor, which was the border of Israel with Egypt
    - It's interesting that David's men just fall in line behind him
        - One moment they are ready to stone him
        - And the next moment they follow
        - The only thing to explain their change of heart was seeing David consult the Lord
        - Godly leadership is inspiring to others, both in our families and in the church
    - The Amalekite raiders were moving in this territory freely, between the land of the Hebrews, the Philistines and pockets of Canaanites

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        - So finding them was going to require quick work and direction from the Lord
        - The journey down from Aphek and the emotional toll of finding Ziklag burned has left some of David's men exhausted
    - So David decides to leave 200 men with the camp equipment while taking 400 men with him to continue to fight
        - This might have discouraged a leader, to lose a third of his already small force
        - But David is following the Lord now, so he shows no doubt or fear
        - Spurgeon remarked:

When God means to bless us, he often takes away a part of the little strength we thought we had. We did not think our strength equal to the task, and the Lord takes away a portion even of the little power we had. Our God does not fill till he has emptied. Two hundred men must be rent away from David's side before God could give him victory … Expect then, O troubled one, that you will be delivered, but know that your sorrow may yet deepen, that you may have all the greater joy by-and-by.

- So in kindness David allows these 200 men to rest
    - Plus by leaving the baggage with them, David's other 400 men can move more swiftly
    - This is reminiscent of his planned battle against Nabal, where David left some men behind to guard the baggage
- As they move out, David and his men encounter an Egyptian in the field
    - This was an odd thing…a foreigner by himself so far north and in the middle of nowhere
        - So David and his men find this suspicious and take the man captive
        - They assume that this man may know something or at least he may have seen the Amalekites passing through
    - But the guy is so famished and weak that he's no use to them without some time to gain his strength
        - This man fell ill three days ago and was left here by the retreating Amalekites
        - So they give him food and water because it's been three days since he's had anything
        - And then they begin to interrogate him
    - He confesses that he was a part of the raiding party that struck Ziklag
        - As an Egyptian, he was probably a slave of the Amalekites, perhaps captured in a previous battle with the Egyptians
        - So he speaks as one under orders to do what he did, not as one with a personal grudge against David or anyone else

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        - So he tells David the complete story that they raided Ziklag
- David realizes this man can lead him to the camp of the Amalekites, so he instructs the Egyptian to take his men there
    - Of course, this worried the Egyptian
        - He will make himself an enemy of his master
        - So if David will not protect him, then he is certain to die
        - Therefore, he asks David for protection and David agrees
    - This entire scene is recorded for us to see the heart of David in the midst of war
        - He regards even the lowest of men with respect and kindness
        - This trait will follow David all the days of his life as king
        - It's one of the marks of a man after God's own heart
        - As Jesus says:

Luke 6:35 "But love your enemies, and do good, and lend, expecting nothing in return; and your reward will be great, and you will be sons of the Most High; for He Himself is kind to ungrateful and evil men.

- So then David goes into the camp

1Sam. 30:16 **When he had brought him down, behold, they were spread over all the land, eating and drinking and dancing because of all the great spoil that they had taken from the land of the Philistines and from the land of Judah.**
1Sam. 30:17 **David slaughtered them from the twilight until the evening of the next day; and not a man of them escaped, except four hundred young men who rode on camels and fled.**
1Sam. 30:18 **So David recovered all that the Amalekites had taken, and rescued his two wives.**
1Sam. 30:19 **But nothing of theirs was missing, whether small or great, sons or daughters, spoil or anything that they had taken for themselves; David brought it all back.**
1Sam. 30:20 **So David had captured all the sheep and the cattle which the people drove ahead of the other livestock, and they said, "This is David's spoil."**

- As the Lord promised, David and his men are successful in the battle
    - They fought all night long, destroying the enemy and freeing all the captives
        - We hear that 400 of the Amalekites escaped on camels, the sports car of that day
        - The significance of the number is in telling us that David had a much smaller force

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        - He was fighting with only 400, and just the escapees of the Amalekites was 400
        - Still the Lord delivered a victory to David
    - David's victory was so complete that nothing was missing, not even his possessions
        - The Amalekites had other possessions taken from other peoples besides David's men
        - And these possessions David took for himself as booty of the battle
        - And it was called David's spoil
- Finally, he carries that spoil back to the other waiting men
    - The distribution of the spoil takes up these five verses and the rest of the chapter
        - We will study it next week as we enter the final chapter of the book
        - It will illustrate once more David's fairness and concern for the welfare of his people
    - And it becomes the means God uses to turn the hearts of Israel to their new king even as Saul loses his life on the battlefield
        - Because when both the king and the prince die at the same moment, it leaves a power vacuum
        - David is God's choice to fill that vacuum
        - And the Lord wants the people of Israel to see that too

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- We're wrapping up our story of Saul's fall and David's rise
  - It's been ten years since David first entered Saul's court
    - And in those years, the Lord has trained David in skills necessary for his time as king
    - David's been trained in warfare and in music
    - He's learned shepherding and diplomacy
  - And during his time in the wilderness, he's learned some of the most important lessons of his entire life
    - He's learned to rely on the Lord, to seek Him in prayer and follow His commands
    - He's suffered loss, deprivation and despair
    - He's known triumph, seen miracles and found love
    - He's almost ready to take the throne
- And so today's the day Saul and Jonathan will die on the battlefield, and as a result the nation will seek for a new king
  - The question of who should succeed Saul will be on everyone's mind
    - And with David having been living in the land of Israel's enemies for the past 16 months, the answer isn't obvious
    - The Lord needs to make sure David is the natural and only choice in the minds of the people
    - For he is the Lord's choice
    - Therefore, the rest of Chapter 30 is devoted to explaining how the Lord prepares the hearts of the people to receive David as king even as He removes Saul
  - David has just returned from defeating the Amalekites in the south and rescuing the families of all his men
    - He won the victory with only 400 men
    - He was forced to leave 200 of his men behind due to exhaustion
    - Despite having a third fewer men, David's army has still managed to win a great victory
    - And as a result of his victory, he's taken considerable spoil
  - In v.20 last week we read that the people called this war booty "David's spoil"
    - In other words, David has the right to determine the distribution of this wealth
    - Logically, he will share it with those who helped him fight in the battle
    - But David is prepared to go well beyond that
  - Here's another difference between David and Saul
    - David is a man after God's own heart
    - So David does the unexpected with this bounty

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1Sam. 30:21 When David came to the two hundred men who were too exhausted to follow David, who had also been left at the brook Besor, and they went out to meet David and to meet the people who were with him, then David approached the people and greeted them.
1Sam. 30:22 Then all the wicked and worthless men among those who went with David said, "Because they did not go with us, we will not give them any of the spoil that we have recovered, except to every man his wife and his children, that they may lead them away and depart."
1Sam. 30:23 Then David said, "You must not do so, my brothers, with what the Lord has given us, who has kept us and delivered into our hand the band that came against us.
1Sam. 30:24 "And who will listen to you in this matter? For as his share is who goes down to the battle, so shall his share be who stays by the baggage; they shall share alike."
1Sam. 30:25 So it has been from that day forward, that he made it a statute and an ordinance for Israel to this day.

- David and his 400 men and the families they rescued return from the battle and enter Ziklag greeting those who returned
  - The word for greet is *shalom*, which means they wished peace upon these who stayed behind
    - It's probably an understatement for what would have been an emotional reunion for those families
    - But it's also an indication that David is not going to hold these men in contempt for their unwillingness to enter the battle
    - Once again David displays a degree of compassion out of keeping with the way most military commanders thought
    - But this is in keeping with God's heart
  - But within the group that entered battle, there were some men who were not like David's heart
    - They are called wicked and worthless in v.22
    - And their wickedness is evident by their willingness to cut off from receiving any of the spoil all those who didn't fight
    - This was probably normal for most armies
    - But it wasn't David's heart
- And the reason David viewed the situation differently was because he understood the source of the victory differently
  - The wicked and worthless soldiers were taking full credit for this victory
    - They believed they had defeated the Amalekites by their own power
    - And therefore, they felt they deserved the spoil

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        - And conversely, the men who failed to fight could not claim a part in the victory nor the spoil
    - But remember we saw last week that these men were likely greatly outnumbered in the fight
        - The number of Amalekites who escaped the battle on camels was equal to the total number of David's force
        - So we can be sure these men were a long shot to win this battle
        - What explains their victory then?
    - David recognized that the Lord brought the victory supernaturally, in keeping with His promise to David that they would recover their families
        - In v.23 David says the Lord gave them the victory
        - And then David concludes that the share of the spoil must be divided equally since no one earned this victory
        - The ones who went into battle could take no more credit for the victory than those who stayed behind with the baggage
        - So the spoil should be divided equally
- The principle David is following has profound implications for all believers in many areas of our spiritual lives
    - This principle recognizes that believers can't take credit for God's work through us
        - And therefore we can't use our successes in ministry as cause for individual distinction at the expense of others
        - This principle impacts how we talk about our success, how we fund our work and how we qualify those who serve in the church
        - Paul says it this way

Rom. 12:3 For through the grace given to me I say to everyone among you not to think more highly of himself than he ought to think; but to think so as to have sound judgment, as God has allotted to each a measure of faith.
Rom. 12:4 For just as we have many members in one body and all the members do not have the same function,
Rom. 12:5 so we, who are many, are one body in Christ, and individually members one of another.
Rom. 12:6 Since we have gifts that differ according to the grace given to us, each of us is to exercise them accordingly: if prophecy, according to the proportion of his faith;
Rom. 12:7 if service, in his serving; or he who teaches, in his teaching;
Rom. 12:8 or he who exhorts, in his exhortation; he who gives, with liberality; he who leads, with diligence; he who shows mercy, with cheerfulness.

- If the Lord has given us the means for our success in serving Him, then who are we to

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elevate ourselves among others?

- If we are part of a body, then how important can any one part be?
- And if the same Spirit is empowering all of us as He desires, then what part did we play in creating any distinction?

- When we operate with an awareness of this principle, several good things will happen
  - First, we remain humble, or as Paul put it, we have "sound judgment"
  - In Greek, the term means having the right mind
  - We see the spiritual world accurately, without deluding ourselves and inflaming our pride
  - We'll worry less about perceptions of us and spend less time promoting ourselves and more time lifting up the Lord
  - We'll experience contentment with our anonymity knowing that it's woe to us when men speak well of you
  - Men and women who serve God in this way typically accomplish far more for the kingdom than those who make personal recognition a priority
- Secondly, living under this principle means we be preoccupied with the contributions of others as they seek to serve the Lord
  - We can set aside questions of who does more or who does enough to serve the Lord
  - We can trust that the Lord will judge all fairly and we can rest in that assurance without passing judgment on one another
  - Again, Paul puts it this way

Rom. 14:4 Who are you to judge the servant of another? To his own master he stands or falls; and he will stand, for the Lord is able to make him stand.

Rom. 14:10 But you, why do you judge your brother? Or you again, why do you regard your brother with contempt? For we will all stand before the judgment seat of God.
Rom. 14:11 For it is written,
"As I live, says the Lord, every knee shall bow to Me,
And every tongue shall give praise to God."
Rom. 14:12 So then each one of us will give an account of himself to God.
Rom. 14:13 Therefore let us not judge one another anymore, but rather determine this — not to put an obstacle or a stumbling block in a brother's way.

- David has made a wise and courageous decision
  - He has resisted the temptation to selfishly exclude the 200 men so as to ensure the 400 received a higher reward
    - Moreover, he has set forth a principle that all those who serve in Israel are equal

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beneficiaries of the Lord's blessing

- In v.25 we're told that as a result of David's actions, a new ordinance or statute was instituted in the nation
- And this unconventional choice becomes the opening for David to claim the throne of Israel

- David's wisdom doesn't end with his distribution to the soldiers
  - David holds some of the spoil back so he can use it to win over the entire nation

1Sam. 30:26 Now when David came to Ziklag, he sent some of the spoil to the elders of Judah, to his friends, saying, "Behold, a gift for you from the spoil of the enemies of the Lord:
1Sam. 30:27 to those who were in Bethel, and to those who were in Ramoth of the Negev, and to those who were in Jattir,
1Sam. 30:28 and to those who were in Aroer, and to those who were in Siphmoth, and to those who were in Eshtemoa,
1Sam. 30:29 and to those who were in Racal, and to those who were in the cities of the Jerahmeelites, and to those who were in the cities of the Kenites,
1Sam. 30:30 and to those who were in Hormah, and to those who were in Bor-ashan, and to those who were in Athach,
1Sam. 30:31 and to those who were in Hebron, and to all the places where David himself and his men were accustomed to go."

- David distributes a portion of the plunder to the elders of Judah
  - Judah is the tribe of David and these towns were the principle places David had spent his years wandering during his time in the wilderness
    - David is taking the same principle we just examined and applying it on an even broader scale
    - David's victory over the enemies of Judah wasn't just the result of a momentary intervention by God
    - On the contrary, the Lord had been working steadily over the past ten years to bring David through the entire episode of wandering
  - It seems that David has learned the final and most important lesson of his time wandering
    - That the Lord was forever and always working in every circumstance to care for David and direct his steps
    - Therefore, the spoil from this victory was just the latest evidence of God's grace in David's life
  - So as David reflected on the events that brought him to this point, he must have realized that the elders of Judah were likewise responsible for this victory
    - When the elders in Bethel or in the Negev supported David, they were doing the

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Lord's work

- When the Kenites or the men of Hormah protected or fed David, they were instruments in God's hands
- So when David received his reward in battle, he understood that the Lord was working long before to grant this outcome
- And therefore, these men should share in the spoil too

- Not only was David living true to the principle he established, but he was also acting in a very politically astute manner
  - This gesture was sure to cement loyalty among the elders of Judah
    - So that after the death of Saul later this day in battle in the north of Israel, David will be positioned to receive their support
    - And David is well prepared to assumed that role
  - In fact, if we glance back across the events of this chapter, we see David exhibiting a list of admirable leadership traits
    - He shows empathy, decisiveness, kindness, integrity, generosity and above all, faith
    - These qualities were present in David to varying degrees from years ago
    - But his experiences in the wilderness fleeing Saul have matured him in necessary and important ways
    - So that now David is clearly qualified to sit on the throne of Israel, in a way that Saul never was
  - And in this way, Saul and David become a striking picture of Satan and Christ, respectively
    - Saul assumed the throne of Israel yet lacked the proper pedigree and qualifications
    - He wasn't of the correct tribe and he didn't possess the tested character nor heart of God
    - And as a result, the usurper's reign brought only death and destruction to Israel
  - Meanwhile, the Lord raises up a humble servant from unassuming circumstances to rule the nation
    - This man comes from the proper lineage
    - He has a heart after God
    - And after a time of severe testing, he is shown worthy to take the throne of God's people
    - A throne he assumes after the usurper is destroyed
  - It's easy to see the comparisons with Satan and Christ
    - Obviously, we aren't suggesting that Saul is satanic or evil or even an unbeliever
    - We're just noting the way the arc of his life represents Satan's role in contending with Christ

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        - Satan wants the throne reserved for Christ, and for a time he appears to have it as he rules the fallen world enslaved to him
    - But a humble Christ was tested and proven worthy to sit at the righthand of the Father
        - Even now the kingdom has been ripped away from Satan and granted to Christ
        - Yet for a time, the body of Christ is being tested, living in a wilderness of the world
        - While our enemy desperately tries to hold on to power and persecutes us as he did our Lord
        - But in a day to come, the Lord will assume His rightful throne and the enemy will be vanquished
- And now has come the time for David to assume his throne

1Sam. 31:1 **Now the Philistines were fighting against Israel, and the men of Israel fled from before the Philistines and fell slain on Mount Gilboa.**
1Sam. 31:2 **The Philistines overtook Saul and his sons; and the Philistines killed Jonathan and Abinadab and Malchi-shua the sons of Saul.**
1Sam. 31:3 **The battle went heavily against Saul, and the archers hit him; and he was badly wounded by the archers.**
1Sam. 31:4 **Then Saul said to his armor bearer, "Draw your sword and pierce me through with it, otherwise these uncircumcised will come and pierce me through and make sport of me." But his armor bearer would not, for he was greatly afraid. So Saul took his sword and fell on it.**
1Sam. 31:5 **When his armor bearer saw that Saul was dead, he also fell on his sword and died with him.**
1Sam. 31:6 **Thus Saul died with his three sons, his armor bearer, and all his men on that day together.**

- The story now turns back to Mt. Gilboa and to Saul and the army of Israel in the north
    - This scene was probably taking place simultaneously during David's fight with the Amalekites in the south
        - Obviously, the Lord is working to time these two outcomes so that they create a contrast with one another
        - On the one hand, Saul's ignominious defeat in the north
        - And on the other, David's triumph in the south
    - The Philistines press the battle and the result is exactly as Samuel foretold the night before
        - Saul's son Jonathan is killed on the battlefield
        - But Saul's other sons Abinadab and Malchi-shua are also killed
        - Once again, this is to be expected since the Lord has said that Saul's dynasty

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would come to an end

- And then Saul himself dies and in a most shameful way
  - Saul is struck by multiple arrows and is mortally wounded
  - Recognizing he has come to his end, Saul instructs his armor bearer to kill him lest the Gentiles capture him alive
- The armor bearer is reluctant to follow Saul's orders for obvious reasons
  - Had the armor bearer killed the king, there would be no one alive to testify to Saul's instructions
  - And the armor bearer would have been seen as Saul's murderer
  - So he refuses to comply

- Saul then decides to do the deed himself, committing suicide by falling on the point of his own sword
  - Saul's death is the final irony in his sad story
    - The day earlier, the Lord had finally spoken to Saul as Saul desired, saying Saul would die in battle
    - The Lord's silence had been the product of Saul's unwillingness to submit to the word of God in prior days
    - Yet nevertheless, Saul was determined to hear from God, necessitating his visit to the medium
  - And once more Saul has heard the voice of the Lord and chosen to go his own way, even in his death
    - Rather than conceding to the Lord's will, Saul decides to take his own life
    - Of course, the word of God was still correct that Saul dies as a result of the battle
    - But the specific cause was Saul's own hand, a fitting conclusion to a life that rejected the word of the Lord time and again
    - It's interesting that Saul was more concerned with what might happen to him when the Philistines found him
    - When he should have been focused on what was to happen when he faced the Lord following his death
  - When the armor bearer sees Saul take his own life, he decides to follow in like way
    - The armor bearer falls on his own sword
    - This was not an uncommon response under the circumstances
    - The armor bearer was charged with protecting the life of the king
    - And if the king died, especially in such a dishonorable way, the armor bearer was likely to be executed anyway
  - His death simply emphasizes that Saul's sin and death brought many others down with him

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- Not only did this armor bearer lose his life because of Saul
- But so did many in Israel's army on that day
- As we read in v.6, all Saul's army died on that day
- Many wives lost husbands and many children lost fathers
- Such is the consequence of sin

- Those consequences extended well beyond the dead on the battlefield

1Sam. 31:7 When the men of Israel who were on the other side of the valley, with those who were beyond the Jordan, saw that the men of Israel had fled and that Saul and his sons were dead, they abandoned the cities and fled; then the Philistines came and lived in them.

- As a result of the army's defeat, the entire north of Israel is overrun by the Philistines
  - The towns throughout the Jezreel Valley and beyond the Jordan are left exposed to the Philistines
  - So the Jewish people and other peoples living in these towns abandon their homes and fields in anticipation of the Philistines' advance
  - This is a terrible defeat for the people and the low point in Israel's history since entering the land
- This is the opposite outcome from the one Saul was supposed to accomplish
  - The Lord declared that Saul was the one through whom He would deliver Israel from the Philistines

1Sam. 9:10 Then Saul said to his servant, "Well said; come, let us go." So they went to the city where the man of God was.
1Sam. 9:11 As they went up the slope to the city, they found young women going out to draw water and said to them, "Is the seer here?"
1Sam. 9:12 They answered them and said, "He is; see, he is ahead of you. Hurry now, for he has come into the city today, for the people have a sacrifice on the high place today.
1Sam. 9:13 "As soon as you enter the city you will find him before he goes up to the high place to eat, for the people will not eat until he comes, because he must bless the sacrifice; afterward those who are invited will eat. Now therefore, go up for you will find him at once."
1Sam. 9:14 So they went up to the city. As they came into the city, behold, Samuel was coming out toward them to go up to the high place.
1Sam. 9:15 Now a day before Saul's coming, the Lord had revealed this to Samuel saying,
1Sam. 9:16 "About this time tomorrow I will send you a man from the land of Benjamin, and you shall anoint him to be prince over My people Israel; and he

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will deliver My people from the hand of the Philistines. For I have regarded My people, because their cry has come to Me."

- Now we understand that the Lord didn't mean that Saul would defeat the Philistines once and all
- Instead, he simply meant that Saul would win meaningful victories in his early days
- But in the end he failed in his mission because of his disobedience and sin
- In fact, reading this opening passage again reveals an interesting symmetry to Saul's time as king in Israel
  - The story began with an innocent Saul seeking for Samuel and finding him with the help of a female guide
  - And the story ended with a wicked Saul seeking for Samuel by means of a female medium
  - His life has gone full circle, albeit in a downward spiral
- And now our story comes to an end with the final disposition of Saul's body

1Sam. 31:8 **It came about on the next day when the Philistines came to strip the slain, that they found Saul and his three sons fallen on Mount Gilboa.**
1Sam. 31:9 **They cut off his head and stripped off his weapons, and sent them throughout the land of the Philistines, to carry the good news to the house of their idols and to the people.**
1Sam. 31:10 **They put his weapons in the temple of Ashtaroth, and they fastened his body to the wall of Beth-shan.**
1Sam. 31:11 **Now when the inhabitants of Jabesh-gilead heard what the Philistines had done to Saul,**
1Sam. 31:12 **all the valiant men rose and walked all night, and took the body of Saul and the bodies of his sons from the wall of Beth-shan, and they came to Jabesh and burned them there.**
1Sam. 31:13 **They took their bones and buried them under the tamarisk tree at Jabesh, and fasted seven days.**

- When the Philistines were scavenging among the dead, they come across Saul and Jonathan and Saul's other sons on Mt. Gilboa
  - They do to Saul what David had done to Goliath years earlier
    - They decapitate the king's dead body, remove his weapons and put his head and weapons on a tour of the Philistine cities
    - The land celebrates this great victory over Israel
  - In another contrast to the start of the book, Saul's head ends up in one pagan temple (according to 1 Chronicles 10:10) and his weapons in another
    - The book opened with Samuel entering service in God's temple

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        - And it ends with Saul in a pagan temple
        - Saul's headless body was nailed to the walls of the Jewish town of Beth-shan
        - This town is located on the east end of the Jezreel valley, near the battle where Saul lost his life
    - In further irony, Saul died worrying what the Philistines would do to him, yet the very thing he tried to avoid happened anyway
        - By treating his body in this way, the Philistines were bringing Saul great dishonor in death
        - To treat a dead body in this way was great disrespect
- Eventually the news of Saul's body reached a nearby Jewish town
    - Jabesh-gilead was about 13 miles away from Beth-shan, which took most of the night to reach by foot
        - They wanted to show respect to their king even in death
        - So they removed him from the wall and burned his body probably to cleanse it of abuse
        - And then they buried the bones in Jabesh
    - This town had been rescued earlier by Saul from the Amalekites, so they were simply repaying Saul
        - They buried him under a tamarisk tree
        - That location serves to remind us of where Saul spent some of the most pivotal moments of his inglorious career as king
        - Earlier, Saul acted foolishly fearing David and making rash accusations while seated under a similar tree
        - Later in 2 Samuel David will further honor the king by reinterring his bones in the family tomb
- Thomas Constable offers a fitting summary of the life of Saul:

This is how the life of Israel's first king, the man after the Israelites' own heart, ended. He was full of promise at his anointing, having many natural qualities that could have contributed to a successful reign. He also possessed the Holy Spirit's enablement after his anointing. Unfortunately he did not become a source of blessing to Israel and the world, nor did God bless him personally. Instead he became a curse to Israel, the world, and himself. He did so because he failed to acknowledge Yahweh as the true king of Israel and because he failed to view himself as Yahweh's servant. His life teaches us that the key to blessing or cursing is one's trust in, and obedience to, God.

This book opened with Samuel's birth, hope, and an answer to prayer. It closes with Saul's death, despair, and an act of divine judgment. It is a book of

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transition, contrasting rule by God with rule by man. If we want to run things, they will turn out as they did for Saul. If we let God rule, they will turn out as they did for Samuel and David.

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